

Falanaras, Blood Knight

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A Note on the Making of This Book

This book was developed through story design, iterative drafting, selection, revision, and editorial direction using AI rather than written entirely by hand. Lorekeeper was the creative writing and worldbuilding environment used to organize, compose, revise, and prepare the work for publication.

Composed, directed, and edited by Jonathan Harmon.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Sundering of Silvermoon

The bells began before dawn. By sunrise, Silvermoon had realized that they weren't ceremonial.

Their clamor crossed the tiled roofs and gilded spires in ragged waves, one tower answering another until the whole city seemed to shudder with bronze voices. Falanaras stood at the eastern windows of House Dawnspear and watched blue-robed messengers run through streets already thick with people. Servants carried water into the courtyard. Neighbors argued at locked carriage doors. Above them, the pale radiance of Ban'dinoriel trembled across the morning sky.

The barrier had always been easier to feel than to see. It lived in the faint pressure behind his eyes, in the wards humming through stone and silverwood, in the assurance that no hostile army could cross the borders of Quel'Thalas unseen. That morning it flickered hard enough to cast violet bands over the city.

Aelrindor Dawnspear entered behind him, fastening the clasp of an old cuirass. The armor had been made for ceremony and maintained out of habit. Its blue enamel and silver edging remained bright, though the leather beneath had stiffened with age. At his hip hung the narrow sword he wore when House Dawnspear attended court.

"The city muster has called every household capable of bearing arms," Aelrindor said. "You will report to the Court of the Sun."

Falanaras turned from the window. "And you?"

"I will see the household secured."

There were six retainers left in the estate, two of them too old for field service and one unable to walk without a cane. His mother's sister had taken the youngest servants toward the inner districts during the night. Caelir was in Dalaran, beyond any message they could send. Secured was a word his father used when the truth offered no dignity.

"Come with me," Falanaras said. "They can use every trained blade at the muster."

Aelrindor's expression tightened. He had never been warm, but neither had he been cruel. Affection in House Dawnspear passed through tuition paid, boots replaced before winter, and corrections delivered before strangers could witness an error. He laid one gloved hand on Falanaras's shoulder.

"Your brother is absent. You are here. Go answer the call."

A concussion rolled across the city. Crystal chimed in every cabinet. In the courtyard, a dragonhawk shrieked and tore free of its handler. The light of Ban'dinoriel flared white, exposing the bones of Aelrindor's hand through his glove, then dimmed to a bruised haze.

Falanaras felt the Sunwell beneath the shock. Its presence had no single place within him. It was warmth without heat, a current too constant to notice until fear sharpened his senses. The current faltered, recovered, and carried on with a sour vibration threaded through it.

Aelrindor removed his hand. "When kingdoms break, survival may ask more of you than dignity."

"That sounds very much like permission to run."

"If the choice is offered, take it." His father's mouth moved in the smallest suggestion of a smile. "Most dead men would."

It was the last kindness Aelrindor ever gave him.

At the Court of the Sun, officers divided citizens by whatever skills panic allowed them to remember. Those with

military training were sent south toward the failing defenses. Magi were pulled into warding circles. Healers vanished into temple wagons. Falanaras admitted to three years of fashionable sword instruction and was handed a spear whose ash shaft had already been darkened by another elf's blood.

"Keep the point toward the Scourge," the quartermaster told him. "If they speak, keep it there."

His company contained jewelers, clerks, gardeners, two apprentices from the royal academies, and a vintner who kept asking when the Farstriders would relieve them. A line soldier with a dented shield tried to teach them how to brace in the time it took officers to argue over which gate had fallen.

Then the southern sky opened.

Ban'dinoriel collapsed in sheets of violet fire. The ward-light poured down the horizon and vanished among the trees. For one breath, every elf in the court stood motionless. The impossible had happened too quickly to understand.

From the walls came a cry taken up by thousands: "The Ranger-General!"

Falanaras was carried south with the company until the city opened before them. Beyond the causeway, the greenwoods churned with undead. Bone wagons rolled beneath the trees. Gargoyles circled above the towers. At the center of the advancing host rode a human in black armor, pale hair streaming behind him, a runeblade shedding mist from its edge.

A blue banner remained upright ahead of the retreating ranger lines, its silver device flashing whenever it caught the failing ward-light. Beneath it, a lone figure loosed arrow after arrow into the Scourge ranks. Distance reduced her to blue, silver, and motion, yet every defender knew the stance.

Sylvanas Windrunner held the road while her people fled past her.

The black rider reached her. Steel flashed once in the failing ward-light. The banner fell.

The scream that followed passed through stone. It began as one woman's agony and spread until it seemed to come from every window, every archway, every open mouth around him. Falanaras dropped his spear and clapped both hands over his ears. The sound remained inside his skull.

Something translucent rose above the road, hair and torn robes streaming in air that did not touch the living. It twisted toward the human prince. Chains of dark magic pulled it back.

The line soldier struck Falanaras between the shoulders. "Spear!"

He snatched it from the paving stones as the first ghouls reached them.

The vintner died without raising his weapon. A ghoul struck him in the chest and folded him over backward. The creature came on with its jaw hanging loose, fingers worn to hooked bone. Falanaras braced too high. The spearpoint skidded across a collarbone and buried itself in the dead elf's throat.

Rot flooded his mouth and nose. The ghoul clawed its way down the shaft. He shoved until his palms tore, felt the point catch against the spine, and kept shoving after the body stopped moving.

When he looked up, half the company was gone. The remainder fled east through streets filled with smoke and the beating wings of gargoyles, searching for a side gate the Scourge had not reached. No officer called them cowards. No officer remained.

* * *

He ran with them for three streets before he remembered his father.

The retreat bent east toward the side gates. House Dawnspear lay west, beyond a district already burning. The western approaches had been overrun, and no organized line remained between the estate and the Scourge. Falanaras slowed at the crossing. A woman seized his sleeve and begged him to help lift her son onto a cart. He did. When the cart moved on, he turned away from the refugees and went home.

He told himself the estate might still be secure. His father might be leading the servants toward safety. He might find the courtyard empty and feel foolish for disobeying the retreat.

The western district answered each hope as he reached it. A dragonhawk lay dying beneath a collapsed balcony, its jeweled tack fused into blackened flesh. Frost coated walls untouched by the morning sun. The fountains ran pink. Along the avenue, corpses had been arranged on their knees by some passing necromancer, faces turned toward the city center.

House Dawnspear's gates stood open.

One leaf had been torn from its hinges. The bronze sunburst above it hung upside down. Falanaras stepped through with the spear lowered and called for his father. His voice carried across the courtyard, entered the house, and returned unanswered.

The first servant lay in the entrance hall. The second had died near the stairs with a kitchen knife still clenched in both hands. Falanaras knew their names. He could not make himself speak them.

Aelrindor sat against the doors of the family solar. His cuirass had been split below the ribs. Blood soaked the

formal sash beneath it and spread over the floor in a dark fan. Three ghouls lay within reach of his ceremonial sword. The blade had broken a handspan above the guard.

Falanaras knelt and touched two fingers to his father's throat. The skin was cool. Aelrindor's eyes remained open, fixed on the ruined doorway as if the next attacker had merely kept him waiting.

There should have been grief. Instead, Falanaras noticed that his father's left boot was unlaced. Aelrindor had lectured him for that exact fault when he was ten. The small disorder horrified him more than the wound.

Something scraped in the solar.

A dead retainer lurched through the doors. One side of his face had been eaten away. Falanaras knew him as Beloran, who had taught both Dawnspear sons to ride and had once carried Falanaras home after a fall. The corpse opened its remaining eye and raised a hatchet.

Falanaras backed into the wall. His spear struck a cabinet and tangled in its carved legs. Beloran swung. The hatchet split the panel beside his head, spraying lacquered wood across his cheek.

A shield rim smashed into the corpse's temple. The second blow broke its neck. A broad-shouldered soldier stepped over the body, drove his sword down through its skull, and wrenched the blade free with both hands.

"Are you bitten?" he demanded.

Falanaras stared at him.

The soldier grabbed his jaw and turned his head toward the light. He had a square face, blood on one eyebrow, and the flat patience of a man accustomed to asking urgent questions of fools. "Bitten."

"No."

“Good. I dislike carrying strangers.” He released him.
“Theron Brightshield.”

“Falanaras Dawnspear.”

Theron glanced at Aelrindor, then at the family crest above the solar doors. His expression changed without softening.
“I’m sorry.”

The words reached Falanaras from a great distance. “I have to bury him.”

“You have to leave.”

“This is my house.”

Theron looked around the broken hall. “Then remember where it is.”

A crash sounded in the courtyard, followed by the wet cries of ghouls. Theron caught Falanaras by the arm and pulled him upright. Falanaras resisted once. Theron struck him across the face.

“You may hate me outside,” he said.

Falanaras left his father sitting guard over a dead house.

* * *

Theron took him through service alleys and walled gardens, avoiding the broad avenues where abominations dragged chains between their swollen hands. The city had become a set of brief decisions: which doorway concealed breathing, which shadow moved against the wind, which cries could still be answered.

They found organized resistance near a bridge choked with refugees. A dozen soldiers held the southern approach behind a wall of overturned carts. Their commander wore blue-and-silver spellbreaker plate and carried a crescent glaive in one hand. Scourge magic struck the shield on his other arm in ropes of green fire. The runes around its rim divided the hostile current and shed it into the paving stones without letting the spell take hold. Rynel answered

with a short, flat cast of his glaive. The blade crossed the carts, cut the necromancer's raised arm, and tore power out through the wound. Green fire burst from the caster's mouth as the loss became injury. The glaive curved back into Rynel's hand.

"Brightshield," the captain called. "You are late."

"I found a nobleman."

The captain's gaze moved over Falanaras's torn court coat, bloody spear, and empty scabbard. "Did you find the useful part?"

"Uncertain."

"We will test it." The captain pointed his glaive toward the carts. "Rynel Starweaver. Hold that gap. If anything dead crosses it, inconvenience it."

Falanaras took his place beside Theron. His hands had stiffened around the spear. Blood from his split palms made the shaft slick, and his father's body waited behind him with every step he had taken away. He wanted to turn back. He wanted an officer to forbid it so that obedience could bear the blame.

A ranger dropped from the roof above them and landed badly. One knee struck the stones. Her red-gold hair had come loose from its braids, and black blood streaked one cheek. She carried a bow with three arrows remaining.

Rynel caught her before she fell. "Report."

She stared south. "The Ranger-General is dead."

No one answered. The scream still lived behind Falanaras's eyes.

The ranger swallowed. "He raised her. She was with them when the line broke."

One of the soldiers cursed her for lying. The ranger crossed the space between them and struck him with her bow. "I watched her kill Taliren," she said. Her voice

remained low, which made the words worse. “She begged us to run before he made her do it.”

Rynel took the bow from her hands before she could strike again. “Your name.”

“Lethira Valeflame.”

He passed her a dead soldier’s quiver. “Valeflame, grieve while shooting. We move when the last cart crosses.”

The next assault came under a rain of burning pitch. Ghouls climbed over the barricade. Skeletal archers fired from balconies already occupied by the Scourge. Lethira’s first arrow took an eye socket. Theron held the gap with shield and shoulder, giving Falanaras room to thrust.

He learned to aim beneath the chin. He learned that a spear trapped in ribs had to be twisted before it could be pulled free. He learned that the Scourge pressed forward without anger, and that their silence between blows was harder to bear than any battle cry.

A necromancer appeared at the far end of the bridge. Frost gathered around his raised hands. Rynel advanced alone. He turned his shield into the spell. The runes resisted the freezing command and divided the impact across his armor, though the force still drove him back a step. His glaive left his hand in a hard, flat cast. The blade cut through the necromancer’s forearm and tore power out through the wound. Cold burst inside the caster as the magical loss became injury; his legs locked beneath him. Lethira’s arrow finished him. The glaive curved back into Rynel’s hand.

Falanaras stared one breath too long.

Rynel drove his glaive through a ghoul reaching for him. “Admire it after we live.”

The last refugee cart crossed. Rynel ordered the bridge supports destroyed and led the survivors east before the dust settled. They numbered twenty-three. By the next side gate

they were eighteen. No one asked whether the city could still be held.

* * *

The eastern inner gate had become a hospital because its walls still stood.

The wounded lay beneath archways and between the feet of statues. Priests moved through them in white and silver vestments darkened by soot. Their prayers competed with the groans, the shouted names of missing children, and the steady impact of the Scourge against the southern doors. Light flared wherever a healer knelt, brief islands of warmth in the smoke.

Rynel's survivors were directed to the eastern wall while the refugees passed through. Falanaras tried to follow. His fingers would no longer close around the spear.

"Sit," Theron said.

"I'm able."

Theron pressed one thumb into his torn palm. Falanaras nearly dropped to his knees.

"Remarkably able," Lethira said. She had found enough water to wash the black blood from her face. Nothing had removed the vacancy from her eyes.

They pushed him toward the healers. A novice wrapped his hands, apologized for the shortage of salve, and left when someone began choking nearby. Falanaras sat against the wall. Through the gates he could see Silvermoon burning by districts, each blaze reflected in the blue crystal windows of the next.

A child cried out from the center of the hall. Her mother had been pinned beneath a fallen beam, and the soldiers lifting it could not move fast enough. A priestess in torn white robes knelt beside them. Her hair, bright as burnished

copper under the gate lamps, had been tied back with a strip cut from her own sleeve.

Falanaras knew High Priestess Liadrin by reputation. House Dawnspear had attended ceremonies where she stood near the Sunstrider dais, distant and immaculate beneath the temple vaults. The woman on the floor had blood to both elbows. One side of her face was blistered. When she called upon the Light, her voice broke on the prayer.

Gold flooded the space beneath the beam. The trapped woman arched with a cry as crushed flesh drew together. Liadrin shook under the effort. She kept one hand over the wound and reached blindly for the child with the other.

“Look at me,” she told the girl. “Keep your eyes here. The Light has not abandoned this place.”

The child clung to her wrist. Liadrin did not pull away, even after the soldiers freed the mother and carried her toward the eastern gate.

An armored messenger forced his way through the wounded. “High Priestess. The king is withdrawing to Quel’Danas. Every healer who can ride is ordered north.”

Liadrin looked toward the sealed doors as another blow shook dust from the arch. Fatigue hollowed her expression. Faith held beneath it, fierce enough to resemble anger.

She placed the child’s hand in a novice’s keeping and rose. “Then find me a hawkstrider.”

As she passed, her gaze caught on Falanaras’s bandaged hands. “Can you still hold a weapon?”

He closed his fingers and lied. “Yes.”

“Good. Hold long enough for someone else to pass you.” She touched two fingers to his brow. Warmth moved through him, slight and immediate. “Then pass yourself.”

The Light vanished when she turned away. Falanaras watched her go through the eastern arch toward the stables,

carrying only a bloodstained staff and the certainty that the Light still listened.

He would remember that certainty long after he learned what had become of it.

The southern doors split before Liadrin's hawkstrider cleared the gate.

Rynel's voice rose over the first rush of dead. "All wounded who can walk, east through the side gate. Those who cannot, carry them. Valeflame, roofs. Brightshield, with me. Dawnspear—"

Falanaras picked up his spear.

"—try to remain useful."

* * *

They escaped Silvermoon through an eastern side gate while the city died behind them.

Rynel led them along an irrigation road toward a rise overlooking the coast. Refugees moved among the orchards in broken columns. Some carried silver caskets from family shrines. Others carried nothing. Above the trees, Silvermoon's tallest spires burned from within, blue crystal turning white before it burst.

The Scourge did not stop at the capital. Their main host drove north toward Quel'Danas, trampling gardens, villas, and bodies into one broad road of decay. The island lay beyond the strait beneath a sky crowded with smoke. Elven ships burned near its piers. Among the defenders, one blue banner still flew, its silver phoenix marking the Sunstrider line.

"The king," someone whispered.

Falanaras had seen Anasterian Sunstrider only during public rites, an ancient figure beneath layers of blue and silver. On the island he was too distant to distinguish from the guard around him. The royal blade announced him instead.

Fire leapt high over the Scourge ranks each time Felo'melorn struck, bright enough to be seen across the water.

The refugees on the rise began to cheer. The sound was ragged, almost embarrassed at first. It grew as the fire advanced. Falanaras joined them. For several breaths, the king was the kingdom, and the kingdom still fought.

A line of blue-white frost crossed the island.

Felo'melorn's flame vanished. The phoenix banner dipped into the mass of dead and did not rise again.

The cheering ended. Lethira lowered her bow. Theron removed his helmet, though no prayer was spoken. Rynel kept watching the island with his glaive braced against the ground.

"Captain," Theron said quietly. "What do we do?"

Rynel looked over the refugees: children with burned faces, magistrates holding kitchen knives, soldiers who had thrown away shields to carry the wounded. "We prevent the Scourge from reaching this hill."

It was too small an answer for a fallen king. It was the only answer anyone had.

They built a defense from orchard walls and abandoned wagons. Falanaras stood between Theron and a woman who had lost two fingers. Lethira climbed an apple tree blackened by passing necromancy. Rynel paced the line, correcting grips and moving the most frightened defenders away from the center.

The expected attack never came.

On Quel'Danas, darkness gathered above the Sunwell. It rose in a column shot through with green and violet fire. The pressure within Falanaras deepened. The sacred current that had touched every day of his life drew taut, strained by a force on the other side of the water.

Then something entered it.

Cold poured through Falanaras without touching his skin. He tasted grave soil. His heart lurched into a rhythm that belonged to another body, slowed, and stopped for one impossible beat. Around him, elves cried out and fell. Lethira dropped from the tree. Theron caught the wall with both hands. Even Rynel bent beneath the violation.

The Sunwell remained. Falanaras could still feel it, vast and intimate. Its radiance had been fouled. Necromantic power moved through the old current, carrying whispers in a language that dragged at the dead. The corruption reached into every elf on the hill because the Sunwell had always reached them. There was nowhere inside himself to close a door against it.

On the island, the column burst outward. A figure rose within it, tall and skeletal, robes streaming around a body remade by death. The Scourge answered with a roar that rolled across the strait.

Falanaras vomited beside the wall. When he could breathe again, he found Theron kneeling near him. Blood ran from Theron's nose. Lethira sat with both arms wrapped around herself, staring toward Quel'Danas.

"What did he do?" she asked.

No one knew enough to answer.

The black-armored prince left the island before nightfall. His army turned south along the road it had carved through Quel'Thalas. From the hill, the survivors watched ranks of undead pass beneath Silvermoon's ruined towers, carrying their new lich toward another war. Scourge detachments remained in the forests and among the fallen, but the great host did not look back.

The living were left with the kingdom he had finished using.

* * *

For three days, survival consisted of counting.

They counted the wounded who needed water, the bodies that had to be burned before necromancers found them, the arrows left in ranger quivers, the streets passable beneath fallen masonry. They counted families at the refugee camps and stopped asking why so few names received answers. Smoke concealed the sun. The corrupted pulse of the Sunwell lingered beneath every task, faint at times, suddenly nauseating at others.

Rynel made soldiers of whoever continued reporting to him. Theron organized water parties. Lethira ranged the eastern woods and returned each evening with fewer arrows and no conversation. Falanaras carried stretchers until his palms bled through Liadrin's bandages, then wrapped them again and carried more.

On the fourth morning, Rynel found him preparing to enter Silvermoon alone.

"House Dawnspear," Falanaras said before the captain could ask. "My father is there."

Rynel studied him. "Dead?"

"Yes."

"Then he can wait another hour." Rynel called to Theron for shovels and to Lethira for a route through the western quarter. "No one enters alone."

They returned as four.

House Dawnspear had burned during their absence. The solar roof had collapsed, but Aelrindor remained where Falanaras had left him. They carried him into the courtyard on a torn door. Theron and Rynel dug beneath an old silverwood whose leaves had shriveled in the Sunwell's corruption. Lethira searched the surrounding houses for other dead who still had someone to name them.

Falanaras removed the broken ceremonial sword from his father's hand. He considered taking it. The weapon had never been meant for war, and war had already judged it. He laid it over Aelrindor's chest instead.

He spoke the Dawnspear funerary blessing. Halfway through, the words escaped him. Theron supplied the next line. His pronunciation was poor. Falanaras finished with him anyway.

When the grave was closed, Rynel waited beside it while Theron and Lethira moved to the gate.

"You were conscripted for the emergency," the captain said. "The authority that issued the order may no longer exist. You can remain with the refugee camp as a civilian."

Falanaras looked at the house. Its open windows showed fire-blackened rooms, each stripped of purpose. His father lay beneath the tree. Caelir remained somewhere beyond the ruined kingdom, alive if fortune had spared him. Everything Falanaras possessed could be carried on his body, and most of it had belonged to dead soldiers.

At the gate, Theron pretended not to listen. Lethira made no such effort.

"If I remain," Falanaras said, "will you train me?"

"Your spear work is terrible."

"I had noticed."

"Your discipline is worse. You abandoned a retreat order, nearly died in a private residence, and required Brightshield to retrieve you."

Falanaras accepted each charge. "Will you train me?"

Rynel's gaze settled on the fresh grave. "All of that can be trained. The desire to remain cannot."

He drew himself upright despite the dried blood between the plates of his armor. "Swear that you will serve

Quel'Thalas, obey commands, and place the survival of its people before all else."

The old words had belonged to soldiers of an unbroken kingdom. Here they sounded stripped of ceremony. No witnesses stood in polished ranks. No trumpets answered. Smoke moved through the branches above Aelrindor's grave.

Falanaras thought of the woman who had begged him to lift her son, of Liadrin holding a child's hand, of Anasterian's fire dying across the water. He thought of his father telling him to run if the choice came.

The choice had come. It had led him back to the dead. He wanted another.

"I swear."

Rynel offered his forearm. Falanaras clasped it with both bandaged hands.

"Report at dawn," the captain said.

"Where?"

Rynel looked beyond the ruined gate toward the smoke over Silvermoon. "Wherever there are still living people."

They left House Dawnspear together. Falanaras did not look back again. Ahead, the wounded waited for water, the dead waited for fire, and the survivors had begun the work of finding one another.

CHAPTER TWO

Hunger in the Ashes

The mana wyrm struck at Falanaras's wrist with all the spite of a hooked fish. He caught it behind the skull before its teeth found him, felt its narrow body twist through his grip, and drew a measured thread of power through the contact.

The creature shone blue-white beneath dark scales, its finned crest flattened and the long feelers beneath its jaw lashing at the chill air. The first pull tasted of rain striking metal. The second carried the thin sweetness of fruit left too long in sun. By the third, the tremor in his left hand eased. Falanaras stopped before relief could become pleasure and released the wyrm into the brass-ringed cage at his feet.

Captain Rynel Starweaver watched from the edge of the drill court. He wore no helmet, though the rest of the spellbreaker company had theirs on. Silver had entered the black of his hair since the war. His red-and-gold armor had been repaired so often that the plates no longer matched, yet he still stood inside it as if it had been forged around him. "Again," he said.

Falanaras closed the cage and reached for his practice shield. Across the court, Theron Brightshield was trying to keep a second wyrm from winding its long feelers around his gauntlet. Lethira Valeflame leaned against the wall with her bow unstrung, laughing without sound while he swore at it. The laugh had become rarer since Silvermoon fell. Falanaras was glad to hear it, even at Theron's expense.

"The point is to feed without fighting it," Rynel told Theron. "If a wyrm has outmaneuvered you, it has learned more from the exercise than you have."

Theron finally peeled the creature from his cuff. “Then it may apply for a commission.”

A few recruits smiled. Rynel did not, but the corner of his mouth relaxed before he turned to Falanaras. “Ward stance.”

Falanaras raised the shield. Rynel sent a narrow bolt of force at him. The spell hit the rim, slid along the etched runes, and burst against the paving stones in a shower of cold sparks without taking hold. Before the recoil left Falanaras’s shoulder, a brass practice ward unfolded beside Rynel and cast bands of blue force around Theron’s ankles. A second current hardened the ward’s thin legs against attack. Falanaras caught the binding on the hook of his glaive, peeled it from Theron, and laid it across the ward instead. In the same turn he stripped away the strengthening current and sent it around Theron’s armor, where blue light settled into the joints. The ward strained against its own restraint and tried to fire again. Falanaras found the command inside the conjuration, closed his will around that simpler purpose, and turned its crystal eye toward the straw target at the edge of the court. Its next bolt struck where he directed.

“Better,” the captain said. “You resisted what was meant to alter you. You moved completed workings instead of wasting strength making new ones. You took the ward because it is a made thing with a command simple enough to seize. Do not mistake that for command over a living caster.” He glanced at the caged wyrm. “And you drew before you began. That is the order. If feeding becomes the purpose rather than preparation, you become dangerous to the people behind you.”

No one mentioned the Wretched. They did not need to. The word occupied the court whenever a recruit held a wyrm too tightly or stared too long at the glow in another soldier’s palm. Rynel had begun every morning of the past

month by making them feed under supervision. He claimed it was training. It was also inspection. He looked at their hands, their pupils, the tension around their mouths, and he remembered who had needed a second turn at the cages.

Before the Scourge, Falanaras had never imagined that a captain would need to know such things. Hunger had belonged to bad harvests, distant villages, and the poorer alleys of Murder Row. It had never belonged to Silvermoon itself. The Sunwell had filled the kingdom so completely that its abundance had passed unnoticed, as air did until it left the lungs.

Nor had the seasons seemed worthy of gratitude. Before the invasion, Eversong Woods had known only its enchanted spring: boughs green above the roads, blossom scent in the air, rain that came without winter's teeth. When Arthas broke the runestone network, winter entered Quel'Thalas for the first time in living memory. Frost sealed the irrigation channels. Snow burdened roofs already split by siege, and survivors burned carved furniture to keep the refugee halls warm. The magisters restored enough of the runestones before the next winter to wake the old enchantment. Now undamaged groves flowered again while the Dead Scar kept its own chill. Falanaras noticed that recovered gentleness. Before the fall, he had mistaken it for permanence.

Rynel dismissed the company at midday with orders to report for city readiness duty. Falanaras retrieved his sword belt and found Lethira waiting beneath the cracked archway that led from the court. Her hair was braided tight for patrol, and a fresh scar ran beneath her left jaw. He had known her long enough to understand that asking after it would earn him a look sharp enough to draw blood.

"Your hand is steady," she said instead.

“It was steady before.”

“Of course. And I have never missed a target.” She handed him a folded duty slate. “Feeding-house count at the Sunfury market, then a report from Murder Row. Rynel is sending the three of us because he finds our company soothing.”

Theron joined them with his helmet tucked under one arm. “He finds us expendable enough for a tedious assignment and competent enough to come back with a count.”

“That is the nearest he comes to affection,” Lethira said.

They crossed a city busy with the work of pretending it had survived intact. Masons floated pale blocks into the broken flank of a tower. Artificers knelt beside severed conduits, testing new ward-lines that glimmered briefly and failed. Merchants called from temporary stalls beneath silk awnings that hid scorched façades. Everywhere, workers had found uses for materials once saved for beauty: shattered crystal ground into mortar, brass railings hammered into braces, fragments of noble statuary stacked around open foundations.

At the market’s eastern end stood one of the new feeding houses. Its doors were copper, its windows clouded ward-glass, and two city guards kept the queue in a single line beneath the awning. Within, a fel crystal taller than a man burned green behind warding braces. Falanaras could not see its core clearly through the glass, only shadows stirring in the light and the slow pulse drawn out through silver conduits.

Those waiting did not speak of hunger. A woman in a mason’s apron asked the man behind her whether his hands had stopped cramping. An old clerk offered his place to a boy whose eyes had begun to unfocus. A young magister in red robes checked each token and wrote the time of every draw into a ledger. The language was orderly: maintenance,

allotment, recovery. Everyone understood the other word waiting beneath it.

Falanaras had taken his first sanctioned draught of fel beneath such a roof. He remembered the shock more clearly than many things from that first year: fierce heat racing up his arm, the sensation of a locked door in his chest thrown wide, the immediate shame of wanting more. In the months that followed, green began to ring the blue of his irises, as it did in nearly everyone living among the city's new crystals and wards. The healer had told him not to stare into the washbasin. Everyone did, eventually.

Small crystals still had their uses. The magisters recharged them before patrols, set them into field kits, and rationed them to sentries posted beyond the city. But a shard carried only a brief reserve, enough to steady a soldier until he reached a source or found a mana wyrm. The wyrms were everywhere now: tethered in markets, kept in barracks cages, carried by rangers in padded tubes. Rommath's lesson had made them part of daily life. A blood elf who could not learn to tap a living current could not reliably serve beyond a warded street.

Rommath had returned again from Outland after Kael'thas departed, carrying methods learned in Illidan's service and no patience for anyone who called them undignified. He had taught the magisters first, then soldiers, then wardens and labor crews. Find the current. Establish the hold. Draw only what was needed. Release before appetite became command. Falanaras had heard some older nobles call the practice degradation. He had seen most of them in the feeding-house line before the month was out.

Theron checked the house's posted count, the guard roster, and the charge of the emergency shards secured behind the counter. Lethira questioned the handler tending a cluster of

mana wyrms in a shaded pen. Falanaras copied the figures to the slate. It was dull work, which was why he noticed the silence gathering at the far end of the market.

A courier had stopped beside a public noticeboard. Dust whitened his boots to the knee. He held a packet bearing the regent's seal, and the people near him watched with the fixed stillness of those who had taught themselves that news could only mean more names to mourn. An officer took the packet inside the market office. The courier mounted again without speaking. The crowd dispersed slowly, ashamed of having hoped for a message meant for them.

"No word from the prince," Theron said quietly once they had moved on.

"There has not been for months," Lethira replied. "That does not stop people from reading every sealed page as if he has remembered the road home."

Falanaras understood the waiting, though he distrusted it. Kael'thas had returned after the Scourge withdrew, pale with exhaustion and still bearing the authority of a prince his people had needed desperately. He had gone with Rommath and Astalor Bloodsworn to the corrupted Sunwell and destroyed what Arthas had poisoned. The loss left every survivor reeling, yet few who had felt the necromancy inside that sacred current called the decision wrong. Then Kael'thas gathered them beneath broken banners, named them sin'dorei—the children of the blood—and promised that Quel'Thalas would endure.

The prince had kept moving after that. Stories reached Silvermoon in fragments: Garithos sending blood elf soldiers on missions meant to kill them, then condemning them when naga aid kept them alive; Kael'thas choosing Lady Vashj's help over the judgment of men who had abandoned his people. Later came Illidan Stormrage,

Outland, and the promise that somewhere beyond the world's familiar borders there was power enough to answer what Quel'thalas had lost. By the time Rommath returned with his grim practical knowledge, Kael'thas had been gone many months.

"The regent sends couriers," Theron said. "The prince sends legends."

Lethira glanced toward the market office. "One keeps roofs over people. The other lets them imagine a better roof someday."

Their second assignment took them southwest toward Murder Row. Beyond the market, the rebuilt avenues narrowed and the repairs grew more provisional. Roofs sagged under patched tile. Shop windows were shuttered against daylight. Green light leaked beneath doors in thin, wavering bands. The feeding houses there were smaller, their ward-glass scratched and their guards paid enough to look away from certain transactions.

The route passed Dawnstar Terrace, where a relay housing stood open beneath a canvas awning. Rain from the previous night had found the gaps in unfinished paving and flooded the conduit trench. The old network had once hidden such workings beneath finished stone and effortless abundance. Now every repair exposed another dependency.

A work crew had gathered around the broken relay. The stone lay split open on the pavement, its interior runes blackened by damp. Two magisters stood knee-deep in a trench of runoff, arguing over a replacement conduit. A woman with plaster in her hair knelt beside a boy who was holding the end of a copper line above the water with both hands. His arms shook with the effort.

"That line should be grounded," Theron said.

One of the magisters looked up, ready to take offense, then saw the spellbreaker insignia on Theron's shoulder. "It was grounded. The lower contact failed."

"And you have a child holding it over floodwater because?" Lethira asked.

"Because he is the only one here whose hands are small enough to reach behind the stone." The magister said it defensively, then glanced at the boy and lowered his voice. "And because the wards on the western end will fail by nightfall if we do not reconnect it."

Falanaras set down the duty slate and waded into the trench. Water soaked through his boots at once, cold enough to make his teeth ache. He took the copper line from the boy. A weak charge crawled through the metal into his palm—a loose current with nowhere to ground. He set his shield between the line and the flooded stone, caught the spill in the runes, and guided it away from the workers.

"Now," he said.

The smaller magister reached into the fractured housing and fitted the contact home. For a moment nothing happened. Then the conduit flared with pale gold. The street lamps on the terrace kindled in a chain, one after another, their reflected light trembling across the water. A few people standing beneath nearby awnings applauded before remembering themselves.

The boy stared at Falanaras's shield. "Did you take it from the line?"

"Only enough to keep it from taking you," Falanaras said.

The answer seemed to matter to the child. He looked from the restored lamps to the magister, who had begun speaking rapidly about replacement housings and drainage stone. His mother caught his shoulder and drew him away from the trench. Before she left, she pressed two fingers to her brow

in the old formal gesture of thanks. Her eyes were green at the edges. So were the boy's.

Lethira waited until they were clear of the water. "You enjoyed that."

"I enjoyed not watching a child get thrown through a wall."

"You know what I mean."

He did. Capturing a spell before it broke, feeling it pass through the shield's runes and answer his hands, still carried a fierce clarity. Rynel's warning returned: use the work after you feed. Do not feed for the feeling of work. Falanaras had followed the order. He knew that. Yet he could not deny the brief lift inside him when the lamps came alive.

Theron walked between them, carrying the soaked duty slate under his cloak. "Rynel would say that enjoying competence is permitted. He would then give a speech about the difference between competence and appetite."

"A very long speech," Lethira said.

"It would be concise," Theron said. "We would simply have to listen to it repeatedly for the rest of our lives."

They found the wardens outside an abandoned dye shop with weapons drawn toward the lane. A man in a torn clerk's coat stood beneath a shuttered window, bent almost double. Green light crawled over his fingers. At his feet lay an overturned carrier cage and a mana wyrm that thrashed against the stones, its finned crest flared and its jaw-feelers snapping at empty air.

"How long?" Theron asked.

"He came out of the shop asking for a source," one warden said. "Then he took the wyrm from a handler. He has already drained two lamp crystals."

The man's head lifted. Falanaras knew him then: a copyist named Varis, who had once sat at the district office's outer desk with ink beneath his nails and a patient contempt for

soldiers who misplaced their forms. The likeness had become difficult to hold. His face had drawn tight over his bones; his ears seemed too sharp for it, his mouth too pale and slack. Green fire leaked between the fingers he kept curled against his chest, but his eyes were a feverish, unfixed yellow.

“Varis,” Falanaras said. “Look at me. Release the wyrm.”

Varis answered with a sound that might once have been his name. Power tore through the lane. The wyrm’s blue-white light collapsed into his hand. He flung out his other arm, and the nearest ward-lamp guttered black. A second lamp failed across the street. Windows above them flashed as he reached for every loose thread of magic he could feel.

“Clear the houses,” Lethira said. Her first arrow struck the wall beside Varis’s shoulder, turning him away from the feeding house at the corner. Theron moved between the man and the wardens, shield raised. Falanaras caught the spill of stolen power in his own runes before it could lash back through the street.

Varis saw the restraint on the feeding house’s copper doors. He lunged for it. Theron met him shoulder-first. The impact drove them both into the lane, but Varis clawed at the shield rim, not trying to strike Theron so much as to pull through him toward the bound fire beyond the ward-glass.

Falanaras hooked Varis’s wrist with the rim of his own shield and forced the siphon away from the doors. The contact burned. For one instant he felt the frantic emptiness inside the other man: no thought of food, family, or pain, only the next current and the next and the next. It frightened him more than any blow.

Varis tore free with a strength his narrow body should not have held. He seized a warden’s field crystal from his belt and emptied it in a breath. The warden stumbled back,

staring at the dead shard. Lethira's second arrow cut Varis across the forearm. He did not seem to feel it.

"Pin him," Theron said.

They moved together. Theron drove Varis backward with the shield. Lethira put an arrow through the sleeve of his coat and into the dye shop's signpost, catching the fabric before he could reach another lamp. Falanaras stepped inside the arc of Varis's flailing hands, struck the man behind the knee, and brought him down hard on the stones.

Varis bucked beneath them, dragging at the ward-lamps even as Theron bound his wrists. One lamp flickered. Falanaras planted his shield over the man's hands and grounded the last of the siphon into the paving. The crackle faded. Varis went still so suddenly that Falanaras feared he had killed him.

Then Varis began to weep. He stared at the blood on his forearm, the dead field crystal, the exhausted wyrm curled in the gutter. Recognition returned in fragments, and terror arrived with it.

"Get a restraint wagon," Falanaras told the wardens. "Take him to the district holding rooms. Put him under dampening wards before dark."

One warden looked from Varis to the darkened lamps. "And if he turns again before the gate?"

Falanaras looked at Varis, who was weeping soundlessly into the stones. "Then you stop him. Do not make the street pay for your hesitation."

Lethira retrieved the exhausted wyrm with a cloth and placed it gently in the carrier cage. "You will have to explain the lamps, the crystal, the arrow, and why you left him breathing," Theron said as the wardens called for the wagon.

At the district office, they learned that the courier's packet had carried revised allotment figures and nothing

from Outland. The regent's council had shifted two feeding-house crystals from the northern quarter to clinics near the western gates. The clerk delivering the news spoke in a careful, level voice. His fingers shook against the paper.

"Lor'themar is holding the city together with ledgers," Lethira said once they were outside.

"Ledgers, patrols, and men who do not sleep," Theron said.

Falanaras had seen the regent lord only twice since the fall, both times from the edge of a crowd. Lor'themar had none of Kael'thas's brightness, none of the old royal distance that allowed strangers to place their hopes upon him. He looked like a ranger who had been handed too many reports and had resolved to read every one. It was a lesser kind of comfort, perhaps. It was still comfort.

They made their final report at dusk. Rynel listened without interrupting, one hand resting on the table in the barracks office. When Lethira reached the spent field crystal, he wrote an authorization for its replacement and pushed it toward the quartermaster.

Rynel folded his hands over the report. "The wardens will decide whether he can be confined. You gave them that choice instead of killing him in the lane. That is all."

Lethira's brow lifted. "You find us soothing after all."

"I find you expensive," Rynel said. "Go eat."

Rynel kept Falanaras after the others had left the office. The barracks had settled into evening noise beyond the open door: bowls striking tables, boots on stairs, somebody attempting a song two rooms away and being told to stop. The captain turned the day's report so that the lamp lit the columns of numbers. Feeding-house attendance. Wyrm losses. Restraint orders. Patrol requests. The pages looked harmless until Falanaras remembered Varis weeping in the gutter.

“Your draw this morning,” Rynel said. “How much?”

“Three measures.”

“And at the relay?”

“I redirected a spill. I did not feed from it.”

“Good.” Rynel did not look up from the report. “You wanted to.”

Falanaras felt the old instinct to deny it rise before he could stop it. The captain had not accused him. That made lying feel smaller. “For a moment.”

“Then you recognized it and did not.” Rynel marked something in the margin. “That is not failure. Do not make the mistake of believing the wish is proof that you are already lost. The mistake is making a home for it.”

Falanaras looked at the column headed CONDITION. Beside each name, Rynel had used the same clipped terms: stable, watch, restricted. No one in the company was marked unfit. Not yet.

“What is my condition?” he asked.

Rynel’s eyes lifted at last. “Capable of asking. Keep it that way.”

Later, Falanaras sat alone on the barracks steps while the last light drained from the repaired towers. In the distance, the Dead Scar remained a dark wound through the land, visible from the city’s higher streets when the weather was clear. It marked the road Arthas had cut north to Quel’Danas and followed south again when Quel’Thalas was finished. In the first months after the invasion, survivors and scattered messengers had learned that he reached Dalaran and destroyed that city as well. Each account differed in its details. None offered a reason to hope.

Caelir had been there when the war began. Falanaras had sent inquiries wherever a courier might carry them: to

Dalaran's surviving registries, to Alliance ports, to names in his brother's old correspondence. At first he had written often, then less often, then only when a new list arrived. No answer had ever come. He had no grave to visit, no body to burn, no final witness who could tell him that Caelir had suffered or been spared. Absence became its own dull discipline.

Theron came out carrying three bowls of stew. He handed one over and sat beside him. Lethira followed with a cage containing a sleeping mana wyrm, its light a quiet blue between the bars.

"You are staring down the road again," Theron said.

"I was thinking of Caelir."

Neither of them offered him a false answer. That was one of the reasons he loved them.

After a time, Lethira said, "If he is alive, he will hear that Silvermoon still stands."

Falanaras watched the blue glow of the wyrm. "He may not recognize what it has become."

"Then he will have to learn," Theron said. "We all did."

Above them, the evening ward-lamps kindled one by one along the avenue. Their light was weaker than the old city radiance, uneven where the repairs had not yet met, but it reached across the stones. Falanaras ate his stew and felt the day's measured draw settle inside him. The hunger remained. It would be there when he woke, and the wyrm cage would wait in the drill court, and someone in Murder Row would need more than the city could give.

Yet Silvermoon stood. Lor'themar held its daily burdens. Kael'thas remained somewhere beyond the sea, distant enough to become hope in the mouths of strangers. Rynel kept teaching soldiers to take what they needed and stop. For the moment, Falanaras could do the same. He set down

the empty bowl, reached through the cage bars, and let the mana wyrm coil once around his fingers without drawing from it at all.

CHAPTER THREE

The Returning Exiles

The summons came while Falanaras was still sweating from drills.

The training yard behind the garrison barracks was white stone and packed dirt, hemmed by scaffolding where masons were resetting a fallen cornice. Spellbreakers ran forms in pairs, blades turning in short, hard arcs, shields lifting to catch the morning light. Falanaras worked the second rank with a borrowed glaive that was too long for him, his shoulders aching, his breath sharp. Every few minutes a magister's apprentice passed along the line with a floating crystal, green-lit and humming, and men stepped aside to breathe from it, to let the ache behind the eyes ease.

"At ease," the master-at-arms called. "Courtyard duty. Dress ranks."

Falanaras lowered the glaive. Theron beside him rolled his shoulder and muttered, "We've not done courtyard duty in weeks."

"The city's receiving guests," Lethira said from the end of the line. She had been watching the gate street. "High elves. By sea," she added, quieter. "Two ships put in south of the city. They came up the coast road on foot."

No one answered at first. The word itself had become unfamiliar in Silvermoon, a name that belonged to letters and memory.

They washed, belted on clean tabards — the new red, darker than blood, stitched with the phoenix — and formed at the Shepherd's Gate, where the road from Eversong entered the inner city. The wind came down the Dead Scar

and carried dust that never quite settled. The gate's guards had polished their armor. Behind them, fel crystals set in braziers burned low and steady along the wall, their light catching in every eye that passed, turning the green there a little brighter.

Silvermoon had learned to look presentable around its wounds. Banners hung straight. Children were kept back from the road. Magisters stood in threes, hands folded, observing. Falanaras took his place with the second rank and felt the familiar pull behind his teeth, the thin restlessness that came before the hour he usually fed. He stared at the crystal in its brazier and then forced his gaze back to the road.

Most came on foot, as if to show they meant no threat.

There were perhaps twenty of them, with two rangers riding as outriders and a train of two wagons behind. The first thing Falanaras saw was the color. Blue. The pale, clear blue of the old Alliance tabard and the silver-white of cloaks kept clean despite the road. The high elves walked with the weary, upright bearing of travelers at the end of a long journey, their faces thin. At their head rode a woman with silver hair bound back, a ranger's bow across her back, and the posture of someone accustomed to being looked to.

Vereesa Windrunner.

The name moved down the line in a whisper. Even the magisters straightened. For a heartbeat the yard forgot the fel light and the hunger and remembered what it had been to hear that name beside Sylvanas and Alleria, when the Windrunners had been a living wall around the kingdom.

Behind her, a little to the left, walked a man in a simple blue cloak over a travel-worn doublet. His hair was the red-gold of House Dawnspear, cut shorter than Falanaras remembered. He had his mother's narrow jaw. He walked with

his hands empty at his sides, as if he did not know what to do with them.

Falanaras' grip tightened on the glaive without his telling it to.

Caelir.

His older brother had been in Dalaran when the Scourge came, studying under the Kirin Tor. The last letter had come long before the fall — more than a year and a half old now, ink smudged, full of lectures and a promise to write again at winter's end — and it said nothing of war or survival, because no war had yet reached him. After Silvermoon fell there had been no more letters at all. Falanaras had written his name twice into the lists of the missing kept at the city registry and had stopped only when Theron told him to stop counting the dead twice.

Caelir was looking at the gate, at the crystals, at the phoenix banners snapping red over white stone. His eyes found the brazier nearest Falanaras and stayed there. The green reflected in his own eyes — his eyes were still blue, clear, untouched — and his mouth thinned.

The column halted. Vereesa dismounted. Lor'themar Theron waited under the arch with Ranger-General Halduron Brightwing and a small escort, his cloak plain, his missing eye hidden in shadow. Lor'themar stepped forward and gave the measured bow of a ruler receiving an honored commander.

"Lady Windrunner," Lor'themar said. His voice carried without shouting. "Quel'Thalas welcomes you home."

Vereesa bowed her head. "Lord Regent. We came as soon as we could. Word reached us late, and the roads out of Dalaran have not been kind." Her Common was crisp; her Thalassian accented the way the diaspora's Thalassian always was, a little

careful. “We brought medicines, linen, some grain. It is not much.”

“It is not small to us,” Lor’themar said. “You will be housed as kin. Enter.”

The guards stepped aside. The high elves passed through the gate, and the line of spellbreakers had to make an aisle for them. Falanaras stood shoulder to shoulder with Theron, eyes forward, and felt Caelir come nearer step by step. The smell of travel — horse, wool, pine soap unlike the perfumed oils used in Silvermoon now — reached him.

Caelir stopped directly before him. The line could not accommodate a private meeting, but no officer ordered them on.

“Falanaras?” Caelir said, quiet.

Falanaras swallowed. “Caelir.”

His brother looked older than Falanaras remembered: lean from months of poor sleep, his Dalaran beard kept short. His gaze dropped to the glaive, the tabard, the bracer on Falanaras’s forearm, then returned to his face.

Caelir lifted a hand as if to touch his shoulder and checked himself. “You’re alive,” he said. His voice broke on the second word, and he forced it steady. “When the ravens stopped, we — I thought —”

“I’m alive,” Falanaras said. It sounded blunt. He tried again. “You are. I did not know.”

Behind Caelir, the rest of the exiles kept moving, but a few had slowed to watch. A woman with dark hair — one of the Dalaran survivors, by her robes — stared at the fel brazier with undisguised alarm. A younger high elf stared at Falanaras’ eyes and then quickly away.

Caelir noticed. His frown settled on the brazier itself, on the way the rank had placed it where every soldier on duty

would breathe it regularly. “What is that?” he asked, too softly for the officers to hear.

“A crystal,” Falanaras said. “For steadiness.”

“It is fel,” Caelir said. It was not a question.

Falanaras did not flinch. He had learned not to. “It is what we have.”

Caelir’s jaw worked. He looked past Falanaras to the city beyond the gate — the scaffolds, the red banners, the thin figures moving in the streets with the quick, efficient steps of people who kept near sources of power. “We heard things in Dalaran,” he said. “That you were — that the city had turned to drawing on — we did not believe it was like this. So open.”

“We do not hide it,” Falanaras said. “Hiding does not help.”

The master-at-arms’ voice cut in, low and firm. “Dawnspear. Let your brother pass inside. You will have leave at evening.”

Falanaras nodded once. Caelir’s hand finally found his forearm, squeezed, and let go. The touch was brief and hot.

“Evening,” Caelir repeated.

“Evening,” Falanaras said.

The exiles continued into the courtyard. Falanaras watched his brother’s cloak move with the others until the gate’s shadow cut it, and the ache behind his eyes came back, louder now.

Leave came at the sixth bell.

Falanaras changed out of the tabard and went to the pilgrim house by the eastern market where the exiles had been quartered. The building had been a clothier’s shop before the Scourge; its upper floor still smelled of cedar and old dye.

Caelir was waiting in the doorway, as if he had been listening for footsteps. He had washed, but he wore the same blue cloak.

“You came,” he said.

“I said I would.”

They stood there a moment too long. Then Caelir stepped forward and embraced him. It was tight and awkward, shoulder to shoulder with no armor between them, and Falanaras felt how thin his brother had become under the cloak, and how quickly his own throat closed.

“You’re taller,” Caelir said into his shoulder, trying to laugh. He pulled back and looked at him. “Or I remember you shorter.”

“You remember correctly. I grew after you left.”

Inside, the pilgrim house’s common room had been cleared for the guests. Bowls of soup steamed on a long table, and a fel crystal in a simple iron stand burned on the mantel, as every mantel in Silvermoon now held one. Its light was low, tended by a matron who kept the house. The high elves sat around it without seeming to know they had leaned away.

A woman — the dark-haired one from the gate — glanced at the crystal and then at Falanaras, and colored. “We are grateful for the lodging,” she said carefully in Thalassian.

“It is bare,” Falanaras said. He did not move the crystal. To move it would have been to make a statement of its own.

Caelir gestured to a bench near the window. “Sit. Tell me —” He stopped, overwhelmed by the size of the question. “Tell me everything. Father — did he —”

“Father is dead,” Falanaras said. He had learned to say it plainly, because hesitation made it worse. “I found him in the house before I fled the western quarter. When the Scourge withdrew, I went back and buried him.”

Caelir closed his eyes. For a long moment his breathing was the only sound. When he opened them they were wet. “And you were alone?”

“Not alone. I was with the retreat through the east gate. Theron — you would not know him — and others. After, I took service. It was the only way to stay.”

Caelir nodded, as if service were natural. He was trying to fit the facts into the brother he had known, the boy who had sulked over calligraphy and loved hawks. “You wear the phoenix now,” he said. “The red.”

“We are sin’dorei,” Falanaras said. The word came easily now, with practice.

Caelir flinched. “Don’t.”

Falanaras looked at him. “It is what we call ourselves.”

“You were quel’dorei when I left,” Caelir said, his voice low. “We were quel’dorei. The name was given for suffering, yes — I understand that. But the change — Fal, do you know what you look like to those who have not been here? Your eyes —” He gestured, helplessly. “The crystals in every house. The way your soldiers breathe them in like air. In Dalaran we heard rumors. Mana-tapping. Keeping live — creatures — for feeding. We thought it was Alliance slander. Vereesa said we should see for ourselves before we judged.”

“And now you have seen,” Falanaras said.

Caelir’s hands were shaking. He clasped them. “I hardly recognize our people,” he said. “Forgive me. I mean no insult to your survival. I cannot understand this as survival. This is alteration.”

The matron came by with a tray. She offered Caelir a small, cut crystal on a porcelain dish, the way one would offer a sweet after a meal. “For the chill, sir,” she murmured. “The house keeps them for guests who feel the draft.”

Caelir stared at the dish. “No,” he said, too loud. “No thank you.”

The matron’s smile stiffened. She offered the dish to Falanaras. He took a shard out of habit, let its faint warmth

touch his palm, then set it back. “Thank you,” he said to her. She left, her jaw tight.

“You see?” Caelir said when she was gone. “You offer it as courtesy. You do not see how it looks.”

“I see,” Falanaras said. “I live here.”

The room had gone quiet. Other high elves were listening without staring. Falanaras felt the heat rise in his neck, the old defensiveness that came whenever someone who had not been in the city judged it.

Caelir leaned forward, earnest. “Come back with us. Or come to Dalaran, at least. There are magisters among us studying the hunger. We share what stores remain and use disciplines that ease the withdrawal. You would not need to —”

“Without what?” Falanaras asked. “Without living here?”

“Without fel,” Caelir whispered.

Falanaras looked at the crystal on the mantel. It burned steady and green, and in its light the room’s white stone seemed less white. He thought of Murder Row at night, of the Wretched he had helped drag from a cellar last week, jaw slack, eyes blind with craving. He thought of the way his own hands steadied after a controlled draw, and how shameful it was to need that steadiness.

“You should see more of the city before you ask me that,” he said at last. “Walk with me tomorrow. I ask only that you see.”

Caelir searched his face. “Will you show me the house?”

The western quarter. Falanaras had not been there since he had buried his father. “Yes,” he said.

They sat a little longer, trying to talk of smaller things — hawks, tutors, whether old Master Aldris still kept his terrible toupee — and failing. When Falanaras left, Caelir walked him to the door and gripped his arm once more, hard.

“I missed you,” Caelir said. “Every day.”

Falanaras nodded, because his throat would not let anything else out.

Outside, the night air was cooler. Theron was waiting across the street, out of sight of the pilgrim house windows, arms crossed.

“Well?” Theron asked.

Falanaras fell into step beside him. “He’s my brother.”

“And?”

“And he thinks we have poisoned ourselves to live,” Falanaras said. He could still feel the grip on his arm. “He is not entirely wrong.”

Theron was quiet a street longer. “Tomorrow will be worse. They are to be received in the court. Vereesa will speak.”

Morning came pale over the eastern sea. Falanaras met Caelir at the courtyard fountain where the water ran thin over repaired stone. Caelir had slept poorly; the skin beneath his eyes was shadowed. He carried no gifts, no parchment — only himself, as if any offering would have been presumptuous.

“You said you would show me,” Caelir said.

They walked west. Silvermoon woke around them in its careful way. Shop shutters lifted. A baker set out loaves that were smaller than Falanaras remembered from childhood but evenly divided. Apprentices moved in pairs to check the crystals set at street corners, tapping each with a wand, noting the resonance in small books. Where the light burned steady, people lingered a moment longer before moving on; where it sputtered, they touched their temples, frowned, and walked faster.

Caelir watched it all without comment at first. His horror had settled into something quieter, more attentive. At the colonnaded arcade, a magister was teaching children how to breathe — in through the nose, out slow, hands hovering

near a crystal without touching it, as if learning to sip rather than gulp. One boy's hands trembled until the magister steadied them.

"You teach them young," Caelir said softly.

"We must," Falanaras said. "Untaught hunger makes Wretched. You remember the stories from the outskirts. Murder Row has earned its name. Last month three of them broke into a cellar looking for an old mana cache and tore one another apart before the guard arrived. We keep the young close to steady sources so they learn measure."

Caelir's mouth tightened. "In Dalaran they call it dependency. They study it as a malady."

"It is a malady," Falanaras said. "And it is also life. We call it hunger because craving is only part of it. The emptiness after the Sunwell reaches beyond the blood. We do not speak of it often because speaking changes nothing. We offer a crystal, we move nearer a ward, we keep working. What would you have us say?"

They had reached the edge of the ruined quarter. The street ended where the Scourge had ended it. Beyond a temporary wooden barrier, the western district lay open to the sky, its white stone blackened, its towers broken like teeth. The barrier was guarded, though no one lived there and few wished to enter. Wind moved through the empty shells and lifted ash that had never quite washed away.

Falanaras stopped at the line where the cobbles gave way to scorched earth. "House Dawnspear stood there," he said, pointing to a plot now marked only by a low foundation and a singed tree that had somehow survived. "Two floors, a courtyard with a lily pool. Our father kept his books on the second. He died inside. The Scourge left many houses in this quarter with no bodies to bury."

Caelir stepped past the barrier before Falanaras could warn him. He knelt at the foundation and set his palm on the stone. His shoulders rose once, hard.

“I was in Dalaran when the sky broke,” Caelir said, his voice rough. “We felt the wind from the north. The masters said Quel’Thalas had fallen. I told myself you might have fled east, that you were clever enough to run. I told myself many things while I was safe behind another city’s walls.”

Falanaras joined him on the other side of the barrier. The ash was fine and clung to their boots. “You were not safe. Dalaran fell too, later. I heard.”

“It did. I survived again, by luck and by being moved to the outer vaults when Antonidas ordered the evacuation. That is my history since I left — survival by being elsewhere.” Caelir looked up, eyes red. “Do you understand why I cannot hear that name without grief? Sin’dorei. You rename yourselves for the dead while you —” He gestured back toward the crystals, the city, the green light. “While you make yourselves unlike them.”

“We rename ourselves because we are unlike them now,” Falanaras said. “Quel’dorei is what we were when the Sunwell lived. That people is gone. The name matters because it tells the truth. We are blood elves. Blood for what was lost. It is in their honor.”

“The name matters,” Caelir repeated, and for a moment they agreed without knowing it. Then he shook his head. “But truth should not be purchased this way. I saw your soldiers, Fal. Their eyes. I saw the way that matron offered fel as if it were tea. You have let Rommath and his green fire into every house. It will mark your children.”

“Our children will live,” Falanaras said. The words came sharper than he intended. He steadied himself. “You were not here when the hunger took hold. You did not see elders weep

because they could not remember a spell, or a boy of nine scratch his arms raw in the night. Rommath brought us a way to keep the ache from eating us alive. The means are dangerous. So is every choice left to us. The wards hold. The Scourge have not returned through the Scar this winter. That is what living looks like here.”

Caelir stood, brushing ash from his knees. “And Kael’thas? Is he the one who approves it? From wherever he is, chasing salvation in Outland?”

Falanaras felt a flicker of the old hope, stubborn even after disappointment. “He named us. He went to find help. Lor’themar holds the city in his name. Grand Magister Rommath speaks for him. We believe he will return with something better than crystals. Until then we hold.”

“Faith in a distant prince,” Caelir said, not unkindly. “It is a thin rope to hang a kingdom from.”

“It is a rope nonetheless,” Falanaras said.

They walked back slowly. Near the bazaar, a patrol passed with a man in custody, his eyes too bright, his wrists bound in cloth to keep him from clawing. The high elves’ escort tightened around Vereesa’s people when they saw it, while the blood elves on the street barely turned their heads. They had seen it too often. Caelir stared until the patrol turned the corner.

At noon the city gathered.

The Court of the Sun still bore the Scourge’s damage: half its colonnade scaffolded, its far wall patched with timber. Lor’themar had ordered it opened for the exiles. Blood elves filled the tiers in quiet ranks: magisters in red-trimmed robes, Farstriders with bows unstrung, matrons with children kept close, veterans with empty sleeves. Falanaras stood with his unit near the base of the dais, Theron and Lethira on either side. On the dais itself,

Lor'themar waited with Halduron and Rommath, the latter's presence a statement in itself, his robes immaculate, his eyes lit faintly green.

Vereesa entered with her company. She wore no crown, no high jewelry, only the battered silver of a ranger who had ridden far. Yet the hall quieted as if a queen had entered. She stopped before the dais and bowed.

"People of Quel'Thalas," she said, and her voice carried. She spoke in Thalassian, clear and unadorned. "We left as high elves. We return and find you calling yourselves sin'dorei. We do not come to quarrel over a name. We come because we heard that you live, and we could not stay away."

A murmur ran through the tiers, soft, involuntary — welcome and warning at once.

Vereesa continued. "In Dalaran we mourned you. We kept your scrolls, your songs, your heraldry behind our walls. We defended your name when others said Quel'Thalas was ended. When the Kirin Tor turned their minds to new dangers, some of us argued that aid should be sent sooner, faster. We were not heeded as we wished. For that, I ask your forgiveness."

She paused, and her gaze lifted to the crystals burning on the pillars, to the green wash over the crowd, to Rommath's still face.

"Grief cannot govern sight," she said, quieter now. "What we have seen in your streets troubles us. The fel you burn openly. The hunger you feed with power taken by force from living things — and I have been told you teach your children to draw it. In exile we learned to endure the same ache differently. It is hard and slow. We did not smother it with demon fire. We fear for you as kin, afraid that the means you have chosen will leave you unable to be who you were, even if the Sunwell were restored tomorrow."

The hall was utterly still. Falanaras felt Theron's hand brush his forearm, a warning to keep his face blank.

Lor'themar stepped forward. He did not raise his voice. "Lady Windrunner speaks as one who loves Quel'Thalas, and we honor it. No one here will pretend our condition is wholesome. Neither Grand Magister Rommath nor I. Dalaran had protected stores and allied lands able to sustain you. We had the Scar at our door and winter coming. Our people stood in the ash of their houses and shook until they could not hold a cup. We chose a hard sustenance over a slow fading. Judge the choice. Remember the place where it was made."

Rommath's smile was thin. "Your exiles endured beyond our borders, Lady Windrunner. Here, endurance required invention. The crystals you dislike are warded, measured, and distributed. Without them the Wretched would number in hundreds more. You speak of what we might be if the Sunwell returned. We speak of whether any of us will live until then."

Vereesa did not look away. "And the tapping? The draining of others to sate yourselves? Is that invention also measured?"

A hiss went through the magisters. Lethira, beside Falanaras, exhaled through her teeth. Falanaras kept his eyes on Vereesa, and for a moment the symbol gave way to a ranger who had walked too many burned villages, whose bluntness was grief made strict.

"Mana-tapping sustains many," Rommath said evenly. "It is governed, and no one is compelled while other sources suffice. Restraint and meditation have their uses. They do not feed every child or hold a single ward."

Vereesa bowed her head again, accepting that no agreement would be reached there. "Then I ask only this. Do

not close the road between us. Let letters pass. Let those who wish to live as quel'dorei be welcomed when they seek you, and let those who wish to remain sin'dorei be known for their endurance rather than their excess. The Alliance is not your enemy if you do not make it so."

Rommath's mouth thinned. "The Alliance you speak for did not seem so even-handed when Grand Marshal Garithos caged our prince in Dalaran and condemned his soldiers to death for accepting naga aid. Forgive us if we learned there that Alliance friendship is conditional upon our obedience – and our disappearance."

Lor'themar answered for the city. "The road will remain open to our kin. You will have quarters here, and escort where the Ghostlands allow." It was courteous and final. The court clapped, relieved that the confrontation had stopped short of rupture. The applause held little fervor.

After, the hall emptied slowly. Falanaras looked for Caelir in the dispersing crowd and found him near a pillar, alone, his face pale with the effort of holding his tongue through Vereesa's speech.

"You heard her," Caelir said when Falanaras reached him. "She was restrained, and even so they took it as accusation."

"She told the truth as she sees it," Falanaras said. "And Rommath told ours."

Caelir stepped closer, lowering his voice so only his brother would hear. "Stay quel'dorei with me. I am asking for your sake alone. You do not need to call that light beautiful to survive it. Come to Dalaran for a season. See that hunger can be borne without fel. If it cannot, you can return. I will not hold it against you."

The offer was sincere, and that made it harder to refuse. Falanaras thought of the pilgrim house, of the crystal offered like a sweet, of the way his own hands had steadied

after a draw. He thought of the foundation in the ash and the phoenix on his tabard.

“I am sin’dorei,” he said. It was a boundary now. “I did not choose it to spite you. I chose it because I stayed. You stayed elsewhere and kept the old name honorably. That is your path. Do not ask me to walk it as if I had not buried anyone.”

Caelir’s eyes filled. “The name matters,” he said again, and this time it sounded like a plea. “If you change what you are called, you change what you will permit yourself.”

“Then perhaps you do not know me,” Falanaras whispered. The words escaped before he could soften them. Caelir flinched as if struck.

Caelir recovered, his jaw set in the familiar Dawnspear stubbornness they had shared as boys. “I will not report to Dalaran that you are lost,” he said. “Only that you are — changed. And that you would not come.”

“Report that I am alive,” Falanaras said. “And that House Dawnspear still has a son in Silvermoon who remembers his brother.”

They embraced once more, brief and hard, as they had at the gate. This time neither tried to laugh.

The exiles left two days later, as they had come — on foot to the coast, with wagons lighter now for having left their stores. Silvermoon did not polish itself for their departure. Only the daily watch lined the road. Falanaras stood in the second rank without his glaive, his hands empty at his sides. Vereesa rode at the head, her face forward. Caelir walked near the middle of the column. He did not look for his brother until the very end, when the road bent south toward the harbor. He turned then, found Falanaras, and lifted a hand. Falanaras lifted his in return. The distance was already too great to read the other’s eyes.

The column passed out of sight. The wind came down the Dead Scar again and lifted dust over the white stone.

That evening, Falanaras went to the barracks' small shrine — no priestess served there now, only a basin and a phoenix etched in the wall — and stood a while before report. Theron found him there.

"You did not yield," Theron said.

"Neither did he," Falanaras said.

"Will you write to him?"

"Yes," Falanaras said. "When I know what to say that will not be a lie."

Above the city, the fel crystals lit one by one as dusk fell, green against the rose of evening, steady and unhidden. From the barracks wall, Falanaras could see the dark reach of the western quarter where his brother would never now live. The hunger moved through him in its slow, familiar pull. Beside it lay the fresher pain of a living brother lost to another name, another loyalty. Both would have to be borne.

CHAPTER FOUR

Friends in Dark Places

Three days after Caelir left Silvermoon, Captain Rynel Starweaver found Falanaras in the spellbreaker yard and told him to pack for the Ghostlands.

Falanaras had been drilling counters against a magister's binding spell. The practice sigil still burned blue around his boots, and sweat cooled beneath his bracers as he lowered his glaive. Across the yard, Theron was helping another recruit to his feet. Lethira watched from the shade of the colonnade, restringing her bow with the absorbed patience of someone who had already guessed the interruption concerned her.

"How long?" Falanaras asked.

"Enough for the quartermaster to complain about what you take." Rynel's gaze traveled over him, measuring fatigue, posture, and whatever else he habitually kept to himself. "Field kit. Three days' crystal allotment. Southern cloak."

Theron joined them, rolling one shoulder beneath his padded training coat. "You could have started with southern cloak. Nothing good follows those."

"You're coming because you can hold a line after everyone else has decided it is broken," Rynel said. He pointed to Lethira without looking around. "Valeflame tracks. Dawnspear reads command magic. I correct the errors the three of you make."

Lethira tested the new string with her thumb. "A stirring endorsement."

“Eastern watch hall in an hour,” Rynel said. “The Ranger-General will brief us.” He turned away, then paused. “Eat first. Pride is a poor field ration.”

The watch hall occupied a repaired tower near the southern road. Its upper windows faced the Dead Scar, where the wound through Quel’Thalas ran toward the Ghostlands in a gray-brown channel. Maps covered the central table, held flat by dagger hilts, spent crystals, and a stone fragment marked with black necromantic scoring.

Ranger-General Halduron Brightwing stood at the table with one hand braced beside the map. He wore field leathers beneath a red cloak, and the scars on the map seemed to converge beneath his fingers. Two Farstrider couriers waited by the wall, mud dried to their boots.

“Captain,” Halduron said. “Your unit is light.”

“It is fast,” Rynel replied.

The Ranger-General accepted that with a slight nod. He tapped a point south of the last maintained relay. “A Scourge column struck two supply caches over six nights. They took iron fittings, alchemical salts, lamp oil, and three pieces of a damaged ward stone. They left food and weapons behind.”

“Building something,” Falanaras said.

“Or repairing it,” Halduron said. “Their trail leaves the Scar near the old border road. The way station there once carried messages between southern patrols and the eastern sanctums. Its relay chamber collapsed during the invasion, but enough stone remains to anchor a working.”

He shifted one of the daggers across the map. “Find the column. Determine what they are assembling. Destroy any command focus you can reach. If the trail passes beyond markers you can still identify as ours, use judgment. The border is less certain on the ground than it appears in ink.”

“Nearest support?” Theron asked.

“A Farstrider squad two days east. They are watching an Amani trail and cannot be stripped away. Assume you have no reinforcement.” Halduron looked at each of them in turn. “The Scourge are moving with purpose. Do not mistake small numbers for aimlessness.”

They left before noon. Silvermoon’s repaired towers diminished behind them, bright against a sky the color of old pewter. Farther south, Eversong’s restored spring faltered at the edges. Gold leaves gave way to bare limbs and red earth, then to the bruised forests of the Ghostlands, where rot had entered root and stone alike.

Falanaras had fought there often enough that the land no longer shocked him. That familiarity felt worse. He knew which streams carried a sweet corpse-stink after rain, which groves hid sinkholes full of bones, which abandoned farms still had doors that moved when there was no wind. The Ghostlands rewarded memory and punished comfort.

Lethira found the column’s trail before sunset. The signs were broad enough for Falanaras to read once she pointed them out: deep heel marks from armored corpses, handprints where ghouls had loped across soft ground, and two parallel grooves from a sledge or narrow wagon. Dark fluid had dried in the ruts.

“Thirty,” she said. “Perhaps more. They are collecting stragglers as they move.”

“They do not need lamp oil to raise stragglers,” Theron said.

Rynel crouched beside the wagon rut and touched two fingers to the residue. Green light shivered across his knuckles. His fingers tightened before he withdrew them, and for an instant Falanaras could not tell whether the captain had tested the magic or stopped himself from feeding on it.

“Embalming pitch,” the captain said. “Mixed with powdered silver.” He wiped his fingers on the soil. “Move.”

They camped without fire in the shell of a forester’s lodge. One wall had fallen outward, opening the room to the trees, but the roof kept off the thin rain. Theron divided dried meat with a dagger. Lethira sat where she could watch the trail. Rynel made them report their hunger in the same clipped numbers he used at the barracks.

“Two,” Theron said.

“Three,” Falanaras said. The ache had sharpened since they passed beyond the last active relay, a hollow pressure behind his eyes and teeth. He could feel the crystal vials in his pack without touching them.

Lethira lifted an eyebrow. “I dislike the question on professional grounds.”

“Answer it.”

“Two. Four when you speak.”

Rynel’s mouth moved by less than a smile. He passed Falanaras a measured shard, then took one for himself. Falanaras’s allotment went dull. Light continued to leak between the captain’s fingers until nothing remained, and even then he held the colorless crystal for another breath.

“Your number?” Falanaras asked.

Rynel opened his hand. The shard lay colorless against his palm. “Low enough to keep watch.”

At first light they found the first corpse from the column. It had been a Scourge outrider, leather armor stiff with old blood. A black-fletched arrow entered beneath one cheekbone and emerged behind the opposite ear. The shot had been made from high ground through a gap in the trees scarcely wider than Falanaras’s hand.

Lethira cut the arrow free. Its head was narrow, darkened against reflection, and marked near the socket with three tiny cuts.

“Farstrider work?” Theron asked.

“The fletching once was.” Lethira rubbed one feather between finger and thumb. “Dyed after it was bound. The cuts are an old range mark, turned backward.”

“A warning?” Falanaras asked.

“A claim.” She looked east, where the ground rose among dead pines. “Someone killed it and wanted another ranger to know.”

They found no footprints near the firing place. Moss had been lifted and laid back over the marks. A branch bent for passage had been tied upright with a strip of gray cloth. Lethira untied it, studied the knot, and said nothing for the next mile.

The signs continued. Two ghouls lay pinned together at the base of an elm, each arrow placed through the temple. A third had been hamstrung, then decapitated with a curved blade. Beside an old milestone, someone had arranged three black stones in a Farstrider trail sign for danger ahead, but the stones pointed south instead of north.

“They are driving part of the column,” Lethira said at last. “Or trying to.”

Rynel scanned the ridge. “How many hunters?”

“Four. Perhaps five. They know our signs.” Her tone had flattened. “They want us to know they know them.”

“Hostile?” Theron asked.

“If they were aiming at us, we would have a clearer answer.” Lethira slid the black arrow into her quiver apart from her own. “I would prefer one.”

By midday the trail divided. The wagon and most of the column continued toward the old way station. A second set of

prints veered southeast: heavier corpses, a dragging chain, and one track broad enough to swallow Falanaras's boot. Black-fledged arrows marked that branch alone.

Rynel considered the fork. "Our objective is the wagon."

Lethira kept looking southeast. "The other trail may join it again."

"Then we will regret leaving it later." He rose. "For now, wagon."

The first sound of battle reached them an hour afterward: metal striking stone, followed by a shout in Common and a burst of golden light between the trees. The light came again, lower and broader, illuminating trunks from beneath. Something screamed with two voices at once.

Rynel raised a fist. They left the trail and climbed the bank above it, moving through bracken gone gray with blight. At the crest, the old way station opened below them.

Half the building had sunk into its cellar. A broken arch still spanned the road, and the relay courtyard lay between two low walls choked with thorn. The Scourge wagon stood beside the collapsed chamber. Three necromancers worked around a frame of iron rods and ward-stone fragments while ghouls and armored corpses pressed six human fighters against the northern wall.

All six humans wore plate or mail beneath silver tabards marked with the Argent Dawn's sunburst. Paladins. Two were already down. One knelt over a wounded companion, holding a golden barrier with his raised shield while the others stood shoulder to shoulder before him. A quieter radiance moved continuously through the formation, firming armor straps, tired legs, and shield arms. The kneeling paladin pressed his free hand to a torn thigh; the blood stopped in a brief pulse of warmth before he returned both hands

to the failing barrier. Every impact drove it closer to the ground.

“They have less than a minute,” Theron whispered.

Rynel’s attention went first to the iron frame. Green-black current ran between its rods and sank into the buried relay. “Dawnspear, break the working. Valeflame, necromancers. Brightshield with me.”

“And the humans?” Falanaras asked.

“Alive until they choose otherwise. Go.”

Lethira’s first arrow took a necromancer through the throat. Rynel and Theron came over the bank together, red cloaks snapping behind them. Falanaras followed half a pace to the left, glaive held low. Surprise carried them into the Scourge flank before the nearest corpses could turn.

Theron struck a ghoul with his shield and drove it into two others. Rynel’s crescent blade hooked beneath an armored corpse’s axe, tore the weapon aside, and opened the rib cage in one return cut. Falanaras reached past the melee with his senses and found the iron frame behaving as both ward and commander. He could not seize the corpses as though they were simple conjurations; dead flesh and bound fragments of will made each one too complex. The frame’s directing lattice was simpler. He caught that purpose against the hooked edge of his glaive and forced one branch of it to answer him instead.

The captured branch resisted like wire drawn through flesh. Falanaras turned the glaive and reversed its instruction. Six ghouls checked their charge, wheeled upon the armored corpses beside them, and struck before the necromancers tore command back. The stolen obedience lasted only a breath. It opened the line.

The human barrier surged. Paladins rose behind it and struck into the hesitation with warhammers bright as

sunrise. Their commander—a broad-shouldered woman with close-cropped gray hair—shouted an order, and the line wheeled away from the wall instead of merely holding it.

One of them turned toward Falanaras. His helm had been knocked away. Dark hair clung to his forehead, and a familiar scar crossed his chin where a hawk's jess had cut him when they were boys.

"Fal?" the paladin said.

Falanaras nearly missed the ghoul coming between them. The paladin stepped inside its reach, caught its claws on his vambrace, and drove a light-wreathed warhammer into its jaw. Bone collapsed beneath the blow. The radiance bound to the weapon discharged through ruined flesh and clung to the hammer's head after the corpse fell. Edric turned the remaining charge upon an armored skeleton beyond reach. A compact lance of gold crossed the courtyard and burst through its breastbone, leaving no heat on the living fighters between.

"Edric," Falanaras breathed.

Edric Hale grinned with blood on his teeth. For one naked instant he looked seventeen again, standing in House Dawnspear's hawk yard with stolen wine beneath his coat. "You took your time."

"You crossed my border."

"Complain after." Edric pivoted, and Falanaras moved with him before thought could intervene.

They had sparred with wooden swords in another life. The old habits survived beneath everything that had happened since. Edric guarded high; Falanaras cut low. Edric yielded ground when Falanaras pressed and returned it the moment the glaive passed. When a plated corpse raised a mace behind Edric, Falanaras stripped the binding from its

joints. Edric turned into the opening and split its skull with golden fire.

The Light in Edric's hands recalled another battlefield: Liadrin kneeling beneath a fallen beam in Silvermoon with blood to both elbows, her voice breaking on the prayer as a crushed wound closed beneath her palm. Edric wielded the same radiance with a soldier's discipline. He grounded his stance before calling it. He drew one measured breath, spoke an invocation too brief to hear over battle, and gave the power one purpose at a time. A low golden plane intercepted an axe meant for the paladin beside him. Two fingers against a split cheek closed the wound in a quick flare, while a longer touch at another soldier's ribs restored breath and strength more slowly. When a ghoul broke through, Edric's hammer released a compact blow of light before the iron landed; the creature locked rigid long enough for him to crush its skull. When an armored corpse retreated beyond reach, he sent a narrow burst after it and burned the necromancy out through its back.

Breath. Word. Intent. Release.

Falanaras fixed the cadence in memory while his body fought. It was economical as spellbreaker work and wholly unlike the currents he intercepted from magisters. Edric did not seize or redirect the Light. He asked, and it answered.

The second necromancer fell to Lethira. The third abandoned the iron frame and ran for the wagon. Rynel's glaive crossed the stones in a low curve and cut through the caster's calf. Power tore out through the wound after the blade. The necromancer collapsed as the loss burned through nerve and muscle, and the command currents feeding the iron frame dimmed with him. Rynel caught the returning weapon and remained over the fallen man, his

free hand half-open toward power he had already taken too deeply.

“Captain?” Falanaras called.

Rynel slashed the remaining current apart. The iron rods went dark. “Finish the line.”

Without the frame’s command, the first Scourge force began to fail. Paladins and blood elves drove them away from the wounded. Theron held the courtyard’s eastern gap alone until the gray-haired commander joined him. Lethira descended from the bank, shooting as she walked. A ghoul reached her; she planted one boot in its chest and buried a short blade through its eye.

The last armored corpse dropped. For half a breath, the courtyard held only ragged breathing and the hiss of consecrated wounds.

Then the southern arch exploded inward.

Stone struck the wagon in a spray of splinters. Through the dust came the chain Lethira had seen in the trail, its hook dragging across the road. An abomination followed: three bodies’ breadth across, belly split by black stitches, one arm ending in a cleaver and the other swollen around the chain. Flies boiled from vents in its shoulders. Behind it crowded another dozen ghouls and two robed necromancers.

“Second trail,” Lethira said, already drawing.

The abomination swung its chain. Theron shoved a wounded paladin flat and took the hook on his shield. The impact lifted him from his feet and flung him against the relay wall. His shield spun away. The gray-haired commander drove the rim of her shield into the earth and called the Light through every undead body before her. Gold erupted across the courtyard. Ghouls flew backward with their wounds burning from within; one collapsed into smoking

bones. The abomination's stitched mass endured and came on through the fading blaze.

Edric drew breath. His commander slammed her shield beside his, and the surviving paladins formed around them. Gold spread across the stones in a shallow curve just as the abomination charged. It hit the ward with a sound like a gate breaking. Every paladin bent. None fell.

Black arrows came out of the dust behind the Scourge.

One necromancer pitched forward with an arrow through the base of his skull. The second spun as three shafts struck his chest in a vertical line. Dark figures moved along the broken southern wall, cloaks gray against the blight, bows already bending again.

Their leader vaulted the fallen arch. She landed lightly for someone whose skin held the pallor of old death. Red points burned beneath her hood. Her longbow was Farstrider work, blackened and repaired with metal fittings from Lordaeron.

Lethira's bow shifted toward her.

The dark ranger saw the motion. Recognition tightened her dead face, but she pointed at the abomination. "That first."

Rynel did not ask who they were. "Valeflame, take its knees. Dawnspear, find the binding. Brightshield—"

"Still here," Theron said hoarsely. He had recovered his shield and was using the wall to stand.

The dark rangers loosed together. Four arrows buried themselves around the abomination's left knee, cutting cords and stitches. Lethira's shaft entered the same joint a heartbeat later. The leg buckled. The creature leaned into the paladins' ward, spraying foul vapor from its torn belly.

Falanaras reached for the magic holding it together. The abomination contained no single command. Necromancy crossed through it in dozens of knotted channels, each

fastening a borrowed tendon, a stolen limb, a fragment of will. He could not break them all before the ward failed.

“Chest,” he shouted. “The binding gathers behind the sternum.”

Edric looked at him once and understood. Breath. Word. Intent. Golden radiance tightened around the head of his warhammer instead of flaring outward. He and his commander stepped apart, opening a narrow lane through the ward.

Rynel entered it first. He caught the abomination’s cleaver on the crescent of his glaive and turned the blow just enough. Falanaras followed beneath the massive arm. He drove his weapon’s point into the seam below the sternum and hooked the central binding out into the open.

The exposed spell burned green-black between his glaive and the corpse-flesh. Hunger surged through him, sudden and intimate. Falanaras drew. Necromantic power came bitter and cold, steadying his hands as the abomination’s central binding dimmed. He took enough to weaken it, closed his will against the rest, and held the unraveling spell open for Edric.

“Now!”

Edric’s warhammer struck the binding. Light flooded the abomination from within, pouring through its stitches and eye sockets. The dark ranger’s next arrow vanished into its open mouth. Rynel tore his glaive free and took a wash of necromantic force across both hands.

The creature came apart in sections. Falanaras threw himself clear as the chain arm collapsed. Edric caught the back of his harness and dragged him beyond it. The impact shook dust from the surviving arch.

The remaining Scourge had lost both necromancers and their largest weapon. Blood elf blades met them from the

north. Paladins advanced from the west. The dark rangers shot into every opening from the southern wall. Within minutes, the second force lay still among the first.

Silence returned unevenly. A paladin prayed over one of the fallen. Theron sat against the wall while another bound his ribs. Lethira stood with an arrow drawn toward the dark ranger's heart.

"Serenya," she said.

The name moved through Falanaras's memory. Serenya Duskrunner had ridden with the Farstriders before the invasion. He remembered her laughing once beside Lethira at a midsummer range, both of them sun-browned and alive. He had known her only well enough to nod in passing.

Serenya pushed back her hood. Death had sharpened the bones of her face and leeched the warmth from her skin. "You still pull left when you are angry."

Lethira corrected her aim by a finger's width. "I watched you die."

"So did I." Serenya's bow remained lowered. "We can discuss Arthas's workmanship after you decide whether to loose."

Around them, weapons shifted. The dark rangers did not aim at Lethira, but their hands settled near bowstrings. Rynel stepped beside her. The fingers of his free hand curled once toward his palm, closing on power no longer there.

Edric approached Falanaras with his warhammer lowered. His first expression was still wonder. He gripped Falanaras by both shoulders, then pulled him into a hard embrace that smelled of sweat, steel, and incense burned into wool.

"I thought you were dead," Edric said. "Every list from the north—Fal, I looked."

"I was here." Falanaras returned the grip before Edric released him. "Where were you?"

“Lordaeron. Then Stormwind. Light’s Hope for this patrol.” Edric smiled again, and the smile faded as he finally looked closely at Falanaras’s face.

His gaze stopped on Falanaras’s eyes. It moved to the green crystal sealed in the socket of his glaive, then to the empty shard vial at his belt. The warmth did not vanish all at once. It drew inward behind caution.

“Your eyes,” Edric said quietly.

Falanaras had heard the words from Caelir days earlier. They hurt differently in a human voice. “I know their color.”

Edric looked toward Rynel’s glowing hands and the crystals carried by the other blood elves. “What are you drawing from?”

“What keeps the wards standing and our soldiers steady.”

“That was fel.” Edric’s voice carried farther than he intended.

One of the paladins turned. Then another. Their attention spread across the blood elves: green eyes, crimson armor, crystal fittings. The relief of rescue acquired edges.

Serenya glanced at Falanaras’s glaive. “Does it kill the Scourge?”

“Yes.”

“Then I have exhausted my objections.” Her red gaze passed over his eyes without interest. “The color is common farther south.”

Edric stared at her. “You serve Sylvanas.”

“I serve the Forsaken.” Serenya’s mouth barely moved. “Today I also served your continued possession of a spine.”

Edric’s warhammer rose a hand’s breadth. Lethira drew farther. A dark ranger behind Serenya nocked an arrow. Theron struggled upright despite the paladin binding his ribs. Rynel shifted his glaive across his body.

The gray-haired Argent commander stepped between Edric and Serenya.

“Lower it, Hale.” Her voice was calm enough to expose every other sound: flies over the abomination, Theron’s strained breathing, rain beginning on broken stone.

“Commander, they are—”

“I know what they are. I also know who broke the line around us and who brought down that construct.” She faced the others without turning her back on Edric. “This patrol is composed of paladins. The Argent Dawn is larger than this patrol. Forsaken serve in our ranks at Light’s Hope and guard the Tirisfal approaches against the same Scourge. Any soldier under my command learns to stand beside them or leaves my command.”

Her gaze settled on Rynel. “Captain, we crossed a border whose markers are ash. We followed the Scourge north. We claim no authority over your land.”

Rynel’s fingers tightened on the glaive. “Then finish your business and withdraw south.”

“After our wounded can travel.” The commander looked around the courtyard. “Until then, the Dawn recognizes one enemy here. Weapons down.”

Edric obeyed first, though his jaw remained set. His hammer head touched the stones. One by one, the other paladins followed. Rynel lowered his glaive. Serenya made a small motion with two fingers, and her rangers eased their bows. Lethira held for another breath before letting the string slacken.

The work afterward was quieter and more difficult than the battle. They moved the wounded beneath the surviving roof. Paladins laid their fallen together and covered each face. The dark rangers searched the southern road. Blood elves dismantled the iron frame and recovered the ward-

stone fragments before corruption could sink deeper into them.

Falanaras found Rynel kneeling beside the broken command focus. The captain's shoulders had folded around a splinter of black crystal held between finger and thumb. Green current crawled from it into his hand. He did not look up at Falanaras's approach.

"Evidence?" Falanaras asked.

Rynel closed his fist and drew until the splinter went gray. His fingers remained clamped around it. "Spent."

"Your hands are shaking."

The captain stood and the tremor disappeared into the cuff of his gauntlet. "So is the wall. Attend to the structure that matters."

Serenya returned with a marked strip of leather taken from one of the necromancers. She laid it beside Lethira's map. "The force we followed came from the southeast. More tracks turn toward Deatholme."

Lethira studied the markings without looking at her. "Your trail signs are backwards."

"We approach them from the other side."

"That is a terrible reason."

"You remembered them." Serenya indicated the map. "There is a culvert here. The Scourge use it to move without entering the Scar. Collapse it and you may slow the next column."

Lethira marked the culvert. Her hand was steady. "If it is a trap, I will find you."

Serenya's dead mouth curved by a fraction. "That sounds almost familiar."

The Argent wounded could travel by late afternoon. Before the patrol departed, Edric found Falanaras beside the broken arch. The human had washed the blood from his face. Without it, he looked older and more uncertain.

“I am glad you lived,” Edric said.

“You were glad before you looked closely.”

Edric took the rebuke without retreating. “I am still glad. I am also afraid of what I saw.”

“You saw us save you.”

“I did. That matters.” Edric glanced toward Serenya’s departing scouts. “So does the rest.”

Falanaras thought of Caelir turning at the coast road, too distant for either brother to read the other’s face. “It always matters more to those who arrived afterward.”

Pain crossed Edric’s expression. “Perhaps. I spent years asking why the Light did not answer here. Today it answered me, and I stood alive because you came with green fire in your eyes.” He looked down at his hands. “I do not know what to do with both truths.”

“Carry them,” Falanaras said. “We have carried worse.”

Edric gave a tired breath that might once have become laughter. He offered his forearm. Falanaras clasped it.

“Light keep you,” Edric said.

Falanaras did not know whether the blessing still knew his name. “Keep your shield higher.”

The Argent patrol went south beneath the gray-haired commander’s silver banner. Serenya’s Dark Rangers had already disappeared east, leaving no tracks Falanaras could see. Only the black arrow in Lethira’s quiver proved they had occupied the same ground.

Rynel ordered the way station burned after they removed the ward stone and maps. The abomination took longest. Greasy smoke followed the blood elves north until rain pressed it low among the trees.

Theron walked with his ribs bound and refused help. Lethira kept touching the black-fletched arrow as if checking

that it had not changed. Rynel set a pace too fast for his own breathing and corrected anyone who mentioned it.

Near dusk, the captain stumbled over a root. His hand struck a tree trunk and remained there. His fingers spread against the dead bark as if seeking a current where none remained. Green light flashed beneath his cuff, brief and hungry.

Falanaras moved toward him.

“Continue,” Rynel said without turning.

Falanaras obeyed because he was still a soldier and Rynel was still his captain. He carried the unease with the other things the day had given him: Edric’s embrace tightening into scrutiny, Serenya’s indifference to the stain everyone else saw, Lethira’s arrow held on a friend’s heart.

Beneath them all remained the cadence of the Light.

Breath. Word. Intent. Release.

Falanaras repeated it silently as they marched north through the Ghostlands, while behind him Rynel’s steps recovered their rhythm and then, little by little, began to fail again.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Prince's Seal

They reached the forward command post two hours after nightfall, with the rain at their backs and the smoke of the burned way station still caught in their cloaks.

The post occupied a fortified lodge where Eversong's last tended road met the first blighted trees. Gold leaves clung to the branches north of the palisade. Beyond its southern ditch, the forest stood bare beneath a low green haze. Farstriders had filled the space between with wet tents, arrow crates, tethered hawkstriders, and braziers whose ward-flames hissed whenever the wind changed.

Healers took Theron at the gate despite his objections. Lethira surrendered the recovered maps but kept Serenya's black-fletched arrow. Rynel crossed the yard without assistance. Only Falanaras, walking half a pace behind him, saw the captain's left boot drag twice through the mud.

Rynel straightened before the command lodge. By the time the sentries opened the door, fatigue had disappeared behind the severe economy of his bearing.

Ranger-General Halduron Brightwing waited over a long table beneath three hanging lamps. Two Farstrider officers stood beside him, along with a magister in a crimson mantle. A map of the southern border covered the table. The markers upon it ended well north of where the day's fighting had taken place.

Halduron looked over Theron's new bindings, the black stains on Rynel's gauntlets, and the blood dried along Lethira's sleeve. "Report."

Rynel gave it without ornament. They had followed the stolen supplies to the ruined relay station, found the Scourge rebuilding its buried command focus, destroyed two linked forces, recovered the ward-stone fragments, and burned what remained. He named their injuries and omitted his own.

"You destroyed a column of that size with four soldiers?" Halduron asked.

"No," Rynel said. "We arrived while an Argent Dawn patrol was already engaged."

Halduron's hand stopped above the map. "Argent forces crossed into Quel'Thalas without notice."

"Six paladins pursuing the same remnant from the Plaguelands," Rynel said. "Their commander acknowledged the border and claimed no authority over it. Two died before we reached them. The others withdrew south with their wounded."

"A border whose markers are ash remains a border." Halduron shifted one of the map weights south. "I will send Light's Hope a notice. Courtesy can arrive after their soldiers, if it must."

His gaze moved to Falanaras. "You knew one of them."

Falanaras had not expected that detail to reach the report. "Edric Hale. We were friends before the war. He is attached to the Dawn from Stormwind."

Halduron studied him for a heartbeat, then returned to Rynel. "You said a second force entered from the southeast. Who was behind it?"

Lethira laid the black arrow across the map. "Dark Rangers. Five of them. Serenya Duskrunner led the patrol."

The room became still in a different way. Halduron did not touch the arrow. "I remember Duskrunner."

"She remembers us," Lethira said. Her voice gave nothing away. "Her scouts were following the reinforcement from the south. They killed both necromancers and helped bring down the abomination."

"Under whose orders?"

"She named the Forsaken," Rynel said. "No commander. No demand. She gave us a Scourge route leading toward Deatholme and the location of a culvert used to avoid the Scar."

Halduron looked from the arrow to the marked leather Lethira had brought. "Sylvanas does not spend rangers without purpose. Useful aid does not make its purpose ours."

"It kept twelve more Scourge from reaching the relay," Rynel said.

"Then it was useful." Halduron's attention sharpened. "You mentioned a standoff after the fighting."

Theron answered from the chair a healer had forced upon him. "The paladins objected to the Dark Rangers. The Dark Rangers objected to being objected to. Their commander reminded everyone that Forsaken serve elsewhere in the Dawn and ordered weapons down."

"And they obeyed?" Halduron asked.

"Eventually," Lethira said.

Halduron exhaled through his nose. "Six unannounced paladins, five Forsaken rangers, and four blood elves with no reinforcement. I would prefer the next border incident to contain fewer claims upon my attention." He held out his hand. "The command focus."

Rynel placed a splinter of black crystal in his palm. The magister raised a warded cloth to receive it. A faint green current crawled over the captain's fingers before releasing them.

Halduron saw the current. He also saw the tremor that followed. "How much did you take from it?"

"Enough to break its hold," Rynel said.

It answered the wording and nothing beneath it. Falanaras watched Halduron recognize the evasion. Before the Ranger-General could press, boots struck the outer corridor at a pace barely short of running.

A young Farstrider entered with rain shining on his shoulders. He carried a narrow case of red lacquer bound with silver wire. The wax impressed over its clasp bore the sunburst seal of House Sunstrider.

Every person in the room straightened. "Message relayed from Silvermoon," the ranger said. He looked at Halduron, then Rynel. "It came through the southern route. From Outland."

Outland had existed in Falanaras's mind as reports, promises, and the distant place where Kael'thas sought salvation for his people. The word displaced the rain, the border, even Serenya's arrow. Halduron broke the wax and read in silence before passing the inner sheet to Rynel.

"His Highness requests reinforcements for an operation of decisive importance," Halduron said. "Its purpose is withheld until the company reaches Outland. Captain Starweaver is named among the officers requested. The company gathers in Silvermoon within ten days."

Pride rose in Falanaras before caution could touch it. Then Rynel's hand trembled against the parchment. Halduron lowered his voice. "You may decline on grounds of current duty or health. I will send that answer under my authority." Rynel folded the message. "Deatholme first." "You have no Deatholme assignment yet," Halduron said. "You have one full day inside this camp. Brightshield will remain with the healers. The rest of you will eat, sleep, and report here at

first light the day after tomorrow. That is an order, Captain.” After a moment, Rynel answered, “Understood.”

* * *

Halduron kept his word. No field order reached them for the whole of the next day.

Theron slept beneath the healers’ supervision after they rebound his ribs. Lethira spent an hour giving a Farstrider scribe the exact placement of every altered trail sign, then took her bedroll to the loft above the hawkstrider stable. Falanaras washed Scourge matter from his glaive, ate without tasting the meal, and slept until the afternoon bells.

Rynel accepted a cot in the officers’ room. When Falanaras passed its open door near midday, the captain lay fully dressed with one forearm across his eyes. A measured crystal sat untouched on the stool beside him. The sight should have been reassuring. It was not.

Near dusk, Falanaras climbed the northern firing step. Eversong shone beyond the road in wet gold. When he turned south, the same rain vanished into the dark canopy of the Ghostlands. The post stood between the two landscapes as if a palisade and fifty tired soldiers could keep one from becoming the other.

Lethira joined him, turning the black arrow between her fingers. Below them, Theron emerged from the infirmary with the careful posture of a man determined to make pain look ceremonial. None of them spoke about Edric, Serenya, or Outland. Rest had given each subject more room rather than less.

After sunset, Rynel found them at the cook tent. He had shaved and changed his blood-stiffened undertunic. His hands were steady around the bowl. “Command lodge at first light,” he said. “Bring field kit.”

The muddy magister waited with Halduron the next morning. When he touched the recovered crystal splinter, a sick green thread rose from it and spread across the map in branching lines. Several converged on Deathholme. Others reached toward abandoned sanctums, grave pits, and stretches of the Dead Scar where patrols had vanished.

"The stronghold is coordinating its outer remnants through linked anchors," the magister said. "The fragment refers to an administrative register below the eastern ruins. It should identify the anchor sites, their garrisons, and the command routes between them."

"The Scourge will alter those routes when the missing column fails to report," Halduron said. "We may have two days. I can assign another unit." Rynel pointed to the eastern wall. "Another unit would need time to study the focus. Valeflame can reach this approach unseen. Dawnspear can read the command currents. Brightshield can keep the passage open." Halduron's gaze settled on him. "And you?" "I correct their errors."

Lethira looked down. Theron's expression did not move. Halduron let the silence stand before he said, "You leave after breakfast. If any one of you believes the captain cannot continue, you withdraw. The same applies if Brightshield's ribs open, if Valeflame loses the route, or if Dawnspear cannot break the outer ward. No objective in Deathholme is worth four soldiers I cannot replace."

They prepared in the wet yard. Theron selected a heavier shield. Lethira blackened the bright fittings on her bow. Falanaras sealed copies of the ward sequence beneath the oiled flap of his pack while Rynel tucked the Sunstrider message case beneath his cloak. The captain divided their crystals with an apothecary's exactness, giving six to each of them and keeping four. When Falanaras challenged the

count, Rynel tied his pouch shut. "Keep your allotment." Farstriders saluted as they passed through the gate. Rynel acknowledged them and led his unit south.

The road failed by degrees. Laid stone gave way to cracked paving, then to two muddy tracks divided by thorn. They avoided the Dead Scar and moved through blighted woodland where pale fungi climbed the trunks. Once, a flock of carrion birds burst from the branches ahead. Lethira vanished into the brush before the last wingbeat faded and returned to report three ghouls worrying at a stag. They circled east without drawing steel.

Rynel maintained a measured pace. He did not stumble. Each time the ground rose, however, his left hand settled near the pouch at his belt. It never opened the flap.

At dusk they sheltered in the remains of a wayside shrine. The image within had lost its face and most of one arm, though a few chips of blue enamel still clung to the robe. Someone had scratched the new name of their people across the old dedication. The letters were crude and deep: SIN'DOREI.

Theron lowered himself against the wall. "If Outland has beds, I volunteer."

"You volunteer whenever furniture is mentioned," Lethira said.

"A soldier should understand his strengths."

Rynel took first watch. Falanaras sat beside him in the roofless doorway while Lethira and Theron rested. Beyond the shrine, the trees stood black against a dim green haze rising from the south. Deatholme lay past those ridges. Its fires stained the low clouds on nights when the wind turned.

"Why did he name you?" Falanaras asked.

Rynel turned the lacquered message case in his hands. He had carried it beneath his cloak all day. "I served with one of

the prince's household officers before the war. He knew my record."

"That is all?"

"It is sufficient." Rynel slipped the case back beneath his cloak. "Secret operations favor soldiers whose records are longer than their questions."

"Halduron offered to refuse for you."

"Halduron offered to let me live with having refused." The captain's profile remained still against the southern haze. "Our prince asks for soldiers while he searches for an answer to what we have become. If I am fit to serve here, I am fit to answer him."

Falanaras heard the flaw and understood why Rynel needed it to remain unspoken. Fitness had become a door that opened both ways. Deny it here, and the captain surrendered his command. Claim it here, and he could not decline Outland without admitting fear.

"Your number?" Falanaras asked.

Rynel's gaze shifted to him. For years, the question had belonged to the captain. Recruits answered because discipline required truth before pride. Hearing it returned seemed to cost him more than anger would have.

"Four," he said at last.

It was the first time Falanaras had heard Rynel answer the question with a number.

He took one shard from his own pouch and held it out. Rynel looked at the green glow for several breaths, then accepted it. He drew slowly. The light faded without the violent flare Falanaras had begun to dread.

"Three," Rynel said, returning the spent crystal.

"Then keep watch."

The corner of the captain's mouth tightened. "Sleep while the privilege remains available."

* * *

They broke camp before first light. Mist filled the low ground and left the ridges exposed like islands of black root and stone. Rynel walked at the front with Lethira, studying the copied route whenever the trees concealed the southern haze. Falanaras followed with Theron, close enough to hear the captain's breathing whenever the path climbed.

For the first hour, no one spoke. The forest supplied its own uneasy company: water dripping from bare branches, carrion beetles clicking beneath the bark, something heavy moving parallel to them beyond sight. Falanaras kept one hand near his glaive and felt the lacquered message case ahead of him as keenly as any hidden threat.

Theron glanced toward Rynel. "The message named him, not us."

"I know," Falanaras said.

"He will answer it if he leaves Deatholme alive."

Lethira looked back over one shoulder. "An ambitious condition."

Falanaras watched the captain's measured stride. "He should not make the journey alone."

"The prince requested officers and reinforcements," Rynel said without turning. "Silvermoon will choose them. You will not volunteer yourself into sealed orders."

"We were discussing whether you could reach Silvermoon without falling over," Lethira said.

Rynel stepped over a fallen branch. "Discuss it more quietly."

Lethira glanced toward Falanaras. "His hearing remains fit."

The exchange did not loosen the pressure in Falanaras's chest. Rynel spoke as though the decision belonged wholly to command, yet the lacquered case traveled at the center of their formation like another wounded man. If the captain

reached Silvermoon, Kael'thas's summons would carry him beyond Quel'Thalas while his control was failing. Falanaras could not imagine allowing that journey. He had no rank with which to prevent it and no order permitting him to follow.

He tried to imagine passing beyond Azeroth. His mind supplied no alien sky or shattered land, only Kael'thas as he remained in public memory: bright-haired beneath a sweeping crimson mantle and a high red-gold shoulder guard, with three fiery Verdant Spheres circling above him as he named the survivors sin'dorei and promised that their suffering would lead somewhere other than extinction. Falanaras had built years of service upon that promise without ever expecting it to reach into his own life.

"Would you go?" Theron asked quietly.

Falanaras knew he was being offered the dignity of treating the question as hypothetical. "Yes."

"For the prince?"

Falanaras watched Rynel's shoulders move beneath the dark cloak. "For what he may have found. For the captain. I do not know which answer I would give first."

Theron accepted that with a nod. "Then the honest answer is both."

The path narrowed along a slope where the soil had slumped away. Rynel stopped before the crossing and removed the message case from beneath his cloak. His hand shook once as he held it toward Falanaras.

"Your pack is better sealed," the captain said.

The claim was plausible enough to preserve them both. Falanaras tucked the case beneath the oiled flap beside the copied ward sequences. The prince's seal rested between orders taken from the Scourge, each document pointing toward a different war.

They saw Deatholme near midday.

The stronghold occupied the southern horizon in broken towers and blackened walls. Once, the site had guarded roads through living forest. The Scourge had enlarged it with timber palisades, bone scaffolds, and siegeworks sunk into poisoned earth. Smoke dragged from its chimneys. Winged shapes circled above the central ruin, too large to be birds.

Falanaras had fought within sight of Deatholme before. Proximity had never made it seem less obscene. The place endured with the patience of a wound that had learned to feed itself.

They left the last trail and crawled through dead bracken toward the eastern wall. Lethira led, choosing ground where exposed roots broke their outlines. Twice she stopped them with a closed fist. The first patrol passed thirty paces ahead: six armored corpses behind a floating crystal lantern whose green beam swept the trees. The second consisted of ghouls driven by an acolyte in stitched robes. Its chant made Falanaras's teeth ache before he could hear the words.

Rynel's breathing changed when the acolyte came near. One slow intake. A held pause. His fingers pressed into the mud.

Falanaras laid two fingers against the captain's wrist. Rynel did not look at him. The patrol passed. When the chant faded, he withdrew his hand and gestured them forward.

The entry lay beneath a collapsed watch post where runoff had cut a channel under the foundations. Old drainage stones formed a passage barely high enough to crawl through. The Scourge had sealed it with a ward instead of rubble. Five hooked runes hung in the darkness, each turning at a different pace.

Falanaras studied the sequence copied from the focus. "The third rune listens outward. The others carry its report inward."

“Can you blind it?” Theron whispered.

“For a breath.”

“Take two,” Rynel said. “It is a generous fortress.”

Falanaras set his glaive against the stones and reached for the ward. Necromantic current slid along the crescent blade, cold enough to numb his palms. He caught the listening rune between one pulse and the next, twisted its attention toward the empty woods, and held. Lethira went first, then Theron. Rynel entered behind them. By the time Falanaras dragged himself through, the false report was fraying. He released it and the five runes resumed their turning.

The passage descended through wet stone. They crawled until the smell of rain vanished beneath old blood, lamp grease, and the dust of opened graves. Farther in, the drain widened into a service corridor. Iron hooks lined the walls. Several still held scraps of yellowed parchment, as if the place had once been used for stores before its keepers found another purpose for the shelves.

Lethira raised one hand. Voices murmured beyond the next turn.

They waited in darkness while two acolytes crossed the adjoining hall. One carried a stack of ledgers chained together through their spines. The other bore a shallow bowl in which three severed fingers twitched and pointed toward different passages. Neither looked into the service corridor.

When they had gone, Rynel touched the wall. A low green pulse answered beneath his palm.

“The anchor current runs through the masonry,” he said. “The register will be near its strongest branch.”

“Can you follow it?” Falanaras asked.

Rynel removed his hand. Green remained in the lines of his palm before his gauntlet closed over it. “Yes.”

* * *

The lower vault had once been an archive.

Stone shelves rose along its walls, crowded with worm-eaten rolls and iron document cases. A long table occupied the center. The Scourge had driven copper stakes through its surface and stretched a hide map between them. Black threads connected marked sites across the Ghostlands. Each thread descended through the map into a stone beneath the table, where power beat with a slow, malignant rhythm.

Three acolytes worked around it. One read figures from a chained ledger. Another moved bone markers across the hide. The third stood with both hands spread above the buried stone, feeding a whispered command into the network. Beside the far door waited what the Scourge called a deathguard: an elven corpse riveted into tarnished plate, held unnaturally upright by iron braces along its spine. Shrunk gray skin clung to the exposed half of its face. One eye socket was empty; the other held a pinprick of corpse-light. Runes cut into its jaw and breastbone glimmered through gaps in the armor, each mark bound to the two-handed sword across its knees. It sat without breath or motion, but both gauntleted hands already enclosed the hilt.

The four blood elves watched through a gap where the archive door no longer met its frame.

Lethira pointed to the acolyte at the anchor, then to the reader. Two arrows. Theron indicated the deathguard and raised his shield a fraction. Rynel gave Falanaras the table and the third acolyte. He held up three fingers, preparing the count.

The anchor pulsed.

Power moved through the wall and across Falanaras's skin. The hunger behind his teeth sharpened at once. Beside him, Rynel stopped breathing.

One finger lowered.

A second pulse entered the room. The acolyte's chant rose with it. Rynel leaned toward the sound. His lips parted, and the tendons in his neck drew taut.

Falanaras caught his wrist.

Rynel tore free and entered the vault before the count was finished.

The first acolyte turned. Rynel seized the front of its robes and struck one gauntleted hand against its chest. Instead of breaking the spell, he dragged it straight into himself. Green light burst between them. The acolyte screamed as its working ripped backward through its body and poured into the captain's arm. Its skin collapsed against the hollows of its face. Rynel flung the corpse aside and reached for the next source before it struck the floor.

Lethira's arrow took the chanting acolyte through the shoulder instead of the throat. The broken count had spoiled her shot. Its command tore loose from the anchor and lashed across the chamber. Falanaras caught the current on his glaive. Pain burned from his palms to his elbows as he forced it down into the floor.

The deathguard rose.

Theron met its sword with his shield. The impact drove him back through the doorway, boots gouging dust from the stones. His bandaged side struck the frame. He grunted, reset his stance, and caught the next blow before it reached Lethira.

The third acolyte sent a fork of shadow at Rynel. He opened his hand. The spell bent toward him, gathered into a narrow

stream, and vanished beneath his skin. His back arched. For an instant Falanaras saw relief cross the captain's face with the terrible intimacy of pleasure witnessed by accident.

Then Rynel pulled harder.

The acolyte's spell failed. Its wards followed, peeling away in strips of green-black radiance. Rynel continued to draw after there was no working left to seize. Light streamed from the runes sewn into its robes, from the charms at its throat, from its eyes and open mouth. His shoulders curved toward the flow. His free hand opened and closed beside it, fingers hooked around nothing.

"Captain!" Falanaras shouted.

Rynel did not hear him.

The wounded chanter clawed at the copper stake nearest its hand. A red spark traveled down the black thread beneath it.

Falanaras abandoned the current on his glaive and crossed the room. He struck the acolyte's wrist aside, but one bent finger brushed the stake.

The anchor-stone awakened beneath the table.

A bell sounded with no metal behind it. The note passed through flesh and stone. Black threads snapped taut across the hide map, carrying crimson sparks outward toward every marked site. From somewhere above came the answer: chains dropping, doors slamming open, the first distant howl of an alarm moving through Deatholme.

The deathguard forced Theron to one knee. Lethira put an arrow through the rune carved in its jaw. Bone splintered. The construct's head snapped sideways, but its sword remained raised.

Falanaras drove the crescent of his glaive beneath the deathguard's breastplate. The blade crossed the runes feeding its sword arm, and power ripped out through the

wound. Cold fire burst between the iron braces as the magical loss became damage inside the corpse. A second working still hardened the two-handed sword and drove strength through its grip. Falanaras hooked that completed enchantment free and cast it across the room. Blue-green force closed around Theron's shield arm instead. He rose behind the stolen strength and struck with the iron rim. The deathguard toppled across the table, tearing copper stakes from the hide. Lethira's second arrow entered the exposed cavity in its chest. The remaining runes went dark.

Rynel still held the last acolyte upright. With his body bowed around the failing glow, the hard planes of his face had sharpened into hollows. His eyes burned too brightly beneath his brow.

Falanaras struck his forearm with the haft of the glaive. Once. Twice. On the third blow, Rynel's grip broke. The acolyte fell, robes smoking where the captain had touched them.

Rynel turned on Falanaras with green fire gathered in his hand. His shoulders remained hunched and his chin thrust forward, stripped for one terrible instant of every posture that made him a captain.

Lethira drew on him. Theron stepped between them, shield dented and blood spreading through the binding at his side.

"Captain," Theron said.

Nothing in his voice pleaded. The title carried years of obedience, training yards, failed walls, shared watch, and all the fallen they had left behind.

Rynel looked at the fire in his hand. His fingers closed. The glow leaked between them, diminished, and went out. His gaze followed the last thread of it with naked craving before he forced his eyes toward Theron.

Lethira lowered her bow by inches.

The alarm continued above them. Heavy feet entered a distant stairwell. The anchor under the table answered with another pulse. Rynel flinched, and his head turned toward it before he caught himself.

“Report,” he said. His voice was raw, though the command within it held.

Theron pressed one hand to his ribs. “Bruised pride. Open wound. Shield remains offensive to look at.”

“Valeflame?”

“I have six arrows less than I wanted and one more target than I expected.” She did not specify the target. “Fit to move.”

Rynel faced Falanaras last. The change was impossible to hide now. His shoulders had drawn forward; his cheeks looked hollow beneath overbright eyes; the fingers around his burned palm remained hooked after the fire was gone. Falanaras remembered the Wretched he had dragged from a Murder Row cellar, jaw slack and all higher thought narrowed to the nearest glow. Rynel had not crossed that final distance. He stood near enough for Falanaras to see it. “Dawnspear?”

Falanaras wanted to say unfit. Halduron’s order gave him the authority. The word waited behind his teeth while he looked at the emptied acolytes, Theron’s blood, and Lethira’s bow. Rynel had fed beyond need, beyond orders, and nearly turned on them when interrupted. He also stood between the team and the approaching undead, forcing his body back into a soldier’s bearing with whatever discipline remained.

“Fit to move,” Falanaras said. “After we take what we came for.”

Something passed through Rynel’s expression—gratitude, shame, or anger denied a proper object. “Then move.”

Falanaras seized the chained ledgers from the floor and cut through their links. Lethira found a lacquered map case beneath the dead reader's robes. Inside lay a narrow plan of Deathholme's lower passages, marked with the same black threads as the hide map. Several lines met at anchors set beneath gates and stairs. One continued east through a service route that emerged beyond the outer wall.

Their entrance lay north of them. The alarm marks had already turned red along that passage.

"The drain is lost," Lethira said.

Falanaras opened the first ledger. Columns of sites and symbols filled its pages. The register they needed was referenced beside a seal stamped deeper in the understructure. The copied line named a primary anchor and a control archive beyond the old ossuary stairs.

Their evidence had shown them the network. The command register lay farther inside it.

Another howl rose beyond the vault door. This one was close enough that dust sifted from the lintel.

Rynel picked up his glaive. The movement brought him upright by force. Green light moved beneath the skin of his throat, too bright in the gaunt hollows above his gorget. "We follow the anchor line to the control archive. From there, we take the eastern route out."

"Deeper," Theron said.

"Yes." Rynel's gaze caught on the emptied acolyte. He tore it away and fixed on the dark passage beyond the archive. "Before Deathholme closes around us."

CHAPTER SIX

Deatholme's Price

The first undead reached the archive before they reached the ossuary stairs.

Lethira heard them beyond the eastern door and raised a closed fist. Four sets of boots stopped among torn ledgers, extinguished runes, and bodies emptied of more than life. The alarm passed through the walls in slow crimson pulses. Each one pulled Rynel's attention toward the buried anchor beneath the ruined table.

Falanaras watched the captain's chin turn a fraction before discipline caught it. Rynel's shoulders remained hunched. The flesh beneath his eyes had drawn tight enough to show every sleepless hour, and his right hand kept closing around the memory of power.

"How many?" Rynel asked.

Lethira knelt beside the door. "Six dragging their feet. One trying very hard to remember how."

"Ghouls and a necromancer," Theron said. He shifted the heavier shield against his arm. Blood had spread beyond the fresh binding at his ribs, though he stood without leaning on the table. "The eastern passage?"

Falanaras consulted the narrow plan. The archive's eastern door opened toward a service hall that crossed the ossuary stairs. The command register lay below them. Their withdrawal route began farther east, beyond a primary anchor set beneath an old gatehouse.

"We need that hall," he said.

Rynel pointed toward the overturned table. "Dawnspear, bind the ledgers. Brightshield, door. Valeflame, take the

necromancer when it enters.” His voice rasped, yet the orders came in the old sequence, each name receiving a task before danger could become confusion. “Call every draw. Mine first.”

Lethira’s eyes rested on his hooked fingers. “And if you do not stop?”

For one heartbeat, shame made him look older than hunger had. “Stop me.”

Falanaras threaded the ledger chains through his belt and tightened the straps of his pack over the Sunstrider message case. The lacquered weight pressed between his shoulder blades. Rynel’s summons had passed into his keeping on the road; now the captain carried only his glaive and the ruin he had made of himself.

The eastern door burst inward.

Theron caught it on his shield and drove forward. The first ghoul struck the iron face hard enough to break its jaw. Lethira’s arrow passed over his shoulder and entered the eye of the robed corpse behind it. The necromancer’s crooked staff fell before the violet spark gathering at its tip could become a spell.

Rynel killed the second ghoul with the inner edge of his glaive. The third came low. He turned the haft, broke its forearm, and stamped its skull against the threshold. Every movement belonged to the captain Falanaras knew. Only the pause afterward betrayed him: his gaze fixed on the dead necromancer’s staff, where the interrupted spark still trembled.

“Rynel.” Falanaras used his name before the distance widened.

The captain struck the staff with his boot. Its crystal rolled beneath a shelf and went dark. “Move.”

They crossed the service hall before another patrol answered the alarm. Ossuary niches climbed the walls around

the descending stair, their contents long since pulled out and given weapons. A chain ran down the center rail. Every few breaths it jerked by itself, carrying the alarm deeper into the earth.

Lethira cut the chain at the first landing. The severed links lashed the stone and stilled. Above them, ghouls poured into the archive they had abandoned. Their claws scraped across the fallen deathguard and the emptied acolytes. One began shrieking over what Rynel had left behind.

The stairs ended at a gallery beneath the foundations. Blue tile remained on portions of the floor, faded remnants of the elven hall that had stood there before Deatholme. The Scourge had cut channels through it and filled them with black resin. Red light traveled along those channels toward an iron door at the far end.

Falanaras crouched over the nearest line. Symbols for gates, patrol routes, and grave pits repeated inside the current. "The archive is ahead. The network is changing the eastern route."

"Because it knows where we are?" Theron asked.

"Because it knows where the first anchor failed. It is closing every route attached to it." Falanaras followed the current with the crescent of his glaive held a finger's width above the floor. "If we take the register, we can identify which line controls the eastern gate."

A pulse swept through the gallery. Rynel folded around it. His glaive struck the tile, and both hands locked on the haft as though it were the only fixed thing in the corridor. The resin brightened under his boots.

Falanaras moved between him and the channel. Rynel's eyes rose to his face slowly. Hunger had pared away the reserve behind them. For an instant he looked ready to shove Falanaras aside and go down on his knees over the current.

"Give me a crystal," Rynel said.

Falanaras removed one from his pouch. He kept it in his own palm while Rynel drew. The measured light thinned at once. When the captain's fingers closed over Falanaras's wrist and tried to pull the crystal nearer, Theron set the rim of his shield against Rynel's forearm.

"Three," Theron said.

Rynel stared at the remaining glow. The tremor moved from his jaw into his hand. Then he released Falanaras and stepped back.

"Three," he agreed.

No one pretended the number meant what it had on the road.

The iron door had no handle. Nine command sigils covered its face, linked by thin strands of necromantic fire. Falanaras recognized five from the copied ward sequence and two from the ledgers hanging at his belt. The remaining pair changed whenever he tried to hold them in his sight.

"It expects an order from the network," he said. "I can imitate one, but the alarm will challenge it."

Rynel lowered his glaive across the corridor. "Then answer faster than it asks."

Falanaras set his palm against the first sigil. Cold entered his bones. He caught the command running beneath the iron, turned it, and spoke the opening sequence through his glaive. One sigil dimmed. Three others flared in challenge. He answered from the ledger. Behind them, the cut alarm chain began hammering against the stair rail again.

The last pair shifted. Falanaras drove the point of his weapon between them and forced their current apart. The door opened the width of a hand. Theron wedged his shield into the gap and heaved until ancient hinges tore free of the wall.

The control archive smelled of wax, old blood, and earth opened too long from the sun. Shelves held iron cylinders stamped with the names of ruined settlements. At the center stood a lectern built around a slab of dark stone. A register lay chained upon it, its pages made from thin gray hide and edged in brass.

A figure waited behind the lectern. It had once been an elf. The remnants of a magister's mantle hung from one shoulder, and silver wire held its split skull together. Both hands had been replaced with bundles of black quills that scratched orders across separate sheets without pause.

It looked at Rynel first.

"Open vessel," it whispered in Thalassian. "Come closer."

Rynel's whole body tightened. The quills rose. Green-black fire ran from their tips through the brass edges of the register, offering a concentrated current stronger than the one beneath the floor.

Lethira's arrow struck the creature through the mouth. It staggered, quills flinging ink across the shelves. Rynel did not reach for the magic. He brought his glaive down on the lectern instead, severing the nearest conduit before the offered current touched him.

The undead scribe screamed around the arrow. Sheets rose from every table and folded into cutting wings. Theron covered Falanaras while paper blades rang against his shield. Lethira vaulted a low shelf and drove her knife into the silver wire at the back of the scribe's skull.

Falanaras hooked the register's chain with his glaive. The first pull drew fire up the haft and opened both burned palms. He reversed the current, caught the locking spell at its hinge, and sent it into the broken lectern. Brass links burst across the floor.

Rynel killed the scribe with one thrust beneath the ribs. The magic inside it rushed toward the wound. His hand jerked open. Falanaras saw the choice arrive before the captain made it.

Rynel wrenched his weapon free and stepped away. The scribe collapsed with its power still guttering through the quills.

"Take it," he said.

Falanaras wrapped the register in the dead reader's mantle and secured it beneath his pack straps. Lethira swept the shelves for route cylinders while Theron braced the ruined door. The first impact from outside bent his wounded arm and drove a cry through his teeth.

"Eastern gate," Falanaras said, reading the opened page. "The primary anchor controls a descending barrier and three side passages. There is a service stair beyond it leading to the outer trench."

"Then we have what we came for," Rynel said. "Withdraw."

* * *

They left through a records chute behind the shelves while Scourge forces battered down the main door.

The chute dropped them into a passage so narrow Theron had to turn his shield sideways. Rynel went last. Falanaras heard him breathing behind the scrape of armor, each exhale rougher than the one before it. When the archive door finally failed, the captain severed a ceiling brace and sent stone crashing into the chute mouth.

The collapse bought them minutes. Deathholme spent them well.

At the next junction, the route marked open in the register ended behind a wall of red force. Falanaras found a secondary line and led them through a burial chamber where corpses stood packed upright in salt. Half woke as the blood

elves passed. Lethira cut their binding cords, and the reanimated corpses fell against one another before they could raise their weapons.

Theron's wound opened fully on the climb beyond. He left a dark print whenever his right hand touched the wall. Falanaras offered to take the shield. Theron shook his head.

"You have the register, the prince, and our captain's better judgment in your pack," he said. "I will carry one ugly piece of iron."

"My better judgment is walking," Rynel said from behind them.

Theron glanced back. "That explains the pace."

The answer might once have earned the smallest movement at the corner of Rynel's mouth. Now his gaze had fixed on the red barrier behind them. Power ran through it in heavy waves. He followed until Lethira stepped into his line of sight.

"The exit is this way," she said.

He looked at her as though returning from a long distance. "I know."

The primary anchor announced itself before they saw it. The passage vibrated under their boots. Dust rose from the joints between stones, and the hunger sharpened inside Falanaras until his tongue felt too large for his mouth. Ahead, pale daylight showed through an arched gate crossed by a curtain of red-black fire.

The anchor stood in a recess beside the arch: a waist-high pillar of black stone bound with iron bands. Threads entered it from the walls and emerged as one thick current feeding the barrier. Beyond the gate, a descending stair turned toward the eastern trench and freedom.

Lethira reached the opening first. She stopped so abruptly Falanaras nearly struck her.

Scourge waited in the side galleries. Armored corpses filled both approaches, shields locked beneath hanging cages. Two acolytes stood behind them with their hands joined around a suspended shard of sickly crystal. The alarm had not driven the garrison toward the intruders. It had driven them here.

"Ambush," Lethira said, already loosing.

Her arrow struck an acolyte's joined hands. The shard dropped. Both shield lines advanced.

Theron met the left line at the mouth of the passage. Falanaras took the right. A necromantic working hardened the first corpse's spear arm and drove the weapon toward him with strength dead muscle did not possess. He caught the spearhead on the crescent of his glaive, peeled the strengthening enchantment from the rune behind it, and cast the stolen force across to Theron. Green-black light tightened around Theron's shield arm. He broke the left line's first rank with a single shove. Rynel entered between them. His weapon cut once across a corpse's throat, reversed, and split another helm to the brow.

The second acolyte raised the fallen shard. Necromantic force gathered above the formation in a dark, turning mass. Falanaras reached for it with his spellbreaker training and found the anchor already holding every strand. The attack and the barrier were one working. Breaking either carelessly would bring the gate down upon them.

"Anchor!" he shouted. "It controls the strike."

Rynel turned toward the pillar. The concentrated current lit his face from below. His pupils narrowed. His free hand rose before he seemed aware of it.

The dark mass fell.

Rynel caught the falling mass on the runes of his glaive. The hostile working pressed for his flesh and found no easy

hold; its force drove him to one knee instead. He drew a hard, measured mouthful from the leading edge, thinning the spell enough to move beneath it. Then he set the crescent against the descending weight and wrenched its physical course sideways. The dark mass crashed into the locked shields. Corpses flew against the gallery wall. The crystal shard broke in the acolyte's hands.

A spear came through the opened line and entered Rynel below the rear edge of his breastplate.

He made no sound. He trapped the shaft under one arm, dragged the corpse close, and opened its throat with the rear blade of his glaive. When he rose, the broken spearhead remained inside him. Blood ran beneath his armor and darkened his thigh.

"Captain," Falanaras said.

"Finish the line."

They did. Theron held the passage while Lethira killed the remaining acolyte. Falanaras broke the last command rune on the right-hand formation and released the magic into the floor. When the final corpse fell, fresh howls answered from behind them. The archive garrison had found another route through the collapse.

Rynel leaned against the anchor recess. He had become terribly still. The pillar pulsed beside his face, and every pulse reflected in his overbright eyes. His blood reached the floor in a steady thread.

Falanaras opened the register across Theron's shield. "The barrier releases if the anchor receives a withdrawal command. It will close again when the network challenges it."

"How long?" Lethira asked.

"Long enough for two, perhaps three. Someone has to keep turning the challenge away."

Theron looked at Rynel's wound. "We carry him."

"You cannot carry yourself," Rynel said.

He set his glaive against the anchor. Green-black fire climbed the blade. His body curved toward it with an eagerness that made Falanaras's stomach turn. The power was enough to flood every empty place inside him, and the task required some of it. Beneath that abundance lay the ward's simpler purpose: receive a withdrawal order, open the passage, reject any command the wider network did not confirm. Rynel closed his will around that purpose. The danger lay in whether he could seize the ward without surrendering to what fed it.

Rynel drew once. The current entered him in a bitter rush, and his shoulders pulled upright. Before relief could become pursuit, he closed his hand, set the weapon's crescent across the flow, and guided the rest away from his skin.

The barrier shuddered open.

"Valeflame first," he ordered. "Find the outer route. Brightshield follows."

Lethira did not move. Her bow remained raised toward the rear passage, but her eyes were on him. "There is room for another hand on that weapon."

"There is room for another corpse beside it." Rynel's arms shook as the network struck back. "I have filled that position."

The approaching Scourge forces rounded the far junction. Theron stepped between them and the anchor, shield lifting despite the blood down his side. "Go," he told Lethira. "I remain offensive to look at."

She crossed with a curse sharp enough to serve as farewell. Theron backed through after her, catching one thrown blade on his shield before the barrier's fire passed over his armor.

Falanaras stayed.

Rynel's gaunt face tightened with effort. Each challenge from the network arrived as a completed order meant to close the barrier, burn the intruder from the anchor, or call the side passages shut. The runes on his armor and glaive kept those hostile commands from fastening directly to him. He skimmed only enough power to hold his wounded body upright, caught each rejected instruction where it returned to the anchor, and forced it into another branch of the same ward network: the closing command into an empty side gate, the burning current into a ceiling conduit, the pressure meant to crush his body through the floor channel beneath the Scourge advancing along the passage. Sweat and blood ran together beneath his gorget.

"I can hold it," Falanaras said. "You cross. We trade from the other side."

"You cannot hold this and the register."

"Then we leave the register."

"No." The word held the same finality with which Rynel had once ordered recruits away from a failing wall. "You said I was fit to move. This is where I moved."

The rebuke entered exactly where Falanaras's guilt had been waiting. He had chosen the objective after seeing what Rynel had become. He could blame rank, urgency, or the captain's remaining usefulness. None of them altered the choice.

Rynel's eyes shifted to the pack on Falanaras's shoulders. "The prince asked for an officer. He will receive one."

Falanaras shook his head. "Halduron decides that."

"Halduron will complain that I made his decision untidy." A broken breath might have been a laugh. "Then he will make it."

The undead were ten paces away. Rynel turned another strike into the side wall. Stone burst outward, and his knees

nearly failed. The anchor's light flooded the hollows of his face, offering more than the failing body could use. His mouth tightened. His hand did not open again.

"Captain," Falanaras said.

Rynel looked at him. For the first time since the vault, his gaze did not slip toward any light. "Take them home. Answer the summons. Those are my last orders, Dawnspear."

Falanaras crossed the barrier.

On the far side, Theron caught his pack and dragged him down the stair. Lethira stood three steps below with an arrow drawn past her cheek. Rynel remained visible through the red-black curtain, bent over his glaive while the Scourge closed around the anchor recess.

He shifted his weapon from controlling the ward to striking its source. The crescent bit through the anchor's iron band. Every remaining current met the blade at once. Rynel tore power out through the fracture, and the magical loss became damage inside the stone. Cracks raced down the pillar toward the gatehouse foundations.

The anchor split.

White-green fire filled the arch. The barrier vanished, followed by the ceiling above it. Falanaras saw Rynel once within the glare—upright despite the spear wound, both hands on the glaive, face set toward the collapsing passage while power tore free around him. Then the gatehouse came down.

The collapse threw all three survivors down the stair. Stone struck Falanaras's shoulder and tore the register loose. He caught its wrapping before it slid into the dust. Behind them, the passage disappeared under iron, rock, and bodies.

Lethira climbed toward the rubble.

Theron caught the back of her harness. "No."

She twisted hard enough to open his wound further. He held on. Dust rolled through the stairwell and covered them both in gray. Somewhere beyond the collapse, Deatholme's linked wards began failing one after another. Each rupture sounded like distant thunder under the earth.

Falanaras heard Rynel's order inside the noise.

"We move," he said.

Lethira looked at him with murder in her face. Then she tore free of Theron, turned, and led them down toward the trench.

* * *

The service stair ended behind a grate overlooking Deatholme's eastern ditch. Lethira forced the rusted latch with her knife. Cold rain struck their faces as they crawled out beneath the wall.

The stronghold had turned upon itself. One tower's ward-flames burned without fuel; another had gone completely dark. Ghouls crowded gates that no longer recognized them. Commands raced along broken anchor lines and returned changed, sending patrols toward empty courtyards while the three blood elves crossed the ditch below.

They reached the blighted trees before pursuit found the correct gate. Lethira chose no trail. She moved by root, fallen trunk, and the memory of ground seen only once. Theron lasted half a mile before his shield slipped from his hand.

Falanaras took it then. Lethira took Theron's other arm. Between them they carried him north while Deatholme's horns sounded through the rain.

At dawn they hid beneath the roots of a fallen tree. Theron drifted in and out while Lethira rebound his side with a strip cut from her cloak. Falanaras sat at the mouth of the hollow

with the register against his chest and Rynel's glaive absent from the weapons beside him.

He could still see the captain taking a measured current from the anchor and closing his hand while power remained. The image demanded meaning. Sacrifice offered the easiest one, and Falanaras distrusted ease. Rynel had concealed his hunger, endangered the mission, emptied the acolytes, and raised magic against him. His last choice erased none of it.

It remained his choice.

When the anchor opened itself to him, Rynel had taken what their survival required and stopped before need became surrender. He had spent the power on their lives and paid with his own. Falanaras could honor that without pretending the road to it had been noble.

Lethira tied off Theron's bandage. "If you make him a saint, I will shoot you."

Falanaras looked at her. She kept her eyes on the knot.

"I was not," he said.

"Good." Her hands shook once after she finished. "He would have hated the promotion."

Theron opened one eye. "He hated most things done badly."

They rested until the horns faded. Then they continued north.

Farstrider scouts found them near the first surviving Eversong ward. The green haze thinned above the road. Gold leaves appeared among bare branches, so bright after Deathholme that Falanaras could not look at them for long.

Halduron met them inside the gate of the forward post. His attention counted three before it touched the register in Falanaras's arms. He did not ask where Rynel was until healers had taken Theron and a ranger had closed the gate behind Lethira.

"Report," he said.

Falanaras gave him everything. He described the vault, Rynel's uncontrolled feeding, the command register, the eastern ambush, the spear wound, and the anchor. He did not soften the moment when Rynel turned on him. He did not improve the captain's final words.

Halduron listened without interruption. Rain ticked against the command lodge windows. The same border map lay across the table, now crowded with markers taken from the register's first pages.

"He told you to answer the summons," Halduron said when Falanaras finished.

"Yes."

"And you crossed."

Falanaras felt the rubble fall again. "Yes."

Halduron closed the register. "Then do not make his order smaller by wishing you had disobeyed it." His expression hardened before the words could become comfort. "You should have withdrawn after the vault. Rynel was unfit, Brightshield was wounded, and you knew both facts. The intelligence may save every patrol between here and the Scar. That does not make your decision wise."

"No, Ranger-General."

"You will write that in your formal account. You will also write why you continued. Command requires both." Halduron touched the Sunstrider case where Falanaras had placed it beside the register. "The company gathers in Silvermoon in five days. Rynel's place remains requested."

Falanaras waited.

"Captain Starweaver made a field recommendation," Halduron said. "I am choosing to accept it. Effective immediately, you hold his rank and his remaining command. Silvermoon will confirm the appointment before you depart."

The title did not feel like elevation. It settled over Falanaras with the weight of a dead man's armor, still warm where another body had worn it.

"Understood," he said.

* * *

Silvermoon confirmed the promotion beneath a roof Rynel had helped defend.

There was no ceremony beyond a clerk, a sealed order, and Halduron fastening a captain's insignia to Falanaras's formal mantle. The room overlooked a rebuilt avenue where workers were raising another crystal into place. Its green light entered through the tall windows and caught on the metal at his throat.

The recovered register had already changed the Ghostlands war. Two anchor sites were destroyed before Deathholme could relocate them. A missing patrol was found alive behind a warded ravine. Halduron listed those results without suggesting they balanced a life.

Afterward, Falanaras found Theron and Lethira on a western terrace above the military quarter. Theron had exchanged field bindings for a rigid brace and leaned against the balustrade with great dignity. Lethira wore Serenya's black-fletched arrow in her quiver among the red and gold of Silvermoon.

She looked at the insignia. "That was quick. Did they run out of better candidates?"

"One," Theron said.

Silence followed. It was brief, which made it bearable.

Falanaras placed the departure order on the balustrade. "I report to the southern quay before dawn. The company sails with the next tide."

Lethira read the names below his assignment. "Liadrin. Rommath. Astalor Bloodsworn." Her brow rose. "You have

found an efficient way to become the least important person in any room.”

“He has practiced,” Theron said.

Falanaras folded the order again. Beyond the terrace, the western quarter remained open to the sky where House Dawnspear had stood. Farther south lay the Ghostlands, Deatholme, and a grave they could not recover. Beyond all of them waited Outland and the prince whose summons had reached into Rynel’s last hours.

“Edric crossed our border,” he said. “Serenya helped hold it. Rynel died inside the place we were trying to take back. I leave tomorrow, and none of it feels connected.”

Theron looked south. “It will. Usually at an inconvenient time.”

Lethira removed the black arrow from her quiver and turned it once between her fingers. “If the prince has found salvation, ask whether it comes with competent border policy.”

“I will include it after the military questions.”

Theron held out his hand. Falanaras clasped his forearm carefully above the brace. Lethira refused any gesture that could be named farewell and adjusted the new insignia where Halduron had set it crooked.

“There,” she said. “Now you may disgrace the rank on your own.”

They remained on the terrace until the western light failed. Below them, Silvermoon’s wards brightened one by one. Falanaras felt each source as a quiet pressure behind his teeth. None drew his gaze away from his friends.

Before dawn, he would carry Rynel’s summons south.

The captain who had received it remained beneath Deatholme. The captain who answered would have to decide what that inheritance required.

Through the Dark Portal

The ship that would carry Falanaras south had been an elven destroyer during the Second War, built to hunt Horde vessels beneath skies fouled by dragonfire. Peace had stripped its weapons before the Scourge gave old hulls new purpose. The scars of refitting remained beneath fresh lacquer: sealed firing ports, patched rails, and blue-and-silver wardwork showing through blood-red paint. It had survived one war to carry them toward the remains of another world.

Falanaras stood at the foot of the gangplank with Rynel's summons inside his coat and a captain's insignia fastened at his throat. The metal had been straight when Halduron set it there. Lethira had "corrected" it afterward. He had resisted touching it since.

Along the southern quay, sailors loaded crystal cases, weapon racks, field chests, and enough preserved food to make secrecy look like ordinary military caution. Magisters inspected each warded crate before it crossed the plank. Rangers searched spaces already searched by soldiers. No banner named the company, though the prince's phoenix appeared on every order that mattered.

"Captain Dawnspear?"

He turned too slowly. The quartermaster waiting beside the gangplank noticed. Her expression suggested that grief, inexperience, and damaged hearing were equally inconvenient entries on a manifest.

"Twelve soldiers assigned to your file," she said. "Six spellbreakers, four conventional infantry, two archers. You

berth aft beneath the officers' deck. Your predecessor's kit arrived an hour ago."

"My kit arrived with me."

"His was in storage." She offered him a brass key. "The glaive rack is empty."

The clarification spared neither of them. Falanaras took the key and climbed aboard.

His assigned soldiers waited near the mainmast in traveling armor. Several had served under officers dead in the Ghostlands; he saw it in the disciplined care with which they avoided studying him. He gave them the marching order, the watch rotation, and the location of the emergency mana stores. Rynel's old sequence came to him without invitation: names first, tasks second, danger reduced until it could be obeyed.

When he finished, a broad-shouldered veteran at the rear saluted. "Sir Daric Sunward. I have the infantry." A scar crossed his mouth and pulled one corner downward, giving every word a disapproving cast. "Rynel Starweaver trained at the old eastern court."

"He trained me."

Daric's eyes touched the new insignia. "Then we will discover what survived the instruction."

Falanaras might have resented him if the words had held contempt. They carried only a soldier's demand for proof. "First watch is yours."

Daric saluted again. This time, approval moved faintly through it.

The quay bells sounded departure. Lines came free. Beyond the harbor wards, the Forbidding Sea waited under a gray morning, its surface pressed flat by distant rain. Falanaras searched the figures behind the gate until he found Theron's

rigid brace and Lethira's black-fletched arrow raised between two fingers. Neither had obeyed his request to stay away.

He lifted one hand. Theron answered. Lethira lowered the arrow with exaggerated care, as though concluding a threat.

Silvermoon receded behind masts and red-gold towers. The rebuilt portions caught the weak sun. Farther west, roofs gave way to scaffolds and open sky. Falanaras watched until distance softened the broken quarter, then hated the sea for making ruin look whole.

* * *

Lady Liadrin came on deck after the harbor disappeared.

Falanaras knew her before any herald spoke the name. The years had changed her clothing first. She wore dark traveling plate beneath a crimson mantle, without the white robes or temple gold that memory insisted upon. Her copper hair was bound high and severe.

The woman crossing the deck carried no staff. No holy symbol hung at her throat. Sailors moved aside for her with the alert respect offered to someone likely to assume command before asking who possessed it.

Grand Magister Rommath followed with two magisters and an escort whose ceremonial polish had failed to conceal field repairs. Rommath's crimson robes seemed untouched by the damp. His gaze moved over rigging, soldiers, wards, and horizon with the same impatience, finding each insufficient in its own fashion.

The senior magister beside him was Astalor Bloodsworn. Falanaras recognized the name from the sealed manifest and from warding papers copied throughout Silvermoon. Astalor was lean, silver-haired, and attending to the green fire along the gunwale with quiet, unmistakable interest. He held two fingers a breath above it as he walked, reading each change in the flame without disturbing the boundary.

Magister Selorien Dawnmark followed half a step behind with a slate tucked against his forearm. He had the drawn face of a man accustomed to confirming difficult conclusions and turning them into procedures a crew could repeat. “Master Bloodsworn, the ship's artificer asked to be warned before we assessed his boundary.”

“Then he should be informed,” Astalor said. The fire dipped at a stanchion. “There is a nine-percent loss here. The repair beneath it is conducting unevenly. Please ask him to join us when he is free.”

Selorien marked the slate. “I will find him before breakfast becomes a formal grievance.” Astalor's mouth softened at one corner. “Bring the repair record as well. If his work has lasted this long under an uneven load, I would like to know how.” Selorien added a second note. “A grievance and a compliment. He may forgive the inspection.”

Liadrin stopped before Falanaras. Her eyes went to his insignia and remained there long enough to acknowledge its freshness.

“Captain Dawnspear,” she said. “You carry Starweaver's summons.”

“I do.”

“And his command?”

“What remains of it.”

Her attention sharpened. Falanaras expected correction. Instead she said, “Remnants are the greater part of Quel'Thalas now. We have become skilled at making them serve.”

Rommath glanced back. “Lady Liadrin.”

“The deck will remain under us for another moment, Grand Magister.” Her eyes stayed on Falanaras. “Have we met?”

“At the inner gate during the fall. I was wounded. You asked if I could hold a weapon.”

Liadrin studied his face. “What did you answer?”

“Yes.”

“I remember the answer. Half the wounded lied to me that day.” Her voice held no warmth, yet neither did it diminish the memory. “Some lies are a bridge across one necessary hour.”

She turned to join Rommath. Falanaras watched her go, the remembered priestess receding beneath dark plate and a crimson mantle.

Every soldier in Silvermoon had heard what became of the high priestess after the Sunwell fell. Liadrin no longer served the Light she had once carried among the wounded, and she made no secret of believing that it had abandoned their people.

Some repeated the story with grief, others with approval, and a few with the avid certainty of people relieved to see sacred things fail someone more important than themselves.

Falanaras had never doubted the reports. The dark plate, the empty place at her throat, and the way Rommath addressed her as a military equal left nothing to explain.

What unsettled him was the memory of her certainty at the inner gate. She had believed completely while the kingdom died around her. Whatever had replaced that faith had been built from the same severity.

He watched her join Rommath without calling her back. To ask why she had turned from the Light would have been to ask what the fall had cost her, as though Silvermoon did not carry the answer in every ruined street.

When the breakfast bell rang, he realized his bandaged hands had begun to ache where no scars remained.

* * *

The voyage taught rank to surrender before weather.

By the second morning, three magisters had been sick over the lee rail, two soldiers had bruises from misjudging ladders, and Sir Daric had acquired the permanent stance of a man fighting the deck. Captain Althene Starwind, who commanded the ranger file, moved with insulting ease. She was spare, sharp-featured, and old enough to remember seas before most of the sailors had been born.

“Your infantryman is trying to threaten the horizon into stillness,” she told Falanaras.

Daric’s face had gone the color of old wax. “It has shown poor discipline.”

“Should I confine it?” Falanaras asked.

Daric considered the water. “At the first opportunity.”

The exchange earned a brief sound from Althene, too dry for laughter. It was the first time anyone in Falanaras’s file had spoken around him without weighing the dead captain between each word.

By the second afternoon, Eversong’s gold had fallen behind them. West of the ship, forested ridges rose toward Zul’Aman, their upper slopes hidden by cloud. Amani watchfires marked two heights even in daylight. No boats came out, but every ranger on deck watched the shore until the last smoke vanished astern.

South of the Amani country, the coast bore the same sickness as the Ghostlands without any surviving ward to hold it back. Bare woods reached down to black shingle. A ruined pier leaned into yellow water beneath the Eastern Plaguelands, and carrion birds rose from it in a single dark cloud as the ship passed. The crew kept well offshore and drew drinking water only from sealed casks.

Routine took hold. At dawn the soldiers drilled in pairs wherever the deck allowed. Rangers checked the coast from the foremast. The magisters fed power into the ship's boundary at noon and dusk, maintaining a thin distortion that made distant observers see an unremarkable trader riding low in the water. Falanaras inspected weapons, heard reports, and learned which of his soldiers hid shaking hands by volunteering for rope work.

The ship's mana allotment was measured twice daily. Crystal dust went into watered wine for the common file. Officers received small cut stones and the expectation that they would need less supervision. The first evening, Falanaras found one of his spellbreakers standing too close to the engine housing, breathing in time with its pulse.

He gave the soldier his own ration and reassigned him beside Daric until the glassy focus left his eyes. No accusation passed between them. By supper, the matter had become a change in watch rotation and nothing more.

"You report him?" Althene asked later.

They stood by the stern while the coast slid past beneath cloud. Forested heights rose to the west, dark with distance. Sea birds followed the wake and fought over refuse from the galley.

"He took the ration and returned to duty," Falanaras said.

"That was not my question."

"No."

Althene nodded toward the engine housing. "Rangers distrust dependence because we spend too much time beyond easy supply. Magisters call that superstition. Soldiers call it a problem when someone misses formation. Everyone becomes wise after the failure."

Rynel's overbright eyes rose in Falanaras's memory. "Then wisdom is late."

“Usually.” Althene rested her forearms on the rail. “You gave him your ration. Eat near a ward tonight. Quietly. If you fall over tomorrow, I will report both of you for making concern inefficient.”

He did as instructed. The nearest ward burned beside the chart room, where Rommath and Astalor spent their evenings behind a locked door. Falanaras sat outside with his back against the bulkhead and felt the green current ease the pressure behind his teeth.

Voices carried through the boards.

“The prince asked for capacity,” Rommath said. “He did not ask for a survey of every neglected mechanism between Silvermoon and the Portal.”

“Capacity without failure tolerances tells us very little,” Astalor replied. “Our readings show that the aft boundary is losing more power than its instruments report. We should understand the discrepancy before it chooses the occasion for us.”

Selorien's answer came lower. “I repeated the measurements from the engine relay. They support Master Bloodsworn's finding. I have given the captain a repair sequence that will hold until landfall without requiring him to dismantle the stern.”

The latch opened. Falanaras stood, expecting reprimand. Rommath looked from him to the ward and understood at once.

“If you require power, Captain, request it,” the Grand Magister said. “Starving discreetly remains starvation. It gains no virtue from manners.”

He passed Falanaras a crystal from his sleeve and continued toward the officers' stair. The stone held more energy than two standard rations. Rommath had offered it as casually as a commander correcting an uneven strap.

Astalor paused in the doorway. His gaze settled on the crystal. “That is a generous dose for you, Captain. If you are willing, note when the relief begins to recede. It would help us set the next allotment more accurately.”

Selorien shifted the slate beneath his arm. “I can add the observation to the ration record. The captain has enough reports of his own.”

“A sensible division,” Astalor said. He looked at Falanaras rather than through him. “One observation will suffice. We are trying to make the allotment fit the soldier rather than the reverse.”

“I will,” Falanaras said.

Selorien tapped the slate. “At last, a measurement the quartermaster may thank us for.”

“Then it will be rarer than the crystal,” Astalor said, with the faintest smile.

“I will leave space in the record,” Selorien said, following him toward the stair.

On the third day, the plague-gray shore gave way to the Hinterlands. Forest climbed from the water in dark ranks, broken by pale cliffs and narrow falls that vanished into spray before reaching the sea. Once, three gryphons wheeled above a headland watchtower. Althene tracked them until distance took them behind the trees.

The coast bent west and returned in broad, hazy reaches. River water stained the sea brown around them, carrying branches, reeds, and once the swollen body of a horse. By evening the wind had begun to sharpen from the east, and the sailors reefed sail while the shore disappeared behind advancing rain.

* * *

The storm reached them on the fourth night.

Wind struck from the east and drove the ship toward a coast hidden by rain. The first squall tore a foresail before the sailors could reef it. Canvas cracked overhead. A loose line swept the deck and caught one soldier across the legs, flinging him against the rail.

Falanaras reached him before the next roll. He hooked one arm through the rail and caught the soldier's harness with the other. Daric seized Falanaras at the waist while Althene cut the thrashing line. Salt water crossed the deck hard enough to blind them all.

"Boundary is failing!" a sailor shouted.

Green fire along the gunwale broke into scattered tongues. The disguise collapsed with it. For a moment the ship showed itself upon the open sea in full military aspect, crystal lamps blazing and crimson armor crowded along the deck.

Rommath emerged without a cloak. Rain flattened his hair and ran over his face. He lifted both hands, caught the broken ward-lines above the mast, and drew them together until fire stretched between his fingers.

"Astalor, aft focus. Selorien, keep the engine from compensating." His voice carried through the gale. "Liadrin, clear the mast."

Liadrin was already moving. She climbed into the forward rigging with a sailor's knife between her teeth, plate abandoned somewhere below. Two deckhands followed until a spar broke loose above them. Liadrin braced one boot against the mast, caught the spar's line, and took its full weight across her harness while the sailors crawled past.

There was no gold around her. No prayer reached Falanaras through the rain. She held because people were beneath her and released only when they were clear.

Astalor knelt at the shattered aft focus with one palm suspended inside exposed ward-fire and the other marking the current's pulse against the deck. Selorien worked at the engine relay under his direction, calling back each measurement and checking it against the relay's response. Green light climbed Astalor's wrist in controlled bands. He watched it with intent fascination, adjusting the angle of his hand whenever the current tried to close around him. His calm suggested mastery remained a reasonable expectation even while it burned him.

"Feedback is rising past the second limit," Selorien shouted.

"I have it," Astalor called. "On my third count, break the compensator. We can return the release to the boundary. One. Two. Three."

Selorien struck the compensator with the iron cap of his staff. The crystal split exactly as Astalor tore his hand free. The released current flashed across the deck and vanished into the restored boundary. Astalor caught the rail, steadied himself, and looked first to the ward above them rather than the burn climbing his palm.

"The boundary was three breaths from failure," Astalor said through the storm. "Record the interval. Reduce the aft draw by one twentieth, and next time we will keep the operator outside the current."

Selorien made the adjustment, then caught Astalor's burned hand and wrapped it without ceremony. "I will make that the first step in the revised sequence." Astalor surrendered the hand without protest. The finding was his; Selorien was already turning it into a procedure another magister could survive.

Falanaras secured the injured soldier beneath the quarterdeck, then returned to the mast with Daric and four others. They hauled the torn sail down hand over hand. The

wind pulled blood from their palms through wet gloves. When a soldier lost his footing, Daric took the rope across his own shoulder and roared until the man found the deck again.

The ward closed at last. The ship faded beneath rain and bent light. Westward, two pale lamps had appeared on the hidden shore. They remained fixed upon the sea for several minutes, searching, then turned inland.

“Observers?” Falanaras asked Althene.

She wiped rain from her eyes. “Humans, perhaps. Dwarves if we have offended good fortune. Whoever they serve, they saw enough to invent the rest.”

Rommath descended from the quarterdeck. Power still ran between his fingers in thin green threads. “Let them invent. Fear is often more useful than accurate numbers.”

Liadrin dropped from the rigging. Rope had burned a red line across one palm. She wrapped it herself and looked over the deck until every injured sailor had been accounted for.

Falanaras held out a clean strip of linen. “You left command to climb the mast.”

Liadrin took the linen and wound it over the first bandage. “Command remained on deck. The spar did not.”

“Another sailor could have taken the line.”

“Another sailor did. So did I.” She tightened the cloth with her teeth. “Ranks are useful while they put the right hands where they are needed. They become vanity when they excuse those hands from the work.”

Falanaras thought of Rynel bent over the anchor, taking what the escape required and spending it on the passage rather than his own hunger. “And when command fails?”

Liadrin flexed her wrapped hand. “Then people choose what the failure will cost.”

* * *

After the storm, they reached the waters below the Hinterlands and resumed their long passage down the continent's eastern edge.

The Arathi coast opened beyond a wide river mouth. Tawny slopes showed between bands of rain, crossed by old roads and walls too distant for Falanaras to judge as occupied or ruined. Fishing boats fled toward shore when the disguised destroyer approached, their crews seeing only a trader riding low and refusing to test the appearance.

Falanaras had spent years thinking of the world outside Quel'Thalas as forces pressing against its borders: Scourge from the south, human judgment beyond the mountains, absent allies, returning exiles. From the sea, those forces resolved into grazing land, woodsmoke, roads, and people hauling nets beneath banners he had been taught to resent.

Althene found him watching an Arathi harbor recede at dusk. "Disappointed?"

"By what?"

"That the wider world has ordinary laundry." She indicated pale cloth strung between houses beyond the seawall. "It weakens the grandeur of foreign enemies."

"They may wash it with sinister intent."

"Keep that thought. You are learning command."

Farther south, the coast grew harsher. In the Twilight Highlands, dark cliffs shouldered into the sea and storm clouds snagged on mountains beyond them. For two evenings a bruise of smoke rested inland above the country of the Badlands and Burning Steppes. Then the shore softened again, and red stone rose among the wooded slopes of Redridge, startlingly bright after the northern gray.

Late in the second week, the red heights sank behind reed-choked river mouths. The air grew warm and heavy. Marsh haze erased the horizon, insects struck the sails far from land, and the water darkened with silt from the Swamp of Sorrows. After midnight the crew altered course and followed a sequence of lights visible only through a magister's lens.

They landed at dawn in a reed-screened inlet where blackwater streams met the sea. Blood elf engineers held a narrow strip of firm ground behind layered concealments, with three low storehouses, a timber jetty, and a ward tower disguised as a dead cypress. Every face on the quay had the weathered, sleepless look of service far from Silvermoon.

They unloaded before the sun cleared the trees. No welcoming party waited and no local ruler claimed a toll. By midmorning the retinue had formed around carts, pack animals, and warded cases, then turned west through the Swamp of Sorrows toward the Blasted Lands.

* * *

Beyond the marsh, the land had been burned too deeply to recover.

Red earth broke beneath their boots. Thorn trees clung to gullies with roots exposed, and hot wind carried grit into armor joints, mouths, and water skins. The sky looked bleached near the horizon. Even the carrion birds circled without calling.

Falanaras had known dead places. The Ghostlands crawled with corrupted magic and the old pressure of the Sunwell's wound. The Blasted Lands offered an emptier hostility. Power did not pulse beneath the soil. It had passed through and left the ground exhausted.

By the second day inland, everyone felt it. Conversations shortened. Soldiers watched the warded carts too often. One

magister snapped at a pack animal and spent the next hour apologizing to no one. Rommath ordered the mana ration increased before any officer requested it.

“This is temporary,” he told the assembled captains. “Do not confuse endurance with deprivation. We brought sufficient stores, and stores serve no purpose unopened.”

Daric drank his portion and rolled his shoulders as relief reached them. “The Grand Magister makes indulgence sound punitive.”

“It improves compliance,” Selorien said. As Astalor's assistant, he was checking the emptied vials against the official allotment and a second record of field observations, repeating any comparison that failed to agree. “Pleasure invites debate.”

Astalor held his own vial toward the sun, studying the residue. “Please keep the local absence separate from our shipboard readings. The contrast should let us distinguish adaptation from ration decay. A miserable environment has given us unusually useful conditions.”

“After we reach the Portal,” Rommath said. “Until then, measure whether the column remains fit to reach it.”

Astalor inclined his head. “Of course. The column comes first. We will reserve the adaptation study until after we reach the Portal.” Selorien moved to the next entry, carrying the priority through both ledgers.

Their route turned through a ravine where old siege damage had fused stones together in black ridges. Althene halted the column at its mouth. Three figures watched from the heights, wrapped against the dust.

“Scouts,” she said. “Human equipment. They have been with us since noon.”

Daric rested a hand on his sword. “Do we remove them?”

“If they wished to challenge the route, they would bring more than three,” Rommath said. “They want numbers, names, and confidence. Deny the last two.”

The retinue entered the ravine without changing pace. Falanaras felt the observers’ attention follow the crimson mantles, green eyes, warded cases, and weapons. Outside Quel’Thalas, their survival had become evidence against them before anyone spoke.

Liadrin walked beside him after they cleared the heights. She had exchanged armor for a lighter coat, though the sword at her side remained within easy reach.

“You disliked being watched,” she said.

“They saw taint before they saw soldiers.”

“Perhaps. We saw enemies before we saw three tired men on a ridge.”

Falanaras glanced at her. “Should we be charitable?”

“We should be exact. Charity is often an excuse for seeing poorly.” She stepped over a split in the road. “They may despise us. They may also be correct that we are dangerous.”

“Does that matter?”

“Everything true matters. It need not decide us.”

Ahead, a cart wheel struck loose stone and broke at the hub. The warded case above it lurched toward the ditch. Daric and three soldiers caught the frame. Green light leaked through the case seams, and every blood elf within sight turned toward it at once.

The moment lasted less than a breath. It was still long enough for shame to pass through the column.

Liadrin walked to the damaged cart and placed both hands beneath the axle. “Lift,” she ordered.

They lifted. Soldiers braced the case. Magisters resealed the seam. No one named the way hunger had moved

through them. Work gave the column somewhere else to put its hands.

When the new wheel was fixed, Liadrin looked down the line. "We continue."

Falanaras heard more in the two words than movement. The prince had gone ahead through prisons, hostile kingdoms, and harsher roads, then sent back power, instruction, and summons. Silvermoon had made a creed from following because the alternative was to remain among its graves.

He touched the message case beneath his coat. Rynel had died to send another officer onward. Falanaras could honor the choice without pretending the road had chosen him kindly.

* * *

They saw the Dark Portal before sunset on the fourth day of the march.

At first it seemed another ridge standing above the red plain. Then distance yielded the pillars, vast and dark against the western sky, and the stone figures crouched upon them with their faces turned toward the road. Green radiance filled the arch between. It did not flicker like fire. It revolved slowly, depth opening where no depth should exist.

The column lost its conversations one by one.

Falanaras had expected a gate. Gates belonged to walls, roads, and hands that could close them. This stood alone amid the ruin it had caused, large enough to make armies look temporary.

Blood elf fortifications ringed the approach. Low barricades, ward pylons, and canvas shelters occupied ground scarred by older camps. Engineers moved among humming conduits that ran toward the Portal's base. Their apparatus

did not create the opening; it steadied what greater power had forced from the far side.

Beyond bow range, other watchers kept their own posts on the heights. Human standards showed in the late light. No one approached. Suspicion had arranged itself around the gateway and learned to live there.

A commander from the Portal garrison met Rommath beneath the first pylon. His armor bore Outland dust in pale streaks. He saluted the Grand Magister, Liadrin, and Astalor before turning to the captains.

"Transit is stable," he said. "The receiving station reports clear ground. Cross in ordered files, no pauses within the threshold. Keep eyes forward if vertigo takes you. If you hear voices behind you, they are carried resonance."

Daric leaned toward Falanaras. "I preferred the sea."

"You threatened it with confinement."

"It improved afterward, didn't it?"

Camp formed for one final night on Azeroth. Soldiers ate beside the ward pylons. Rangers inspected the road behind them as though Quel'Thalas might appear at its end. Astalor spent an hour questioning the engineers, listening as closely to their descriptions of the Portal's behavior as to the instrument readings. Selorien laid each answer beside the logs and marked the points that required a repeatable procedure. When the account was complete, Astalor thanked the engineers and sent them to supper. Selorien remained with him to reduce their findings to a sequence the next watch could use.

Falanaras could not sleep. The Portal's hum entered the ground and rose through his bedroll. Near midnight he walked beyond the tents and found Liadrin standing at the edge of the lit approach.

Green light moved across her face. For an instant it recalled the radiance beneath Silvermoon's gate, altered in color and stripped of mercy.

"Do you know what the prince wants?" he asked.

"Enough."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the portion you require tonight." She looked toward the turning radiance. "Tomorrow you will see a world where our prince found allies after humans imprisoned him, where our people learned methods Silvermoon now depends upon, and where survival has demanded more than it demanded at home. Decide nothing in advance. Watch what each necessity asks of the person naming it."

"And if I decide the cost is too high?"

Liadrin's gaze settled on the insignia at his throat. "Then know what you would let die instead."

She returned to camp. Falanaras remained before the Portal until the cold drove through his coat. The answer troubled him because Rynel had already given it another form. At the anchor, the captain had chosen what his failure would cost and who would live instead.

Dawn came red through the dust.

The retinue formed in marching order. Rommath crossed first with the garrison commander. Astalor waited beside the threshold until the engineers confirmed that the ward pylons had settled. He compared their count with his own instruments, thanked them, and entered at the prescribed interval. Selorien followed at his shoulder, carrying one case while Astalor carried the other. Liadrin entered alone, shoulders square beneath her crimson mantle. Green swallowed each of them without ripple or sound.

Captain Althene led the rangers. Daric took the infantry file. Falanaras stood at the head of the spellbreakers with Rynel's summons against his heart.

Behind him lay the sea road, Silvermoon, Theron's brace, Lethira's raised arrow, Halduron's rebuke, and a gatehouse collapsed over the man whose place he carried. Ahead waited Kael'thas and the answer for which Quel'Thalas had spent so much hope.

The Portal filled his sight. Its power pressed against every hungry part of him, immense and unreachable. Within the green, a second sky burned red.

Falanaras gave the order to advance and stepped out of Azeroth.

The Prince's Design

The first thing Outland took from Falanaras was the horizon.

He came through the Dark Portal expecting distance. Instead the world ended in torn red shelves beneath a sky split open by green fire. Fragments of land hung far above Hellfire Peninsula, their undersides trailing dust into emptiness. Beyond them, the Twisting Nether burned through wounds no cloud could cover. The sight gave his eyes nowhere safe to rest.

Then heat struck through his armor, dry enough to strip the wet from his mouth. His boots found black stone. The Portal released the rest of his file behind him in measured intervals: armor, glaives, pale faces washed green by the threshold. One spellbreaker stumbled and recovered before Daric could catch him. No one laughed.

“Count,” Falanaras ordered.

Names passed down the line. Twelve answered. Captain Althene’s rangers emerged next, already turning toward the broken ridges with bows half raised. Rommath and the magisters stood beside a bank of Outland machinery whose crystal housings throbbed in answer to the Portal. Astalor had one case open and both hands buried among the instruments. Selorien held the other case beneath his arm while recording figures on his slate.

The reception awaiting them consisted of twenty blood elf soldiers, two wagons, and a captain with a bandage darkening beneath his left pauldron. Their armor carried the prince’s phoenix, scored by travel and battle. No musicians sounded a welcome. No standard dipped for the

company that had crossed a world in answer to Kael'thas's summons.

The wounded captain saluted Rommath. "Grand Magister. The route west remains passable. We lost two outriders yesterday and drove off a fel orc patrol before dawn. If we leave within the hour, we can make the ravine camp before dark."

Rommath looked beyond him. "Where is His Highness?"

"Netherstorm. The campaign moved before your departure message reached us." The captain's gaze touched Liadrin, Astalor, and the sealed wagons. "The prince ordered us to bring you through without delay."

Falanaras had carried the summons down an entire continent and through the Dark Portal. Some quiet part of him had still expected Kael'thas to stand on the far side, bright-haired and impossible, ready to explain why Rynel had been worth calling from the Ghostlands. The foolishness of that expectation became obvious only after it failed.

Althene stopped beside him. Her eyes had not left the ridges. "You look disappointed."

"I look overheated."

"Already? Outland will take that personally." She turned to her rangers. "Water now. Cloaks over the bowstrings. If the air smells sweet, call a magister before breathing deeply."

They formed under a sun that seemed too small for the heat it gave. As the Portal shrank behind them, Falanaras looked back once. The green threshold stood inside its stone arch, the only whole thing in sight. Azeroth waited beyond it, close enough to cross and already unreachable by any ordinary road.

The column marched west.

* * *

Hellfire Peninsula taught them its distances by withholding shade.

For three days the escort led them between scorched ridges, shattered siegeworks, and pits where old bombardments had fused sand into dark glass. Fel iron spikes rose from abandoned fortifications. Once they passed a field of bones too broad to belong to a single battle. The Outland soldiers did not slow or name the armies that had died there.

The magical hunger changed in that wounded country. Power saturated the air in violent traces—fel seepage, old wards, ruptured currents from the Nether—yet little of it could be taken safely. Every breath carried the scent of a feast laid behind locked iron. Rommath ordered smaller, more frequent rations. Soldiers accepted crystals without comment and watched one another's hands afterward.

At the ravine camp, Falanaras found the prince's soldiers sleeping in armor beside ward pylons patched with draenei metal and demon hide. Their quartermaster greeted the newcomers by name, found Daric a whetstone, and pressed a cup of bitter stimulant into Althene's hand before she asked. It felt almost like a Silvermoon post until a pair of broken draenei constructs passed overhead under blood elf control, their blue cores caged inside crimson bindings.

"Salvage?" Falanaras asked the escort captain.

"A useful word." The captain tightened the bandage beneath his pauldron. "Out here, ownership lasts until someone stronger arrives."

On the fourth day, red stone gave way to a descent where the air cooled and thickened. Blue growth spread across the valley below. Giant mushrooms rose through violet mist, their caps broad enough to shelter companies. Water

gleamed between reeds and luminous pools. After Hellfire, the marsh looked merciful from above.

Its smell reached them first: wet earth, mineral rot, and a sweetness that coated the tongue.

Althene covered her mouth with a scarf. "Magister."

Selorien tested the air with a silver wand. "Spores. Irritating, mildly intoxicating, and likely to produce poor judgment in anyone who mistakes pleasant for harmless."

"That excludes the infantry," Althene said.

Daric adjusted his scarf. "We have survived the rangers' judgment so far."

At the marsh road, their blood elf escort halted. Figures waited in the shallows ahead: scaled torsos rising above coils thick as ship cables, polearms held upright in four-fingered hands. Jeweled armor caught the mushroom light. Some bore the severe faces of women; others had long jaws, fins, and teeth that showed even with their mouths closed.

The naga commander inclined her head to Rommath. "The path is prepared. Lady Vashj honors the prince's passage." Her gaze traveled over the retinue with the slow interest of someone inspecting cargo that might prove edible. "Your landborn soldiers will remain upon the stones. The deeper pools are not forgiving."

Falanaras looked toward Liadrin. "Do we trust them?"

"Count them," she said. "Count the paths they offer and the ones they keep for themselves. Trust is a luxury observation may later justify."

"The prince trusts Lady Vashj."

"The prince accepts her aid. Those are separate acts." Liadrin watched the naga slide aside to receive them. "Nothing in Outland is given. Someone paid."

They entered Zangarmarsh between naga outriders who moved through water without sound. The stone path twisted

among pools bright with inner color. Huge moths drifted beneath the mushroom caps, leaving silver dust behind their wings. Once, a reed bank opened to reveal huts woven around a dead fungal trunk. Broken baskets floated in the shallows. The naga passed without looking.

“Who lived there?” Falanaras asked.

The naga commander did not turn. “Those who failed to keep it.”

That night, camp stood upon an island of stone while the naga kept watch from the water. Falanaras took second patrol with Liadrin. Blue light rose around her boots. Somewhere beyond the reeds, something large disturbed the pool and settled again.

“They stripped that village,” he said.

“Probably.”

“And we march under their guard.”

Liadrin stopped at the island's edge. “Every ruin was someone's Quel'Thalas. Remember that before necessity makes the people beneath it too small to see.” Her reflection broke in the moving water. “Then remember that seeing them will not always give you the power to save them.”

“You make certainty sound cruel.”

“It often is. Being correct about necessity will not make terrible things less terrible.” She resumed the patrol. “Anyone who promises otherwise is selling comfort.”

* * *

Blade's Edge rose from the marsh in knives.

The naga left them at the first ascent, turning back toward the water after a final exchange of sealed messages. Blood elf outriders met the column beneath a rib of stone and led them onto ledges where two soldiers could scarcely walk abreast.

Spines from creatures larger than ships pierced entire mountainsides. Wind screamed through their hollow bones.

They climbed for two days. The path offered no level ground, only shelves, rope bridges, and steep cuts slick with pale dust. Falanaras moved his spellbreakers toward the column's outer edge where their shields could catch attacks from above. Althene sent scouts ahead and lost sight of them within fifty paces whenever the trail bent.

The attack came at noon beneath a natural arch. Shadows crossed the stone. Althene shouted before Falanaras found their source.

Winged shapes folded out of the glare—black hides, hooked limbs, mouths bright with gathered flame. The first bolt struck a shield and burst green across the ledge. A soldier went down with his cloak burning. Daric dragged him against the cliff while the infantry locked shields over both of them.

“Air ward!” Falanaras drove his glaive's lower blade into a seam in the rock. Six spellbreakers answered. Overlapping red planes rose above the file as another volley descended. The fel bolts struck armor, runed shields, and barriers trained to deny hostile magic an easy hold. Fire spread across them, hungry and corrosive, but the curse within it could not fasten to the spellbreakers beneath. Falanaras caught the leading current and opened its loose power to the whole line. Spellbreakers, infantry, and the rangers nearest the gaps drew measured threads together, thinning the volley while he turned the undrained force along the ward's edge. Daric dragged the first burned soldier beneath the cover. Green flame still clung to the man's cloak and tried to enter the wound. A spellbreaker hooked that completed burning into the ring of his glaive, lifted it whole from the soldier, and cast it onto a diving attacker. The creature's own fire closed over its wings.

Rangers fired through the gaps, steadied by the stolen heat. One creature spun into the gorge with three arrows buried in its throat. The spellbreakers cast their glaives at those gathering another volley. Each blade cut hide and tore power out through the wound; fel light burst inside the attackers as their lost magic became injury. Two dropped before they could release. Another struck the barrier feetfirst, claws shrieking across the red plane. The infantry beneath it seized at the magic in its limbs, their smaller draws weakening the force that held it aloft. Falanaras released the ward, stepped beneath the falling body, and cut upward with both blades. Black blood struck the cliff. The creature crashed across the path and nearly carried him over the edge.

Daric caught the back of his harness. “Your captaincy remains experimental, sir.”

“Then preserve the evidence.”

A deeper cry rolled above them. The remaining creatures scattered as something larger passed behind the arch. Astalor raised one hand and spoke a quiet phrase. Violet force gathered around a winged attacker and tightened. Bones snapped inside the field. He let the ruined body fall, then turned the same measured attention toward the larger shadow.

The great creature plunged through the opening, all horn, membrane, and furnace light. Rommath met it with a lance of crimson fire. Liadrin stood inside the blast, braced behind her shield as the creature struck the ledge. Stone broke under its forelimbs. Falanaras saw the path collapse in pieces behind her boots.

He crossed the distance before the thought completed. A mantle of furnace fire wrapped the creature's chest, fed its wings, and hardened the scales around its heart. Falanaras

caught that active enchantment between the glaive's blades. He took a measured surge from its outer heat to steady his grip, then stripped the mantle from the demon and cast the stolen fire across Liadrin's shield. Her iron face burned white-green without consuming. The creature's chest went dark and vulnerable. Liadrin drove the strengthened shield beneath its jaw. Daric's soldiers thrust together into the exposed throat, and Althene's arrow vanished through one cooling eye.

The creature convulsed. Falanaras tore his glaive free and brought both blades down. Its inner fire collapsed with a pressure that drove everyone to one knee.

Silence returned in fragments: first the wind, then the hiss of scorched leather, then wounded soldiers naming themselves for the count.

Falanaras helped bind the burned man Daric had pulled clear. His own hands shook when the knot was finished. The combat draw had been useful and controlled. The danger came afterward: the smell of ruptured magic filled his head, and every bright remnant in the dead creature called for him to continue though the fight was over.

Selorien crouched beside him and held out a narrow crystal. "Take it before you begin explaining why you do not require it."

Falanaras looked toward his soldiers. Those who had drawn from the volley were already checking one another for steadiness under Althene's supervision. Daric drank water with his back to the creature's leaking fire, the deliberate posture of a man who had taken enough.

He closed his hand around the crystal. Arcane warmth passed into him, controlled and thin. The corpse's pull receded, leaving the sharper recognition that his first draw had ended with the battle and his wanting had not.

Selorien watched his pupils settle. “Master Bloodsworn says a soldier who accepts the care he requires has no cause for shame.”

“And you?”

“I believe he is correct, though I resent having so little to improve upon.” Selorien rose and offered him a hand. “We still need you upright.”

They left the carcasses for the mountain and continued north.

* * *

Netherstorm announced itself with thunder beneath the ground.

The mountains opened onto a country broken into violet islands over an abyss. Arcane storms walked the distances in white columns. Bridges of iron and bound energy linked shelves that should have drifted apart. Far beyond them, Tempest Keep floated against the wounded sky, pale and immense, its towers lit from within by a radiance colder than sunlight.

Below the first ridge, Kael'thas had built a war.

Camps spread across three terraces behind layered wards. Smithies rang beside field hospitals. Magisters charted the storms from towers of red crystal and scavenged metal. Infantry drilled between siege engines whose frames combined Thalassian craft with parts taken from draenei constructs and demonic machines. Supply clerks moved through it all carrying tablets, ration lists, and the familiar expression of people who knew every victory depended upon someone signing for lamp oil.

The welcome there was louder than Hellfire's. Soldiers called Rommath's name. Officers embraced companions they had not seen since Dalaran. A magister from Silvermoon's old western academies recognized Astalor; Astalor answered

the man's hurried greeting with a slight smile before both of them bent over a slate and began debating conduit tolerances. Someone thrust spiced wine into Daric's hand and apologized that it came from a fungus.

Falanaras should have felt at home. Phoenix banners moved above red tents. The soldiers cursed in Thalassian when a wagon jammed. Every ward carried methods he understood, adjusted by field use until the old elegance had become spare and brutal.

Yet satyrs unloaded ammunition beside blood elf quartermasters. A felguard stood chained at a forge while smiths drew heat from the furnace burning inside its chest. Nobody stared. Nobody lowered a voice. The compromises that had followed the retinue across Outland lived here as routine.

Althene watched a young courier squeeze between the satyrs without breaking stride. "They became accustomed."

"So did Silvermoon," Falanaras said.

Her expression tightened. "Yes."

That answer unsettled him more than disgust would have.

They were assigned quarters on the second terrace. Before Falanaras could remove his armor, a runner brought orders for the captains to report at dusk. He left Daric arranging the file and followed Althene toward the command ward.

A lone figure waited outside the ward-line where the stormlight struck hardest.

He was sin'dorei. The long ears, high cheekbones, and red sash left no doubt. The rest had been remade. Black cloth covered his eyes, bound beneath swept horns that rose from his brow. Fel scars crossed his bare arms and glowed in the failing light. Two crescent blades rested across his back. He faced the Netherstorm with the stillness of a sentry listening to an enemy no one else could hear.

Althene's hand settled near her knife. "Netharel Suncleft."

The demon hunter turned his covered gaze toward them. "Captain Starwind. You brought the homeborn through alive." His voice remained recognizably Thalassian, though a second roughness moved beneath it.

"We had competent guides," Althene said.

"Then Outland is becoming generous." Netharel inclined his head toward Falanaras. "Dawnspear. You carry a dead man's command."

Falanaras felt the summons against his chest. "You know why we came?"

"I know why everyone comes. Need, followed by a name grand enough to command it." The demon hunter's mouth curved without humor. "You are wondering whether I regret what I became."

"I did not ask."

"You were polite enough to keep it behind your teeth." Fel light brightened along Netharel's scars as thunder rolled below. "Regret is for choices that can be undone. I ask whether the weapon still serves."

"And does it?"

Netharel turned back toward the storm. "Tonight."

The ward admitted Falanaras and Althene. Behind them, the demon hunter remained outside, guarding blood elves from dangers he had taken inside himself.

They crossed the inner court as a shivarra descended the command steps.

She towered over every elf present, blue-violet skin draped in black silk and gold chains. Six jeweled arms moved with separate grace. Two carried curved blades; another turned a goblet by its stem; the others rested empty, which made them no less threatening. Horns framed a face of severe beauty. Magisters stepped aside and bowed as she passed.

“New captains,” she said. Her attention settled on Falanaras with predatory courtesy. “Silvermoon still sends beautiful things into ugly wars. I am Xirathra.”

He gave the minimum bow owed an allied commander. “Falanaras Dawnspear.”

One of her empty hands lifted his chin before he could step away. A claw traced the air beside the scar at his jaw without touching it. “This one has begun to improve.”

Falanaras held still until she withdrew. Althene's silence had become lethal beside him.

Xirathra smiled at them both. “The prince's people retain their pride. Good. Pride gives pain somewhere interesting to enter.” She continued down the steps. The magisters behind her rose from their bows and resumed discussing siege intervals.

No alarm sounded. No ward rejected her. A line Silvermoon would once have guarded with fire had been crossed so often that no one heard the passage anymore.

* * *

The war room had been built around a captured draenei lens.

Its blue surface filled the floor and held a moving image of Tempest Keep. Towers revolved in pale light. Lines of force linked the fortress to its satellites and sank into the storms below. Red markers showed blood elf companies, siege engines, and planned breaches. Black markers named losses already accepted.

Kael'thas stood at the far edge of the lens.

Falanaras knew the prince from coins, proclamations, and portraits preserved through the fall. None had captured the force of his presence. Bright hair fell over a sweeping crimson mantle. A high red-gold guard rose above one shoulder. Three Verdant Spheres circled him in slow fire,

answering his smallest movements. He wore no crown. The room had arranged itself around him without one.

Rommath stood at his right. Astalor and Selorien had already opened their cases beside Master Engineer Telonicus. High Astromancer Solarian waited over the eastern projection, her hands bright with starfire. Voren'thal the Seer watched the lens with distant, exhausted eyes. Lord Sanguinar and Thaladred the Darkener held the military side of the table. Liadrin stood among them in dark plate, the only person present whose office Falanaras could not yet name.

Kael'thas looked up as the captains entered. "You have crossed far to reach us." His voice was quieter than Falanaras expected, carrying without effort. "Quel'Thalas has paid for every soldier in this room. I will not pretend the distance makes that debt smaller."

His gaze found the new insignia at Falanaras's throat. "Captain Starweaver?"

Falanaras removed the sealed summons and placed it in both hands. "Dead in service, Your Highness. He named me to answer in his place."

Kael'thas received the case. Grief moved across his face too briefly for ceremony. "Then his last command stands. You are welcome here, Captain Dawnspear."

Three sentences, and Rynel's death had entered the prince's war. Falanaras bowed. He hated how much the acknowledgment mattered.

Kael'thas turned to the lens. "We begin at dawn."

The plan unfolded in layers. Solarian described the storm cycles that would cover the first advance. Telonicus marked the siege engines assigned to break the outer conduits. Sanguinar's heavy infantry would draw the fortress defenders toward the southern approach while Althene's rangers

screened the western bridges. Thaladred would lead the assault through the first breach. Falanaras's spellbreakers were assigned to the central force under Liadrin, charged with suppressing hostile wards long enough for Astalor's magisters to enter.

Falanaras followed the sequence with a soldier's relief. Numbers of companies, crossing times, reserves, retreat signals: these belonged to a world where danger could be divided into duties. The prince questioned every delay. Rommath challenged the mana allowances. Astalor studied one proposed conduit, then declined it. "Its failure would seal the breach team inside. The western feed will carry less power, but it leaves us a second path out." Selorien revised the casualty estimate after hearing him.

They were prepared. More than prepared. The campaign had been waiting for the people named in the summons.

When every outer movement had been assigned, Kael'thas touched two fingers to the lens. Tempest Keep opened in luminous sections. Towers fell away. Corridors narrowed toward a central chamber buried behind the fortress defenses.

A white symbol burned there.

"The fortress matters," the prince said, "but it is not our purpose."

No one in the inner circle reacted. Liadrin's hands remained folded behind her back. Astalor watched the white mark with a scholar's quiet wonder. The pale radiance reflected in his eyes; he leaned a fraction nearer the lens, open admiration breaking through his habitual reserve. Falanaras understood then that some people in the room had crossed Outland already knowing what waited at the end.

Kael'thas looked around the lens. "Within the innermost sanctum is a naaru called M'uru. The naaru are living beings of the Holy Light—ancient, intelligent, and composed of the same power priests and paladins invoke. They created Tempest Keep as a fortress against the Burning Legion."

A stir passed through the officers who had received no fuller briefing. The unfamiliar word acquired weight by degrees: living Light, housed within the pale fortress, powerful enough that Kael'thas had built an entire campaign around reaching it. Falanaras glanced at Liadrin. Her face had gone still.

Rommath spoke into the silence. "The Sunwell fed an entire civilization without conscious effort from any citizen who depended upon it. We have replaced that inheritance with crystals, scavenged currents, and methods that fail most severely among those least able to secure them. M'uru contains a stable power unlike the stores we ration now."

Astalar adjusted the projection. Bands of crimson light appeared around the white symbol. He waited until the room quieted. "M'uru is magnificent. Its power is stable at a scale no reservoir within our reach can match. The chamber readings show that a layered matrix can contain the entity and govern the current without material loss during transport. Once it is in Silvermoon, we can begin the work of distributing that power on our own terms."

The room changed around the promise. Falanaras saw soldiers in Silvermoon straighten after feeding. He saw common quarters where children slept beside weak crystals because their parents could afford nothing stronger. He saw the fixed concentration in Rynel's eyes inside Deatholme and the captain refusing the anchor at the end. A source that did not diminish. Power enough to quiet the hunger before it stripped another person down to appetite.

The scale of the possibility quickened his pulse. If M'uru could give what the magisters promised, children might grow without learning to hide shaking hands. Soldiers could take the field without measuring every exertion against the next ration. Rynel's collapse would cease to be a future waiting inside anyone who misjudged one bad day. For the first time since the Sunwell's destruction, long-term relief stood before him as more than a prince's distant assurance.

Spellbreaker training followed close behind hope. Power on that scale would not travel quietly. A failed restraint could tear through soldiers, engines, and whatever road carried it home.

"You mean to bring it back to Silvermoon," he said.

Sanguinar looked toward him as though a junior captain had interrupted a funeral rite. Kael'thas only nodded. "Alive and whole."

Falanaras kept his gaze on the bands surrounding the white mark. "Can the binding survive the journey?"

Astalor indicated the bands around the white mark. "It can. The Portal crossing presents the greatest uncertainty, so the transport frame will carry an independent inner restraint and replaceable outer anchors. We need not ask one binding to survive every strain."

"And if it resists after the breach?" Falanaras asked. Apprehension sharpened the promise rather than diminishing it. An answer powerful enough to sustain Quel'thalas was powerful enough to destroy its escort.

The Verdant Spheres turned behind Kael'thas, casting green fire across the lens. "Then every layer of the restraint answers together. M'uru's nature does not exempt it from force, Captain. We have mapped the chamber, measured its emissions, and built redundancy into the extraction."

Rommath's voice followed, hard and level. "The greater danger lies in leaving our people dependent upon failing stores because certainty was unavailable."

"How soon after it reaches Silvermoon can the power be distributed?" Falanaras asked.

"Not immediately," Astalor said. "First we must establish a controlled draw and observe how quickly M'uru's power restores itself. If direct distribution proves unstable, we will test storage vessels and wardstone relays before widening access. Our purpose is lasting mastery of the current. Relief that exhausts its source is merely another ration."

Kael'thas enlarged the inner sanctum. "Lady Liadrin will accompany the breach team. She once served the power we intend to secure. If M'uru responds to any memory of that bond, she is best placed to read it."

Every gaze found her.

Liadrin's knuckles had whitened where one hand enclosed the other. She released them deliberately. The prince was sending a former high priestess into the presence of living Light, and she received the assignment as she had every other: by mastering the first visible reaction before anyone could mistake it for hesitation.

"I will go," she said.

Her answer set the room moving again. Astalor resumed, describing how the restraint pylons would overlap and how each failed layer could be replaced without opening the whole binding. Rommath revised the escort strength. Kael'thas assigned Falanaras's file to hold the inner approach while Liadrin and the magisters entered the sanctum.

Falanaras listened and understood his place. He would hold the inner approach while the magisters secured M'uru. If they

succeeded, the hunger that had governed every ration, every tremor, and every private failure since the Sunwell's destruction might finally face something larger than endurance.

When the council ended, dawn remained several hours away. Officers carried their orders into the camp. Tempest Keep shone beyond the wards, remote and pale above the storm.

Liadrin stopped beside Falanaras at the command steps. "You asked the useful questions."

"I would prefer our answer reach Silvermoon without killing its escort."

"A promising instinct in a captain." Her gaze remained on the fortress. "Do you believe it can end the hunger?"

"I believe it may be the first answer large enough." For once, hope did not feel like a slogan sent from somewhere beyond his reach. It hung before them in the storm, guarded by walls that could be breached and measured in duties he knew how to perform.

Below them, soldiers prepared the siege. Mana crystals passed from hand to hand. Blades came free of sheaths for inspection. Magisters woke the engines one conduit at a time.

Across the broken dark, M'uru waited within the pale heart of Tempest Keep.

At dawn, they would begin the work of bringing it home.

CHAPTER NINE

The Cage of Light

At dawn, Tempest Keep had lost the merciful distance that made it beautiful.

Its pale towers filled the eastern sky above Netherstorm, each curved surface bright against the violet dark. Bridges hung between the fortress and its lesser satellites without chains or visible supports. Blue fire moved through channels along their undersides. The storm below answered in slow flashes, revealing rock fragments adrift beneath the host as if the broken world were still deciding where to fall.

Falanaras watched from the forward assembly trench while Daric tightened the last strap on his shield. Around them, spellbreakers checked the emerald crystals set into their polearms and blades. Magisters moved down the line with baskets of mana stones, placing one in each waiting hand. No one called the ration generous. No one refused it.

Falanaras closed his hand around the mana stone and drew. Cold spread through his palm and climbed his arm as the crystal dimmed. Relief followed almost at once: the ache behind his eyes eased, his fingers steadied, and the fortress sharpened until he could distinguish moving defenders along the nearest bridge. The ration was enough for the advance and perhaps the first breach. Beyond that, enemy magic and discipline would have to carry them.

Daric rolled one shoulder beneath his dark plate. "I preferred the ship."

"You spent half the voyage insulting it."

“It never hung over a bottomless storm and invited me to walk across.” Daric looked toward the luminous span ahead. “A quality I failed to appreciate.”

The men nearest them laughed quietly. The sound did what Falanaras could not have managed with another inspection. Backs loosened. A soldier whose breathing had grown too quick forced it down into the cadence they had practiced. Falanaras met Daric’s eye and received the barest shrug.

Across the trench, Astalor’s restraint pylons stood on six low sledges. Their crimson bands were dark for now, the metal forks nested inward around hollow centers. Selorien passed among the teams with a ledger in one hand and a wrench in the other, correcting harness lengths and marking each change. Astalor inspected a hairline fracture in one focusing crystal, discarded it, and selected another without looking toward the fortress.

Liadrin waited beside the first sledge in blackened plate. She carried no priest’s staff, only a sword and a round shield scarred from Blade’s Edge. The coming encounter with living Light showed nowhere in her posture. Her stillness had the effort of a barricade built before anyone else knew an attack was coming.

Rommath crossed the assembly ground without an escort. Officers stepped toward him with reports; he answered each before they finished bowing. A failed western relay received two reserve crystals. A healer requesting more carriers received six soldiers from the prince’s household guard. When a magister warned that the storm cover might end before the second engine reached position, Rommath looked once at the fortress and ordered the engine crews forward early.

“The western crews will be exposed,” the magister said.

“Then Althene will screen them,” Rommath replied. “If the conduits remain intact, every company will be exposed.”

There was no speech before the advance. Kael'thas emerged onto the command rise in a sweep of crimson, the three Verdant Spheres burning above him. He raised one hand. Along the broken plateau, hundreds of blood elves became silent. Falanaras felt the scale of the army then: soldiers from a wounded kingdom standing beneath an alien sky, ready to spend lives on the chance that those left at home might someday stop measuring survival in mouthfuls of magic.

The prince closed his fist.

Solarian tore open the storm.

A lance of starfire descended through the cloud bank and struck the first outer conduit. The impact turned the horizon white. Siege engines answered from three ridges, hurling coils of red arcane force across the void. The fortress shields flared blue, vast and translucent, and the first barrage spread over them in burning veins.

Sanguinar's infantry moved south in ordered ranks, shields high beneath answering bolts from the Keep. On the western heights, Althene's rangers vanished into violet dust as if the landscape had taken them. Thaladred led the central force toward a narrow bridge of pale metal while engineers dragged the first breach engine behind him.

Falanaras drew his spellbreaker's glaive. The metal beneath his boots had begun to hum.

“Inner approach,” he called. “Stay with the pylons until I release you. Wards before defenders. If the bridge fails, trust the anchor lines and keep your hands off the storm.”

Daric lifted his shield. “You heard the captain. We have crossed too much ground to become weather.”

They advanced beneath a sky crowded with power.

* * *

The first defender reached them halfway across the bridge.

It came over the rail in a rush of blue metal and crystal, a construct with four bladed limbs turning around a bright core. Daric caught the descending strike on his shield. The impact drove him to one knee. Falanaras cut across the construct's center, felt an answering ward turn his blade, and reversed before the second pair of limbs could close around him.

The ward was elegant. It moved the force of his blow into the bridge instead of resisting it. Pale light rippled beneath his boots, carrying the impact toward the pylons that held the span aloft.

Falanaras turned the inner hook of his glaive across the pale current. The ward caught there as though it had found another path. Beneath its reflex he found a simpler command bound into the made creature: defend the bridge, answer the nearest hostile force. He closed his will around that purpose and changed what the construct recognized. Its blades stuttered, then turned away from Daric. When more constructs dropped from beneath the rail, the seized guardian met them in a collision of blue metal. Two went over the edge together. The command tore loose before Falanaras could preserve it. Daric rose under the first construct's failing weight and drove the shield rim into its crystal core. Two soldiers struck with him. Blue fragments streamed away into the storm.

The surviving constructs regrouped beneath the bridge. Behind them came armored draenei, tall figures in pale plate whose crystal-headed weapons shone with the same blue-white power running through the Keep. They formed around the nearest support arch rather than charging. The

first rank planted shields. The second raised glowing staves.

“Ward front,” Falanaras warned.

The draenei released their spell. A wall of force swept along the span, bright enough to erase armor and faces. Falanaras set his glaive’s point against the bridge and opened every ward fixed into his armor. The spell struck. Its command pressed for flesh and found the spellbreakers armored against its hold; heat entered their bones, but the force could not impose its full effect. Behind them, infantry, haulers, and magisters drew disciplined measures from the loose radiance, thinning the attack while the spellbreakers’ runed armor and weapons denied the remaining pressure a full purchase. The ward crystals at Falanaras’s shoulders screamed under what remained.

He could not hold it. Holding had never been the work.

“Break left!”

At his signal, the spellbreakers turned their glaives left. The runes along their armor and weapons continued denying the wall its full hold while the whole file changed angle beneath it. They did not steal the spell. They gave its remaining physical force a slanted surface and a weaker path. The blue pressure skidded west across the hooked blades and swept into the draenei’s own outer rank, casting shields, staves, and armored bodies against the rail. Daric’s infantry surged through the cleared center. Shield met shield. The bridge filled with the blunt violence of close ranks: metal battering plate, boots slipping in blood, blades finding the seams beneath arms.

A draenei defender struck down one of the pylon haulers and turned toward the exposed sledge. Liadrin intercepted him. Her shield took the crystal hammer high; her sword entered beneath his breastplate. She wrenched it free, caught

the falling harness before it slid from the bridge, and thrust it into another soldier's hands.

"The burden moves," she said. "So do you."

The soldier seized the straps. Liadrin moved on before gratitude could slow either of them.

A green signal burst over the western satellite. Althene's rangers had taken the first firing platform. Their arrows began crossing the central span, black lines against the fortress glow. One struck a draenei caster through the wrist. Another shattered the focus above him. The remaining ward collapsed, and Thaladred's forward infantry drove the defenders back beneath the outer arch.

Then the Keep answered through the bridge itself.

The pale metal split along a line beneath the third sledge. One hauler disappeared before he could cry out. The sledge tipped after him, its restraint fork grinding across the deck. Selorien threw himself onto the rear brace and caught it with both arms. The harness snapped taut around his waist.

Falanaras reached him with Daric. Together they dragged the pylon back while the gap widened under their boots. Astalor took in the missing hauler, the harness cutting into Selorien's waist, and the blue power pulsing through the exposed interior. He ordered the remaining crews off the fractured section, then knelt at the edge.

"The support current cycles through four pulses," Astalor said, his voice quiet and level. "The third can be suppressed. That will open an interval."

Selorien watched the luminous channels, still gasping against the harness. "Confirmed. The next interval will reach the western fork."

"Good." Astalor drove a copper probe between two luminous channels. "Captain, suppress the third pulse."

Magister Dawnmark, reverse the pylon on my mark. We will support the bridge long enough to clear our people.”

They obeyed. Falanaras caught the rising current and crushed it flat. Selorien forced power through the restraint pylon in the wrong direction. Astalor turned the probe. Crimson force entered the bridge’s wounded support and held the split closed long enough for the remaining sledges and soldiers to cross.

The bridge collapsed behind them.

For several heartbeats, Falanaras heard only the long metallic groan of the span falling into Netherstorm. Then the outer doors opened under Thaladred’s assault, and the army poured into Tempest Keep.

* * *

Inside, the fortress resisted them with light.

It ran through walls without lamps, gathered beneath each arch, and moved in quiet patterns across the floor. There was no soot, no dust, no stale air from sealed rooms. Tempest Keep felt awake. Every surface carried the presence of its makers, and the blood elves entered it trailing smoke, blood, and the sharp green scent of fel-fed armor.

The central force divided at the first junction. Thaladred drove east toward the defensive nexus. Sanguinar’s companies struck upward to keep the remaining garrison from concentrating around the shrine. Falanaras followed Liadrin and Astalor into a descending corridor with Daric’s infantry, Selorien’s magisters, and four surviving restraint pylons.

The loss of two pylons did not shake Astalor’s certainty that elven magic could master the task. It made him more deliberate about the danger. He redistributed the remaining emitters into a square configuration, then removed three

safety limiters from their focusing crowns while Selorien recorded each alteration.

“Four emitters will form the square,” Selorien said after checking Astalor’s revised scheme. “There will be no reserve if the field recoils.”

“The original limits would deny us the strength to contain our objective,” Astalor replied. “We will accept the greater discharge.”

“The open sides of the crowns will take it first.”

Astalor glanced at the scorched leather around Selorien’s waist and nodded. “Then no one will stand there. Mark each convergence, keep the crews behind the housings, and repeat the warning before every activation.”

Selorien marked the page and raised his voice to the haulers. “You heard the magister. When the crowns open, remain behind the red housing. If a pylon turns, move with the housing and do not cross its open side.”

The corridor bent inward. The noise of the larger battle faded behind layers of sealed crystal. Falanaras began to hear another sound beneath the alarms: a low sequence of tones, too measured for machinery and too resonant for any instrument he knew. Each note settled in his chest. The ache left by the morning ration stirred, then quieted as if listening.

Liadrin heard it. Her next step shortened before discipline restored it.

A white barrier dropped across the passage. Astalor’s forward magister touched it and screamed. Fire climbed his arm beneath the skin. Liadrin seized the back of his harness and pulled him clear while Falanaras caught the barrier’s outer edge with his blade. The magic was unlike the construct wards. It did not redirect force. It entered

whatever touched it and demanded an answer from the will inside.

For one searing instant he remembered Edric at the ruined way station, gold radiance held around wounded bodies while the Scourge pressed in. He remembered Liadrin among Silvermoon's refugees, spending strength on strangers because faith had once made that use seem inevitable.

The barrier found no such faith in him. It found duty, hunger, grief, and a refusal to release the weapon in his hand.

"Now," Rommath said behind him.

The Grand Magister's spell entered through the weaknesses Falanaras held open. Red and gold light spread across the white barrier in branching fractures. Rommath did not attempt to understand the defense on its own terms. He fed power into every exposed fault until the working burst inward and left both of them smoking at the threshold.

Rommath stepped over the ruined line. Blood ran from one nostril. "The reserve has secured the upper junction. We have one hour before the fortress redirects enough power to isolate this wing."

"The wounded need evacuation," Liadrin said. The burned magister lay breathing in shallow jerks at her feet. Two soldiers had already lifted him onto a shield.

"The western route remains open." Rommath looked at the men carrying the shield. "Take everyone who cannot fight. Return with no one. Your work is to bring them out."

It was an order to retreat and an order to save lives, given in the same hard tone he used for ammunition. The carriers turned back. Rommath faced the inner corridor.

"Silvermoon has buried enough people while waiting for power to arrive by grace," he said. "Move."

They moved.

The next defenders fought to delay rather than kill. Small groups withdrew behind seals, forcing Falanaras to spend strength breaking each one while constructs struck from wall recesses and vanished before Daric could pin them. Time became another enemy. Every pause meant the fortress gathering itself around the central wing.

At the final junction, draenei vindicators held a circular stair beneath an arch of living crystal. There were fewer than twenty. Their armor was broken, and several bled through bandages tied in haste. They had chosen the place where numbers mattered least.

One called to the blood elves in accented Common. “Leave this chamber.”

No one answered. Falanaras saw the vindicator understand before the charge began. These invaders had crossed a dying world, a sea, half a continent, and the Dark Portal for what lay behind him. A warning could not send them home.

The stair became a crush of shields and radiant weapons. Daric took the center. Around him, blood elf soldiers drew measured currents from the gold strengthening draenei armor, limbs, and crystal blades, dulling each advantage through ordinary sin’dorei practice before closing with its bearer. The spellbreakers worked differently. Thrown glaives cut vindicators and caster-defenders through arm or thigh; power tore out after the blades, and the sudden loss burned through flesh from within. Others hooked completed weapon enchantments away and sent them across the line. Gold hardened Daric’s shield arm. A stolen edge of radiance settled along Liadrin’s sword. Falanaras stayed half a pace behind Daric’s right shoulder, read the most intricate working, and stripped the force from a crystal spear aimed at Daric’s throat. He took only enough loose

warmth to steady his numb shoulder, then sent the intact strengthening effect into his glaive. The charged crescent broke the spear.

Liadrin fought on the left. A vindicator's hammer split her shield and drove her against the rail. She abandoned the wreckage, caught his next swing on the strong of her blade, and stepped inside his reach. When he fell, she took the hammer in her free hand and used it to shatter the crystal brace protecting the stair's final seal.

Daric's shield buckled. Falanaras's left shoulder went numb beneath a glancing blow. Selorien lost two magisters to a burst of white fire and dragged a third behind the pylon housing himself. Astalor remained crouched at the seal, his calm attention fixed on the Light moving through it while violence closed around him.

"The seal is reading intent as well as power," Astalor called through the clash of weapons.

Selorien parried a blade with his staff. "The response confirms it. Force alone will keep the way closed."

Astalor glanced toward Liadrin. "Then we will not force it. The seal recognizes the Light. Give it what it was made to welcome."

Liadrin stared at the crystal arch. The tones beyond it had grown strong enough to tremble through the rail beneath her hand.

"I have none to give it," she said.

The last vindicator lunged for her. A completed holy enchantment wrapped his crystal weapon, lending the strike a radiance the arch recognized. Falanaras caught that working on the hook of his glaive and peeled it from the hammer before it landed. He did not disperse it. He reassigned the stolen Light to the crystal doors. Gold entered the arch in branching veins.

The doors opened.

* * *

The shrine contained no throne.

It was a round chamber open through its center to the storm below. Slender arches leaned inward without meeting, their crystal surfaces filled with slow-moving constellations. At the far side, a platform floated over the open shaft. White-gold radiance filled the air above it.

M'uru turned toward them.

Falanaras had expected a creature wearing Light as armor. The naaru had no flesh to separate from its power. Faceted limbs revolved around a hollow center brighter than the sunlit glass of Silvermoon. Runes traveled along its crystalline body and vanished into the brilliance at its heart. The tones he had heard through the fortress came from M'uru without breath or instrument, immense chords reduced by distance into something his bones could endure.

Every hunger in him went still.

Relief arrived without feeding, brief and total. The emptiness left by the Sunwell seemed to recognize what stood before him. Men behind Falanaras lowered weapons by inches. One began to weep with no sound. Daric's damaged shield slipped against the floor, and he did not correct it.

Liadrin crossed the threshold last. The Light touched her face. For a heartbeat, the woman at Falanaras's side vanished beneath the memory of the high priestess at Silvermoon's inner gate: hands bright over the wounded, voice hoarse from prayer, faith offered against the end of everything.

Then Liadrin's mouth hardened. The memory belonged to him. Whatever she faced in M'uru's radiance was her own.

No defenders waited inside. No weapon rose from the platform. M'uru watched the blood elves bring four crimson pylons into the shrine and place them around its light. Astalor

stood beside the first sledge, his gaze following the great crystalline forms as they revolved. Wonder entered his face without disguise even while his apparatus encircled the being before him.

“Extraordinary.” He inclined his head toward M’uru, then rested one hand on the control focus. “Take your positions.”

His magisters opened the restraint crowns. Curved forks unfolded toward M’uru. Crimson lines joined the pylons into a square, each one wavering where it crossed the white radiance. Selorien checked the distance twice, confirmed each position against the ledger, and directed the haulers behind the housings before reporting the square ready.

Rommath entered with Kael’thas and the surviving household guard. The prince bore a cut across one cheek. One Verdant Sphere burned lower than the others, its fire unsteady, yet triumph had made him look more like the portraits than he had in the war room.

Kael’thas stopped before the containment square. M’uru’s revolving limbs inclined toward him. A sequence of notes passed through the chamber. The prince’s expression shifted, too slight for Falanaras to name.

“Will it answer you?” Rommath asked Liadrin.

She stood close enough that white light filled the scars on her gauntlets. “It already has.”

“What did it say?” Falanaras asked.

Liadrin looked at M’uru. “Nothing I can make smaller by speaking.”

Astalar studied the four control readings, then raised his hand over the focus. “The matrix is aligned. We will begin containment.”

The crimson square rose into a cage.

Bands of force climbed around M’uru, crossed above it, and tightened. Falanaras braced for the violence Kael’thas had

planned against: a burst of Holy power, shattered pylons, soldiers burned away before they understood resistance had begun.

M'uru did not strike.

The naaru descended from the floating platform and entered the restraint square. Its light passed through the first band without effort, then drew inward until the crimson line could close around it. One faceted limb turned toward a pylon and halted a finger's breadth from the housing. The machine trembled. M'uru withdrew rather than break it.

Astalar's hand remained above the focus. Surprise showed only in a slight narrowing of his eyes, followed by an almost reverent attention. "Remarkable. The field has closed without opposition."

Selorien checked the four readings in sequence. "Confirmed. There is no pressure against any crown."

Astalar looked from the instruments to M'uru. "Then the naaru is permitting us to hold it." No one contradicted him.

Beyond the shrine, the fortress alarms began to fail one by one. Each silence marked another blood elf objective secured. The campaign had succeeded. The outer conduits were broken, the defensive nexus taken, the surviving garrison divided, and the power at the center of it all stood within Astalar's cage.

Falanaras wanted the success to feel complete. He thought of Silvermoon's dim common rooms, of soldiers watching one another's hands for tremors, of Rynel bowed over stolen power in Deatholme. M'uru might end that inheritance. The promise had become more credible with every step toward the shrine.

It had also watched them arrive and chosen not to stop them.

That willingness entered the victory and remained there.

* * *

They carried M'uru out through a conquered fortress.

The four pylons locked into a levitating frame around the naaru. Crimson bands held their square while white radiance spilled between them, washing blood from its color and laying bright paths across the walls. Soldiers stepped aside as the frame passed. Some bowed. Others stared with the naked concentration of the starving before a feast.

The wounded lifted their heads. One elf with a bandage wrapped across both eyes reached toward the warmth until a healer caught his wrist. M'uru's tones moved through them all, gentle enough to make the chains around it seem harsher.

No one fed. Astalor had forbidden contact until the matrix could be tested under controlled conditions. The order traveled ahead of the procession, repeated by officers and enforced by guards. Falanaras heard disappointment sharpen into irritation along the ranks, then vanish beneath discipline.

At the broken outer arch, Althene waited with seven of the rangers who had taken the western platform. Blood had dried down one side of her neck. Her left sleeve was burned away from shoulder to wrist.

She looked past Falanaras to the cage. "That is what we came for?"

"Yes."

Althene studied the open storm behind it, the unbroken pylons, and the blood elves escorting it with weapons drawn. "How difficult was the restraint?"

Falanaras glanced at Selorien. The magister's ledger remained closed beneath one arm. "It came with us."

Althene's gaze returned to M'uru. Her expression did not change, but she asked no more questions.

The return bridge had been secured from the western satellite. Below it, wreckage from the assault turned slowly in the storm. Daric walked beside Falanaras with his ruined shield strapped across his back and one hand pressed to a cut beneath his ribs.

“You were right,” Daric said.

“About what?”

“The bridge was worse than the ship.” His eyes stayed on the white figure within the cage. “I have not decided about the rest.”

Neither had Falanaras.

The staging grounds saw the radiance before they saw the returning soldiers. Figures emerged from trenches and repair tents. Work stopped along the siege lines. When Kael'thas stepped onto the plateau behind M'uru's frame, the first cheer began among Sanguinar's infantry and spread across the camp.

The sound rolled over Falanaras in waves. Bloodied soldiers raised weapons. Magisters who had spent the night counting losses embraced beside their engines. Someone cried, “For Quel'Thalas,” and hundreds answered until the fractured land seemed to carry the name homeward.

Falanaras joined them. His voice broke against the last syllable. The victory was real. Men and women had died to secure it. The source within the cage might spare others from Rynel's end, from the Wretched quarters, from years of rationed weakness and private shame. Refusing to name that hope would have been another kind of dishonesty.

M'uru made no sound above the cheering.

Later, after Astalor's teams had anchored the cage inside the command ward and guards had cleared the curious from its perimeter, Falanaras found Liadrin standing beyond

the outer line. The Light painted one side of her armor white. The other remained black against Netherstorm.

“You said it answered,” he said.

“It saw us.”

“That is not the same.”

“No.” Liadrin watched the bands pass over M’uru’s revolving limbs. “It is worse.”

The admission struck harder for its lack of defense. Falanaras had expected her severity to offer a way around what happened in the shrine. Instead she held her gaze on it.

“Then why did it come?” he asked.

“I do not know.” Her voice was low. “Perhaps it knows more of the road ahead than we do. Perhaps mercy can look like surrender when seen from the wrong end of time. Perhaps it judged us and found resistance less useful than witness.”

“We mean to imprison a living being and take its Light into ourselves.”

Liadrin turned to him. Her face held the exhaustion of the battle and something older that the shrine had uncovered.

“Yes.”

“You do not hesitate.”

“I served the Light while our kingdom died,” she said. “I know what it means to profane what I once held sacred. M’uru’s power could steady our soldiers, preserve our children, and keep hunger from finishing what the Scourge began. We have chained a being who offered us no violence, and we intend to take what belongs to it. Say the wrong plainly. Then remember whom we commit it to save.”

Her answer offered no pardon and sought none. Liadrin placed the wrong beside the need without allowing either to erase the other, then moved forward under both. Falanaras understood why soldiers would follow her, even beneath the

burden of what they had done. The act remained unrighteous, and responsibility became impossible to evade.

Inside the command ward, Astalor began the first containment measurements. Magisters adjusted the pylons without drawing from their captive. Kael'thas stood over the results while Rommath dispatched casualty rolls and orders for the return route. The machinery of victory resumed around the being who had permitted it.

M'uru turned within the crimson bands. White-gold light passed over Falanaras, Liadrin, the guards, and the blood drying on the ground. Its tones began again, quiet enough to hear beneath the storm.

At dawn, Falanaras had believed they were marching toward an answer.

By nightfall, the answer was marching with them.

CHAPTER TEN

A Light Beneath the City

By morning, Astalor had built a mouth into the cage.

The device hung between two of the surviving pylons: a narrow ring of crimson metal inscribed with channels too fine to see until power entered them. Three conduits ran from the ring to a waist-high receiving frame. Beyond it, M'uru turned within the restraint field, white-gold radiance sliding through the bands in slow pulses.

The Sunfury command ward had been cleared of everyone without a stated purpose. Kael'thas stood at the forward line with Rommath and Liadrin. Lord Sanguinar watched from his right, one hand resting on his sword. Daric, Althene, Selorien, and the officers of the Silvermoon retinue waited behind them with the bruised stillness of soldiers who had slept in armor.

Falanaras felt every magical current in the ward. The cage pressed outward with immense contained force. The receiving frame waited empty. Beneath both ran the ordinary pulse of the camp's fel-fed defenses, familiar enough to ignore. M'uru's presence made that green power feel coarse against his senses.

"Containment held through the night," Astalor said. A fresh burn crossed his left wrist beneath a strip of hastily tied cloth. "Ambient output returned after every measurement. M'uru shows no fatigue from restraint alone. Our wards are equal to the burden."

"Restraint was never the claim we came to prove," Kael'thas said.

He looked rested despite the cut on his cheek. His crimson mantle had been replaced, his high shoulder guard polished free of battle soot. The three Verdant Spheres moved behind him with their habitual fire restored. Victory had already been made presentable.

Astalor rested his fingertips on the receiving frame. Red lines woke along its rim. "We will begin with a narrow draw. Captain Falanaras may break the channel if the current rises beyond his control. Lady Liadrin will judge the nature of what reaches him. I will govern the apparatus and duration."

Liadrin's gaze stayed on M'uru. "Who receives it?"

Kael'thas extended one hand toward Falanaras. "The captain asked the correct questions before the assault. Let him help answer them."

Falanaras stepped through the line. He had drained hostile spells in battle since his first months of formal training. He knew the intake of arcane force, the oily heat of fel, the cold pressure of necromancy. Each demanded a different posture, yet all could be caught, measured, and made useful.

Nothing in that knowledge told him how to take hold of the Light.

He placed his palm inside the ring. The metal was warm. Liadrin moved beside him, close enough that the edge of her gauntlet touched his wrist.

"Do not reach as you would for an enemy spell," she said. "Let the channel bring it to you."

"You make that sound simple."

"It was, once."

Astalor opened the channel.

M'uru's radiance tightened toward the nearest pylon. White fire entered the crimson conduit and ran through the frame. The first touch struck Falanaras behind the breastbone. His lungs opened on a breath he had not known he was holding.

Warmth passed into his blood, through the old ache in his bones, and into the hollow place the Sunwell had left.

The hunger vanished.

For three heartbeats he remembered what it was to live without constant ache. No ration waited at the edge of thought. No active ward drew a portion of his attention. Power gathered in him with a clarity that asked for movement: a shield raised over wounded soldiers, a blade bright against the undead, strength carried where ordinary flesh would fail.

Then M'uru cried out.

The sound held no voice, but pain needed none. A chord broke across the ward and drove several soldiers back a step. M'uru's revolving limbs shuddered. The white center of its body dimmed around the channel, then surged as the captive tried to restore what had been taken.

Falanaras jerked his hand away. The channel clung to him in a bright thread until Astalor cut it.

Silence followed. It lasted only long enough for everyone present to understand what the device had done.

Astalor studied the gauges. "The transfer exceeded our upper estimate by thirty-one percent. Remarkable." His attention lingered on M'uru's returning radiance. "Recovery has already begun."

"Captain?" Rommath asked.

Falanaras closed his hand. Light remained beneath his skin, responsive and immense. "The ache is gone. I can hold the power. It wants expression more than storage."

Liadrin watched him with an intensity that made the ward fall away. "Call it."

He thought of Edric in the Ghostlands, breath measured behind a lifted shield. Falanaras raised his empty hand and gave the stolen Light one purpose: stand between danger and

flesh. Red-gold radiance spread over his forearm and opened into a narrow plane before him. Astalor sent a testing spark against it. The plane received the impact, held for one breath, and broke into fading embers.

The officers stirred. Sanguinar smiled.

M'uru brightened again within the cage. Astalor compared the restored radiance to his first reading, then turned the gauge so Kael'thas could see.

"M'uru has returned to its prior strength," he said. "The transfer causes immediate pain, but no measurable depletion. We can claim the Light without diminishing its source."

Kael'thas faced the gathered blood elves. "Again. Lower duration. We will learn what we have won."

They came in turn. A Sunfury lieutenant with a shallow sword cut laid two fingers beside the wound; a quick pulse closed skin and stopped the bleeding. The deeper damage beneath her bandaged leg required a longer current. Warmth moved slowly through torn muscle until she could stand without favoring it. Another soldier carried fel residue in a burn that the healers had contained but not removed. White-gold fire passed through the injury and drove the green stain out as smoking vapor. Daric drew a narrow current and cast it around a shieldless hauler just before Astalor released another testing spark. For one heartbeat the man stood inside a sheath no force could enter; then the protection vanished and left him staring at his own hands. Althene accepted the test without ceremony. She bound radiance along an arrow, loosed at the practice plate, and released the stored force through the impact. The shaft shattered. The plate rang hard enough to silence the ward.

Each draw hurt M'uru. Each ended with the captive's light returning to its prior strength.

When Liadrin placed her hand inside the ring, the naaru's tones changed before Astalor opened the conduit. She went rigid. White radiance crossed the space between them, entered the apparatus, and poured into her with enough force to drive one knee against the ground.

Falanaras reached for her shoulder. She caught his wrist and held him away.

The Light gathered around Liadrin as it had around no one else. It traced the edges of her black armor, filled the old sunburst engraved beneath later scoring, and burned from her eyes. Her face twisted with pain or fury; Falanaras could not separate them.

"Enough," Astalor said, and closed the channel.

Liadrin remained kneeling until the last radiance withdrew beneath her skin. Then she rose under her own strength.

Kael'thas regarded her with open calculation. "You held more than the others."

"I knew it once," Liadrin said. "My body remembers what faith no longer grants."

* * *

The discussion moved into the command pavilion while guards closed around M'uru.

Astalor spread the trial records across the central table. Beside each instrument reading, his precise hand recorded the power gained, the recipient's response, and the pain M'uru had voiced. Selorien stood at his shoulder, confirming every copy against the sealed gauges while Astalor retied the cloth around his own burned wrist.

"Direct access through a common reservoir would fail," Astalor said. "Too many simultaneous claims would create surges, contamination, and loss. We must master the flow before we widen it. Silvermoon will need buffers, separate channels, and regulated demand. These first recipients have

shown us how the Light answers a living vessel. From that, we can build.”

Rommath leaned over the record of M’uru’s recovery. “An individual transfer proves the source can relieve the hunger. The kingdom needs a method that does not depend on selecting one recipient at a time.”

“Agreed. The individual transfers are the beginning, not the limit.” Astalor rested two fingers beside Liadrin’s result. “Lady Liadrin received more than any of us and governed it without collapse. Her former intimacy with the Light has left her unusually receptive. If we learn from that affinity, we may carry M’uru’s power safely into less responsive vessels, and eventually into the city’s wards.”

Liadrin stood at the table’s end. The Light had left her pale, though her voice remained steady. “Then begin with vessels you can govern while the broader channels are built. Priests once carried the Light to the wounded. Paladins carried it into battle. We have soldiers enough, and no shortage of wounds.”

Sanguinar gave a low laugh. “Then make paladins.”

Liadrin looked at him. “Paladins are formed through devotion. Whatever we make from this will answer to discipline.”

“Even better,” Sanguinar said.

Falanaras remembered Edric’s revulsion in the Ghostlands and the flare of radiance that had answered his own hand moments ago. The power itself had felt pure. Its path into him had been an injury done to someone else.

“A military cadre could test healing, warding, and force under controlled conditions while the distribution work continues,” Rommath said. “It would give us disciplined recipients, reliable records, and defenders who no longer draw on the failing stores needed by the rest of the kingdom.”

Kael'thas walked to the pavilion opening. M'uru's cage shone beyond the canvas, surrounded by soldiers and siege wreckage. "Quel'Thalas once waited for sacred power to judge us worthy. That patience brought only blood. We did not take this prize to ease the hunger of a favored few."

He turned back. "Take M'uru home. Learn how its power can reach our infirmaries, ration halls, public wards, and every household the old Sunwell once sustained. Until that method exists, use controlled recipients to prove what the Light can do. If the same work gives our people warriors who can wield it without heaven's approval, we will use that strength as well."

No name followed the command. No oath, uniform, or doctrine existed yet. Still, attention shifted toward Liadrin. She had borne more of the stolen Light than anyone present, and she alone understood what its old service had required.

She accepted their scrutiny without lowering her eyes. "If soldiers are chosen, they must know what stands beneath their power. Forgetting will make appetite of duty."

"Teach them, then," Kael'thas said.

Liadrin's mouth tightened. "First Astalor must learn how to give them the power without killing them."

Astalor gathered his readings. "Then we have two related tasks. We must carry the Light outward without collapse, and teach living recipients to receive it without death. We have already proved that M'uru's power can be claimed. With the same apparatus, we will learn to master both uses."

* * *

They left Netherstorm under a victory order that forbade celebration.

Sunfury translocators carried the retinue and M'uru's frame from the staging grounds to a secured platform in Hellfire Peninsula. The transfer took six linked casts and most of a

day. At every arrival, Astalor inspected the binding array in person. Selorien followed with the transfer roster, confirming ward seals and guard changes before the next cast.

M'uru passed over Outland wrapped in false darkness. Layered veils concealed the white radiance, though they could not silence its tones. Soldiers assigned to the transport learned to speak only when necessary. The sound entered conversation and made ordinary words feel disrespectful.

At the final Hellfire station, Falanaras looked back toward the road they had crossed weeks earlier. The red waste ran beneath a sky split by distant fire. Somewhere beyond it lay Zangarmarsh, Blade's Edge, the Netherstorm camp, and the fortress they had broken open. The distances had seemed large while they marched. Now secrecy folded them into a chain of guarded rooms.

Daric joined him beside the Portal approach. A new shield rode on his back, Sunfury issue and too ornate for his taste.

"I preferred the ship," he said.

"You complained about the ship."

"I had not yet acquired perspective." Daric glanced toward the shrouded cage. "Will you tell them at home?"

"What part?"

"That it came willingly. That it screamed when we tested it. That it works."

Falanaras watched magisters widen the Portal's stabilizing field around the transport frame. "If I tell the truth, I tell all three."

Daric considered that. "You did acquire something in Outland."

"A captaincy."

“I was going to say an alarming tolerance for impossible answers.”

The shrouded frame entered the Dark Portal between two files of spellbreakers. Falanaras crossed beside the left forward pylon. Netherstorm’s pressure vanished behind him. The Blasted Lands received them with barren wind and a night sky whose stars held their proper places.

Home lay far to the north, but Rommath had prepared the last road before they departed. Inside the blood-elf-held fortifications, a relay chamber waited beneath wards keyed to his authority. Its receiving circle opened onto a sealed magisterial vault below Silvermoon.

The spell took every magister in the retinue and twelve stationed at the Portal. Crimson light rose around M’uru’s prison. For one instant Falanaras saw the naaru through all its veils, brilliant enough to throw shadows across two worlds.

Then dry wind became cool stone, and the air smelled of silverleaf incense, lamp oil, and home.

The receiving vault had been emptied except for guards. Theron Brightshield stood in the first rank with a restored shield on his arm. Lethira waited above him on a narrow gallery, bow drawn toward the arriving frame until she recognized the figures within the light.

Theron’s scarred face changed by less than a smile. It was enough.

Lethira lowered her bow. “You were meant to bring back a report.”

“The report required containment pylons.”

“Naturally.” She looked at M’uru’s veiled radiance. The sarcasm left her face. “What did you bring us?”

Before Falanaras could answer, the far doors opened and Lor’themar Theron entered with Halduron Brightwing and a guard of senior magisters. The Regent Lord wore no

ceremonial mantle. He had come dressed for an interrupted night, his hair bound back, his expression already fixed on the work ahead.

Rommath bowed. "Regent Lord. By order of Prince Kael'thas, we deliver the answer secured from Tempest Keep."

Lor'themar looked through the veils. M'uru's tones moved through the vault, soft enough to raise the hairs along Falanaras's arms.

"An answer to which question?" Lor'themar asked.

* * *

The council convened before the transport wards had cooled.

They met in an adjoining chamber built for supply disputes and emergency command. Its table still bore old knife marks from the defense of the city. Lor'themar took the head. Halduron stood at his right, Rommath at his left. Astalor quietly arranged his instruments along one edge of the table. Liadrin remained near the closed door to M'uru's vault.

Falanaras had expected to be dismissed with the other field officers. Lor'themar kept him, Theron, and Lethira as witnesses to the arrival and representatives of the soldiers now guarding it.

"Begin with custody," Lor'themar said. "Who owns the prisoner?"

Rommath's reply came without pause. "Prince Kael'thas seized M'uru through force of arms and sent it for the preservation of Quel'Thalas."

"That tells me who gave the order. Here, beneath a city I am charged to govern, who controls access?"

"The magisters maintain containment," Astalor said. "Military guards secure the approaches. Lady Liadrin will advise on Light exposure."

"Under whose authority?"

Astalor looked to Rommath. Rommath looked to Lor'themar.

“Mine,” the Regent Lord said. “The prince’s purpose will be honored. Silvermoon will not contain an unknown power beneath its streets through divided command.”

Rommath inclined his head. “Agreed.”

Halduron folded his arms. “If the cage fails?”

“M’uru could have broken it during capture,” Falanaras said. “It chose not to.”

Every face turned toward him. Theron’s did not move, but Falanaras felt his attention sharpen.

Lor’themar rested both hands on the table. “You brought into my city a prisoner powerful enough to escape and unwilling to do so?”

“Yes,” Liadrin said.

“Do you know why?”

“No.”

The honesty settled heavily. Lor’themar shifted to Astalor. “What happens when you draw from it?”

“The recipient gains usable Holy power and immediate relief from magical withdrawal,” Astalor said. “M’uru suffers during the transfer; we have no evidence of lasting depletion, and its output returns to its former strength within moments. Even unchanneled, its presence is already easing symptoms near the vault. What we have not yet mastered is regulation over distance.”

Lethira’s fingers tightened around the strap of her bow. “You tested that more than once.”

“We repeated the trial to establish whether that recovery was reliable,” Astalor said.

“Pain also appears repeatable.”

Astalor met her stare. “It is. Control does not make the act painless.”

Lor’themar did not rebuke either of them. “Who knows?”

Rommath listed the Outland command, the transport teams, the Portal garrison, and the Silvermoon guards. The number was already too large for permanent silence.

“Then we control the truth before rumor supplies a worse one,” Lor’themar said. “The city will be told that the prince has sent a new magical resource under study. No location. No access. No promise of a ration before you can deliver one. The work remains directed toward public relief, and the reports will state whether it is approaching that goal.”

“And the nature of the resource?” Halduron asked.

Lor’themar looked toward the sealed vault. “Anyone who draws from a living prisoner should know the source. Anyone merely passing through the market does not need a riot handed to them before breakfast.”

Rommath’s expression remained hard. “The primary application is relief throughout the kingdom. That requires a distribution method we do not yet possess. A trained military cadre can be developed in parallel: controlled recipients for the research and defenders who can wield the Light without devotional dependence.”

Halduron looked at Liadrin. “Under you?”

“If the method can be made survivable,” she said. “If those chosen can govern the power under command—where it goes, and what purpose it serves. If they understand that effectiveness does not alter the source of what they carry.”

Theron spoke for the first time. “Does it work against the undead?”

“It is the Light,” Liadrin said. “Yes.”

Theron nodded once. Falanaras knew that motion. His friend had placed the horror and the utility beside each other and begun considering where a shield might stand between them.

Lor'themar saw it too. Weariness crossed his face before discipline removed it. "You will submit a containment plan by noon, a distribution program and trial protocol by tomorrow. No further draws tonight. The guards rotate every two hours. Anyone who enters that vault is named in writing."

Astalor inclined his head and closed the trial record.

"The prince sent us salvation," Lor'themar said. "It arrived as a military prisoner, a religious crisis, and an apparatus that can injure half the city if mishandled. Permit me one night to govern it."

* * *

Over the next three days, Silvermoon began to absorb the secret.

Magisters closed three lower passages for "structural repair." Supply carts moved under guard through service streets. A notice praised Kael'thas's victory in Outland and promised that a new source of power had reached the kingdom for study. Citizens gathered beneath the posted words and argued over how soon study should become ration.

The city had practice receiving necessities with dangerous names. Fel crystals already burned green above restored avenues. Mana distribution queues formed beside buildings whose carvings still honored the Sunwell. Children learned which public wards eased the ache and which alleys held people who had stopped choosing limits.

M'uru entered that life unseen. Its presence traveled through stone as a low warmth. Guards stationed nearest the vault reported easier breathing and steadier hands. One kitchen worker sat down on a stair and wept because the hunger had receded for the first time in years, though she did not know why.

The effect weakened with distance. Two levels above the vault, a guard could still feel it as warmth behind the eyes. At street level it became no more than an easier breath, readily mistaken for a strong ward or a generous ration. Even that was enough to alter behavior. Soldiers due to rotate away found reasons to finish reports slowly. A pair of laborers volunteered twice to carry conduit housings into the lower halls. Their foreman sent them back to the loading yard before gratitude became loitering.

The first rumor named the source as a cleansed fel crystal large enough to power a district. The second claimed Rommath had recovered a fragment of the Sunwell. By midday, a jeweler near the Royal Exchange was selling brass pendants stamped with a sunburst and promising that they would attune themselves when the prince's gift entered public service.

Lor'themar's clerks confiscated the pendants for fraudulent enchantment and left the rumor untouched. Denial would have given it an official spine. Silence allowed a dozen competing hopes to exhaust one another.

Below, the guards learned the harder facts. They heard M'uru's tones through the sealed doors and felt the containment bands answer in their teeth. Those who had served before the fall stood straighter when the radiance passed beneath the threshold. One former temple sentry requested reassignment without naming a reason. Another placed both hands against the door after his watch ended and remained there until Theron told him quietly that reverence did not grant entry.

Theron reported each incident in the plain language Lor'themar had ordered: time, name, action, disposition. Lethira took the upper approaches with rangers who trusted stone corridors less than open sight lines. She found two

magisterial apprentices tracing the outer wards from a ventilation court and sent them away with such inventive predictions of disciplinary labor that neither returned.

None of it resembled the celebration at the Sunfury camp. The city met M'uru through rosters, sealed passages, diverted deliveries, and the faint relief of people who did not know why their hands had steadied. The captive's suffering remained below ground. Its usefulness rose invisibly through the floors.

That division unsettled Falanaras more than open approval would have. In Outland, everyone who accepted the Light had heard M'uru cry. Silvermoon might receive the benefit at a distance, softened by official language and several layers of stone. Lor'themar had insisted that future wielders know the source, but knowledge could still become ritual phrasing—repeated correctly, felt less each time.

Under Astalor's direction, the work already extended beyond prospective soldiers. In adjoining chambers, magisters fed traces of M'uru's ambient radiance into wardstones, healing foci, and empty mana vessels. One stone held a weak warmth for eleven minutes. Two crystals clouded from within. A conduit meant to carry the current toward the nearest infirmary bled half its charge into the surrounding walls before Selorien identified the leak and closed the channel.

Rommath's clerks spread maps beside the instruments. Their inked routes ran outward from the vault toward clinics, ration stations, barracks, workshops, and the common quarters where weak crystals served too many households. Every route remained hypothetical, branching across the city in red ink.

Liadrin did not leave the lower complex. When Falanaras passed the vault on his way to final debriefing, he saw her

through the open inspection door, standing beyond the apparatus with her helmet beneath one arm. Astalor's magisters moved around her, measuring and marking. She watched M'uru without prayer and without retreat. The posture carried the same severity she had shown in the shrine: responsibility maintained through attention.

On the third evening, Falanaras emerged from a final round of debriefings into streets washed by the setting sun. Silvermoon's towers caught the light in gold and crimson. Repaired bridges arched over avenues where merchants closed their awnings and ward-lamps woke one by one. After Outland, the city seemed impossibly delicate. After Tempest Keep, it seemed defenseless against what had been placed beneath it.

Theron and Lethira waited outside the barracks court. Someone had found Falanaras a fresh uniform, but Netherstorm dust remained in the seams of his boots. Lethira noticed before offering him her forearm.

"You look offensive," she said.

"Outland has lower standards."

"That is the first credible report you have given me."

Theron clasped his shoulder. The grip was careful around an injury Falanaras had stopped noticing. "Welcome home."

The words reached somewhere the cheering had not. Falanaras looked past them toward the barracks windows, the familiar training court, the wall where Rynel had once corrected his stance with a wooden staff and an insult. Home had continued without him. He had returned carrying an answer large enough to alter it.

They found a quiet place on the western terrace, where reconstruction ended against the ruins. Beyond the rail, broken foundations descended toward the dark scar of the lost quarter. Lethira produced three cups and a bottle that

tasted of berries, smoke, and someone's impatience with proper aging.

"Tell us what the notice does not," Theron said.

Falanaras told them about the road across Outland, the naga in Zangarmarsh, the fel creatures in Blade's Edge, and the blood elves at Kael'thas's camp who had learned to count demons among useful allies. He described the assault in fragments because a whole account would have sounded less true. Daric's shield. Althene's bridge. Selorien dragging a wounded hauler away from a failing pylon.

Then he told them about M'uru.

Lethira listened without interruption until he described the first draw. "It hurt."

"Yes."

"And you did it again."

"We needed to know whether the first result was stable." The answer came too quickly. It followed Astalor's reasoning: admit the harm, then set it beneath what the work required.

Lethira looked toward the city. "There you are."

"Where?"

"Somewhere past the point where you used to admit a thing was terrible before explaining why you did it." Her tone stayed dry, yet concern had entered beneath it. "Outland taught you efficiency."

Falanaras wanted to deny it. Instead he remembered the receiving ring, the instant of perfect relief, and how readily he had raised a radiant flare from another being's pain.

Theron turned his cup between both hands. "Does it work?"

"Yes."

"Well?"

Falanaras opened his hand. Nothing answered him. The radiance from Astalor's test had faded before they reached Silvermoon; without a lasting bond, only the memory of

perfect relief remained. “Well enough to change how we fight. Perhaps how we live.”

Theron studied the empty palm. His face held no wonder, only the practical attention he gave a damaged shield that might still save someone if repaired correctly.

“Rynel could have used that,” he said.

The thought had followed Falanaras across two worlds. “Yes.”

“Would it have saved him?” Lethira asked.

“I do not know.” Falanaras closed his empty hand. “I know it could save the next one.”

Below the terrace, ward-lamps brightened along the avenue. Citizens moved through their evening routines with mana crystals in pockets and green light above their heads. Few knew what slept beneath the city. None knew what name its power would eventually take.

Lethira poured the last of the bottle. “You are home,” she said. “Try to remain recognizable.”

Falanaras looked from her to Theron. Familiar faces, familiar ruins, familiar hunger. Outland had changed the distance he could travel inside necessity before alarm caught up with him. His friends had seen it within an hour.

Under their feet, too deep for sound, M’uru’s presence warmed the stone.

Silvermoon had taken another dangerous thing into itself and called the act survival. This time Falanaras had helped carry it home.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Blood Knights

For six days, Silvermoon tried to teach stone how to carry salvation.

The first wardstone held M'uru's radiance for eleven minutes. The second cracked along an old flaw and filled the testing chamber with a warm gold mist that soothed everyone's hunger until the magisters vented it into the vault. A third remained bright through the night, then surrendered all its stored power when an orderly touched it with an ungloved hand.

Healing foci fared better. One closed a laborer's burned palm before its internal lattice spoiled. Another sent a pulse through two floors of the lower complex and briefly relieved every blood elf standing above it, including three guards who had not been told what the experiment was meant to do. By the time the result reached the nearest infirmary, the power had thinned into little more than warmth.

Falanaras spent those days carrying reports between the vault, the barracks, and Rommath's clerks. It was work suited to a captain trusted with the secret and useless to anyone who wanted sleep. Each morning the maps showed new red routes into the city. Each evening half of them had been crossed out.

The seventh attempt reached farther than the rest.

Astalor had joined three silver conduits around a receiving vessel the size of a wine cask. From there, a buried line ran beneath Farstriders' Square toward a small clinic serving reconstruction crews and the families housed near

the eastern wall. Forty-three people waited inside under the pretense of a ward inspection. Two healers stood ready with ledgers and no explanation for their patients.

Falanaras watched from the upper gallery as the magisters opened the draw.

M'uru brightened inside the cage. Crimson force-chains tightened around its drifting sigils, and the chamber filled with the high, fractured cry Falanaras had first heard in Netherstorm. Light poured into the receiving vessel. The cask shuddered against its braces. Along the wall, crystal indicators woke in sequence—one, two, three, then all the way to the clinic relay.

A cheer rose from the western station.

It ended when the fourth indicator burst.

The conduit screamed beneath the floor. A seam of red-gold light raced back toward the vault, scorching mortar black as it came. Selorien threw both hands over the western relay and twisted the flow into an empty wardstone. Astalor severed the main channel an instant later. The vessel split down its middle and spilled radiance across the tiles.

Falanaras felt the ache behind his ribs vanish. Around him, magisters stopped with mouths open and hands slack. The relief lasted three breaths. Then the loose Light fled into the walls, and hunger returned with the intimate cruelty of a door shutting in one's face.

Below, M'uru dimmed and recovered. Astalor closed every remaining control, then crossed to Selorien and examined his burned hand before looking to the split vessel and the gauges.

"Begin with the clinic," Astalor said.

"The clinic received enough to ease twelve patients," Selorien said. "Three reported nausea. One lost consciousness for several seconds. No lasting harm yet."

"And the conduit?"

“Ruined.” Selorien opened his burned hand and regarded it without drama. “As is the receiving vessel.”

Rommath descended from the gallery. His robes passed through the fading radiance without stirring it. Lor’themar followed at a slower pace, his good eye moving over the split cask, the scorched wall, and the captive at the chamber’s center.

“Can it be corrected?” the regent asked.

Astalor crouched to examine a fragment of silver casing. “Yes, in time. The current resists interruption, divides poorly, and degrades outside a living vessel. Each failure has shown us another condition we must master. None lies beyond sin’dorei ability.”

“How long?”

“Longer than those waiting at the ration halls can afford,” Astalor said. “We should not confine our work to storage while they wait.”

Lor’themar’s expression hardened. “They have waited through every promise we have made them. Continue.”

“Of course. We will correct the distribution system.” Astalor glanced toward Liadrin. She had stood beside M’uru throughout the failed draw, close enough for its radiance to sharpen the edges of her armor. “In parallel, we have devised a method that already succeeds.”

Liadrin met his gaze. “For moments.”

“Our first design mistook the recipient for another vessel,” Astalor said. He indicated the broken cask without disdain, as though it had served its purpose by failing. “Stored power fades. Conduits leak. A living recipient can remain joined to the source.”

Falanaras remembered the Light fading from his hand before they reached Silvermoon. “You mean to bind the recipient directly to M’uru.”

A slight smile touched Astalor's face. "A governed bond, replenishing because it remains joined to M'uru and narrow enough to preserve both source and recipient. We have already proved transfer. The problem before us is subjugation: claiming the terms under which M'uru yields and the recipient receives."

The word settled across the chamber with greater weight than the broken equipment.

Rommath turned toward the upper galleries, where clerks and junior magisters watched from behind the rail. "You have all heard gentler names for what keeps this city alive. Rationing. Adaptation. Necessary practice. Those names have their uses. They do not alter the act."

No one moved. Even the ward-crystals seemed quieter around his voice.

"Quel'Thalas does not owe the world a beautiful extinction," Rommath said. "We will build the public channels. We will fill infirmaries and ration halls if it takes every magister in Silvermoon. While that work continues, we will use the method that succeeds. Survival first. Structure second. Interpretation after."

Lor'themar studied M'uru. "And who risks this bond first?"

Liadrin stepped forward before Astalor could answer. "I do."

* * *

Astalor rebuilt the receiving apparatus with the patient absorption of a scholar refining difficult work. He thanked orderlies who anticipated his needs and never softened the purpose: the new design would bind a living soul directly to a captive source. Falanaras found no malice in him. Astalor regarded every difficulty in governing M'uru's power as another property to master and the binding as an achievement of sin'dorei ability.

He set four pylons around M'uru's cage and joined them to a silver platform outside the inner restraint circle. Each pylon carried two controls: one governing the draw from M'uru, the other limiting what could reach the recipient. Selorien verified those limits independently and added a fifth line from the platform back into the cage. It would return excess current before it burned through the recipient or destabilized M'uru. Astalor approved it as the safeguard that made a sustained bond possible.

They worked through the night. By morning, a dozen soldiers and former temple guards waited in the gallery. Falanaras stood among them with Theron, Daric, and Captain Althene Starwind. None had been promised a place. They had been ordered to observe the first direct binding and decide afterward whether they wished to submit themselves for testing.

Lethira watched from farther back, arms folded over her ranger leathers. Her presence had required three signatures and an argument with a vault officer. She had acquired all four.

Liadrin entered wearing plain crimson plate, stripped of insignia. She carried no priest's staff and offered no prayer. When she stepped onto the platform, M'uru's sigils turned toward her with the slow attention of something that had been waiting.

Falanaras remembered her at Silvermoon's inner gate, white and blue vestments stained with blood, calling on the Light as wounded civilians screamed around her. That woman had believed service made the power holy. The woman below had survived the answer to that belief.

Rommath took position beside the northern pylon. Astalor stood at the controls. Selorien remained near Liadrin with one hand hovering over the emergency severance rune.

“The bond may resist severance once it forms,” Astalor said. “You should expect pain, disorientation, and some loss of voluntary control. We have limited the initial draw to what your prior use of the Light suggests you can sustain. If you lose speech, raise your left hand. If you cannot raise it, Magister Dawnmark will sever the draw when your responses cross the limits we have set. We will not wait for collapse.”

“If he ends it too early?” Liadrin asked.

“Then the bond may fail, and we begin again after you recover. There is no useful result in losing you before we understand the method.”

“Then he will wait for my signal.”

Selorien checked the emergency severance rune. “I will wait while the readings permit it.”

Astalor opened the first control.

The force-chains pulled inward. M'uru's song broke across the chamber, a bright harmony crushed into shrieking fragments. Light struck the pylons and became four narrow streams. They met above Liadrin, circled once, and descended through her armor without touching the metal.

Her back arched. Both hands closed into fists. Radiance spilled between the plates at her throat and wrists, too fierce to look at directly. The platform's runes flared white, then red-gold as the restraint current bled into the transfer.

Falanaras knew the relief inside that agony. His brief test in Netherstorm had cleared the hunger so completely that its absence had frightened him. Liadrin received many times that measure now. Her face held the stillness of someone enduring a blade without granting it the satisfaction of movement.

“The bond remains within the limits we established,” Astalor said. “Increase the draw by one division.”

Selorien looked at Liadrin. She gave the smallest nod.

The second surge drove her to one knee. A sound escaped her then, low and furious. M'uru answered with another glass-edged cry. For one terrible instant Falanaras could not tell whether the pain in the chamber belonged to captive or recipient. The apparatus had joined them closely enough that the distinction ceased to offer comfort.

Liadrin raised her head.

Golden fire gathered around her empty hand. It tightened at her command, becoming a dense sphere no larger than an apple. She turned her wrist. The sphere unfolded into a radiant shield, held for three breaths, then collapsed into sparks that vanished before reaching the floor.

Astalor watched the gauges, pleasure warming his expression. "Excellent. The power is answering her intention rather than the pylons."

"Stop the draw," Lor'themar said from the shadow beneath the gallery.

Falanaras had not seen him enter. The regent stood without escort or ceremonial dress, one hand resting on the pommel of his sword. He had chosen the darkest part of the chamber and still refused the protection of absence.

Liadrin lifted her left hand. "Continue."

"You have proved the transfer," Lor'themar said.

"I have proved I can survive it. Those are different results." Liadrin forced herself upright. "If others are to accept this bond, I will know the full weight first."

Lor'themar's jaw tightened. He did not countermand her.

The binding continued until sweat ran beneath Liadrin's gorget and blood marked one nostril. Astalor guided the draw through several measured changes, announcing what he meant to test and waiting for Selorien's confirmation before each one. At last he closed the source while the

platform still held steady. M'uru's song softened. Liadrin remained standing.

When the apparatus fell silent, the radiance around her did not disappear.

It diminished to a red-gold seam beneath her skin, visible at the eyes and along the hand she opened toward M'uru. The Light answered. A small flame rose above her palm and held there, fed through a channel no instrument now touched.

Astalor studied the gauges. The readings drew a slight smile from him. "Stable. The bond remains without the apparatus, and M'uru's baseline has recovered. Magnificent."

Selorien wrapped his burned hand around the edge of the console. "Stable, with measurable strain to source and recipient."

"As expected," Astalor replied. "We have made a single governed system of them. Our work now is to keep that strain survivable and the bond obedient."

Liadrin extinguished the flame and faced the gallery. Fatigue had hollowed her cheeks, yet her voice carried to every waiting candidate.

"The Light did not save us," she said. "It did not keep Arthas from our gates. It did not preserve the Sunwell, our children, or the dead we still speak to when sleep is poor. I served it faithfully, and faith did not make our suffering meaningful."

Her gaze moved across soldiers, rangers, former temple guards, and Falanaras.

"If the Light will not save Quel'Thalas by grace, the sin'dorei will take from it what is needed and save ourselves. Do not mistake that declaration for innocence. M'uru suffers beneath us. Our enemies will call us profane, and some among our own people will agree.

Remember the source. Remember the purpose. Then decide whether you can serve under both truths.”

She stepped down from the platform. No one cheered.

Daric was the first to descend from the gallery.

“Where do I stand?” he asked.

* * *

The trials lasted nine days.

Twenty-one candidates entered the lower complex. Seven failed the first attempt. Two lost consciousness before a direct binding could be established. One former priest broke into sobbing when M’uru’s voice entered his mind and could not be persuaded to return. Astalor recorded each failure in an orderly hand, separating rejection, physical shock, and loss of control as different problems. Three soldiers accepted the power easily, then kept drawing after Liadrin ordered them to release the source. Astalor began outlining stronger governor restraints. Liadrin dismissed them before he finished; a knight who required the apparatus to enforce obedience had already failed her test.

“Capacity without obedience is another form of weakness,” she told the remaining candidates. “You know this from taking power out of living currents. The Light does not excuse appetite. It gives appetite a sharper weapon.”

Daric endured his transfer with clenched teeth and a stare fixed on the cage. When the bond settled, he drew a practice sword and bound radiance along its edge. The stored Light released through his first strike in a compact burst that cracked a shield and nearly knocked its bearer into the wall. Liadrin made him repeat the exercise until he could choose how much of the bound force left the weapon. On the final attempt the shield moved one pace, the soldier behind it remained unbruised, and no radiance lingered on the blade after purpose ended.

Althene approached the Light as she approached a narrow trail: testing each step, wasting nothing. Her first healing attempt sealed a cut on Selorien's forearm in a quick pulse so precisely that Astalor examined the sealed flesh, then asked whether she had served in a temple. She told him rangers learned to keep people alive where temples were unavailable. He accepted the correction with a slight nod. Liadrin then gave Althene a harder injury: a practice burn laced with a harmless arcane irritant that kept the skin inflamed. Althene learned to send the Light through the wound without closing it first. The foreign current came out as blue smoke. Only then did she seal the flesh.

Theron's bond resisted for almost a minute. He stood inside the receiving circle with his shield planted before him, sweat darkening his collar as the stolen radiance broke around his armor. Liadrin watched from the circle's edge and ordered him to hold. Then the current found him. A low, steady gold spread from his stance into the three candidates nearest him. Their shoulders settled. Their footing firmed. When the magisters sent practice bolts toward the group, Theron raised his shield and the same sustained current folded forward into a curved wall from its rim. Three impacts broke against it. The quieter strength around his companions remained until he dismissed it.

When it ended, he looked at Liadrin and said, "Useful."

She almost smiled. "A ringing endorsement."

Liadrin inclined her head toward the practice floor. "Set the shield down. The next test is harder."

A candidate named Caerith lay on a cot beside the practice floor. The bond had rejected him that morning, leaving burns across his chest where the transfer current had sought paths his body could not hold. He was conscious, though each breath caught before completion. Two healers had salved the

burns and steadied his heart. The remaining damage lay too deep for their exhausted reserves.

Theron crouched beside him. "You want me to heal this?"

"I want you to find out whether you can," Liadrin said. "A wall is useful until someone falls behind it."

Theron removed one gauntlet and placed his palm over Caerith's sternum. His first attempt produced a flash that made the injured elf flinch. Theron withdrew at once. A shallow wound could have closed under that brief force; the damage beneath Caerith's burns lay around lungs, heart, and exhausted muscle. Theron called a slower current and held it. The Light gathered around his fingers in an uneven glow, entered the burns, and spread deeper with each breath. Caerith's next breath reached the bottom of his lungs. The one after it came without a catch.

M'uru cried below the working. Theron's shoulders stiffened. He kept his hand in place until the healer touched his wrist and said the heart had steadied, then severed the call immediately. The glow died. Caerith slept.

"Still useful?" Falanaras asked when Theron joined him along the gallery rail.

Theron watched the healers carry Caerith toward recovery. "More than I wanted it to be."

Beyond the dividing wall, the public-distribution team opened another receiving vessel. Its indicators rose, held, and failed one by one. Selorien crossed between the two experiments with a complete comparison for Astalor: the living bonds retained nearly all the power they received, while the latest storage crystal had lost two-thirds of its charge in under an hour. Astalor listened without interruption, then sent him back with revised safeguards for both teams. Rommath ordered both lines of work to continue.

The disparity changed the candidates' posture. They had arrived expecting to become soldiers with an unfamiliar weapon. By the third evening, healers from two clinics had begun observing the trials. Astalor described trained recipients carrying stable charges to places the conduits could not yet reach, dwelling on the negligible loss. He called it an interim use of a method the sin'dorei had already mastered. No one called it an answer for the city. It was a bridge built from living bodies while the safer work lagged behind.

Theron flexed his bare hand. "Rynel would have hated the ceremony."

"He would have corrected everyone's stance during it."

"And used the power." Theron looked down at the faint radiance answering beneath his skin. "If someone had put it in his hands before Deatholme, he might have lived. If we put it in ours now, someone else might."

It was the closest Theron came to explaining his choice. Falanaras understood. Theron had always built conviction from the person immediately behind his shield.

Falanaras went last on the fourth day. Astalor explained that the earlier exposure had given the Light a familiar path and improved the chance of a stable bond, though it removed neither pain nor risk. Falanaras believed him. The restraints made belief no comfort.

Liadrin faced him inside the circle. Her bond had altered her in small ways. Her eyes held a gold ember beneath their fel-green glow, and fine tremors sometimes passed through her fingers after a heavy draw. She hid neither.

"You remember the first test," she said.

"Every moment."

"That will work against you. You will anticipate relief and pull toward it. Do not reach. Receive."

After Astalor and Selorien independently confirmed every safeguard, the apparatus opened a channel from M'uru toward him.

M'uru's pain came first. The cry entered Falanaras behind the eyes, immense and intimate. Then the Light followed along the channel. It drove through muscle, scar, and memory, finding every absence the Sunwell had left in him. Hunger vanished. Grief remained. For a heartbeat he mistook the distinction for mercy.

He wanted to seize the current and make abundance itself the proof. Rynel at the ward-anchor returned to him. The captain had spent every measure the escape required, then turned the strength away from his own hunger and toward the soldiers depending on him. He had chosen what power was for.

Falanaras opened his hand instead of closing it.

The current settled. A bond remained behind it, narrow and bright, running directly toward the captive presence at the city's heart. He could feel the Light waiting there. It no longer filled him without end. It answered when he called, and every answer carried the faint echo of broken music.

"Now give it purpose," Liadrin said.

A practice target stood at the far edge of the chamber, armored in layered wards meant to imitate Scourge resistance. Falanaras drew his glaive. The Light was not hostile magic to drain, but his spellbreaker training still showed him where the target's protections crossed and which layer governed the rest. He bound red-gold radiance along the crescent blade and gave the stored force a point of release: the weakest crossing, on contact, and nowhere else.

The first strike released only enough holy force to rupture the governing ward. The remaining protections

dimmed with it. Falanaras rebound the Light along the blade, stepped through the opening, and discharged the second store into the target's armored center. Red-gold fire crossed from shoulder to hip and left the cut edges smoking. The glaive went dark the instant the work was complete.

Astalor looked from the ruined target to his gauges. "Excellent. You broke the governing ward, held the second charge until contact, and ended the call when its purpose was complete. The bond answered your intention exactly."

"You called Lady Liadrin's result excellent," Selorien said.

"It was accurate then as well."

Later, while healers checked the burning behind Falanaras's eyes, Liadrin sat beside him on the lowest gallery step. The chamber had emptied except for guards and the tireless magisters working on another public-distribution vessel beyond the wall.

"You governed it," she said.

"Rynel taught me the lesson late."

"Late lessons still count." She flexed one trembling hand. "You accepted enough to destroy the target and put it where it belonged. That is discipline. You are trying to decide whether accepting the power makes you responsible for every cry below us."

"Doesn't it?"

"Yes." Liadrin gave him no pause in which to hope for comfort. "It also makes you responsible for what you do with the power. Refusing one burden does not remove the other. It only chooses which lives receive your loyalty."

"You make it sound simple."

"It is unbearable. That is different." Her gaze shifted toward M'uru. "If you join what we are building, do not offer half an oath. Do not serve while imagining your

private reluctance keeps your hands untouched. Know exactly what we are, and remain in service anyway.”

Falanaras looked through the bars of the restraint field. M’uru’s sigils drifted in their patient revolutions. The naaru had entered Astalor’s cage willingly in Tempest Keep. It remained now beneath a city that had learned to call captivity a system.

“I will decide before the oath,” he said.

Liadrin rose. “See that you do.”

* * *

They told Lethira on the western terrace where she had welcomed Falanaras home.

The city below had grown accustomed to new rumors. Citizens spoke of a sealed reliquary under Farstriders’ Square, a weapon from Outland, a restored fragment of the Sunwell, or a private source reserved for the ruling houses. The official notices mentioned improved ward research and asked for patience at ration stations.

Lethira sat on the parapet with one boot braced against the stone. “You both have the expression people wear before volunteering for something unpleasant.”

Theron leaned his shield against the wall. A faint gold line remained around its rim from the morning’s exercises. “We are joining Liadrin’s order.”

“It has an order now?”

“By tomorrow,” Falanaras said.

Lethira’s eyes moved between them. “What does it require?”

Theron answered first. “Discipline. Training. A willingness to be hated by anyone who learns where the power comes from.”

“So military service with brighter uniforms.”

Theron considered. “The uniforms are darker.”

She looked at Falanaras. The humor eased from her face. “And you?”

“I have spent years learning to take hostile magic and decide what it becomes in my hands. This is harder because the source is innocent.” He rested both palms on the terrace rail. “It works. I can protect people with it. I can kill the things that still cross the Dead Scar. I cannot make M’uru’s captivity righteous.”

“That was almost recognizable,” Lethira said quietly.

“I intend to become one of them.”

She nodded once, accepting the statement without blessing it. Then she tapped the bow at her shoulder.

“No thanks. I’ll stick to my bow.”

Theron lifted one eyebrow. “We had assumed.”

“Good. I would hate to think the Light had damaged your judgment.” Lethira stood and offered each of them a forearm. “Try not to become insufferable before your first deployment.”

Falanaras clasped her arm. The three of them remained on the terrace until the ward-lamps came alive below. Their paths had diverged before and would again. For that evening, the differences still fit inside the reach of their hands.

* * *

The founding took place beneath Farstriders’ Square before dawn.

Fourteen candidates remained. They wore black tabards edged in crimson over whatever armor had carried them through the trials. The cloth was new, the equipment beneath it scarred and mismatched. Daric stood near the front. Althene had tied her ranger’s braid back with a strip of black ribbon. Theron rested both hands on his shield. Falanaras carried his glaive upright beside him.

The magisters had opened the aperture above M'uru's vault. Light rose through it in a broad red-gold column, colored by the restraints it passed. The candidates formed two lines around the opening. No altar stood between them and the captive. Liadrin had refused one.

Rommath and Astalor waited at the chamber's edge. Selorien stood with the access ledger. Lor'themar occupied the same shadowed place from which he had witnessed Liadrin's binding. He spoke to no one and claimed no ceremonial role. His presence denied every official above him the excuse of believing the decision belonged to lesser hands.

Liadrin entered in black and crimson plate. A new ranseur rested in her hand, its blade dark red along the edge. The Light moved beneath her skin in faint pulses synchronized with the radiance rising from below.

She took her place at the head of the aperture.

"The old orders were founded in devotion," she said. "Their knights served the Light and trusted that service to answer them. We stand here because trust failed, because our kingdom burned, and because survival demanded power that would answer discipline."

She lowered the ranseur until its point hovered above the column.

"We carry the blood of those Quel'Thalas lost and the blood we will spend in its defense. We wield a captive Light. We will neither disguise its source nor surrender its strength. From this hour, we are Blood Knights."

The name entered the chamber without applause. Falanaras felt it settle onto him with the weight of armor issued before a battle.

Liadrin planted the ranseur's butt against the floor. "Kneel."

Fourteen candidates knelt around M'uru's rising radiance.

“Whom do you serve?”

“Quel’Thalas,” they answered.

“What do you bear?”

“The strength our people require. The cost by which it came.”

“What governs your hand?”

“Discipline. Duty. Honor. Remembrance.”

Liadrin’s gaze moved down the line. “Spend what the task requires. Obey command. When purpose ends, so does force. Rise, Blood Knights.”

Falanaras stood beside Theron. The bond opened at the motion, and stolen Light entered him in a controlled current. It eased the hunger, strengthened the hand around his glaive, and carried M’uru’s distant cry through the chamber. Pride rose with it—fierce, unwelcome, and his own.

He had chosen this. The order would defend roads, close wounds, break the undead, and give soldiers strength no enemy expected from a people already dangerous to magic. Those truths deserved their full measure. So did the being held below them.

No absolution came. Falanaras had ceased waiting for it.

Above them, Silvermoon woke beneath crimson banners and ward-lamps, its clinics still waiting for conduits that could carry relief without failing. Below, M’uru remained in chains. Between city and captive stood the first Blood Knights, carrying power enough to save lives and knowledge enough to understand the wound beneath it.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Stolen Light

Three weeks after the oath, the Light still answered Falanaras too quickly.

He called it into his sword as Theron advanced across the practice court. Red-gold fire ran from the crossguard to the point, thin at first, then bright enough to stain the black lacquer of his gauntlets. Theron's shield came up. A matching radiance spread over its face in a curved plane.

Falanaras struck.

Steel met the shield with a crack that jarred both arms. The ward bowed inward. Theron slid half a pace across the flagstones and turned the blade aside. Falanaras let the motion carry him around, brought the pommel toward Theron's temple, and found the shield rim waiting. Theron drove forward behind it. The blow caught Falanaras in the breastplate and sent him back hard enough to scrape sparks from one heel.

The Light surged in answer to his anger.

For one dangerous instant the whole length of the sword blazed. Hunger vanished from his body. The old ache behind his ribs disappeared so completely that relief became its own temptation. Beneath that sweetness ran another sensation: a high, broken vibration at the edge of hearing. M'uru's pain trembled within every measure he took.

"Enough," Liadrin said.

Falanaras closed the channel. The fire collapsed to a thread and went out. Theron lowered his shield, breathing through his nose. A pale line showed where the sword had bitten into the red-black enamel.

Around them, the other Blood Knights halted their exercises. Fourteen black-and-crimson figures stood across the court beneath Silvermoon's early light. They had been soldiers, guards, rangers, and former servants of a faith that no longer held them. The new tabards made an order of them. Their mismatched armor still revealed how recently the order had been named.

Liadrin crossed the flagstones with her ranseur resting against one shoulder. Light moved beneath her eyes in faint gold currents, visible within the fel-green. The gold burned more brightly in her than in any of them. Her hand remained steady around the weapon.

"Why did you let anger increase the draw?" she asked.

"He had me off balance."

"Then recover your balance. More force is not failure. Letting temper choose it is."

Theron leaned on his shield. "I offered to wait."

"You said I looked tired." Falanaras kept his gaze on Liadrin. "It was phrased less generously."

"You still look tired," Theron repeated. "I stand by the diagnosis."

A few of the knights smiled. Liadrin did not, though something in her expression eased.

"The Light will answer fear, pain, pride, and appetite," she said. "That makes it useful in battle. It also makes every weakness in you a hand upon the channel. If you cannot tell need from impulse on a quiet court, you will fail when someone is dying beside you."

Her gaze traveled across the order. "Use the force the task requires. Put it where it belongs. Hold it as long as command and purpose demand, then end it. Discipline is not timidity, and the Light does not exempt you from judgment because the current wears a sacred color."

Falanaras felt the rebuke settle deeper than the dent Theron had put in his breastplate. He had heard the same lesson beneath Deatholme, when Rynel spent his last strength on the passage and the soldiers depending on him rather than on his own hunger. The source had changed. The danger had learned to shine.

Boots sounded beneath the archway. Lethira entered the court with rain darkening the shoulders of her ranger leathers and three Farstriders behind her. She looked over the scorched practice posts, the cracked shields, and the knights standing in ordered lines.

“I see the city has found a cheaper way to ruin training equipment.”

Theron glanced at his shield. “Cheaper remains unproven.”

Lethira’s answering look held the old familiarity. The strain beneath it was newer. Mud streaked one boot to the knee, and the fletching at her shoulder had been tied down for hard riding. She carried a sealed message tube in one hand.

She offered the tube to Liadrin. “Halduron’s report. Amani war bands have moved west of Zul’Aman in strength. They struck two southern watch posts, left one burning, and broke every Scourge fetish they found along the Dead Scar.”

Liadrin broke the seal. “Driving the undead before them.”

“That is the assumption. Our southern riders lost the trail in the blight. The runestone wardens felt three impacts against the boundary before dawn.” Lethira’s mouth tightened. “The last one was larger.”

The court went silent. Beyond its walls, Silvermoon’s ward-lamps hummed and market awnings snapped in the wet wind. Three weeks of training had given the Blood Knights a uniform, a doctrine, and wounds earned beneath controlled ceilings. None had yet carried M’uru’s Light beyond the city.

Liadrin rolled the message shut. "Mount within the hour."

* * *

They rode south under a sky the color of old steel.

Hawkstrider claws tore at the rain-soft road. The Blood Knights traveled in two files behind Liadrin, black cloaks lifting over crimson saddlecloths. Lethira's Farstriders ranged ahead and along the flanks, appearing between copper-barked trees before vanishing into the enchanted green. Eversong held perpetual spring again, yet the restored runestones could not erase the scars beneath it. New grass covered old trenches. Pale sap bled from trunks split by siege fire years before.

Falanaras rode near the front with his two-handed sword secured across his back. No shield burdened him. He had tried one during the first week and learned what Theron had known for years: protection required a patience different from endurance. Falanaras's instincts drove him toward the spellcaster behind the line, the ward holding a gate, the hand directing the blade. Theron preferred to become the obstacle those threats could not pass.

They had built the order's first field doctrine from such differences. Some knights learned to hold overlapping barriers. Others turned Light through heavy weapons or carried it into wounds. Every exercise ended with Liadrin demanding an accounting: how much power, for what result, and what remained after the need had passed.

The questions had sounded severe in Silvermoon. South of the city, with smoke staining the horizon, they became practical.

Near midday they passed the first watch post. The tower still stood, though its lower room had burned. Two rangers lay beneath cloaks beside the road. A third sat against a runestone marker while a healer wrapped his forearm. He

watched the Blood Knights pass with a ranger's habitual suspicion sharpened by pain.

One of the knights broke formation and dismounted. She knelt beside him, laid two fingers above the soaked bandage, and drew a narrow current. Red-gold radiance entered the wound. The ranger gasped. Torn flesh closed beneath the cloth, enough to slow the bleeding and restore movement without hiding the damage entirely.

The Light withdrew. The knight swayed once when she stood.

The ranger flexed his hand. Distrust remained in his face. So did wonder.

"You can thank the naaru when we return," Lethira said from the saddle.

The wounded ranger looked between her and the knight. He seemed unsure whether she had made a joke. Falanaras was unsure as well.

They pressed on. The air changed by degrees. Spring warmth thinned. Birdsong failed. The golden leaves nearest the southern boundary curled inward despite the rain, and every active runestone carried a faint pressure against Falanaras's spellbreaker senses. The network was holding something away. Each mile made that resistance more urgent.

Theron rode beside him. When the tremor entered Falanaras's fingers, he admitted a measured thread of Light. Relief moved through him at once, warm and complete, with M'uru's broken music beneath it. He closed the draw while more remained. Theron watched his hand settle and said nothing until the current was gone.

"Better?" Theron asked.

"Adequate."

"A stirring endorsement."

Ahead, Lethira raised a fist.

The column slowed. A lone figure stood where the road bent around a fractured runestone. Hood down, bow held across her body, she wore the dark leather and black fletching of Sylvanas's rangers. Rain silvered the gray skin at her temples. A narrow scar divided one dead eyebrow.

Serenya Duskrunner waited on the northern side of the boundary.

Lethira's hand lowered to the hilt of her long knife. The motion appeared unconscious. Serenya saw it and gave no sign.

"You are late," the dark ranger said.

"You are north of the line," Lethira answered.

"So are they." Serenya pointed past the trees. "The Amani broke the control fetishes and drove a Scourge column up the Scar. Ghouls, skeletons, two necromancers, at least one stitched brute. They struck the runestone web before my scouts could turn them. The western span failed."

Falanaras reached toward the boundary with his trained senses. The runestone network trembled around a gap farther east, its currents frayed and lashing. Beyond that breach, necromantic power moved through Eversong in pulsing knots.

"How far?" Liadrin asked.

"Less than a league. Boundary wardens and a ranger patrol are delaying them near the old orchard road. Six of mine are on the eastern flank." Serenya looked at the black-and-crimson ranks. Her eyes were filmed and cold, yet the attention behind them remained exact. "Whatever you have become, use it while there are living elves left to defend."

Liadrin turned her mount. "Shield file with Theron. Strike file with Falanaras. The rest hold between them and recover the wounded. Rangers screen both flanks." She looked once toward the south, where the Dead Scar cut through the

hostile Ghostlands toward ruins no one held. “We fight inside Eversong. We close the breach after.”

No speech followed. The hawkstriders surged north.

* * *

The first corpse Falanaras saw wore a warden’s crimson cloak.

It lay beneath an apple tree whose spring blossoms had blackened in a single afternoon. Past it, the orchard road opened onto a low rise churned to mud. A dozen boundary defenders held the crest behind a failing ward. Ghouls clawed against its surface. Skeletons pressed through the gaps with rusted spears, and death bolts fell among the defenders in slow green arcs.

Behind the Scourge front came the abomination, huge enough to rise above the trees. Hooks swung from chains buried in its shoulders. Three mismatched arms dragged a butcher’s cleaver through the mud. A necromancer walked in its shadow, staff raised, feeding commands through a web of sickly light.

Falanaras saw the web before he saw the individual strands. Spellbreaker training separated the pressure into its parts: control lines, reinforcement knots, death magic drawn from charms tied along the brute’s spine. The structure was crude and strong. Breaking the necromancer alone might leave the creature raging without direction.

“Dismount!” he called.

The knights hit the ground at a run. Theron’s file reached the crest first. Five shields locked. A low, sustained current spread from Theron’s stance through the other shield knights and into the exhausted wardens beside them, firming legs, grips, and battered armor. When the file raised its shields, that same red-gold strength folded forward into a joined barrier. It struck the failing warden spell from behind and

braced it. Holy radiance ground against blue arcane lines, but the two workings held together.

The nearest defenders stared for half a breath. Theron slammed his shield rim against the earth.

“Be surprised later,” he said. “Brace now.”

The wardens obeyed.

Liadrin’s ranseur swept forward. “Strike.”

Falanaras crossed through the barrier as Theron opened a narrow seam. He bound the Light along his sword during the first step. M’uru’s wounded music rose within the rush. He gave the stored force a point of release—the first undead body his edge entered—and let no anger choose beyond it.

His first cut took a ghoul across the chest. The force bound to the sword discharged through dead flesh and burned along the bones beneath. The creature came apart before it reached the ground; the blade went dark at once. Daric struck beside him with a heavy weapon carrying its own stored radiance. He released the charge through a skeleton’s breastbone in a compact burst bright enough to cast tree shadows, then rebound the Light before the next blow. Two more knights widened the breach.

The effect on the Scourge was immediate. Holy fire clung to necromantic bindings. Sigils ruptured. Ghouls that had endured arrows and ordinary steel recoiled from wounds that continued consuming them. For years Falanaras had fought the undead with exhaustion as his closest companion. Now the functions he had watched in Edric’s hands answered through coercion: radiance stored in steel, released through impact, and called again without prayer. The difference lay beneath every use, audible in M’uru’s pain.

A death bolt came low from the right. Falanaras’s old training read the current before his body answered with the Light. He raised a narrow red-gold plane across its path and

angled the defense toward empty ground. The killing spell struck, spread across the barrier, and broke into the mud beside him.

Fel-green force thinned between his fingers as he took a bounded measure from the spell's loose power before it dispersed. Beyond the scorched mud, the caster raised both hands for another attack. Falanaras closed the distance and released the arcane power he had retained in a tight blue-white rush. It struck the necromancer at the opening of the invocation. The word died in its throat; the gathered spell went dark, and no new command left its hands. Lethira's next arrow took the creature through the eye.

Light and arcane power answered different needs in him. One came through the governed bond and carried M'uru's cry. The other was the familiar residue of hostile magic taken in combat, held only long enough to break a caster's next use. Neither absolved the hand directing it. Together they opened the line.

Arrows passed over his shoulders. Lethira's rangers fired from the orchard rows, each shot chosen to break knees, throats, and casting hands. Black-fletched Forsaken arrows answered from farther east. The Scourge compressed around the breach despite both volleys. Liadrin planted the butt of her ranseur in the mud and called the Light through every undead body before her. Red-gold fire erupted across the rise. Skeletons burst apart at their joints. Ghouls flew backward with radiance burning through eye sockets and open wounds. The living defenders inside the same sweep felt only heat and the pressure of its passing.

The abomination reached the crest.

Its cleaver struck Theron's barrier. The impact flattened grass and drove every shield knight back a pace. One dropped

to a knee. Light swelled around him in panic, spilling past the joined ward in bright, ragged sheets.

“Close it,” Theron ordered.

The knight’s eyes were wide. “It will break through.”

“Then give me the strength to stop it. Close your excess.”

Theron’s calm reached him where reassurance might have failed. The ragged flare narrowed. Theron caught it through the joined shields, gathered the current into a dense curve, and leaned into the next blow. Cleaver met radiance. This time the barrier held.

“Falanaras!” Liadrin called.

He was already moving. The necromantic web around the abomination tightened with every strike. Three knots pulsed beneath the stitched skin: one at the spine, one in the chest, one under the forward shoulder. The Light showed them as shadows within a brighter world.

Daric went left. Falanaras went right.

A hooked chain swept toward him. He ducked beneath it and cut upward through the creature’s lower arm. Holy fire filled the wound. Daric’s blade struck the shoulder knot from the other side. The binding snapped with a sound like wet rope. One of the abomination’s arms fell slack.

The brute roared. Its cleaver tore free of Theron’s ward and came down toward Falanaras.

Red-gold radiance closed around Falanaras from throat to boots. The descending cleaver met the sheath and skidded aside as though it had struck an unseen wall; for that single heartbeat, iron could not reach him. The protection vanished before the abomination recovered. Falanaras rolled clear and came up on one knee. Behind the shield line, Theron lowered the arm he had extended through the gap.

“Adequate?” Theron called.

Falanaras drove his sword through the chest knot. “Improving.”

Radiance burst inside the abomination. Stitches blazed. The creature convulsed, struck blindly, and crushed two ghouls beneath its own feet. Liadrin’s ranseur entered the final knot at the spine. She released a single concentrated pulse. The binding vanished. The stitched brute sagged forward, its stolen parts surrendering to weight.

The victory lasted one breath.

Then a horn sounded from the eastern orchard. Three short notes. Serenya turned toward it before anyone else.

“My scouts are cut off.”

Through the trees, Falanaras caught movement: black cloaks among a knot of skeletons, ghouls closing from behind, another necromantic current hidden below the rise. The eastern Scourge flank had curled around the Forsaken position. Worse, it carried the stronger command line. The necromancer behind the abomination had been a decoy or a subordinate.

Lethira reached Serenya with an arrow nocked. “Can they withdraw?”

“No. The hollow behind them commands the eastern flank. If they run now, the whole line follows.” Serenya pointed toward a stand of white-barked trees beyond her trapped scouts. “Give us twenty breaths under cover. My scouts will expose the focus. When it breaks, we withdraw through the confusion.”

“And if you are wrong?” Lethira asked.

Serenya met her eyes. Rain ran across dead skin and gathered at her jaw without drawing a blink. “Then you lose twenty breaths and six Forsaken. If I am right, the whole host loses its spine.”

Their shared history stood between them: the ranger they had each been, the kingdom that had died around one and failed to bury the other, Sylvanas's shadow over every word. Lethira's face closed until only the field remained.

"Twenty," she said. She turned to Falanaras. "Can you cover them?"

Twenty breaths. A low ward that preserved the scouts' sight lines and took the death bolts where they were falling.

"Yes," he said. "Bring two rangers to mark the edges. Daric, with me."

They fought east through the orchard. Falanaras cut a path while Daric guarded his exposed side. Lethira's arrows marked two trees at the edge of the trapped scouts' position. Each shaft carried a blue ward-thread. Falanaras drove his sword into the mud between them and opened the Light.

Pain sang through him. The current pressed toward release.

A high, seamless wall would blind the scouts and diffuse strength across ground the Scourge was not striking. He built the ward low and angled, thickest beneath the falling death bolts. Daric added his current at the western edge. Two recovery knights reached them and anchored the other side. Red-gold planes joined between the marked trees, uneven as hammered metal and fitted to the retreat beneath them.

The first death bolt struck and spread green fire across the surface. The shield held.

"One," Lethira counted.

Serenya ran beneath the cover. Her scouts moved with her, some limping, all still shooting. They did not flee north toward safety. They wheeled south and east, drawing the ghouls after them, peeling the Scourge flank away from the hidden hollow.

At eight breaths, a skeleton reached the shield's end. Daric met it with his shoulder and smashed it against a tree.

At twelve, the hidden necromancer understood the maneuver. The command line tightened. Every ghoul in the eastern orchard turned at once.

At fifteen, the ward bowed so deeply that Falanaras saw the nearest death bolt through a handspan of red-gold fire. He opened the current wider and drove the added force into the failing span rather than across the whole barrier. Daric's jaw clenched at the western anchor. Across the ward, one recovery knight's arms shook as the reinforced planes brightened over the impact line, still low enough for the scouts to see their marks.

He held the strengthened ward against the next strike.

A black arrow rose from the hollow. It struck a branch above the necromancer's concealment. The shaft carried a strip of white cloth.

"There," Serenya shouted.

Lethira pivoted. Her bow bent to the ear. She did not look toward Serenya again. She trusted the mark.

The arrow vanished between the trees.

A robed figure staggered into view with the shaft buried beneath its jaw. The necromancer clawed at the fletching. Serenya's second arrow struck its wrist. Her third entered the green crystal mounted within the bone frame behind it.

The focus cracked.

Falanaras felt the command line recoil through the entire host. Skeletons faltered in mid-stride. Ghouls spun toward the sudden absence behind them. The remaining necromancer near the road raised both hands, trying to gather the severed strands.

Liadrin reached him first.

Her ranseur passed through his staff and breastbone in one red-gold stroke. She wrenched the blade free and lifted it high.

“Advance.”

Theron's shields moved as one. The wardens advanced behind them. With Serenya's scouts clear and the command line broken, Falanaras tore his sword from the earth and let the rough ward fall. Exhaustion struck at once, followed by the returning ache of magical hunger. He accepted both. The Light had done what he asked of it, and M'uru had suffered for every measure.

The Blood Knights drove down the rise.

Their first field battle ended without ceremony. Theron's shield crushed a ghoul against a broken cart. Daric split the last deathguard's helm. Liadrin burned the remaining fetishes from the abomination's corpse. Falanaras and Lethira fought back-to-back near the orchard wall, sword and bow choosing whatever survived the other. Serenya's scouts came in from the flank and put black arrows into every undead creature that tried to crawl south.

One of the boundary defenders fell as the line moved. A Forsaken ranger caught him before he struck the ground. For an instant the living elf hung in gray arms, horror plain on his face. Then the dark ranger dragged him behind Theron's shields and shouted for a healer.

A Blood Knight knelt beside them. The cut across the defender's side was pouring blood but had missed the organs. A quick red-gold pulse closed skin and the largest vessels, stopping the immediate loss. His breath still came shallow from shock and bruised ribs. The knight kept one hand against his breastplate and called a slower current through the deeper damage until the breathing steadied. The Forsaken held the living elf still through both workings.

No one named the strangeness. There was too much blood in the mud.

* * *

By dusk, the Scourge incursion had become rows of burning remains along the orchard road.

The rain stopped. Smoke climbed through the branches and turned the restored spring air bitter. Wardwrights arrived from the north with replacement stones and silver wire. Under guard, they began drawing the western span of the boundary closed. Each repaired line gave a low note that Falanaras felt in his teeth.

The wounded lay beneath orchard awnings. Blood Knights moved among them in black and crimson, closing wounds, easing shock, and learning how much Light a body could bear after terror had stripped away the discipline of a practice chamber. Their radiance made the scene beautiful from a distance. Up close, clenched jaws, shaking hands, and breaths held until each flare faded betrayed what the radiance cost at its source.

Theron sat on a fallen section of wall while Lethira stitched a cut above his ear.

“We have healers now,” he said.

“You have people who set practice posts on fire.” Lethira pulled the stitch tight. “Hold still.”

Falanaras leaned against the wall beside them. His arms felt hollow after the sustained ward. The ache of magical hunger had returned with exhaustion. He reached for the Light, took only enough to still the tremor, and let it go. M’uru’s pain lingered behind the rain-smoke bitterness in his mouth. He watched a Forsaken scout splint a ranger’s ankle while the ranger pretended to study the smoke.

“We would have buried twice as many without the order,” Theron said.

Falanaras knew what he meant: the shields, the healing, the way stolen Light had torn through creatures that had cost

them blood for years. The judgment held no triumph, only the hard accounting of a soldier whose line had survived.

“Yes,” Falanaras said.

The answer did not require him to forget the source.

Near the fractured runestone, Serenya gathered her scouts. Two could still walk without help. One had lost an arm below the elbow and bound the stump with a strip torn from her own cloak. Liadrin ordered a recovery knight to offer healing once. The words came hard, as though forced through clenched teeth. When every Forsaken refused, relief crossed her face before she mastered it. She understood what they were. Her body still answered them as Scourge.

Lethira approached Serenya alone. The dark ranger held out the white cloth she had used to mark the hidden necromancer. An old Farstrider emblem had been embroidered at one corner, faded almost beyond recognition.

“You kept that,” Lethira said.

“It was useful.” Serenya’s ruined voice gave the word no warmth. She folded the cloth and returned it to a pouch.

“Your judgment was sound.”

“So was yours.”

The words seemed to cost Lethira more than drawing the bow had. Serenya inclined her head. Neither reached across the distance between them.

Liadrin joined them at the boundary and stopped beyond easy reach. Her grip tightened on the ranseur. Red-gold Light kindled along its blade before she extinguished it, a reflex too swift to disguise. “There will be another incursion.”

“There is always another,” Serenya said.

“Then send warning to this line,” Liadrin said. Each word came clipped by an anger battle had not spent. “If the Scourge cross it, we will answer. Do not mistake that for

welcome.” Her gaze stayed on Serenya’s dead face. “Today proved the method.”

Serenya looked past her to the Blood Knights among the wounded. Red-gold light rose and faded beneath the trees. “It proved several things.”

Liadrin’s jaw tightened. She offered no defense and no acknowledgment. Acceptance would have been too generous a name for her silence.

The repaired runestone span brightened. A curtain of faint blue force passed through the orchard from west to east, stirring smoke and dead leaves. South of it, the Ghostlands lay under gathering dark. Tranquillien remained a hostile ruin beyond sight. Deatholme still stood farther down the Scar. The day’s victory had reclaimed none of that ground.

Serenya’s scouts crossed through the boundary before the ward settled to full strength. The living elves watched them go. A few offered stiff gestures of acknowledgment. The Forsaken returned them without turning around.

Lethira stood beside Falanaras as Serenya disappeared among the blighted trees.

“Do not say anything thoughtful,” she murmured.

“I was going to ask whether you intended to keep pretending your hands were steady.”

She glanced at his hands. The magical tremor had eased, but the muscles still shook from strain now that battle discipline was loosening. “Sit down before you fall down.”

“That was almost concern.”

“You have been struck in the head repeatedly.”

Behind them, Liadrin called the Blood Knights to order. Fourteen had ridden south. Fourteen still stood, though several needed help to mount. Boundary defenders lined the road to watch them form. Awe, gratitude, and unease shared the same faces.

Falanaras took his place beside Theron. Blood darkened the new crimson edging of his tabard until cloth and stain became difficult to distinguish. His sword felt heavier than it had on the practice court. The Light still waited within reach, effective, coerced, and ready to answer again.

They had saved southern Eversong. They had held the boundary beside people many in Silvermoon regarded as monsters. Neither fact softened the other. Neither erased the captive beneath the city whose suffering had made their strength possible.

Liadrin looked down the line. Weariness had sharpened her face, but her voice carried across the orchard.

“We return north.”

The Blood Knights turned toward Silvermoon, leaving the restored ward at their backs and the hostile south beyond it. Their first victory followed them in the eyes of the living. M’uru’s cry followed in the Light.

Silence from Beyond

By the third month, the Blood Knights had learned how little victory changed the Ghostlands.

Tranquillien still stood empty beneath a bruised evening sky. Rot stained its plaster walls. The inn roof had fallen inward, and pale weeds crowded the road where merchants had once argued over wagon space. No banner flew above the town. No cooking smoke rose from its chimneys. Scourge tracks crossed Amani prints in the mud, old violence overwritten by newer passage.

Falanaras withdrew north through the ruins with six Blood Knights, nine Farstriders, and three wounded scouts between them. They had entered before dawn to destroy a necromantic focus feeding the Dead Scar. The focus was broken. The creatures it had stirred were still coming.

“Left lane,” Lethira called from a roofless doorway. “Ghouls in the tannery yard. At least twelve.”

Theron shifted toward the opening before Falanaras answered. His shield file had become four knights instead of five after Althene remained at the boundary with the worst of the wounded. Four were enough. Red-gold radiance joined their shields in overlapping curves while the Farstriders carried the scouts past.

The ghouls struck the ward in a wave of claws and spoiled flesh. Theron gave half a step, caught the force across his legs, and held. The three knights beside him matched his draw without being told. M’uru’s pain entered the street as a thin vibration beneath the clash.

Months earlier, someone would have flared too brightly. Someone would have spent enough Light to burn the first rank apart and left the whole file weakened for the second. Now the barrier bent, endured, and gave Falanaras room to work.

He and Daric passed through the shields at opposite ends. Falanaras's sword caught fire from hilt to point. He cut the nearest ghoul through the neck, turned under another creature's reach, and drove the blade backward into its ribs. Daric's heavy weapon rose and fell beside him with punishing economy. Each blow carried enough Light to ruin the bindings inside dead flesh. None wasted radiance on the air.

An arrow with black fletching struck the tannery lintel.

"Down," Lethira said.

The living elves dropped. A volley hissed over them from the southern roofs. Black arrows entered skulls, joints, and open mouths. Serenya's scouts never showed themselves. They had agreed on signals at the runestone boundary, then separated before entering the blight. Trust had advanced far enough to coordinate fields of fire. It had not advanced far enough for either patrol to sleep near the other.

Falanaras rose into the sudden gap and finished the last ghoul. The Light withdrew at his command. Hunger did not return; the power drawn from M'uru had quieted that ache before the patrol began. Fatigue remained, honest and deep in his arms. The captive's broken music lingered after every use.

Daric wiped his sword on a ghoul's ragged tunic. "I preferred our first battle."

"You were nearly dismembered by an abomination."

"The weather was better."

Theron released the joined ward. “Your standards have declined.”

“Service does that.” Daric looked toward the ruined southern street. Nothing moved there except carrion moths and one strip of black cloth tied to a gutter spike. Serenya’s signal meant the way remained open for another hundred paces. “We should continue degrading with purpose.”

They left Tranquillien before full dark. The town remained behind them for the Scourge, the Amani, and anything else willing to inhabit a place soaked in too many kinds of death. At the runestone boundary, wardens opened a narrow passage and counted every returning face. The Forsaken were already gone. A bundle of recovered dispatches waited beneath a black arrow at the edge of the road.

Limited coordination, the reports called it. The phrase concealed how often a gray hand had marked an ambush before living blood reached it, and how often red-gold Light had covered a dark ranger’s retreat. It also concealed the way Liadrin’s mouth hardened whenever those reports crossed her table.

The Blood Knights had proven their worth. Southern Eversong still needed proving every week.

* * *

Outland arrived in Silvermoon every fourth morning.

The schedule was never publicly posted, yet the Court of the Sun learned it. Families gathered near the sealed magisterial annex before dawn. Quartermasters came with tablets and carts. Petitioners carried letters for sons, daughters, spouses, and commanders serving beneath a sky they had never seen. Traders waited with requests for Netherstorm crystals and Zangarmarsh medicines. Children

traded descriptions of Hellfire Peninsula as though the red wastes were a province awaiting proper roads.

The Portal stood far to the south in the Blasted Lands, held behind blood elf fortifications and watched from distant ridges by people who distrusted its keepers. Transit reports moved first through that garrison, then through a chain of secured relays. The final gate opened beneath Silvermoon only for approved cargo and personnel. Even so, the city had made a ritual of the arrivals.

Crimson ward-lines brightened across the annex doors. Magisters called names. Dusty soldiers emerged carrying sealed orders. Couriers surrendered metal cases into waiting hands. Sometimes a traveler halted beneath Silvermoon's towers and wept before remembering that others could see.

Kael'thas rarely wrote to the city as a whole. He did not need to. His authority traveled in requisitions bearing the royal seal, casualty lists signed by his officers, and precise demands for metals, spell components, trained bodies, and patience. Each message assured Silvermoon that the prince still fought toward the future he had promised them.

Falanaras had crossed Outland and returned. The world remained more vivid in other people's hopes than in his memory. They imagined a realm of power and opportunity. He remembered red dust in his teeth, naga counting every favor, soldiers burning over a Blade's Edge gorge, and a luminous being lowering itself willingly into a cage.

Still, he watched each arrival.

On the morning Lord Sanguinar came home, the first warning was silence inside the annex.

The receiving spell faded. No magister called a name. Armored boots crossed the threshold with deliberate weight, and the waiting clerks moved aside before being ordered.

Sanguinar emerged in scarlet plate darkened by Outland dust. Four soldiers followed him, all wearing the hard assurance of elves accustomed to command among strangers.

He had been broad-shouldered before Tempest Keep. Outland had pared him down without diminishing him. A pale scar ran from his left temple into his hair. His expression held the same fierce satisfaction Falanaras remembered from the assault staging grounds, when every casualty had seemed to confirm the worth of the objective.

Lady Liadrin waited at the foot of the annex stairs with Falanaras, Theron, and Daric behind her. Sanguinar bowed to the depth owed her rank and no farther.

“Lady Liadrin. Silvermoon has dressed your work well.” His gaze moved over the black armor and crimson tabards of the Blood Knights. “His Highness will be pleased to see it carried properly into his army.”

“The order serves Quel’Thalas,” Liadrin said. “You will learn its discipline before you carry its name anywhere.”

Sanguinar smiled. “Then teach me.”

* * *

M’uru’s chamber received the Outland delegation under triple guard.

The apparatus had changed since Falanaras’s binding. More conduits crossed the floor. Fresh wardstones stood in iron cradles along the walls, each part of another attempt to carry relief into the city above. Their inner light flickered weakly. The public system remained partial, unreliable, and hungry for magisterial attention. At the chamber’s center, individual binding still worked with brutal certainty.

M’uru hung within force-chains above the lowered dais. Its radiance filled the vault in slow pulses. The connection within Falanaras stirred in response, bringing warmth beneath his breastbone and the familiar note of suffering behind it.

Sanguinar looked up without awe. He studied the restraints, the conduits, and Astalor's control table with a commander's interest in a siege engine.

"Your bond will be personal, as every Blood Knight's is," Astalor said. "Our method has held across every distance we have tested, but passage between worlds remains unmeasured. After your return, you will report every interruption, surge, delay, or distortion. You will also remain within the measure we set. Mastery of the Light begins with command of one's own appetite."

"If the power answers, it will be used."

"Your intention is clear," Astalor said. "Our work requires observations, and you will provide them."

Sanguinar's smile returned. "You make conquest sound remarkably dull."

Astalor adjusted one silver dial. "Properly governed, the bond is magnificent. Appetite is a poor substitute for mastery."

Liadrin entered the binding circle with Sanguinar. "You will feel the source when the channel opens. Do not reach beyond the measure Astalor sets."

"You doubt me."

"I remember you."

Astalor engaged the first restraint. Crimson bands tightened around M'uru. The chamber's radiance drew inward, and the naaru's cry passed through Falanaras before the sound reached his ears. Sanguinar's shoulders locked. Gold flooded his fel-green eyes.

"Receive," Liadrin ordered.

For a moment he obeyed. Red-gold Light gathered along his arms and settled beneath his skin. Then his right hand closed. The current lurched toward him. M'uru brightened in pain, and one of the force-chains rang against its pylon.

Liadrin struck him across the face.

The blow turned his head and broke his concentration. Astalor closed the channel. Light spilled from Sanguinar's fingers in fading threads.

Sanguinar touched the corner of his mouth. Blood marked his thumb. "An old priest's correction?"

"A commander's. Reach again, and you leave without access to M'uru."

His eyes remained bright with stolen gold. Anger passed through them, followed by calculation. He inclined his head.

The second attempt held. Sanguinar accepted the governed measure, settled into a sustained flow, and released it when ordered. M'uru's radiance recovered to Astalor's recorded baseline. The suffering within Falanaras did not recede as quickly.

One by one, the other Outland soldiers entered the circle. One wept without sound when the hunger vanished. Another vomited after hearing M'uru. A third failed twice before learning to let the current come without dragging at it. Liadrin dismissed the fourth when he lied about how much he had taken. Sanguinar watched them all with open impatience.

Afterward, Liadrin found Falanaras in the passage outside the chamber. Through the wall, the apparatus gave off a steady mechanical hum.

"At Tempest Keep," she said, "Sanguinar ordered a wounded company back onto the bridge because their replacements had not arrived. The bridge was already lost. He knew it. He wanted the draenei to spend ammunition killing soldiers who could no longer hold a line."

Falanaras remembered bodies beneath violet fire, too many uniforms fused into the crystal surface to know which officer had sent them. "Did it delay the defenders?"

“For less than a minute.” Liadrin looked toward the chamber doors. “He called the exchange favorable.”

“Why bind him?”

“Because the order cannot belong only to those I would choose as friends. Because Kael’t has commands an army beyond our reach, and that army is still ours.” Her voice hardened on the last word. “Because refusing him would keep the Light from soldiers who may need it while leaving Sanguinar exactly what he was.”

“And giving it to him?”

Liadrin’s gaze did not leave the doors. “May reveal what we have made.”

* * *

Sanguinar asked for a sparring partner the following afternoon.

Liadrin refused him twice. He pressed the request before the assembled order, framing it as a practical test of whether the new connection would withstand the return passage and whether Silvermoon’s doctrine could withstand Outland methods. Daric stepped forward before refusal became public humiliation.

“I have survived both,” Daric said. “One more comparison should be manageable.”

The practice court had been repaired since the order’s first weeks. New posts stood where uncontrolled flares had burned the old ones. Weapon racks lined the eastern wall. Fourteen Blood Knights formed a loose ring, joined by Sanguinar’s three successful companions and a pair of magisters assigned to measure each draw.

Daric carried a blunted greatsword. Sanguinar chose a single-handed war blade and no shield.

“First yield,” Liadrin said. “Bounded draw. No directed force above the breastplate.”

Sanguinar and Daric gave their word to the terms, then saluted.

They met in the center with enough force to send a hard report across the court. Daric used his greater reach to control the first exchange. Sanguinar slipped along the edge of each cut, testing wrists, knee, and shoulder with swift blows. He fought without Theron's patience or Falanaras's search for the power behind a line. He looked for pain and made it useful.

Daric caught him across the ribs. The blunted sword rang against plate hard enough to split skin beneath the cuirass. Sanguinar gave ground, smiling. He laid his free hand over the new wound, not to heal it, but to open a path from his pulse into the war blade. Heat climbed his veins. Crimson entered the red-gold radiance gathering along the steel, and the power took payment from him as it grew.

The blood-fed Light ignited around Sanguinar's free hand and ran into his weapon.

Sanguinar used enough force to turn the exchange and no more than the terms permitted. Falanaras felt the draw as a sudden wrench beneath his breastbone. M'uru's cry sharpened beneath the answering pain in Sanguinar's ribs. He released the power through a low strike at Daric's shield. Holy force burst across both weapons and drove Daric to one knee. Blood darkened the seam beneath Sanguinar's cuirass. The advantage was real, costly, and legitimate.

"Keep it below the breastplate," Liadrin warned.

Sanguinar reduced the flare. He circled while Daric stood. The obedience looked exact. Falanaras distrusted it more than open defiance.

Daric attacked again. Three heavy cuts drove Sanguinar toward the court wall. The third stopped at his throat.

“Yield,” Daric said.

Sanguinar seized the flat of Daric’s sword with his bare hand. The blood-fed radiance still stored in his weapon answered the motion, brightening as his own wound opened farther beneath the plate. He wrenched Daric’s blade aside and struck beneath the lifted arm.

The blow landed above the breastplate.

He released the stored force through Daric’s shoulder—above the pledged boundary. Radiance entered the joint with a flash bright enough to erase every shadow in the court. Bone cracked. Daric fell on his side, his sword skidding away. The contest had ended. Sanguinar kept the blood-fed current inside the broken shoulder anyway, spending his own pain to deepen another man’s after purpose was gone.

Falanaras crossed half the ring before thought caught him. His own sword was in his hand. Theron moved with him, shield raised.

Liadrin reached Sanguinar first. Her ranseur stopped against the hollow beneath his jaw. Red-gold fire climbed its blade in a narrow, controlled line.

“Close the channel.”

Sanguinar looked down the ranseur’s length. Light still burned around his hand. “He did not establish the yield.”

“You heard it.”

“I heard a claim from a man who still held a weapon.”

The point of the ranseur touched skin. “Close it.”

The Light went out.

Theron knelt beside Daric. The shoulder sat wrong beneath the armor, and Daric’s breath came in shallow pulls. A recovery knight cut the straps while Theron first sent a brief current around the break, stilling the bleeding and preventing the damaged joint from worsening when they moved it. Only after the armor was clear and the bone set

did he call the slower restoration. Red-gold warmth entered tendon, muscle, and fractured bone by degrees. It repaired enough to preserve the arm, not enough to erase swelling, pain, or the weeks of recovery ahead.

Sanguinar watched without remorse. "In Outland, an enemy will not honor your limits."

Falanaras stood over Daric with his sword still drawn. "Daric was not your enemy."

"Then he should have been safer."

Liadrin's face had gone still. "An enemy's dishonor does not release us from our own. You will leave at first transit tomorrow. You will take the three who completed the binding. The fourth remains here until he can face the truth inside the circle."

"His Highness requested four."

"His Highness will receive three."

For the first time, Sanguinar's satisfaction faltered. He bowed with open contempt and left the court.

Daric opened his eyes while the healers worked. Sweat shone across his brow.

"I withdraw my complaint about the weather," he said.

Theron let out a breath that might have become laughter in a kinder hour. "Save your strength."

Falanaras looked toward the archway where Sanguinar had disappeared. The order had been founded to make necessity answer discipline. Sanguinar had given his word, then broken the oath beneath it when obedience ceased to please him. He wanted victory freed from command, proportion, and the safety of anyone he did not consider an enemy. In his hands, strength ceased to serve and became permission.

M'uru's pain still trembled beneath Falanaras's breastbone.

* * *

Sanguinar crossed back into Outland at dawn.

The transit report reached Liadrin before midday. All four connections had endured the passage. Sanguinar's first message from the far-side station contained no acknowledgment of Daric's injury and no comment on M'uru's pain. He reported combat readiness, stable access, and his intention to begin training candidates within Kael'thas's army once Silvermoon supplied a method for additional bindings.

Astalor refused to send the apparatus plans. A living recipient still had to come before M'uru, and the designs exposed the controls by which Silvermoon subdued the naaru's power and governed each bond. The method belonged to Silvermoon and the order it had created; he would not surrender its mastery to an Outland command beyond Silvermoon's supervision. Liadrin supported the refusal. The matter went upward to Rommath and Lor'themar, where questions of authority became sealed correspondence.

Two days later, the Blood Knights prepared for another southern patrol.

Daric watched from a bench with his arm bound across his chest. The Light had repaired the worst damage, though the healers refused to restore full movement before the swelling eased. He criticized saddle straps while Theron inspected the shield file and Falanaras checked the strike weapons.

Lethira entered the courtyard carrying two message tubes and a look that promised inconvenience.

"The boundary wardens want a second recovery file," she said. "Serenya's scouts found fresh movement east of the Scar, and no one agrees whether it is Amani, Scourge, or both attempting cooperation."

“That would show troubling initiative,” Theron said.

“I knew you would understand the strategic concern.” Lethira handed Falanaras the first tube. The second remained tucked beneath her arm. “This one is the route. The other is —”

Every ward-lamp in the courtyard dimmed at once.

The change lasted less than a heartbeat. Crimson light returned along the walls. Hawkstriders stamped and hissed in their lines. Falanaras felt no disturbance from M'uru's presence within him, yet the arcane network beneath Silvermoon shuddered hard enough to tighten every trained muscle in his back.

A bell began ringing in the magisterial quarter. Three measured strokes, a pause, then three again.

Lethira's expression changed. “Relay failure.”

Liadrin came through the opposite arch before Falanaras could answer. A magister followed at a run, his formal robes gathered in both hands. He carried a transit crystal whose center had gone black.

“Report,” Liadrin said.

“The Dark Portal has collapsed.” The magister struggled for breath. “The near-side garrison saw the field contract without warning. Travelers were assembling for passage. The surface went dark in front of them. All far-side contact ended in the same instant.”

No one in the courtyard moved.

Falanaras remembered the Portal as an impossible wall of green fire held inside ancient stone. He remembered the Outland engines pushing against it from beyond, the blood elf pylons steadying its edges, and the instructions to cross without pausing. Something powerful enough to end that field had acted between one breath and the next.

“Attack?” Theron asked.

“Unknown.”

“Failure of the stabilizing engines?” Falanaras asked.

“Unknown.” The magister looked down at the dead crystal. “The garrison is intact. The Portal itself is stone and darkness.”

Liadrin’s gaze found Daric’s bound arm. Then it moved to the empty place where Sanguinar had stood two days earlier.

“Can you sense anything of the four beyond it?” she asked.

The question was for Astalor, who had not yet arrived, but Falanaras reached instinctively toward his own connection. M’uru answered beneath the city, immediate and wounded. Beyond that presence lay nothing he could distinguish. He had never sensed the other knights as individuals through their shared source. The absence gave him no proof of death and no comfort of life.

Liadrin turned to the assembled order. “The southern patrol proceeds. Eversong does not become safer because the Portal has failed. Falanaras, Theron, take the original files. Add two recovery knights. Lethira, send your second report to Halduron and ride with them.”

Duty moved the courtyard again. Saddles tightened. Weapons returned to scabbards. The familiar work felt smaller than it had moments before, yet no less necessary.

As Falanaras mounted, the relay bell continued over Silvermoon.

* * *

The first explanations arrived before the Blood Knights returned from the boundary.

A stabilizing engine had failed in Hellfire Peninsula. Illidan had closed the route to punish Kael’tas. Human magi had sabotaged the Azeroth side. The prince had sealed the Portal himself while preparing a greater passage. A demon army had taken the far-side

fortifications. Each account came from someone whose cousin had heard it from a clerk attached to a magister who possessed no answers.

By sunset, families crowded the Court of the Sun. They held letters that could no longer be sent and demanded names from officials who had received no casualty list. The magisters cordoned the annex. City guards kept the gathering from pressing against the wards. Every time the doors opened, the crowd surged toward them.

Falanaras stood with Liadrin beneath the annex portico after midnight. Theron had taken Daric home. Lethira carried Halduron's sealed assessment to the regent. The remaining Blood Knights formed a line between frightened citizens and frightened clerks.

An elderly man pushed a letter toward Falanaras. "My daughter serves with the prince's healers. The last dispatch said she was transferring to Netherstorm. You have been there."

Falanaras looked at the careful seal, already softened where the man's thumb had rubbed it. "Yes."

"Then tell me whether she is safe."

A lie would have cost little. Falanaras had seen officers spend them freely when fear threatened order. He had also carried Rynel's final truth home from Deatholme and learned what duty became when facts were softened for comfort.

"I cannot tell you," he said. "No message has crossed since the closure. If the Netherstorm positions remain as they were, she serves behind fortified lines. We do not know whether they remain as they were."

The man's hand lowered. He did not thank Falanaras. The letter remained clenched in his fist when a guard guided him away from the doors.

Liadrin watched him go. "You could have given him hope."

“He already had hope. He asked for knowledge.”

“And we have none.”

The admission sounded angrier than any accusation. Liadrin had built herself around burdens that could be named, measured, and carried. Silence offered no weight to lift and no enemy to strike.

On the second day, Lor'themar issued a statement: the Portal garrison remained secure, Silvermoon's magisters were investigating, and no evidence indicated the loss of Kael'thas or his forces. The careful wording steadied the markets for several hours. By evening, people were arguing over what the statement had refused to say.

Some insisted the prince would reopen the route as he had opened it before. Others claimed enemies in Silvermoon wanted contact broken. Veterans accused merchants of panic. Merchants accused the magisters of hoarding information. Outside the annex, someone began a prayer to the royal line and stopped halfway through, embarrassed by the old habit.

On the third night, Falanaras entered the receiving chamber with Liadrin, Astalor, and Rommath.

The circular platform stood empty. Its embedded crystals were dull. Before the closure, a faint pressure had always rested behind the relay wards, proof of the long chain reaching south to the Portal and beyond it. Falanaras had noticed the sensation only when it vanished.

Rommath finished the final diagnostic and lowered his hands. Arcane symbols faded around him.

“The Azeroth relays are functional,” he said. “The garrison can reach us by ordinary transport. The break is the gateway. Nothing crosses the threshold.”

“Can it be forced?” Liadrin asked.

“Perhaps. The first opening required Illidan’s power, Kael’thas’s magisters, and engines built in Outland. We possess one side of that effort.” Rommath’s expression remained severe. “Attempting the work blindly may destroy the standing frame or attract something prepared to answer.”

Astalar set the blackened transit crystal on the platform with unusual care. When he spoke, strain tightened his measured cadence. “Sanguinar’s channel has left no trace we can isolate from M’uru’s other currents. That tells us nothing. The world between us may conceal it. He may be drawing without interruption. He may be unable to draw. He may be dead.”

Liadrin’s eyes flashed gold beneath the green. “You take comfort in precision.”

“There is no comfort in this.” Astalar’s voice sharpened, and the break from his habitual restraint made the words carry. “Four bonds fashioned for our order now lie beyond Silvermoon’s reach. We cannot determine whether they endure, whether they have failed, or what is being done through them. I will not make that danger sound smaller.”

Falanaras stood at the platform’s edge. Three days earlier, Sanguinar had crossed with stolen Light inside him and Kael’thas’s certainty before him. Falanaras had been relieved to see him go. The memory now carried shame, though he could not decide what better wish he should have made.

“Contact had been stable,” he said. “The far side reported no attack. Sanguinar crossed safely. Supply requests came through the previous cycle.”

Rommath looked at him. “Yes.”

“Then either they did not know this was coming, or they did not warn us.”

The chamber held the words without answering them.

Falanaras had spent years believing distance explained the prince's silence. Kael'thas fought in another world. Messages required ships, hidden roads, guarded relays, and powers beyond ordinary reach. Every delay had possessed a reason. Every order that arrived renewed the promise connecting Silvermoon's suffering to his purpose.

Now the road had vanished while certainty was still traveling upon it.

Beneath the city, M'uru remained in chains. Along the southern boundary, the Blood Knights kept watch. Outland held Kael'thas, Sanguinar, and thousands of sin'dorei beyond any answer Silvermoon could compel.

The relay platform stayed dark.

The Future He Refused

By the eleventh month, Silvermoon had learned to live around the silence.

The magisterial annex no longer drew a crowd before dawn. Families still delivered letters, but the clerks stored them unopened in lacquered cases against a road that might never return. Outland medicines disappeared from apothecary shelves. Quartermasters dismantled the cargo wards and reassigned their crystals to the city wall. Children who had once argued over the color of Netherstorm's sky found newer contests.

No proclamation declared Kael'thas lost. His banners remained above the Court of the Sun. Royal seals still marked old requisitions in military offices, and officials continued to speak of interrupted contact rather than abandonment. The distinction had survived so long that it had become part of the city's discipline.

Falanaras had stopped looking toward the annex when he crossed the Court.

He was beneath the eastern barracks when the relay bell began.

The first three strokes pulled him from sleep. The next three brought him upright before thought. Across the dark chamber, Theron reached for the sword beside his cot. Daric woke more slowly, one hand going to the shoulder Sanguinar had broken. The injury had healed months ago, though cold mornings still drew stiffness through it.

The bell continued.

"That is not the failure signal," Theron said.

Falanaras was already fastening his sword belt. “No.”

The signal for restored contact had not been used in nearly a year.

They reached the courtyard as crimson lamps flared awake along the walls. Doors opened throughout the barracks. Blood Knights emerged half-armored, carrying gauntlets and scabbards. A runner in magisterial gray came through the gate hard enough to skid on the paving stones.

“The Portal has opened,” he said. “Lady Liadrin requires Captain Dawnspear at the annex.”

Hope moved through the courtyard before anyone could forbid it.

It showed in lifted faces and suddenly quick hands. One knight laughed once, breathless and disbelieving. Daric’s expression tightened around a thought he did not voice. Sanguinar had crossed two days before the closure. Three other Blood Knights had gone with him. Whatever they had become in the silence, an open road offered the first chance to know.

The runner had not smiled.

Falanaras followed him into the waking city.

The receiving chamber beneath the annex held no travelers. Its circular platform burned with a sick green reflection cast by the relay crystals. Rommath stood within a ring of suspended sigils, both hands raised. Astalor watched the instruments beside him. Lor’themar and Halduron occupied the edge of the platform, armored as though the bell had called them straight from another crisis. Liadrin waited near the doors.

A man’s voice came through the central crystal in bursts of static.

“—field stabilized. Repeat, the gateway is active. Legion forces hold the lower stairs and both eastern approaches. We have withdrawn to the ridge fortification. Casualties—”

The crystal shrieked. Rommath closed two fingers, cutting the noise before it broke the receiving array.

“Begin again from the activation,” Lor’themar ordered.

The garrison commander’s answer arrived thinly. “Doom Lord Kazzak came out of the Blasted Lands with an artifact our magisters could not identify. He drove its power into the standing frame. The gateway answered. Demons began crossing before the field had fully formed.”

“From Outland into Azeroth?” Halduron asked.

“Yes. The first ranks secured the stairs. More followed. We could not hold the threshold.”

Falanaras remembered green fire stretching between the carved stones and blood elf pylons biting into the ground to steady it. He remembered the old garrison’s confidence, born from years of believing the route belonged to those who had forced it open. Kazzak had turned that certainty into an invitation for the Legion.

“Has any Sunfury signal crossed?” Liadrin asked.

A pause answered first.

“None, my lady.”

“The prince’s transit cipher?” Rommath asked.

“Silent.”

The Portal had reopened. The road was there. Nothing they had waited for stood upon it.

* * *

Silvermoon knew the Portal was open before sunrise.

No official notice had been posted. The relay bell had done enough, and servants carried fragments from the annex into kitchens, guardhouses, workshops, and mana lines. By midmorning the Court of the Sun had filled with families

holding letters retrieved from storage. Traders reopened old inventories. Two transport factors began arguing over cargo priority beneath windows that remained shuttered against them.

The Regent Lord's proclamation appeared at noon. Its first line confirmed what the bell had promised: the gateway was active.

The gateway is active. The approaches remain under hostile occupation. No civilian passage has been authorized. The Regent Lord has received no communication from His Highness or his appointed commanders. Further reports will follow when verified.

Most readers needed nothing beyond the opening line.

Falanaras spent the day at the annex with a Blood Knight guard, holding back people who believed urgency could turn prohibition into passage. A jeweler offered three months of earnings for a place in the first caravan. A mother demanded that the magisters send her through because both her sons served in Netherstorm. One young man arrived with a pack, a ceremonial sword, and a copy of Kael'thas's earliest proclamation to the sin'dorei folded inside his coat.

"He called for us," the young man said. "If the road is open, we should answer."

"The road is held by demons."

"Then His Highness needs soldiers."

Falanaras looked at the untouched sword and the pack tied with household cord. "He needs soldiers who can reach him. You would die on the lower stairs."

The young man's face hardened. He left without thanking him.

Near dusk, Theron brought Falanaras a cup of watered wine and stood beside him under the portico. Across the square,

citizens read the proclamation aloud to one another and supplied kinder meanings between its lines.

"They have waited a long time to misunderstand good news," Theron said.

"There may still be good news."

Theron drank from his own cup. "You have begun sounding like me. I object."

The annex doors opened behind them. Rommath emerged with Halduron and four Farstriders dressed in travel leathers darkened to swallow light. No red marked them. Their weapons had been wrapped, their hair bound close, and each carried enough warding metal to burden a pack animal.

Falanaras set down the wine. "When do we leave?"

Rommath regarded his black plate. "We do not."

"I know the far-side fortifications."

"And every demonic ward on that plateau will taste the Light in you before your boots touch the ground. The rangers will cross under concealment, observe, and return. If the route can bear a larger force, you may resent me afterward."

Lethira came through the doors last, checking the fletching on a short bundle of arrows.

"I offered to make his armor less conspicuous," she said. "Apparently burying him to the neck exceeds the mission parameters."

She stopped before Falanaras. The mockery left her face without leaving her voice. "We will look for the prince's standards. Sanguinar too, if he has been considerate enough to stand somewhere visible."

Falanaras wanted to tell her what dangers waited beyond the green field. She had fought through Silvermoon's fall, Deatholme, and every blighted mile between the runestones and Tranquillien. Warnings would only name risks she had already counted.

“Come back with what is true,” he said.

Lethira drew her hood up. “That is usually the goal.”

* * *

The scouts returned on the third night with one wounded ranger and no word from Kael'thas.

Falanaras met them in a secured chamber beneath the annex. Lethira's cloak smelled of sulfur and old blood. A narrow burn crossed her jaw. The wounded ranger lay on a table while a healer drew green corruption from his thigh in smoking threads.

Halduron stood over a map of Hellfire Peninsula. “Report from the crossing.”

Lethira placed three black stones on the map. “Legion emplacements here, here, and along the old supply trench. Felhounds patrol the lower approach. The stabilizing engines have been altered or destroyed. I could not reach the western controls without exposing the team.”

“The Sunfury station?” Rommath asked.

“Abandoned. We found blood, burned papers, and racks stripped of weapons. No bodies. The garrison may have withdrawn before the Legion arrived.”

“A second possibility is that they abandoned the station to join the Legion,” Astalor said. “The stripped racks suggest they departed armed. The blood and burned papers do not tell us where their loyalty lay afterward.”

Lethira's eyes cut toward him. “The room contained no oath of allegiance helpfully left beneath a paperweight.”

Astalor inclined his head. “Quite so. Your report establishes that the station was abandoned, not why. We should retain both explanations until further evidence distinguishes them.”

Falanaras studied the map. The road from the Portal into Hellfire Citadel had once carried Kael'thas's detachments west. "How far did you see?"

"Far enough to find every ridge occupied and no blood elf formation holding the route. We saw smoke over the northern works. Nothing flew above them except Legion standards." Lethira removed one glove. Her fingers trembled once before she closed them. "Hellfire is open. It is not ours."

Lor'themar had listened without moving. "You said three nights. Your planned observation required two."

Lethira looked toward the chamber door. "We brought someone back."

The guards admitted a blood elf woman in scorched traveling robes. Dust had turned the fabric almost gray. An unfamiliar silver eye had been stitched over her heart, and a warded case hung from both wrists on a short chain. She carried herself like a magister who had spent too many days pretending to be a corpse.

Her gaze moved across the room, caught on the red-gold light beneath Liadrin's eyes, and stopped.

"Regent Lord," she said. "I carry a letter from Voren'thal the Seer of the Scryers, sworn now to the Sha'tar of Shattrath. It is for your hand."

The old name passed through the room with more force than the title that followed it. Voren'thal had advised Kael'thas in Outland. Falanaras remembered him at the edge of the Netherstorm war room, white-haired and severe, speaking rarely because the prince had listened when he did.

"The Scryers," Rommath said. "Who named you that?"

"Those who watched us surrender and expected treachery. We kept the name."

She raised her chained hands. “The case will open for the Regent Lord, Grand Magister Rommath, or Lady Liadrin. The cipher inside was laid before the Portal closed. Voren’tal believed at least one of you would recognize it.”

Lor’themar approached her. “Why did Voren’tal believe his word required chains and three days through Legion territory?”

“Because what he asks you to believe will sound like betrayal.” The messenger looked at the royal banners hanging above the map. “And because much of it is.”

* * *

They moved to Lor’themar’s council chamber before the city could learn whom the scouts had brought home.

Rommath examined the case beneath seven separate wards. The first yielded to Lor’themar’s touch. The next five answered old royal ciphers and magisterial signatures. The last opened when Liadrin laid two fingers against a seal formed from pale crystal.

“Voren’tal keyed this before we left for Tempest Keep,” Rommath said. “I remember the sequence.”

Inside lay a letter, three narrow dispatch rolls, and a shard of violet crystal. Astalor took the shard to a side table without being asked. Halduron unrolled the dispatches. Lor’themar broke the letter’s seal.

Falanaras remained near the doors with Liadrin. He had not been summoned as a councilor. He was there because he had walked the roads the letter described, served beneath the prince’s eye, and entered Tempest Keep with the army now accused of turning against its own future.

Lor’themar read in silence at first. His expression altered so little that each small change carried weight: a tightening at the mouth, one stopped breath, a glance toward Liadrin that ended before she met it.

“Read it aloud,” Liadrin said.

Lor’themar looked around the chamber. “What is heard here remains here until I decide otherwise.”

No one answered. He began.

Regent Lord Theron, I write from Shattrath because the truth can no longer travel through the prince’s command. I served Kael’tas as counselor, magister, and soldier. I believed his victories purchased a road home. I now believe every victory carried us farther from it.

The messenger kept her eyes lowered. Liadrin did not.

Illidan ordered an assault upon Shattrath, fearing the naaru power gathered there. Kael’tas entrusted the attack to me. I accepted command and led our people across Outland toward a city we knew only as another objective.

Before we reached its walls, a vision took me. I saw Quel’Thalas beneath a sky unmarred by smoke. Our people stood without trembling hands or hidden shame. No child watched a crystal with an addict’s patience. No mother measured the magic remaining in a room before deciding whether her family could sleep there.

At the heart of that vision shone a naaru. Its Holy Light lay over our land, and every sin’dorei it touched remembered what it was to live without craving. I felt the torment leave my own spirit. When I woke, I could no longer call our suffering permanent, nor every cruel answer necessary.

The Light within Falanaras stirred. M’uru’s presence rose beneath his breastbone, warm and wounded. He could almost hear the force-chains answering in the vault below the city.

Liadrin’s fingers had closed around the edge of the table.

“Continue,” she said.

I returned to His Highness and entered his war chamber without ceremony. Before officers who had survived Dalaran, Northrend, and the long campaigns across Outland, I told him what I had seen. I urged him to abandon the assault, seek the naaru of Shattrath, and consider that salvation might require us to surrender power rather than acquire more.

His Highness heard me with the patience he once gave unwelcome counsel. Then he asked whether a vision would feed one starving citizen in Silvermoon that night. He asked whether the naaru had offered armies, transport, or stores. He said our people had waited upon grace before and buried a kingdom for the privilege.

I answered that a warning does not become false because it arrives without provisions. He dismissed me from command.

Falanaras heard Kael'thas's voice inside the words. The questions were cruel because they were the ones Quel'Thalas had asked of every promise. Food. Power. Soldiers. Time. The prince had once made answers from whatever the world withheld.

Those who believed me left the Sunfury ranks with me. We approached Shattrath prepared to die before reaching its walls. Instead, we laid down our weapons before A'dal and were received. We became the Scryers: servants and uneasy guests in the city we had marched to conquer.

Our departure did not turn His Highness back. I fear it drove him toward a harsher answer.

After we left, I learned that Kael'thas had broken with Illidan's command. Sunfury forces seized the remaining wings of Tempest Keep, expelling or killing garrisons that would not answer to the prince alone, and turned Netherstorm's engines against former allies. Supply posts vanished into his private war. Orders began carrying seals unknown to me and instructions routed through demonic intermediaries.

I cannot tell you every vow he has made, Lor'themar. I can tell you what his soldiers now guard. Legion envoys have entered Tempest Keep. Fel armaments arrive without Illidan's mark. The prince gathers power against enemies in Outland while no longer sending relief, explanation, or command to the kingdom whose suffering justified his rise.

He has not ceased speaking of our people. That is the danger. He names Quel'Thalas in the same breath as every weapon he desires, as though our survival can sanctify an ambition that no longer returns to us.

Lor'themar lowered the page.

No one spoke for several breaths. The city's wards hummed beyond the chamber walls. Somewhere below, power drawn from M'uru passed through conduits that still failed to carry enough relief to the districts above.

Liadrin broke the silence. "He saw a naaru above Quel'Thalas."

The messenger looked at her. "Yes."

"And we brought one beneath it." Gold flared through Liadrin's green eyes. "In chains."

Rommath's expression hardened. "A vision is not an instruction manual."

"No," Liadrin said. "It is an accusation."

Falanaras felt M'uru's pain within the warmth under his ribs. Voren'thal had been shown freedom from hunger through a naaru's willing radiance. The Blood Knights had achieved relief through restraints, measured force, and obedience. Both paths passed through the Light. Only one had asked the naaru's consent.

Liadrin turned on the messenger. "Did A'dal send this vision?"

"Voren'thal does not claim to know. A'dal received him after it occurred."

"Does A'dal know we hold M'uru?"

The messenger hesitated. "Yes."

The word entered the room softly. Liadrin took it harder than a shout.

* * *

The dispatch rolls supported too much of the letter.

Halduron found Sunfury unit designations beside attacks on Illidari supply lines. Rommath authenticated two command signatures and rejected a third as deliberately obscured. The violet shard held a recorded image of Tempest Keep's outer platform: blood elf soldiers admitting a horned emissary beneath banners Falanaras did not recognize. The recording ended before any words passed between them.

"The recording establishes contact," Astalor said. "It does not reveal the terms, the authority behind the emissary, or whether the meeting concerned alliance, petition, or threat. Before Silvermoon judges the crown, we will need evidence that distinguishes among those explanations."

"Can we question other witnesses?" Lor'themar asked.

The Scryer messenger nodded. "If your scouts can reach the marks I carried, Shattrath will send them. Some served within Tempest Keep after the closure. Others deserted when

Legion agents appeared. A few still have family here and fear being named traitors before they can speak.”

“They deserted their prince,” Halduron said. “The name is not wholly inaccurate.”

“No,” she replied. “The question is whether they also deserted Quel’Thalas.”

Lor’themar looked to Falanaras. “You heard the prince name M’uru as Silvermoon’s answer. You fought under his command. Does this account describe the man you saw?”

Every face turned toward him.

Falanaras remembered Kael’tas in the war room, bright-haired beneath circling spheres, reducing an impossible assault to assignments men could survive. He remembered the prince receiving news of Rynel’s death without pretending the name meant more to him than it did. He remembered M’uru lowered into crimson force while Kael’tas watched the salvation of his people become an accomplished objective.

“I saw a commander who believed power was justified when it served Quel’Thalas,” he said. “The letter describes the same belief after Quel’Thalas ceased to limit what he would take.”

Liadrin released the table. Faint dents remained beneath her fingertips.

“He gave us M’uru,” she said.

“He sent M’uru home,” Lor’themar said. “We decided what to build from the captive.”

“Then his fall does not carry our guilt away with him.”

“No.” Lor’themar folded Voren’tal’s letter along its existing crease. “It gives us one more burden to carry ourselves.”

Rommath moved the dispatches into separate ward circles. “We need independent confirmation before making any declaration against the crown.”

“We will obtain it,” Lor’themar said. “Halduron, prepare another concealed crossing. Rommath, trace every cipher and seal. Astalor, determine whether Sanguinar or the three who crossed with him have drawn upon M’uru since the Portal reopened.”

Astalor considered the order, then gave a slight nod. “M’uru’s current does not distinguish distant recipients with sufficient precision. The records from their bindings may still let us test for changes consistent with each knight’s established pattern. I will refine the wards and report only what the comparison can support.”

“Good,” Lor’themar said. “If the source cannot answer directly, improve the question.”

Lor’themar turned to the messenger. “You are under protective custody. You will be treated as an envoy until your claim is disproved. If you have lied, you will learn how temporary that protection can be.”

“Voren’tal expected no warmer welcome.”

“He knew us, then.”

The council dispersed near dawn. No oath had been severed. No royal banner had come down. Yet Falanaras felt the absence before any order made it visible.

* * *

By afternoon, Silvermoon knew a messenger had come from Shattrath.

The city did not know her name, what she carried, or why the annex guard had doubled. Those omissions became proof for every preferred account. She was Kael’tas’s herald. She was an Illidari assassin. She brought a cure for the hunger. She had come to accuse Rommath of engineering the Portal’s closure. By evening, someone claimed she was a high elf wearing green lenses.

Lor'themar issued a second statement. It confirmed contact with blood elves based in Shattrath and said their reports were being examined. It named neither Voren'thal nor the prince.

The restraint lasted less than an hour.

"Scryers," a silk merchant shouted outside the annex. "They deserted His Highness and crawled to the draenei. Now they send poison home because they fear we will learn what they did."

A veteran in a faded Sunfury sash shoved him. "If they reached Shattrath, they know the roads. Let them speak."

"Traitors speak readily."

City guards separated them before the quarrel became a fight. Falanaras watched from the annex stairs with six Blood Knights behind him. Their black armor and crimson tabards quieted the nearest voices without settling anything.

The elderly man who had once asked whether his daughter was safe in Netherstorm found Falanaras near the cordon. He carried the same letter. Its edges had worn soft over the silent months.

"They say the messenger came from Outland."

"She did."

"Did she bring lists?"

"No casualty lists."

The man gripped the letter harder. "Then she cannot know what happened in Netherstorm."

Falanaras could have answered that she knew enough. He could have said Tempest Keep had become a fortress against former allies, that demons entered beneath blood elf guard, and that Kael'thas had permitted Silvermoon to wait through eleven months while his war changed allegiance around him.

The evidence had not yet become a public judgment. The man before him had a daughter somewhere inside it.

“She does not know your daughter’s fate,” he said. “Neither do I.”

“The prince will know.”

It was faith without prayer, directed toward a bright-haired prince in a world most of Silvermoon had never seen. Falanaras had carried the same faith through the Portal. He had watched Kael’thas command armies, capture a living answer to their hunger, and send that answer home. The belief had never been foolish. That made its breaking crueler.

“If he does,” Falanaras said, “he has not told us.”

The man stared at him, then turned away. This time the crowd took him before a guard could guide him.

Liadrin came down the annex stairs after sunset. She had spent the afternoon beneath the city with M’uru. The captive’s radiance showed through her eyes, and exhaustion had hollowed the skin beneath them.

“Did Astalor learn anything?” Falanaras asked.

“Nothing he can defend as knowledge.” She looked across the Court, where Kael’thas’s banners shifted above citizens arguing in their shadow. “Sanguinar may be alive. He may still draw from M’uru. He may be serving the prince beside demons while carrying the power I placed in his hands.”

“You tried to teach him that strength still answers command and purpose.”

“I taught him how to reach the Light across worlds.”

The admission carried no plea for comfort. Falanaras gave none.

“What will Lor’themar do?”

“Verify every line. Summon everyone who still has the right to object. Then decide whether loyalty to Kael’thas has become disloyalty to Quel’Thalas.”

Above them, the royal banners moved in the evening air. No one had ordered them lowered. People still gathered beneath the phoenix and spoke of reopened roads, returning armies, and the prince who would explain everything when his message finally came.

After nearly a year, Silvermoon had received its first true word from Outland.

It had come from those who abandoned Kael'thas, warning that Kael'thas had abandoned them first.

Oaths Severed

The second Scryer testimony reached Silvermoon before the first had finished producing rumors.

Halduron's rangers brought the witnesses through the eastern relay under concealment: a Sunfury quartermaster with burns up both hands, and a spellwright who had served in Tempest Keep's southern wing until Kael'thas's soldiers turned its guns upon their former allies. Their statements differed in dates, unit strengths, and the names of officers who had survived. They agreed on the Legion envoys. They agreed on fel armaments entering Netherstorm under the prince's seals. Most damningly, they agreed that no order had been issued to restore contact with Quel'Thalas.

By dusk, Rommath had authenticated six more ciphers. By midnight, Astalor had proved that one of the unfamiliar command marks on Voren'thal's dispatches was layered over a royal transit seal. Before dawn, Lor'themar summoned the council.

Falanaras stood inside the chamber doors with Theron at his right hand. Blood Knight plate was ceremonial only to those who had never waited through a council deciding whether soldiers would become enemies. The black armor held heat beneath the crimson tabard. M'uru's presence rested within Falanaras as a muted ache, distant beneath layers of stone and force-work. Each time he drew breath, the personal bond answered with enough warmth to remind him what Kael'thas had sent home—and what Silvermoon had chosen to do with the gift.

The council table had disappeared beneath testimony, copied seals, troop ledgers, and a map of Outland crowded with black stones. Lor'themar occupied the head without a throne behind him. Halduron stood over the Hellfire approaches. Rommath and Astalor had taken the Netherstorm side, where red ink marked seized installations and vanished supply posts. Liadrin remained seated with both hands bare upon the table. The gold beneath her green eyes had sharpened during the sleepless days since Voren'thal's letter.

Lor'themar waited until the doors were sealed. "State only what can be defended."

Rommath's hand moved over the nearest documents. "Kael'thas broke Illidan's command, seized strategic holdings in Netherstorm, and redirected Sunfury stores to forces answering solely to him. Demonic representatives entered Tempest Keep beneath protection. Fel weapons arrived through channels concealed from his established command structure. These matters are independently attested and supported by authenticated records."

"His agreement with the Legion?" Halduron asked.

"Still hidden," Rommath said. "We know there is intercourse. We do not know its terms. Any proclamation naming a sworn allegiance would outrun the evidence."

Halduron tapped the empty road between the Dark Portal and the western reaches. "He permitted this kingdom to remain blind for eleven months. After the road reopened, he sent no warning that demons held it. Whatever terms he made, our patrols cannot assume his troops are friendly."

"Some may still be," Liadrin said. "Sanguinar is not the whole of them." Her voice tightened around the name. "There are soldiers in Outland who took their oaths before any demon entered the prince's halls. There are three Blood

Knights beside Sanguinar whose judgment I have no cause to condemn.”

“Can you close their binding?” Lor’themar asked.

Astalor answered in his mild, measured voice. “No. We made each bond to survive distance, interruption, and hostile transit. The design has fulfilled that purpose. Its durability also prevents us from closing it from Silvermoon.”

Liadrin looked at him. “Do you regret that?”

“I regret that our work may now be used beyond our governance,” Astalor said. His gaze remained upon the layered seal he had exposed. “I do not regret making it strong enough to endure the road it was meant to cross. If those knights draw, M’uru supplies them and suffers. Should they waste the current, continue after its purpose is fulfilled, or employ it for cruelty, distance leaves us no means to intervene. We must admit the limit of our control without pretending the bond itself has failed.”

The chamber fell quiet enough for Falanaras to hear the low thrum of the wards. He remembered Sanguinar smiling after Daric’s shoulder broke beneath red-gold Light. The injury had been deliberate, the excess a pleasure disguised as instruction. Kael’thas had not witnessed it. He had still chosen the man who committed it.

“There is another question,” one of the senior magistrates said. “If ruthless acquisition is proof of corruption, we should consider where that judgment leads.” His eyes went briefly toward Liadrin, then lower, toward the hidden vault beneath the city.

No one mistook the reference. The Light shifted under Falanaras’s ribs. He felt a thin echo of M’uru’s fracture and resisted the instinct to close himself against it. Forgetting the pain would make the bond easier. Liadrin had never promised ease.

Astalor turned from the seal. When he spoke, his voice was quiet enough to draw the chamber toward him. “There is a distinction, though it does not absolve us.”

“Then name it,” Liadrin said.

“Kael’thas taught us to master dangerous power because our people needed it. We followed him because every weapon, alliance, and sacrifice was offered in service to Quel’Thalas.” Astalor laid one hand lightly upon the dispatches. “These records show that service has ceased. He withholds stores, command, warning, and protection from the kingdom while invoking its name to sanctify his private designs. The danger in his methods merits judgment. The abandonment of their declared purpose makes his command treasonous. He has placed his ambition where Quel’Thalas once stood.” His voice sharpened. “Our kingdom will not be destroyed to feed it.”

The senior magistrate’s mouth tightened. “A convenient line for those of us standing over a captive naaru.”

“It is an exacting line,” Astalor said, without raising his voice. “M’uru is captive. We subdued a being of the Light and made its power answer to our need. That power strengthens our wards, heals our wounded, relieves the hunger of every knight bound to M’uru, and may yet reach more of the city if we perfect the conduits. The suffering is real. So are those accomplishments. I will not call our mastery shameful while it preserves our people, nor will I pretend preservation makes the suffering unreal.”

Liadrin’s fingers curled once against the table. “And who decides when service becomes appetite?”

“We do,” Astalor said. “That is why our work must remain measured against the people it claims to serve. We examine the source, the recipient, and the result. We continue the public conduits. We stop those who turn strength into

appetite. We do not discard the evidence when it becomes inconvenient.”

Astalor had offered no absolution and none of Liadrin’s grief. His confidence troubled Falanaras more: the magister believed mastery could hold the boundary, provided those who wielded it continued to examine what their success cost. Yet the same hands taking the power would conduct the examination. Rynel had spent what the escape required, then turned the strength away from his hunger and toward the soldiers depending on him. Sanguinar had continued after the agreed purpose ended because suffering pleased him. Between those choices lay an entire kingdom’s claim to discipline and honor.

Lor’themar gathered the testimony into a single stack. “We are not judging whether Kael’thas has sinned more elegantly than we have. We are deciding whose commands can be allowed to spend blood elf lives.”

He looked first to Halduron. “Can our forces in Outland obey the prince without endangering Quel’Thalas?”

“No,” Halduron said. “Any unit claiming his authority must be treated as potentially hostile until it submits to Silvermoon’s command and disarms for examination.”

“Can the magisters continue sharing transit ciphers, stores, or strategic intelligence with his command?”

“No,” Rommath said. The word cost him nothing visible. He had carried Kael’thas’s methods home, defended them, and built Silvermoon’s recovery around what the prince’s followers had learned in exile. “All royal ciphers tied to Outland will be revoked. The relay architecture will be altered before sunset. Any message bearing the prince’s seal will be contained and examined rather than obeyed.”

Lor'themar turned to Liadrin. "If Sanguinar or another Blood Knight acts under Kael'thas's command against this kingdom?"

The gold in her eyes brightened. "Then the oath has already been broken. My knights will answer force with force."

At last Lor'themar looked to the table as a whole. "Kael'thas Sunstrider remains the son of our king and the prince to whom this people gave its hope. He no longer commands Quel'Thalas. His faction in Outland will be regarded as unfriendly until its members renounce concealed allegiances and submit to lawful examination. No soldier, magister, ranger, or civil officer in this kingdom will obey his seal."

The words did not sound like the fall of a dynasty. They sounded like orders read before a march. Falanaras found that harder to bear. Kael'thas had survived the Scourge, exile, Garithos, and Outland long enough to become the future tense of every blood elf promise. Now Lor'themar removed that future with a sequence of practical restrictions.

No one voted. Each answer had already been given.

* * *

The phoenix above the Court of the Sun came down at noon.

Officials had removed smaller royal banners from military halls and relay offices before the proclamation was posted. Those disappearances could be overlooked as caution. The great standard could not. It hung from the highest arch in restored Silvermoon, crimson silk worked with a gold phoenix broad enough to catch fire at sunset. Kael'thas had not raised it with his own hands. Most citizens had never seen him stand beneath it. They had still looked up and believed the kingdom's road led back to him.

Falanaras commanded the Blood Knight cordon around the square. Theron held the western stair with six shield-bearers. City guards lined the proclamation boards, and Rommath's magisters stood at intervals beneath the colonnades, their hands empty and their sleeves marked with active restraint sigils. The preparation told the crowd how the government expected grief to behave.

Two workers climbed the arch. When the first fastening released, the phoenix leaned over the Court as though straining to see the faces below. A sound moved through the gathered citizens—too low for a shout, too rough for prayer.

"Leave it," someone called.

The second fastening came free. Wind entered the silk and lifted one golden wing. Citizens pressed against the cordon. Falanaras smelled perfume, hot metal, mana crystals opened too early in anxious hands. The hunger threaded through the square beneath the anger: shallow breathing, fixed attention, the fine tremor of people who had waited through the morning rather than leave their place near an active ward.

Lor'themar stepped onto the annex balcony as the workers began lowering the banner. He wore no ceremonial mantle. Halduron stood behind him in ranger leathers, Rommath in dark magisterial robes, and Liadrin in black plate. Their presence offered the city every form of authority it possessed except the one being taken down.

Lor'themar read the proclamation without ceremony. He named the verified break with Illidan, the seizure of Tempest Keep, demonic contact, diverted resources, and the failure to communicate with the kingdom. He did not accuse Kael'thas of serving the Legion. He did not call him mad, fallen, or traitor. The restraint denied the crowd an easy lie to attack.

“Until the prince submits his conduct and alliances to examination,” Lor’themar concluded, “his seals hold no authority within Quel’Thalas. Forces acting in his name beyond our borders are to be regarded as unfriendly. The defense and governance of this kingdom remain under the Regent Lord and the lawful offices of Silvermoon.”

A woman near the front began to weep without covering her face. Behind her, a veteran raised a clenched fist and shouted that Lor’themar had usurped the crown. Another voice demanded the evidence be shown in the square. A third called Voren’tal a draenei servant. The accusations multiplied faster than the guards could identify their sources.

The banner reached the lower ledge. A young man broke from the crowd and ran for it.

Falanaras intercepted him before the first stair. He caught the man across the chest and turned the charge aside. They struck the paving hard enough to jar his armor. The man had no weapon. He clawed at Falanaras’s gauntlet and stared past him toward the descending phoenix.

“My sister followed him,” he gasped. “You cannot make her a traitor because she believed what all of you told us.”

Falanaras held him while two city guards approached. The square had blurred around the rawness in his face. “Your sister has not been judged.”

“You said his forces are enemies.”

“Unfriendly until they submit. Those were the words.”

“Words.” The man laughed once, breathless and broken. “You put armor around words so the rest of us have to call them law.”

The guards took his arms. Falanaras ordered them to hold him for questioning and record that he had carried no weapon. It was the narrowest mercy available within the

duty. The man disappeared behind the cordon still watching the phoenix fold into the workers' hands.

By the time Lor'themar withdrew from the balcony, the crowd had begun chanting Kael'thas's name.

* * *

For three days, Silvermoon argued with the proclamation.

Copies appeared with lines crossed out and kinder words written above them. Demonic contact became coerced negotiation. Diverted stores became preparation for a greater return. Eleven months of silence became proof that Kael'thas had been imprisoned by enemies who now forged his seals. Someone circulated a letter claiming the prince had ordered Silvermoon evacuated to Outland and Lor'themar had suppressed it to preserve his regency. The letter used a royal cipher revoked six years earlier. Hundreds believed it before noon.

Outland recovered its old place in the city's imagination. People described terraces in Netherstorm where no one hungered, estates waiting beneath violet skies, armies gathering to reclaim the Sunwell. Hellfire's Legion emplacements disappeared from these accounts. So did the abandoned Sunfury station and the empty road. Outland had been promised too long to surrender to geography.

Falanaras moved between duties with Theron beside him: the annex at dawn, the western mana queue by midday, Murder Row after dark. Liadrin assigned them where black armor might end a dispute before drawn weapons did. Sometimes it worked. More often the sight of Blood Knights proved only that the government had brought M'uru's power to defend its judgment.

On the fourth morning, they found a royal phoenix painted across the doors of a ration hall. The guards had covered it with canvas, but citizens lifted the edge as they passed and

touched two fingers to the red paint. A bowl of mana shards sat beneath it as an offering. Most were poor pieces, cloudy from repeated use. One still held enough charge to ease a family through the night.

“That may be the saddest shrine I have ever guarded,” Theron said.

Falanaras watched an attendant carry the bowl inside for inspection. “You have guarded a shrine with a chained naaru beneath it.”

“That one has better funding.” Theron’s humor faded. “Do you think they are all wrong?”

“About the evidence?”

“About needing him to remain what we said he was.”

Falanaras looked toward the upper towers. Empty clasps showed where royal standards had hung. “No. We built too much of ourselves around his return. Belief does not become stupidity because the person trusted proved false.”

“You should tell them that.”

“They would hear the armor first.”

Theron rested one hand on the rim of his shield. “Then I will stand farther away and look decorative.”

The ration hall doors opened before Falanaras could answer. A runner emerged at speed with orders bearing Rommath’s seal. A gathering had formed outside the old pilgrims’ hospice near the southern market. Witnesses reported weapons, plans to seize a relay chamber, and promises of passage through the Dark Portal.

Theron read over Falanaras’s shoulder. “I withdraw my offer.”

* * *

The hospice had once housed families waiting to follow Kael’thas into Outland. Its courtyard was built around a dry fountain, with narrow galleries rising on three sides and a

single gate opening onto the market. More than a hundred citizens had packed inside by the time the Blood Knights arrived. Phoenix cloth hung from the upper railings. At the fountain, a former Sunfury officer stood upon the basin and read from the forged evacuation order.

Rommath's magisters had reached the side streets first. They sealed both ends of the market with translucent walls and laid restraint glyphs beneath the paving. City guards waited behind Falanaras's line. Their captain reported six visible swords, perhaps twice as many knives, and three spellcasters in the galleries. No relay chamber had yet been attacked.

"Then we disperse them before they try," said Magister Varethis, the officer commanding Rommath's detail. He was young enough that Falanaras remembered him carrying messages during the reconstruction. Power had since smoothed his voice and put silver rank marks on his collar. "Captain Dawnspear, place your knights across the gate. No one leaves until examined."

Falanaras studied the courtyard. Children stood among the adults. An elderly woman had brought a camp stool. Two men carrying swords wore them with the awkward care of heirlooms rather than practiced weapons. "Give them a path to leave peacefully."

"They have gathered in defiance of an emergency order."

"Half of them will have come to listen. Let the unarmed depart one at a time under guard. Arrest those who remain or resist."

Varethis considered him for a breath. "One warning."

Falanaras entered the gate with Theron and eight Blood Knights. Conversation faltered as black plate filled the opening. The former officer at the fountain lowered the

forged order. He wore an old campaign sash over civilian clothes, its red faded almost brown.

"This assembly is unlawful," Falanaras said. "Lay down weapons. Those who submit to search may leave in single file. Anyone attempting the relay stations, raising magic, or resisting the guard will be detained."

"Detained for loyalty?" the officer asked.

"For threatening a secured relay and carrying weapons into a prohibited gathering."

"The relay belongs to the prince."

"It belongs to the kingdom that built and defends it."

The officer raised the forged page. "He called us to Outland. You went. You returned with power and shut the road behind you."

Anger stirred through the courtyard. Falanaras felt his knights respond: shields shifting, hands settling on hilts, bonds of power opening by disciplined degrees. M'uru's pain brushed the edge of his awareness as red-gold light gathered beneath black gauntlets. Effective. Immediate. Another captive answer to fear.

"I went because Kael'thas summoned a soldier to replace a dead man," he said. "I returned because he sent M'uru to Silvermoon. I fought under his command. I heard the evidence against him from those who served closer than I did. The page in your hand is false."

"According to Rommath."

"According to a cipher I carried on my own orders before I crossed the sea. That sequence was retired before the Dark Portal opened for us."

The certainty disturbed the crowd more than accusation had. Several people looked toward the gate. The elderly woman folded her stool. A father lifted his child onto one hip and began edging through the bodies.

Then one of the gallery spellcasters cast.

The bolt struck Theron's shield and broke into violet fire. He had moved before Falanaras saw the lifted hand. Red-gold radiance curved across the gate, shielding the nearest civilians as the other Blood Knights locked into line. Falanaras reached into the spell as it collapsed against the barrier and took a bounded measure of its loose arcane power. The caster in the gallery lifted both hands for a second attack. Falanaras released the stolen charge in a tight blue-white rush. It struck at the opening of the invocation and emptied the words from the man's mouth. The next spell failed before it formed.

Magister Varethis activated the courtyard.

Silver restraint lines flashed beneath every foot. The paving gripped ankles, knees, wrists. Citizens crashed against one another as the spell forced them downward. A woman struck the basin and split her lip. One Blood Knight caught her before the restraint could wrench her shoulder, pressed two fingers to the cut, and closed it with a brief pulse while the silver bands still held her on her knees. The former officer remained standing for half a heartbeat longer than the rest, then a band of arcane force closed around his throat and dragged him down.

The spellcaster in the gallery tried to speak again. Varethis closed his hand. The man's jaw snapped shut. Silence wards descended across the courtyard, swallowing cries, orders, even the scrape of armor. A hundred citizens knelt beneath a net they could neither see nor resist.

Falanaras turned on Varethis. His voice vanished inside the ward. The magister read the demand in his face and made a small adjustment. Sound returned around the Blood Knight line alone.

"Release the children and the unarmed," Falanaras said.

“A spell was cast at your second.”

“By one man. Hold the galleries and those carrying weapons. The others were offered passage.”

Varethis glanced toward the former officer. Arcane pressure had drawn blood beneath his chin. “They heard sedition and remained.”

“Listening is not an attack.”

“Today it became cover for one.” Varethis’s expression remained calm.

It was an argument Falanaras understood. That did not make the woman bleeding against the fountain less real. He could break the restraint web. His spellbreaker senses already found its anchors in the courtyard walls. Doing so would free the armed with the frightened and turn disagreement between officers into open defiance before the crowd.

Theron stood beside him, shield still raised. “If the state waits for every grievance to become an attack, we will fight the city street by street,” he said quietly. “This attack is contained. No need to punish the ones it missed.”

Varethis studied both of them, then lifted two fingers. The restraints loosened around the children first, then around thirty adults nearest the gate. Guards searched and released them in groups of five. The rest remained kneeling while magisters moved among them, touching light to temples and asking names, affiliations, intended routes, known organizers. The answers came through clenched teeth. Some came after the compulsion sigils brightened.

Falanaras watched the former officer resist until his body shook. At last the man named two meeting houses and a clerk inside the western relay office. Varethis recorded each

answer. When it was done, the officer sagged against the fountain, conscious but unable to lift his head.

No one called the process torture. Silvermoon had learned to keep its ugliest truths behind accurate administrative language.

* * *

The emergency orders were posted that evening.

Assemblies of more than twelve required approval. The relay chambers, city gates, armories, mana distribution halls, and principal ward stations passed under military protection. Travel permits were suspended. A curfew closed the lower markets after second bell. Advocacy of unauthorized passage to Outland was designated incitement to breach the kingdom's defenses. The phrase martial law appeared nowhere, though soldiers now stood at every place the orders named.

Falanaras read the notice outside the Blood Knight barracks while Theron cleaned a scorch mark from his shield. Around them, patrols prepared to enter streets that had greeted the order as heroes only months before.

"You were right," Falanaras said.

Theron examined the shield. "This is a rare opening. Be specific."

"You were right. We would fight street by street if the state waited for every grievance to become an attack." Falanaras looked toward the Court, where the empty banner clasps caught the last light. "The attack was contained. That is what makes it dangerous."

Theron set the cloth aside. "We have spent years learning that necessary things can still be dangerous."

"We say that when we want to keep doing them."

"Yes." Theron met his eyes. "We also say it when stopping would leave someone else to pay." He nodded toward the

patrol assembling by the gate. “The question is whether we remember whose pain is being entered into the account.”

M’uru’s distant anguish lived beneath the warmth in Falanaras’s chest. The former officer’s forced answers had no such lasting bond. That made them easier for the city to forget.

A messenger arrived before first bell with a summons to the council chamber. This time Theron was included.

The evidence against Kael’thas had been cleared from the table. In its place lay maps of the Eastern Kingdoms: Quel’Thalas isolated at the northern edge, the Ghostlands below it, hostile territories and ruined roads stretching south. Halduron’s casualty ledgers sat open beside reports from the runestone boundary. Rommath had arranged reserve estimates in descending columns. None reached far into the year.

“Kael’thas gave this kingdom an answer to hunger and a road beyond its enemies,” Lor’themar said. “We have severed the road. M’uru remains, but the distribution program is still limited, and the forces beyond the Portal can no longer be counted as ours. We must replace what we have lost before our enemies discover the absence.”

Halduron named the borders first. The runestone line had held, though Scourge pressure continued along the Dead Scar. Amani warbands were testing Farstrider patrols more boldly. The Ghostlands remained unheld, its roads usable only by armed movements. Silvermoon could defend southern Eversong against a single incursion. Two simultaneous breaches would force choices measured in villages.

Rommath named what assistance would not come. The Alliance had neither forgotten Garithos nor forgiven the sin’dorei’s methods, and its scattered contacts had shown

more interest in observation than defense. The Kirin Tor would debate jurisdiction until the Dead Scar reached their doors. The Argent Dawn might cooperate against the Scourge, but neutrality prevented the political and military commitment Quel'Thalas needed. Shattrath lay beyond a demon-held Portal and could offer witnesses sooner than armies.

"Then we have no allies," Liadrin said.

"We have no allies we would have chosen," Lor'themar replied.

Halduron placed a black marker south of the runestone boundary. "Forsaken scouts continue operating in the Ghostlands. Serenya Duskrunner's unit has honored the warning signals established after the Eversong incursion. They have shared Scourge movements twice and accepted our demand to withdraw south after contact."

Liadrin rose so abruptly her chair struck the wall. Light flashed beneath her skin. "Field signals are not an alliance. They are corpses wearing the memories of our rangers."

"They are soldiers who helped keep an undead host from cutting farther into Eversong," Halduron said. His voice held the quiet firmness of someone accustomed to speaking across old wounds. "Their arrows killed the necromancer controlling it. Their scouts pulled our wounded clear."

Falanaras remembered Serenya's gray face beneath a dark hood, Lethira's arrow following her mark, Forsaken hands hauling injured Farstriders out of the abomination's reach. Liadrin remembered different dead: friends raised against their own walls, the Scourge taking holy ground beneath Arthas's command. Both memories were true. Only one had occurred recently enough to serve as policy.

Rommath moved another marker into the Ghostlands. “The Forsaken answer to Sylvanas Windrunner. Through her, they possess ties to the Horde.”

The name carried the old horror into the chamber. The Horde had come north once before, orcs marching beside Amani warbands that burned through the border forests during the Second War. Falanaras knew that invasion through veterans’ accounts, memorial rolls, and stretches of woodland that had taken decades to mend. Now the same word arrived through Sylvanas Windrunner. He saw Lethira during Silvermoon’s fall, staring after the ranger-general who had been murdered and raised. Sylvanas had once embodied Quel’Thalas’s defense. Whatever ruled the Forsaken had emerged from that desecration with her skill, her hatred, and her claim upon the land still intact.

“You propose asking the Banshee Queen to save Silvermoon,” Liadrin said.

Lor’themar looked down at the map of a kingdom bordered by enemies and memory. “I propose asking what her help costs.”

He ordered Halduron to prepare a complete account of every field contact with the Forsaken. Lethira would be questioned about Serenya and the reliability of her signals. Rommath would calculate what military and magical aid Silvermoon could offer in return. No envoy would depart yet. The city had only begun mourning one promised savior; Lor’themar would not offer it another before he knew the terms.

When the council ended, Falanaras and Theron crossed the Court beneath bare arches. Patrol lamps burned along every street. A pair of magisters questioned a bookseller beside a shuttered stall while guards searched the rooms above it.

Farther on, workers scraped a painted phoenix from white stone. Red pigment clung in the chisel marks.

“What do we call this oath?” Theron asked. “The one after the prince.”

Falanaras had sworn to the Blood Knights beneath stolen radiance. Before that, he had sworn to serve a kingdom whose king was dead and whose prince had been far away. Those words had seemed to point in the same direction. Now the kingdom, the order, and the prince stood on separate roads.

“The same one,” he said. “We serve Quel’Thalas.”

Theron watched the magisters lead the bookseller away. “That answer is doing a great deal of work.”

“It always has.”

They continued toward the barracks. Behind them, the last royal phoenix in the Court disappeared beneath the workers’ tools. Ahead, beyond the restored walls and the runestone line, the Ghostlands waited with its Scourge, its ruins, and the undead rangers who had once defended Silvermoon in life.

Quel’Thalas had severed itself from the prince who promised its future. By morning, it would begin counting the monsters close enough to help preserve one.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

In Need of Monsters

Lethira chose the western signal stone because no living ranger had used it in six years.

It stood beyond the restored runestone line where Eversong's enchanted spring gave way to the long sickness of the Ghostlands. White bark had grayed there. The grass lay in damp mats beneath thorn and ash, and the Dead Scar cut the eastern horizon with a darkness that morning could not soften. Falanaras waited ten paces behind Lethira with four Blood Knights, far enough to leave the meeting hers and close enough to answer if she called.

She had tied three strips of faded blue cloth to the stone. Ranger colors from before the fall, before crimson became grief worn as statecraft. The message was older than either of them: parley requested, familiar eyes preferred, approach from the south.

"If she does not come?" Falanaras asked.

Lethira kept her bow lowered. "Then I have spent half a night decorating a rock for the benefit of ghouls."

The answer carried less bite than usual. The old field signals had carried warnings between their patrols since the incursion, but this request reached beyond troop movements and shared targets. Lethira had refused to trust its details to writing. So she had come herself, carrying Halduron's authority and Lor'themar's request beneath a cloak whose hem had collected the Ghostlands mud.

A black-fletched arrow stood in the wet earth at the clearing's southern edge, marking the safe approach before any ranger showed herself. Two undead scouts stepped from

the trees with bows in hand and strings slack. Falanaras recognized both from the fighting in Eversong; one gave him the same brief field salute they had exchanged across the wounded. Serenya Duskrunner followed. Rot had spared the precision of her movements. Her face remained the gray likeness of the ranger Lethira had known, emptied of warmth and sharpened by preservation spells. Three more Forsaken followed in dark leathers and settled along the treeline in the loose scouting interval Lethira already knew.

Serenya looked at the blue cloth. “You remembered.”

“I remember many things I would prefer to forget.” Lethira’s gaze moved across the undead rangers and returned to Serenya. “Silvermoon requires a formal channel to your command.”

“To my command, or to my queen?”

Lethira’s fingers tightened around the bow grip. “To Sylvanas Windrunner.”

The old title went unspoken. Falanaras felt its absence among the trees. Ranger-General had once meant the shield of Quel’Thalas, a living certainty in blue and silver standing against the southern road. Banshee Queen meant a throne beneath another ruined kingdom. Both names belonged to the same woman. Neither could contain what Arthas had made between them.

Serenya studied Lethira for a long moment. “My queen expected this after your prince was disowned.”

“He was not disowned,” Falanaras said. “His authority was severed.”

Serenya’s dead eyes shifted to him. “The distinction only holds meaning for the living.”

Lethira stepped between the exchange before pride could make policy more difficult. “We need scouts in the Ghostlands, pressure against Deatholme, and a route to

powers beyond the Eastern Kingdoms that do not answer the Alliance. Your people need a northern force strong enough to keep the Scourge from rebuilding behind you. We have already proved those needs can share a battlefield.”

“Once,” Serenya said. “For less than an hour.”

“It was a productive hour.”

Something almost familiar passed across Serenya’s mouth and vanished. “My queen will send a delegation into Silvermoon to hear the request under your laws. If your city can endure that, she will receive Lor’themar at Windrunner Spire.”

Lethira looked west, toward ruins hidden beyond leagues of blight. “Her family’s home.”

“Her ground,” Serenya corrected. “She will not enter your living city to be displayed beneath guard. Your regent will not be asked to descend into hers before terms exist. The Spire belongs to memory and no present government. That is as close to neutral as our people are likely to find.”

Lethira untied one strip of blue cloth and held it out. Serenya accepted it with fingers that had once fletched arrows beside hers. Their hands did not touch.

* * *

Silvermoon endured the Forsaken poorly.

Serenya entered through the southern gate two mornings later with one deathguard and a hooded apothecary. Falanaras commanded the escort. Blood Knights surrounded the visitors in black plate, while magisters carried active ward-rods behind them and Farstriders watched the roofs. The precautions made the delegation resemble prisoners even though every order named them envoys.

Citizens withdrew from the avenue before the procession reached them. Shopkeepers pulled children indoors. A mana vendor abandoned an open tray of charged slivers rather

than remain beside it as the undead passed. The shards shone unattended in green and violet rows, bright enough that three hungry onlookers stared at them despite the deathguard's exposed jaw and the apothecary's chemical stink.

An elderly ranger stood rigid beneath a restored arch. The left side of his face had been burned during the fall. When he recognized Serenya's leathers, he raised two fingers in the old field salute before horror caught up with memory. His hand dropped. Serenya continued as though she had seen neither gesture.

Liadrin waited in the annex court with no helmet and both gauntlets fastened. Gold moved under her green eyes. The stolen Light had answered her anger before she permitted any of it into her hands.

"You will surrender weapons inside the council level," she said.

Serenya unstrung her bow and gave it to Falanaras. The deathguard yielded a sword broad enough to split a shield. The apothecary produced six knives, two glass needles, a bone saw, and a stoppered vial that made the receiving magister's ward-rod hiss.

"Medicinal," the apothecary rasped.

"For whom?" Theron Brightshield asked from beside the doors.

The apothecary's ruined lips parted. "That depends upon the dosage."

Theron glanced at Falanaras. "Diplomacy already offers educational rewards."

Liadrin did not share the humor. "Do not mistake entry for welcome," she told Serenya. "Your freedom from the Lich King does not restore the lives the Scourge used your bodies to take."

“No,” Serenya said. “Nor does your hatred restore mine.”

For an instant Falanaras thought Liadrin would end the meeting in the court. M’uru’s anguish stirred through him as her power rose nearby, a distant chime dragged through pain. Then she closed her hands. The radiance under her skin receded.

“The council is waiting,” she said.

Halduron had covered the table with casualty ledgers. Patrol losses in the Ghostlands stood beside maps of breaches along the runestone boundary and reports of Amani movement east of the Dead Scar. Black marks showed Scourge concentrations that had survived every limited strike. Each time the rangers destroyed one focus, two more appeared beyond roads they lacked the soldiers to hold.

Rommath’s contribution occupied less space and carried the same verdict. Reserve estimates had fallen again. The relay changes after Kael’tas’s severance consumed power faster than planned, civil wards strained under increased use, and M’uru’s public distribution conduits still failed whenever they extended beyond tightly governed chambers. Blood Knights relieved pressure on military supplies, but fourteen founders and a small number of later candidates could not feed a city one recipient at a time.

Lor’themar let Serenya read the table before he spoke. “Your queen offers aid.”

“She offers a hearing,” Serenya replied. “Aid follows terms.”

Rommath’s gaze settled on her. “Then state the price of the hearing.”

“The Regent Lord travels to Windrunner Spire with a delegation small enough to prove he expects negotiation rather than battle. My queen will discuss patrol coordination, support against the Scourge, and sponsorship

before the Horde. Nothing is promised beyond her advocacy. Thrall does not admit nations because Sylvanas Windrunner commands it.”

Liadrin stood over the map. “And if the Horde refuses?”

“Then you will still know what our aid costs.”

The council dismissed the Forsaken to guarded chambers and continued without them. No one argued that the old Horde had been harmless. Orcs and Amani had burned the border forests within living memory, and veterans still carried wounds from that war. The current Horde included trolls whose kin claimed Quel’Thalas as stolen land and undead who wore the faces of murdered defenders. Revulsion required no exaggeration to justify itself.

Halduron placed three casualty rolls beside the southern boundary. “Pride will not hold this line. Another incursion on the scale of the last breach will force us to strip the city wards or abandon villages. If the Amani strike at the same time, we lose both choices.”

“The Alliance will not come,” Rommath said. “Dalaran will not commit itself. The Argent Dawn will fight the Scourge beside us and refuse every obligation beyond the battlefield. Shattrath is separated from us by a demon-held road. These are the powers available, not the powers we would prefer.”

Liadrin stared at the marker representing Windrunner Spire. “Sylvanas once promised no enemy would enter these lands.”

“She died keeping that promise as long as anyone could,” Halduron said.

“And returned as the thing that entered.”

Lor’themar looked toward Falanaras, though the decision was not his to make. “You fought beside Serenya’s scouts.”

“They warned us of the breach, exposed the Scourge command line, and pulled our wounded clear,” Falanaras

said. “They withdrew when Halduron ordered it. I would trust them to keep a field agreement whose purpose remains useful to them.”

“A narrow trust,” Liadrin said.

“It is wider than what Kael’thas left us.”

The words hurt more after he spoke them. Lor’themar gave no sign that pain altered their accuracy. He ordered Halduron to choose the route, Rommath to prepare terms concerning magical and military aid, and Liadrin to select a Blood Knight honor guard. Lethira would attend as the ranger who had opened the channel. Falanaras would command the guard.

When the meeting ended, Liadrin remained beside the casualty rolls. “We chain a being of Light beneath our city and recoil from corpses who broke their own chains.”

Falanaras waited.

“Do not mistake that for admiration,” she said. “I hate what they are. I hate that Arthas can still force their faces upon those who loved them. Yet hatred is a poor fortification.”

“It has held parts of this kingdom for years.”

“Then we have mistaken endurance for defense.” Liadrin lifted one of Halduron’s ledgers. “Choose six. We ride at dawn.”

* * *

They crossed the runestone boundary under a cold rain that turned the Ghostlands roads black.

Lor’themar rode beneath a plain crimson cloak with no royal device. Rommath traveled at his left, Liadrin at his right. Lethira and two Farstriders ranged ahead with Serenya’s scouts. Falanaras kept the six Blood Knights close enough to close around the delegation and far enough apart that a single necromantic strike could not take them all.

Nothing along the road pretended the Ghostlands had been reclaimed. Ruined farmsteads watched from behind dead orchards. Scourge marks appeared on stones the Farstriders had cleared a month earlier. Near a collapsed bridge, Serenya's rangers found two ghouls crouched over a stag and killed them before the delegation came within bowshot. The bodies were dragged from the road. No banner rose over the work.

They kept west of Tranquillien. From a ridge, Falanaras saw the town's broken roofs through the rain, empty except for drifting mist and movement that might have been Scourge. The road below could carry soldiers north or south. Whoever held it would place a hand around the throat of the Ghostlands. For now, no one did.

Windrunner Spire rose from the western blight near the sea, its towers broken and its pale stone stained by years without wards. One outer wall had fallen into a ravine. Dead ivy covered the surviving arch, and the Windrunner crest above it had been split through the center. The place retained the severe grace of a noble house built by rangers: narrow windows, high walks, open sightlines over every approach.

Forsaken archers occupied the walls without displaying a flag. Falanaras counted twenty before the gates opened and assumed he had missed half. Lethira counted too. Her mouth settled into the flat line she wore when memory threatened to become visible.

Sylvanas waited in the roofless great hall beneath a stair that led nowhere.

Falanaras had last seen her alive at a distance, bright armor moving along a failing defense while the Scourge pressed north. The figure before him carried the same poise after warmth, breath, and mercy had been cut away. Dark

armor enclosed her narrow frame. A hood shadowed the gray severity of her face. Red eyes passed over the delegation, and the surviving hall seemed to contract around the attention.

“Lor’themar.” Her voice scraped softly against the stone. “You took your time.”

“Quel’Thalas spent years believing its prince would return.”

“Hope is most expensive when purchased in advance.” Sylvanas looked past him to Liadrin. “And now Silvermoon has discovered other forms of credit.”

Liadrin’s jaw tightened. “If you mean the Blood Knights, speak plainly.”

A colder interest entered Sylvanas’s expression. “I mean the captive source from which your knights draw. So that much of the rumor is true. Good. The Horde will prefer an ugly truth it can measure.”

Lor’themar did not look at Liadrin. “We came to discuss the Ghostlands and your sponsorship.”

“They are the same discussion. Thrall will ask what you bring, what you require, and which disasters will follow you into his councils. Your hunger. Your fel use. Your prince’s treachery. Your captive Light.” Sylvanas moved to a cracked table where a map of the northern kingdoms had been pinned beneath knives. “I can make your usefulness louder than your liabilities. I cannot make either disappear.”

Rommath approached the map. “State what advocacy requires.”

“Silvermoon petitions as a nation prepared to join, not as a client seeking charity. If admitted, you answer Horde calls with soldiers, intelligence, and passage where your territory makes passage necessary. You coordinate with Forsaken forces against the Scourge from the Plaguelands to the runestone boundary. You do not use our undead as a

convenient shield while reserving every victory for yourselves.”

Lor'themar placed one hand on the edge of the table. “No Forsaken garrison enters Eversong without invitation. No Horde force acquires land in Quel'Thalas through service. Tranquillien and the roads around it remain blood elf territory whether or not we presently hold them.”

“Territory unheld is a claim written for the benefit of maps.” Sylvanas's nail rested over Tranquillien. “My scouts already bleed on those roads. I want the town cleared and rebuilt as a joint base of operations. Forsaken and Farstrider patrols will provision there, exchange intelligence there, and strike against Deatholme from the same road. Neither force will raise a sovereign banner over it.”

Halduron had sent Lethira with authority over field practice. She stepped to the map. “Tranquillien remains blood elf territory. The base answers to paired commanders, one ranger and one Forsaken. Garrison strength is agreed in advance, stores are counted by both forces, and no unit moves north of the runestone boundary without warning. Joint operations require defined objectives.”

Sylvanas regarded her. “Valeflame. You used to object less when I assigned a field.”

Lethira met her gaze. “I remember.” The words carried no plea.

Sylvanas's gaze moved past Lethira to the broken stair. For one breath, the ruin held her attention without serving any argument. When she looked back, her voice had hardened. “Then remember where weak southern defenses led us. I died waiting for help that could not reach us. Keep your paired command and your ledgers.

Tranquillien must hold long enough to matter. I will not repeat that failure to protect your comfort.”

The argument continued through garrison strength, supply caches, courier rights, command disputes, and the treatment of wounded taken by the other force. Every term exposed another place where trust was absent and cooperation might still function. Falanaras understood why Sylvanas had chosen a ruined home. No polished chamber could have held the conversation honestly. They were bargaining over how much of the wound each side could enter without claiming it.

At last Sylvanas turned toward the honor guard. “These are the soldiers built from your captive.”

“Blood Knights,” Liadrin said.

“Paladins without faith.”

“Knights governed by oath.”

Sylvanas pointed to Falanaras. “Show me what that distinction buys.”

Liadrin gave the smallest nod. Falanaras called the Light across the distance from Silvermoon. M’uru’s pain entered first, vast beneath the rain. Red-gold radiance left his gauntlet and closed around Lor’themar, Lethira, and the two nearest guards just as a loosened length of stone fell from the broken gallery. Masonry struck the sheaths surrounding them and glanced away as though armor and flesh had become unreachable for one breath. The protection vanished before the fragments stopped skittering. Falanaras ended the draw at Liadrin’s signal.

The dead rangers along the walls recoiled from the radiance. Sylvanas did not.

“How many?” she asked.

“Enough to have held southern Eversong when Serenya’s scouts brought warning,” Liadrin said. “Enough to heal wounded rangers, break Scourge workings, and destroy what

crossed our boundary. Fewer than the Horde will want. More than our enemies expect.”

“And every use hurts the source.”

“Yes.”

Sylvanas looked from Liadrin to Lor'themar. “Thrall will despise the method. He may respect that you admit it. The orcs know what stolen power can make of a people.” Her red gaze returned to Falanaras. “Can your knight make that strength useful when another warrior is trying to break him?”

“He has done so against the Scourge,” Liadrin said.

“Then the Horde will want to see how he meets a living opponent who knows his purpose.” Sylvanas’s expression hardened with old military judgment. “Power is easy to display. Discipline must survive resistance and command. Honor must survive victory.”

Falanaras met her gaze. “Then let the Horde choose the opponent.”

The silence that followed carried the attention of every archer on the walls. Sylvanas inclined her head by the smallest degree, accepting an answer rather than granting approval.

By dusk they had a provisional understanding. Blood elf and Forsaken forces would clear Tranquillien and establish a joint base under paired field command, without surrendering Quel'Thalas’s territorial claim or granting the Forsaken a separate one. Agreed numbers of rangers and Forsaken scouts could provision there, share warnings, and coordinate limited actions against the Scourge. No force would cross the restored boundary into Eversong in strength without invitation except to pursue an immediate threat. Silvermoon would petition for Horde membership and accept military obligations if admitted. Sylvanas would carry the petition before Thrall and the other leaders.

“You will come to the Undercity,” Sylvanas said. “The Horde will judge you where it can see what I am risking on your behalf.”

Lor’themar fastened his seal beneath the terms. “And what are you risking?”

Rain moved across the dark sea beyond the broken western wall. Sylvanas watched it for a moment longer than the question required. “The chance that you will mistake survival for independence once more.”

* * *

Rumor reached Silvermoon before the delegation returned.

Someone had seen Forsaken envoys at the annex. Someone else knew Lor’themar had ridden south beneath guard. By the time Falanaras passed through the city gate, handbills accused the Regent Lord of selling the Ghostlands to Sylvanas, surrendering Silvermoon to orcs, and inviting Amani trolls to finish what the Scourge began. The details contradicted one another. Fear gave them a common authority.

The largest gathering filled the Walk of Elders near a dry reflecting pool. A priest in faded white and red stood on the rim, speaking to several hundred citizens. His robes belonged to the old clergy rather than Liadrin’s order. Hunger trembled in his hands, though his voice carried clearly across the square.

“The orcs came north with the Amani,” he called. “They burned our forests and called it conquest. The undead murdered our families and returned wearing them. Now we are told these are our protectors. We cast down one absent prince and kneel to a dead ranger in the same week.”

Agreement rolled through the crowd. Falanaras heard grief beneath it, and the sharper relief of people given enemies they already understood. Theron waited beside a patrol at the

edge of the pool. When he saw Falanaras, he tipped his head toward the speaker.

“He has been careful,” Theron said. “No call to violence. No attempt to breach a ward. He tells history in the order most useful to his conclusion.”

“That remains legal.”

“At the moment.”

Three magisters entered the square from the eastern arcade. Between them walked another priest in formal crimson, his eyes fixed on the speaker with disciplined vacancy. The crowd quieted as the magisters raised restraint sigils. Theron’s patrol had received no order to advance. Falanaras realized the purpose of the second priest one breath before the spell reached the first.

Shadow gathered around the crimson-robed priest’s fingers and crossed the pool in a thin violet thread. The speaker stiffened. His mouth remained open while every muscle in his face fought a command no one else could hear. One magister sealed the square against interruption. Another laid an amplification charm over the captive voice.

“I have spoken from fear,” the priest said. His tone had become smooth and dead. “The Regent Lord seeks strength for Quel’Thalas. The Forsaken are free allies against the Scourge. The Horde offers honorable fellowship. Silvermoon must stand with those prepared to defend her.”

The crowd listened in horror. A woman near the front began reciting the words with him, perhaps from agreement, perhaps because agreement suddenly looked safer. Others followed. The coerced declaration spread unevenly through the square until several hundred voices praised an alliance no treaty had yet created.

Falanaras moved before deciding what intervention would mean. Theron caught his forearm.

“If you break the spell,” Theron said quietly, “the magisters arrest you beside him. Then the city learns the Blood Knights oppose the Regent Lord’s road.”

“Do we support this?”

“No.” Theron’s grip remained firm. “We support Quel’Thalas. You warned me that answer was doing a great deal of work.”

The controlled priest smiled. Tears ran down his face while his mouth proclaimed loyalty to the Horde.

Falanaras had seen bodies compelled in Deatholme. Necromantic strings had been cruder, tearing flesh when the dead resisted. The violence here left no wound for a healer to close. It entered memory, speech, and public record. By nightfall, officials would report that an anti-Horde gathering had dispersed after its leader withdrew his objections.

The spell ended. The priest collapsed into the reflecting pool. There was no water to soften the fall.

* * *

Liadrin received Falanaras’s report in M’uru’s outer vault.

The naaru’s captive radiance rose beyond layers of stone and restraint. Its presence pressed against every Blood Knight in the chamber, offering relief entwined with pain. Liadrin stood beneath it while attendants fitted travel seals to her armor. On a nearby table lay the provisional terms from Windrunner Spire and the formal summons to Undercity.

“A vow spoken through another person’s mouth has no worth,” she said when he finished.

“The magisters called it correction of incitement.”

“Of course they did.” Liadrin dismissed the attendants. When the doors shut, anger entered her voice. “I will stand before orcs, trolls, and the undead and argue that this alliance may preserve our people. I will not pretend the people already consent.”

“Will you challenge the order?”

“Lor’themar did not issue that method. He has declined to revoke the emergency authority that permits it.” She looked toward M’uru. “We have become skilled at placing distance between a decision and the suffering that serves it.”

M’uru’s pain moved through Falanaras in a low sustained pulse. Above them, the city prepared proclamations describing fellowship and mutual defense. Below, a captive supplied the power of the soldiers who would embody that argument before the Horde.

Liadrin fastened the last clasp on her gauntlet. “You will travel with me. Rommath comes to answer for our magic. Lethira comes because Sylvanas listens to rangers who have bled in the same ground as hers. Lor’themar will speak for the kingdom. You will speak for the Blood Knights if the Horde asks what we are.”

“What answer do you want me to give?”

“The true one. We took power from a captive because it saved lives. We govern the taking because need does not govern itself. We are effective. We are dangerous. If they require innocence, we will return alone.”

At the barracks, Theron helped select the remaining honor guard. He did not ask to join. Someone had to hold the Blood Knight patrols inside a city where loyalty could now be placed in a citizen’s mouth by force. Lethira arrived with her travel bow, three spare strings, and an expression suggesting every available road had offended her personally.

“Windrunner Spire was insufficient?” Theron asked.

“Apparently we must now inspect the kingdom buried beneath Lordaeron.” Lethira set down her pack. “I had worried this alliance might become pleasant.”

Theron looked to Falanaras. “And after the Undercity?”

“If they admit us, obligations. If they refuse, the same borders with fewer illusions.”

“A favorable range of outcomes.”

Outside, patrol bells marked curfew. Magisters moved through the lower streets beneath new notices forbidding agitation against recognized diplomatic envoys. Somewhere beyond the restored walls, Forsaken scouts watched roads Silvermoon could not hold. Farther south and west, the Horde waited to decide whether blood elves belonged among its old enemies and wounded peoples.

Falanaras secured his sword across his back and felt M'uru's distant suffering beneath the familiar warmth in his chest. The power would travel with him into the Undercity. So would the coerced priest's tears, Kael'thas's silence, Rynel's final restraint, and the memory of Sylvanas standing inside the ruin of her own name.

Silvermoon had counted the monsters near enough to help. At dawn, it would go below the ruins of Lordaeron and ask to stand among them.

The Measure of Strangers

Rommath's transit circle opened beneath a sky the color of old iron.

Falanaras crossed first with his sword on his back and felt Silvermoon vanish behind him. The spell released him onto rain-dark flagstones inside the ruins of a gatehouse. Cold entered through the joints of his armor before his sight cleared. Broken walls enclosed a receiving yard where Forsaken wardens stood around a second ring cut into the stone. Beyond them, dead trees bent across the hills of Tirisfal, and the remains of Lordaeron's capital rose against the eastern gloom.

The Forsaken did not raise their weapons. One deathguard watched the green fel light in Falanaras's eyes with faint curiosity, then gave the receiving circle a soldier's inspection. No one had promised affection on either side.

Liadrin emerged behind him, followed by Lor'themar, Lethira, the remainder of the Blood Knight guard, and two Farstriders carrying the sealed terms from Windrunner Spire. Rommath came last. The portal folded shut at his back, leaving only a brief violet afterimage and the smell of charged stone.

"The return circle remains keyed for six hours," Rommath said. "After that, Silvermoon must open it from their side."

"Comforting," Lethira said. "We have been granted an exact measure of time in which diplomacy may fail."

Serenya Duskrunner stepped from the ruined arch. She wore the same dark leathers as at the signal stone, though Undercity's black arrowhead marked one shoulder. Four dark

rangers accompanied her. Falanaras recognized two from southern Eversong. Their presence eased nothing in Liadrin's posture, but the honor guard received them as known soldiers.

Serenya gave Lor'themar a shallow bow. "The banshee queen waits below. The Horde representatives have begun arriving."

"We will not keep them waiting," Lor'themar said.

They left the gatehouse under escort. The road crossed a city that had died in stages. Outer houses had collapsed behind weeds and blackened hedges. The inner wall still bore the royal crest beneath Scourge cuts deep enough to catch rain. Forsaken sentries occupied the surviving towers with a practical indifference to the human dead whose kingdom had raised them.

Falanaras had seen human banners above camps in the southern kingdoms and human dead marching beneath Arthas. He had never entered Lordaeron while it lived. The ruin nevertheless felt familiar. A capital abandoned after slaughter required little translation. Silvermoon had hidden more of its wound behind crimson cloth and restored crystal, but the same absence waited wherever a doorway still expected a household that would never return.

The broken royal courtyard opened ahead. Dead rose petals clung to seams in the paving despite the rain. A dark stain led through the doors of the throne room, too old to remain blood and too deliberate to be mistaken for weathering. No one in the delegation asked who had died along that path.

Lethira slowed beneath the throne-room arch. Serenya matched her pace.

“Arthas walked here after he killed his father,” Serenya said. Her voice held no reverence for the memory. “The echoes repeat it when the upper halls are quiet.”

Lethira’s gaze followed the stain. “Does your queen ever come this way?”

“When she chooses.” Serenya’s eyes remained forward. “She does not yield ground because it remembers him.”

The passage beyond the throne room descended toward a bank of iron lifts. Chains rattled in shafts wide enough to swallow a siege tower. The delegation entered one platform with their escort. Serenya pulled a lever, and the living capital rose away above them.

Cold air climbed from below carrying alchemical bitterness, rot, wet stone, and the sour reek of green channels moving through buried streets. One of the younger Blood Knights swallowed hard. Liadrin did not look at him. Falanaras kept his breathing even and watched rings of masonry pass the open cage: crypts, old sewers, Scourge-cut tunnels, then arches strengthened with Forsaken iron.

The lift released them into a city built for inhabitants who did not breathe. Poisonous water shone beneath bridges. Apothecaries passed with stoppered crates while deathguards drilled beside old tombs. Orcs, trolls, and tauren moved through the Trade Quarter among the Forsaken, visibly uncomfortable and entirely unsurprised. The sight carried its own argument. The Horde already contained peoples who found one another difficult to endure.

An orc quartermaster stopped counting spearheads as the sin’dorei passed. His eyes settled on the green light in Falanaras’s face, then shifted to the gold beneath Liadrin’s green eyes. He touched two fingers to his own green skin above the gorget, acknowledging the resemblance.

Falanaras understood the accusation before the orc spoke it. Their bodies both carried the history of power accepted in desperation. The orcs had at least learned where their road ended. Silvermoon was still naming its first milestones.

* * *

Sylvanas received them in the Royal Quarter beneath banners bearing the broken mask of the Forsaken.

At Windrunner Spire she had stood inside the remains of a life taken from her. Here every arch answered to the rule she had built afterward. Deathguards lined the chamber. Dark rangers watched from shadowed galleries. Apothecaries waited near a side door with ink, seals, and instruments whose medicinal purpose was not obvious. Sylvanas sat beneath a stone canopy in dark armor, one hand resting against the arm of her throne.

A dreadlord stood behind her.

Varimathras towered over the Forsaken court with folded wings and a courtier's stillness that could not disguise the weight of him. His hide held the bruised color of storm clouds. Curved horns framed a face made for contempt. Fel heat touched Falanaras's senses from across the chamber, heavier than the crystals sustaining Silvermoon's wards and fouler in its intent.

Liadrin's stolen radiance stirred. Falanaras felt the answering impulse in his own chest and held it quiet.

"Regent Lord," Sylvanas said. "You reached my city without incident."

"Your escort was efficient." Lor'themar's gaze moved once to Varimathras. "Your court remains surprising."

The dreadlord smiled. "The living elf objects to demons while carrying their stain in his eyes."

Rommath looked him over with the clinical displeasure he reserved for defective apparatus. “I object only to pets that mistake the audience for their master.”

Varimathras’s wings opened a handspan. Fel pressure thickened the chamber. “Careful, magister. Silvermoon cages a holy creature and feeds its streets with fel. The difference between servant and master may trouble you sooner than you imagine.”

Rommath drew breath to answer. “Enough,” Sylvanas said.

The word cut through the fel pressure. Varimathras held himself rigid for one dangerous breath. Then his wings folded, the heat withdrew, and he lowered his head. Obedience cost him visibly.

Sylvanas turned her red gaze upon Rommath. “He offered me his brothers to purchase his life. He serves because I continue to find value in his survival. Draw whatever lesson seems useful.”

“Several,” Rommath said. “None flattering.”

Lor’themar presented the provisional terms. A Forsaken clerk read each clause aloud: the clearing and rebuilding of Tranquillien, paired command, agreed garrison strength, shared stores, coordinated action against the Scourge, and the preservation of Quel’Thalas’s sovereignty. Sylvanas interrupted twice to tighten language around courier access and the obligation to answer an immediate threat. Lethira corrected the field definitions. By the time the seals were pressed beneath the agreement, nothing had become warmer between them. It had become harder to misunderstand.

“The wider question remains,” Sylvanas said. “I can sponsor Silvermoon. I cannot admit it.”

“What has been said against us?” Lor’themar asked.

“That your people are starving aristocrats who discovered fel magic, enslaved a source of Holy Light, abandoned one

alliance, and followed a prince who has now abandoned them." Sylvanas's mouth tightened. "Most accusations become persuasive when arranged well."

Liadrin stepped forward. "You intend to place the Blood Knights before them as evidence against us."

"As evidence," Sylvanas replied. "What judgment follows is theirs. The Horde knows enough to fear the method. Concealment beyond that would only make cowards of us all."

"We will answer for what we do," Liadrin said. "We will not surrender the workings beneath Silvermoon to earn a hearing."

Sylvanas regarded her for a moment. "A sensible limit. Keep it until Thrall decides whether it resembles prudence or evasion."

A deathguard entered and bowed. "The Warchief has arrived."

For the first time since the delegation entered, Sylvanas's attention moved past the political use of the room. Her gaze caught on Lethira's ranger clasp, worn smooth from years before the fall. The pause lasted no more than a breath.

"The Horde will judge what Quel'thalas has become," she said. "Give it reason to remember what your people endured to remain."

* * *

The delegation waited in an antechamber while the council assembled.

No window interrupted the black stone. A channel of green fluid passed behind an iron grate beneath the floor, warming the room with poisonous vapor. Rommath and Lor'themar reviewed their order of argument. Liadrin stood apart with her gauntlets resting against the pommel of her sword. The other Blood Knights remained in the corridor under guard.

Lethira leaned against the wall beside Falanaras. “At the Spire, I could still see where she used to stand.”

Falanaras knew she meant Sylvanas. “You can see it here too.”

“That is the difficulty.” Lethira rubbed her thumb across the old clasp. “At Windrunner Spire, every broken stone accused Arthas. Here the stones obey her. I thought one place would show what remained and the other what replaced it.”

“And?”

“They are both her.” Lethira’s voice dropped. “The woman who counted our arrows. The thing Arthas raised. The queen who keeps a demon at heel and still notices a ranger clasp she issued before either of us had learned to distrust orders.”

Falanaras remembered the anti-Horde priest in the Walk of Elders, his voice seized by magisters and forced to praise the alliance while tears ran down his face. “Recognition does not make command safe.”

“No.” Lethira released the clasp. “It makes refusal harder.”

The council doors opened before either could answer further.

* * *

Thrall stood at the head of a long stone table scarred by weapons and chemical spills.

The Warchief was younger than the weight of his title suggested. Broad shoulders filled his black plate, and his hands rested openly on the table. Doomhammer hung across his back. The green of his skin carried no ornament or attempt at concealment. Falanaras had seen orcs only through inherited war records and the reports of scouts. He had expected savagery to announce itself. Thrall’s

stillness held something more difficult: strength taught to fear its own worst use.

Cairne Bloodhoof sat at Thrall's right, enormous even while seated. Age silvered the fur around his muzzle. Feathers and carved beads hung from his braids, and the quiet around him felt deliberate rather than empty. Vol'jin occupied the next place, narrow-eyed and watchful, one tusk catching the sick green light. Sylvanas sat opposite them with Varimathras absent from the chamber. Orc officers, Darkspear envoys, tauren elders, and Forsaken ministers filled the remaining seats.

Lor'themar remained standing. Liadrin, Rommath, Lethira, and Falanaras took places behind him.

Thrall began without ceremony. "Sylvanas Windrunner asks the Horde to admit Silvermoon and Quel'Thalas. She claims your kingdom can hold the northern road, strengthen our war against the Scourge, and answer Horde calls with soldiers and magic. Tell us why we should accept the risks she brings with you."

Lor'themar did not offer gratitude for the hearing. "Because the risks already exist. The Scourge remain between our borders. The Amani strike every weakness they find. The Alliance has neither forgiven us nor offered protection. If Quel'Thalas falls, the force that destroys it will not stop at our southern line. Silvermoon brings territory, trained armies, intelligence from the Eastern Kingdoms, access to the northern coast, and a people with reason to keep every one of those assets from becoming an enemy's."

An orc commander tapped one thick finger against the table. "Your people brought fel into their homes."

Rommath answered. "We use controlled sources to sustain wards, industry, and a population severed from the

Sunwell. We do not drink demon blood. We do not surrender command to demons.”

“You think control makes corruption obedient?” the commander asked.

“I think knowledge makes power governable,” Rommath said. “Your history may argue otherwise. Ours has not granted us the luxury of refusing every dangerous tool.”

Thrall’s gaze hardened. “Our history argues because we buried clans beneath it. Orcs accepted power that promised victory. It marked our skin before it consumed our will, and many called the change strength until they could no longer remember what strength had been for.”

His eyes moved over the blood elves’ green-lit faces. The resemblance was imperfect. It remained close enough to wound.

“We did not come to ask you to admire our methods,” Lor’themar said. “We came because isolation is killing us more reliably than pride can save us.”

Lor’themar continued before another question could come. “There remains the matter of the Amani. They joined the old Horde in burning our forests and still seek our destruction. Silvermoon will not enter any alliance that asks us to forget Zul’jin’s claim upon Quel’Thalas.”

Vol’jin’s fingers tightened around his staff. “Who be askin’ you to forget? You speak of da Amani and look to me. You think tusks make one tribe answer for another?”

“I think an old war will enter this alliance whether either of us invites it,” Lor’themar said.

“Den learn who stands before you. Darkspear blood be troll blood, but it do not belong to Zul’jin. Da Amani chose their war. My tribe chose dis Horde, and we bled beside peoples our ancestors never knew. If Silvermoon joins us, you name your enemies true. You do not spit ‘troll’ and make every

tribe carry da Amani's crimes. Bring that pride into dis Horde, and it poison every line we try to hold."

Lethira spoke from behind Lor'themar. "Amani arrows have pointed north all my life. I have no cause to place a Darkspear spear beside them unless its wielder does."

Vol'jin looked at her ranger bow. "You seen a Darkspear spear hold your line?"

"Not yet," Lethira said. "I have seen Forsaken arrows do it. I can judge the next soldier by where they stand."

"Dat be a beginning," Vol'jin said. "Keep your pride from poisoning it."

Cairne's deep voice entered the chamber without force. "There is another power to discuss."

Liadrin met his gaze.

"A captive being of Light suffers so your warriors may heal and kill." Cairne's grief held no theatrical outrage. "You carry that suffering across distance and call upon it by choice."

"Yes," Liadrin said.

"Do you believe need makes the suffering just?"

"I believe need makes refusal a choice with victims of its own." Liadrin kept both hands visible. "Our order saved defenders who would have died in southern Eversong. We broke Scourge workings our diminished magisters could not have broken in time. None of that dulls our captive's pain. None of it grants us innocence."

Cairne studied her. "Then what governs you?"

"Training. Command. Witness. We name misuse as failure even when it wins."

"Your order writes the law, wields the power, and judges the breach."

Liadrin's jaw tightened. "Yes."

The answer settled more heavily than a defense would have. Cairne inclined his head, acknowledging honesty without accepting the act.

Sylvanas placed one hand on the table. “The Horde did not require the Forsaken to become pleasant before accepting our soldiers, roads, and war against the Scourge. Silvermoon offers the same practical proof. Its knights held a breached boundary beside my rangers. Its regent has accepted terms at Tranquillien that place blood elf and Forsaken troops under mutual goals. If moral purity is the price of admission, empty the chamber before you begin with them.”

“You advocate loudly for a living kingdom,” an orc elder said.

Sylvanas’s red eyes found him. “I advocate for a northern ally that keeps the Scourge away from Forsaken territory. My reasons do not require your romance.”

The rebuke concealed more than it denied. Falanaras saw Lethira hear it too.

Thrall looked from Liadrin to Falanaras. “At Windrunner Spire, one of your knights offered to be tested under pressure.”

Falanaras stepped forward. “I did.”

“A demonstration in a hall proves that the power answers,” Thrall said. “It does not prove that your order can fight with honor, and be fit to stand beside Horde soldiers.”

“Then choose the test.”

A low voice came from among the orc officers. “I will test him.”

Gorath Stonebinder rose. He wore layered mail beneath hides marked with ocher and ash. His black hair had been bound behind his head, and carved stones hung from his belt beside a one-handed axe. Rain-dark green skin showed at his throat and across his broad hands. The power around him

moved through the floor and the moisture in the walls, quiet until acknowledged.

“Your eyes carry fel,” Gorath said. “Your hands carry stolen Light. Your people call both power. I want to see what that word means when power answers back.”

“Then watch,” Falanaras said.

Gorath’s tusks showed around something that was not a smile. “We will hear.”

* * *

They returned to the ruined courtyard above Undercity under a hard afternoon rain.

Forsaken guards cleared the broken flagstones while the council gathered beneath the surviving arcade. Thrall and Cairne stood at its center. Vol’jin watched from beside a cracked pillar. Sylvanas remained in the open rain with her hood drawn low, occupying Lordaeron’s ruin as if weather had lost authority over her.

Liadrin fastened Falanaras’s final shoulder clasp. “They expect power.”

“Gorath will have it.”

“Give them no reason to mistake discipline for timidity.” Her fingers tightened once against the plate. “Fight as a Blood Knight. Win with honor.”

Falanaras drew his two-handed sword. He had left the spellbreaker glaive behind when he entered Liadrin’s order, but its lessons remained in his hands: read the hostile current, find where intent passed into power, break the use, subdue the source.

Across the courtyard, Gorath pressed his palm to the wet stone. “No killing stroke,” he said. “Yield ends the fight. Losing the weapon does not.”

“Agreed.”

Thrall lifted one hand. “Begin.”

The courtyard struck first.

Stone rose beneath Falanaras's forward foot. He shifted before the slab could lock his knee, but a second ridge caught his heel and threw him sideways. Wind hit while he recovered, driving rain through his vision and turning the sword's broad blade into a sail. Gorath crossed the distance behind it with his axe held low.

Falanaras caught the axe on his crossguard. The impact jolted both arms. Gorath drove a shoulder into his breastplate and released another pulse through the ground. Flagstones bucked. Falanaras yielded three steps rather than fight the earth for ownership of his footing.

Gorath pursued. His axe moved in short practical cuts, forcing the longer sword to work inside its preferred reach. Falanaras turned one blow, caught another against his vambrace, and felt the edge score black lacquer from the plate. He answered with the pommel. Gorath slipped it and swept his free hand upward.

Lightning flashed from palm to sword.

The lightning entered through sword and gauntlets. Wards etched into Falanaras's plate resisted the current's attempt to seize muscle and nerve; they divided enough of it across his armor to keep his heart beating, not enough to spare him pain. White fire crossed his sight. He broke contact by falling backward, rolled through mud, and came up with one knee refusing to straighten. Scorched leather smoked around both hands.

Gorath waited only long enough to see whether he could stand. Then the shaman stamped.

A line of stone teeth tore across the courtyard. Falanaras called the Light hard. M'uru's pain entered with it, a fractured tone beneath the rain, and red-gold radiance surged along his left arm into a slanted barrier. The first

stone exploded against it. He drove through the second impact, turned the ward like a shield, and smashed the third ridge aside before cutting toward Gorath's shoulder.

Gorath turned the blade with his axe and sent wind between them. The blast carried no heat, yet it struck like a gate thrown open by a siege ram. Falanaras skidded across the wet stones. The shaman did not attack his strength. He attacked every place strength required stability.

Falanaras changed his grip and began reading.

Elemental magic did not lie in wards as arcane work did. It moved through relationship: Gorath's request, the answering pressure below, the breath drawn before wind gathered, the sharp lift in the air before lightning chose metal. The spellbreaker in Falanaras could not strip command from the earth. He could still see when the command passed between them.

Gorath raised his axe. Falanaras moved before the lightning came, thrust the sword into a crack between flagstones, and released the hilt. The bolt struck the grounded blade. Thunder burst across the courtyard. Gorath had already called wind to punish the expected advance, but Falanaras went low beneath it, one palm in the mud, and used a brief flare through his legs to drive himself forward.

His shoulder struck Gorath's waist. They fell together. The orc hammered an elbow against the back of his helm and rolled. Falanaras caught the axe haft with both hands. Gorath pulled, stronger at that angle, while stone climbed around Falanaras's forearms in heavy bands.

The captive Light answered at once. Falanaras sent a narrow current through his limbs, loosening the stone's hold on his movement without pretending to command the earth itself. The bands cracked away from his forearms. He carried

the same release into the axe haft between them, opening Gorath's grip without crushing the ribs beneath it.

Power without placement was waste. The spellbreaker's lesson had survived every change of weapon: find the point that governed the contest and break it.

Falanaras tore one hand free, struck the inside of Gorath's elbow, and ripped the axe from his grip. The orc answered with his forehead. Falanaras's helm rang. Gorath surged upright, empty-handed and blood dripping from one tusk, while broken stone hissed around their boots.

Falanaras kicked the axe away and reached for his sword. Gorath called the earth beneath it. The weapon sank deeper into the crack as stone closed around the blade.

Losing the weapon did not end the fight.

Gorath opened both hands. Wind circled him, pulling rain into a gray veil. Lightning began to gather above the courtyard rather than in his palms. The watching orcs stepped back beneath the arcade. Thrall did not stop him.

Falanaras had no steel to ground the strike and no stable footing from which to evade it. He planted both boots and gave the stolen Light one immediate purpose: stand between his body and the descending force. M'uru's anguish sharpened as crimson-gold radiance vaulted over him in a broad arch, its surface layered like heated plate.

Lightning fell.

The barrier caught the bolt and bent nearly to his shoulders. Light and lightning filled the courtyard with red-white glare. Falanaras could not steal the answer Gorath had received from the storm. He could choose what surface received it. At the instant the strike spread across the arch, he turned the barrier's face and gave the current a steeper path into the flooded stones. Thunder rolled under

the arcades as the grounded lightning split flagstones on both sides of him.

Steam erupted. Gorath's wind broke apart.

Falanaras collapsed the barrier. Part of its released force gathered around his right fist, brightening toward a white core as he drove through the steam. The holy discharge reached Gorath a fraction before the gauntlet and locked the orc's limbs in place. The physical blow struck his chest while he could not turn with it. Gorath left his feet and hit the base of a broken pillar hard enough to split its remaining plaster.

Gorath tried to rise. One knee held. The other failed. He reached toward the earth.

Falanaras retrieved the shaman's axe and crossed the last steps. He bound red-gold radiance along its edge and held the stored force there, ready to release only if Gorath refused the end. The weapon gilded the rain without spending its charge.

Gorath's throat lay exposed. Falanaras had sworn himself to a duel without killing. Honor demanded that he end the contest by forcing Gorath's yield and spare the life already at his mercy.

Falanaras brought the axe down. Its burning edge stopped against the iron rim of Gorath's breastplate, close enough that heat raised steam from the rainwater there. The force in Falanaras's arm remained ready, visible, and entirely still.

"Yield," he said.

Gorath looked at the burning edge, then at Falanaras's face. Rain ran through the blood at his mouth.

Gorath released his hand from the earth. "I yield." Only then did Falanaras dismiss the holy fire along the axe.

Falanaras stepped back and offered him the axe handle first. Gorath accepted it, rose with a grimace, and gave

him a warrior's nod. Respect had entered the space between them. Trust had not yet followed.

* * *

The council returned below while healers bound Gorath's ribs and treated the burns beneath Falanaras's gauntlets.

No one pretended the duel had answered Cairne's objection. M'uru remained captive beneath Silvermoon. Fel still shone in sin'dorei eyes. Kael'thas's betrayal remained recent enough to stain every promise made in his wake. Falanaras had proved that Blood Knight power could withstand a shaman's full assault, answer with overwhelming force, and remain governed by skill, command, and an oath honored at the point of victory. The Horde still had to decide whether one warrior's honor could stand as evidence for an order and a nation.

Thrall called Lor'themar forward. The Warchief stood with Cairne, Vol'jin, and Sylvanas behind the long table. Gorath had taken a place among the orc officers despite the binding around his chest.

"The Horde was formed by peoples who survived powers that expected them to disappear," Thrall said. "Orcs carry the shame of corruption we chose. The Darkspear carry exile. The tauren remember enemies that hunted them from their homes. The Forsaken came to us feared by every living nation, and Cairne asked me to judge what they did with freedom rather than what slavery had made of them."

Cairne's grave expression did not change. Sylvanas watched Thrall with the patience of someone hearing her own history used for another purpose.

"Silvermoon brings dangers," Thrall continued. "Fel has marked your people. Your prince sold loyalty for power. Your Blood Knights wield suffering as a weapon. Admission does not make those truths smaller."

Lor'themar held his gaze. "We did not ask it to."

"Good. Then hear the obligation. If Quel'Thalas enters the Horde, its soldiers answer Horde calls. Its roads and intelligence serve common defense. Its leaders speak in council and accept that other members will speak against them. No blood elf may treat Darkspear, tauren, or Forsaken lives as lesser payment for Silvermoon's survival. The Horde is not a shield hired for your border."

"Quel'Thalas accepts those obligations as a sovereign member," Lor'themar said. "It does not enter as Sylvanas's dependency or as conquered territory."

"Agreed," Thrall said. "Then by the authority entrusted to the Warchief and the consent given in this council, I admit the blood elves of Quel'Thalas into the Horde."

No cheer followed. Orc hands struck breastplates in acknowledgment. Darkspear envoys touched fists to their chests. Cairne bowed his head. The Forsaken remained still until Sylvanas rose, and then their weapons struck the floor as one.

Liadrin exhaled beside Falanaras. The sound carried no relief. They had acquired obligations, roads, and allies. Nothing beneath Silvermoon had become less captive. Nothing in the Walk of Elders had become more freely spoken.

A courier entered before the seals had cooled. He wore Silvermoon crimson beneath a Forsaken travel cloak. Lor'themar broke the message, read it once, and passed it to Liadrin.

"More arrests?" Falanaras asked quietly.

Liadrin's mouth tightened. "Three gatherings dispersed. Two magisters injured. A mana ration station burned in the Bazaar after someone accused its keeper of poisoning the

supply for the Horde.” She lowered the letter. “Theron reports the Blood Knight patrols are holding.”

Across the chamber, orc officers were already arguing over how soon Silvermoon could provide troops in Lordaeron. A Forsaken minister named Tranquillien’s supply requirements to one of Rommath’s aides. Vol’jin spoke with Lethira about Amani movement east of the Dead Scar. Admission had become work before the declaration finished echoing.

Gorath approached with one arm held close to his ribs. “Blood Knight.”

“Stonebinder.”

“You fought with power enough to kill me,” Gorath said. His gaze moved to the bandages beneath Falanaras’s gauntlets. “You fought with honor.”

“That is our oath.”

Gorath considered the answer and nodded once. “An oath is easy in a courtyard, with witnesses and a friendly voice to call the end. I will see whether yours holds when an enemy offers no honor in return.”

Sylvanas joined Lor’themar at the council doors. “You have what you came for.”

“Membership,” Lor’themar said. “Trust appears to have been withheld.”

“Trust from the others will take time,” Sylvanas said. Her gaze drifted briefly toward the ceiling, beyond which ruined Lordaeron endured the rain. “Your people already have the trust of the Forsaken. My rangers have watched sin’dorei hold the same line, and they do not grant that judgment lightly. Let the rest learn.”

The return transit would not open for another hour. Falanaras stood among new allies beneath a dead kingdom and listened to them decide where Silvermoon’s soldiers

would bleed first. The Horde had admitted the sin'dorei in law. Belonging waited beyond the next order, the next field, and the first time strangers trusted his strength beside them.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Color of Mercy

Silvermoon sent its first soldiers to the Horde beneath banners the city had learned to tolerate before it learned to welcome them.

The red field and black device of the Horde hung beside the phoenix standard above the eastern gate. Magisters had warded both against rain, ash, knives, and the small destructive spells favored by people who lacked the courage to throw stones in daylight. Three weeks of proclamations had declared the alliance lawful. Three weeks of arrests had made dissent quieter. Neither effort had made the Horde colors beloved.

Falanaras stood in the departure yard while quartermasters counted thirty-seven sin'dorei into a force assembled to prove a kingdom's promise. Six Blood Knights wore black plate edged in crimson. Eight Farstriders waited with Lethira beneath oiled cloaks. The magisters had sent four battle-casters and an apprentice whose hands shook whenever he moved beyond the gate wards. Three men and one woman from Murder Row carried narrow blades, lock tools, and the expressions of people invited into respectable service because respectable methods had failed. A warlock named Elthas Emberweave kept his hood raised and his felguard dismissed, though the demon's contract smoldered against the iron plates sewn into his coat.

Theron checked the straps of his greatshield and looked toward the banner. "It is still hanging."

“For now,” Lethira said. She tightened her quiver against her hip. “Give the Bazaar another night.”

A mana line had formed across the square behind them. Citizens waited beneath the glow of a public wardstone while armed attendants measured each allotment. Two magisters watched the line from a balcony, their hands folded in sleeves broad enough to hide spellwork.

“They want us gone before someone decides the send-off requires an opinion,” Falanaras said.

“They want us visible while leaving,” Theron replied. “The distinction appears important to government.”

Liadrin walked the files without ceremony. She inspected weapons, armor seals, field dressings, and the governed bonds she could sense without touching. When she reached Falanaras, the captive Light answered her presence through the connection beneath his breastbone. M’uru’s distant anguish entered him as a thin, enduring note.

“You will serve under Gorath Stonebinder,” Liadrin said. “His command is lawful. His suspicion is earned. Give him no cause to regret either.”

“He told me he would test our oath when an enemy offered no honor.”

“Then Hillsbrad has saved him the trouble of waiting.” Her gaze moved to his two-handed sword. “Use what the field requires. When victory gives you a choice, remember what governs the hand.”

“Discipline. Duty. Honor. Remembrance.”

Liadrin inclined her head. “Return with all four.”

They crossed into Lordaeron by Rommath’s transit circle, then marched south beneath a sky heavy with autumn rain. The road left Tirisfal’s dead woods and climbed toward country that still remembered harvest. Hillsbrad’s fields lay brown beneath the season, divided by low walls and

streams swollen from the highlands. West across the wet country, Dalaran's ruin occupied a rise above Lordamere. Broken houses and toppled masonry showed dark around the base of an immense violet dome, opaque beneath the rain; whatever remained at the city's heart lay hidden behind its magical wall. Human farmsteads stood at long distances from one another. Some flew Southshore blue. Others had black Horde marks painted over doors already broken by war.

Gorath met them at a Forsaken post north of the river. The binding around his ribs was gone, but his left shoulder still moved stiffly from their duel. He carried the same axe and wore small Horde pennants tied beneath the carved stones at his belt.

Three officers waited with him. Jazreth Shadowtide, a lean Darkspear priest, wore bone charms among strips of dark cloth; shadow moved around him in the wrong direction whenever clouds crossed the sun. Mavren Coldwake had once been a broad human man. Death had tightened gray skin over his jaw and left one cheek opened to the teeth. He carried a rectangular shield scarred by axes and a sword with no ornament except old blood in the fuller. Tahu Windtotem stood a head taller than Gorath, his horns wrapped in red cord and his staff hung with feathers damp from travel.

Gorath looked over Silvermoon's contribution. His attention paused on Elthas's hood, the rogues, the green light in every sin'dorei face, and finally Falanaras. "You brought every reason my soldiers have to distrust your people."

"Silvermoon wished to be representative," Lethira replied.

Jazreth's tusks framed a quiet laugh. Mavren gave Lethira a long dead stare. "If that was humor, warn me. My face has limited range."

Tahu studied the Blood Knights with grave patience. "The Light around you is wounded."

Falanaras could have offered Liadrin's answer, Rommath's answer, or Astalor's. None would change what the tauren sensed. "Yes."

Gorath heard the admission and moved on. "Tarren Mill has held against raids for months. Southshore sent a larger force yesterday: infantry, archers, magi, and paladins. They took the southern farms and the ridge above the road. We expect the main assault before dusk. Forsaken hold the mill. My company holds the north road. You will reinforce whichever breaks first."

"Whose command in the field?" Falanaras asked.

"Mine," Gorath said. "Until I fall. Then Mavren. Then you." Several orcs behind him objected without words. Gorath turned his head. The objections ended.

They heard Tarren Mill before they saw it. Cannon fire rolled across the hills. A tower bell clanged without rhythm. Smoke climbed behind the ridge, black at its root and gray where the rain worried it apart.

A Forsaken runner came up the road with one arm hanging by sinew. "South wall breached. Abominations engaged east. Living cavalry through the orchard."

Gorath drew his axe. "No camp. No rest. Mavren, take the Forsaken and rogues through the mill. Tahu, wounded and eastern flank. Jazreth, with me on the road. Rangers take the ridge. Magisters suppress their cannon and casters." He looked at Theron, then Falanaras. "Blood Knights divide. Shields to the breach. Swords with me."

The orders cut the unfamiliar force into useful pieces. Whatever distrust remained had to keep pace.

* * *

The road descended into battle.

Tarren Mill crouched around a stone tower and timber buildings stained by plague, weather, and Forsaken

occupation. The southern palisade had opened inward. Human infantry forced through the gap behind blue shields while skeletal guards and Forsaken axemen fought among burning carts. To the east, an abomination dragged a broken cavalry horse beneath its cleaver as Alliance riders circled beyond reach. Archers held the ridge. Their arrows fell in disciplined flights, driving Horde defenders away from the breach each time they tried to close it.

Gorath struck his axe against the road. Earth rose ahead of the charging company in a rolling shelf. Arrows hit the sudden bank or climbed over it too steeply to retain force. “Now,” he said.

Falanaras passed the earthen cover at a run. Two Blood Knights kept pace, swords kindling red-gold along their edges. Jazreth cast one hand toward the ridge. Darkness unrolled across the archers’ sight, deep enough that the next flight scattered. Horde soldiers roared from the breach.

The first human spearman braced for Falanaras’s charge. He turned the spearhead against his breastplate, let it slide, and cut through the shaft. His return stroke entered beneath the man’s lifted arm. Holy force burst from the wound and threw the body into the shield behind it.

First blood under Horde command soaked the edge of his sword.

There was no revelation in it. The man died with surprise still in his eyes. Falanaras stepped over him because Gorath’s line was advancing and another spear had already found his range.

The Blood Knights hit the infantry with the violence Silvermoon had promised in Undercity. One cast a fan of radiance low across the mud and broke three shield grips at once. Another drove both hands into a wounded orc’s split

breastplate; stolen Light sealed the pumping artery before the orc could finish falling. Falanaras kept the greatsword moving. Each impact carried force through wood, steel, and flesh. M'uru's pain sounded beneath every draw, distant enough to endure and impossible to mistake for consent.

Human soldiers recoiled from the crimson tint.

A paladin behind their line raised his warhammer. Golden light spread through the blue ranks as warmth, steadiness, and the conviction that the ground beneath them could still be held. "Profaners!" he shouted. "The Light bears witness!"

Falanaras felt the paladin's conviction pass through the human ranks, warming tired limbs and steadying shield arms. He answered by putting his sword through the next shield.

The human line bent without breaking. Their paladins did more than strike. One stood in the breach with a shield lifted while a quiet current of gold strengthened every armored body around him. Another laid a hand against a soldier's back as he fought, closing a sword wound beneath mail. A third drove the ferrule of his hammer into the churned earth and spoke over it. Gold spread under Horde boots in a shallow field that burned Forsaken flesh and made living muscles seize with sacred heat.

Mavren entered it anyway. Smoke lifted from his greaves. He caught a human shield on his own, hacked the bearer behind the knee, and shouted, "If holiness intends to stop me, it requires better aim."

Theron's shield file reached him. A red-gold barrier folded over the Forsaken as the human paladin brought his hammer down. Sacred gold and stolen radiance collided, each making the other look harsher.

Tahu became a bear beside the burning stable. Bone and hide surged outward until his forepaws struck the mud with enough weight to jar the nearby carts. He met the Alliance

cavalry where the abomination had failed, taking a lance across one massive shoulder and overturning horse and rider with the same charge. Lethira's rangers shot past him. Their arrows found reins, exposed throats, and the hands of cavalymen trying to turn.

A bolt of blue fire descended from the ridge. One of Silvermoon's magisters caught it against a layered ward. The spell spread across the barrier in branching lines, searching for weakness. Elthas stepped from behind the earthwork and tore open his contract. His felguard arrived in green flame, axe already falling into the Alliance caster's bodyguard.

Orcs who had distrusted the warlock shouted approval before remembering themselves.

Gorath drove the center forward until a golden hammer of force struck him in the chest and stopped the attack around him. The blow carried no iron. It rang through armor and bone with the authority of a bell. Gorath dropped to one knee, stunned, while an Alliance paladin advanced to finish him.

Falanaras reached the shaman first. He turned the descending warhammer with his crossguard and felt the gold-burning weapon sear through both gauntlets. The paladin stared into his green eyes, then at the red-gold current running along the sword. "What have you done to it?"

"What was required."

The answer enraged him. At his word, white radiance tightened around the hammerhead. Falanaras caught the next strike on a barrier held close to his body and released the ward outward. The paladin flew back into his own line.

Gorath regained his feet. "You always answer sermons with excessive force?"

"When time permits."

The Alliance horn sounded twice from the ridge. Their infantry opened lanes through the center. Paladins moved into them in pairs—one shield forward while the other sent compact bolts of gold across the field—and archers shifted fire toward the Blood Knights. The change was deliberate. The humans had identified the threat and placed faith against theft.

One of those bolts struck a Blood Knight before she could raise her guard. Radiance bound her feet to the earth. Three arrows found her breastplate. Theron planted his shield over her, broke the binding with a pulse through the mud, and carried her bodily behind the line.

“Fal!” Lethira called from the slope.

He followed her arrow toward the ridge.

A man in silver-edged plate descended through the human ranks with a warhammer in one hand and a kite shield in the other. Dark hair showed beneath his open helm. The scar across his chin caught the gold burning around him.

Edric Hale saw him at the same moment.

The battlefield narrowed without becoming quieter. Falanaras still heard shields split, wounded men call for water, Jazreth chanting beneath the din, and the abomination bellowing as Tahu knocked a gnome clear across the field. Through all of it came the remembered cadence.

Edric grounded his stance. Drew breath. Spoke a brief invocation. Gave the Light its purpose.

At his brief prayer, warmth settled across Edric’s shoulders. Gold brightened the rim of his shield and the head of his hammer. The soldiers nearest him straightened as his devotion spread among them.

In the Ghostlands, Falanaras had watched that cadence preserve life. Here it prepared Edric to take his.

“Fal,” Edric said. No warmth remained in the name.

“Edric.”

“You chose this.”

Falanaras looked once at the Horde banner above the mill, snapping in smoke. “Yes.”

Edric’s gaze moved over the Blood Knights fighting behind him. “That is the Light.” Horror roughened his voice more than hatred did. “Bound. Hurt. I can hear it in what you wield.”

“You hear enough to condemn. Never enough to help.”

“I came north. I searched for you.”

“After.” The old wound opened with familiar ease. “You all came after.”

An orc lunged between them. Edric’s shield struck the warrior aside without breaking his arm. A human swordsman rushed Falanaras from the opposite direction. Falanaras cut through his breastplate and left him dead in the mud.

Edric watched the body fall. “You call that necessity now?”

“I call it battle.”

“So did every butcher who found a banner.”

Edric raised his hammer. Falanaras brought the greatsword to guard.

Their first collision split the noise around them.

* * *

Edric fought as a wall that advanced.

His shield received the greatsword near the forte, where Falanaras had least leverage. His hammer answered in compact blows toward elbow, knee, and helm. He wasted no movement. Gold traveled from his armor into the torn ground, giving his footing a certainty mud should have denied him. Each time Falanaras tried to circle, Edric turned the shield and shortened the available field.

Falanaras fought to open what Edric closed. The two-handed blade threatened from beyond hammer reach,

changed level midway through cuts, and made defense expensive even when it succeeded. Red-gold force lengthened the danger beyond the steel. Edric's shield rang under one strike, flared beneath the next, and held.

They had sparred with wooden swords as boys. Neither had learned this future from the other.

Edric spoke one word. The radiance held close around him compressed above the hammerhead and broke free.

Gold crossed the space between them before Falanaras could evade. It struck his chest, entered the joints of his armor, and locked his stride beneath the demand for justice. Edric followed behind it. His hammer hit the flat of the greatsword, tore the point downward, and drove a second blow into Falanaras's ribs.

Plate folded. Breath vanished.

Falanaras released a burst from his left hand. Edric raised the shield. Red-gold fire broke around its rim and scorched a furrow through the infantry behind him, but the paladin remained upright.

"Power without grace," Edric said.

Falanaras forced air back into his lungs. "Grace without arrival."

He widened the draw from M'uru. Anguish sharpened beneath his heart. The sword ignited from guard to point, and he drove forward hard enough to make Edric yield three steps.

Edric gave ground only until his boot entered the fading circle another paladin had burned into the mud. The gold surged at his presence. Falanaras's next step landed inside it.

Holy heat climbed through his greaves. It burned Mavren's dead flesh, Elthas's fel contract, and Falanaras's coerced radiance with equal hostility. Edric struck his sword arm.

A stunning pulse burst from the hammer and turned every muscle rigid.

Falanaras fell to one knee.

Edric could have crushed his skull. Instead he reversed the hammer and drove the haft against the sword, knocking it from numb fingers. “Yield.”

The same word Falanaras had given Gorath. Here no terms protected either life. An Alliance archer raised his bow beyond Edric. Lethira’s arrow reached the man first.

Falanaras looked up. “You know me better than that.”

“I knew you before you decided survival excused everything.”

“No.” Feeling returned as knives along Falanaras’s arm. “You knew me before survival asked anything of you.”

Falanaras called the sword back with a lash of red-gold force. Edric intercepted it on the shield, but the distraction let Falanaras rise and close inside the hammer’s arc. He struck with gauntlet, shoulder, and the crossguard when the blade returned to his hand. Edric answered with the shield edge beneath his chin.

Blood filled Falanaras’s mouth.

He opened a path between his pulse and the sword.

The change began in his own body. Heat opened along his veins. Each heartbeat fed the edge until crimson ran within the gold. He cut across Edric’s shield. Holy force detonated through both men. The power took payment from Falanaras as it struck; pain tore beneath his ribs, and blood seeped through the folded plate Edric had damaged.

The shield’s upper rim split.

Edric stared at the wound Falanaras had accepted to create his. “You consume yourself and call it strength.”

“We learned from generous teachers.”

Edric's anger broke his economy. He thrust the damaged shield forward and sent gold snapping from its rim, struck high behind the burst, and let the hammer's holy charge flare before contact. Falanaras met it with all the force he had been taught never to fear.

Gold and red-gold touched.

The combined flash swallowed a whole section of the battlefield.

Light rose in a column above the road and spread outward at ground level. Human infantry flew across the mud. Orcs tumbled behind Gorath's earthen bank. Arrows became brief black strokes and vanished. The golden field burned into the mud ruptured in a ring, throwing clods of blazing soil against the mill walls. Windows burst inward. For one immense heartbeat, every shadow from Tarren Mill to the ridge pointed away from two men.

Sound returned as a blow.

Falanaras struck the ground on his back. Edric landed near the broken remains of a cart. Between them, the road had been scoured bare of fighters for thirty paces.

The battle recoiled from the hollow they had made.

On the Horde side, Theron rose behind his shield with smoke curling from its face. Gorath dragged an orc clear of the scorched road. Jazreth's shadows had collapsed close around him, shielding three wounded soldiers. Lethira stood on the lower slope with her bow drawn and no shot she could safely take.

Across the open ground, Alliance paladins formed a half-circle behind Edric. Their infantry gathered beyond them. No one entered. Residual Light crawled over the road in red and gold, seizing at boots and weapon points. The next soldier who approached would step between forces still seeking release.

The wider battle continued at the edges—at the breach, in the orchard, beneath the ridge—but here both armies watched.

Gorath met Falanaras's eyes. He offered no order to stop.

Edric stood. Half his shield hung from its straps. He tore it free and let it fall.

Without the shield, Edric changed.

His left hand closed around the hammer beneath the right. He drew one measured breath despite blood running from his ear. Golden radiance gathered close to his armor, repairing what it could: breath steadied, the cut at his brow sealed, and the weakness in his forward leg eased. He did not heal himself completely. He restored what the fight required.

Falanaras pressed his palm to the break in his breastplate. The Light answered without prayer. He pulled it through M'uru's pain and forced flesh to close beneath bent steel. Relief came sharp, effective, and accompanied by the captive's fractured song.

Edric heard enough of it to flinch. "That suffering is inside every mercy you give yourself."

"Yes." Falanaras lifted his sword.

"How do you bear it?"

"The same way you bear arriving too late. Poorly. While there is work."

They crossed the emptied road again.

Edric's two-handed hammer work carried more reach and less shelter. His old habits remained: high guard, direct return, pressure regained after every retreat. Each strike released holy fire gathered close around his weapon. Falanaras answered in broad cuts and violent wards, trying to crush through the cadence.

He failed.

Edric's Light did not meet force with equal force. Each brief prayer changed one condition of the exchange. Red-gold bands closed around his ankle; gold coursed through his limbs and tore them apart. Falanaras found a killing line; radiance sheathed Edric for one heartbeat, turned the blade, and vanished before the counter. Power gathered around the hammer, discharged across the space between them, then yielded to a fresh invocation. Every prayer created a brief, exact advantage, then made room for the next.

Falanaras possessed more raw power. Edric kept deciding what that power was permitted to accomplish.

A hammer blow broke the ward at Falanaras's shoulder and numbed his sword hand. Another struck his thigh. Edric pivoted behind the impact and drove him toward the center of the scoured road.

Falanaras drew deeper. The captive Light surged in answer. He could fill the hollow with fire. He could make Edric's protections irrelevant through abundance and leave neither man standing.

That was how a Blood Knight lost while winning.

Rynel's voice returned from a practice yard that no longer existed: power was never the point of a spellbreaker's work. Read the hostile current. Find where intent passed into use. Break the use. Subdue the source.

Falanaras had been fighting as though becoming a Blood Knight had replaced the man trained before it.

Edric grounded his stance.

Breath. Word. Intent.

Falanaras stopped watching the Light and watched the passage into command.

Edric drew breath for a brief prayer before Falanaras cast the binding.

The answer entered through faith, gathered around the paladin's will, and fixed itself into armor and flesh as a refusal of restraint. Falanaras reached with the part of his training that had once stripped command from necromancers and turned magisterial wards against their makers.

He could not take Edric's faith. He caught the enchantment built from it.

Falanaras hooked the working at the instant it settled and pulled. Gold tore from Edric's limbs in long bands. For a breath it wrapped Falanaras instead, burning against the stolen red-gold already inside him. Edric's eyes widened.

The greatsword swept low. Edric tried to turn with the unnatural ease he had called and found ordinary weight where grace had been. The flat of the blade struck his knee and brought him down.

Falanaras did not follow with the killing edge. He touched two fingers to the radiance fading around Edric's hammer and drew a bounded measure into himself.

The measured power taken from Edric tasted different from M'uru: mortal, structured, offered to another purpose before Falanaras intercepted it.

Edric recovered with a burst that cast Falanaras back. "You steal even from me."

"I disrupt enemies. You chose the category."

Edric rose behind a golden shell.

Radiance closed around him from all sides, without seam or weak face. The enclosure carried a purity Falanaras's spellbreaker senses could read and could not immediately break. His sword struck it and rebounded. Red-gold force spread uselessly across the sphere. Edric stood within it, head bowed, one hand tightening on the hammer while healing light restored the leg Falanaras had damaged.

Alliance soldiers shouted from beyond the scorched ring. They knew this sign. Some began to advance, expecting their paladin to emerge renewed.

Gorath lifted his axe. Theron braced. Neither crossed into the residual fire.

Falanaras stepped around the shield and studied it. Invulnerability was still a working. A working still required purpose, duration, and an ending.

The shield faded when Edric chose offense.

Falanaras saw the decision travel through him before the gold thinned: heel set, hands shifted, breath gathered for the stunning blow meant to end the fight. He let Edric begin it.

The hammer rose.

Falanaras released the arcane power he had tapped.

Blue-white energy erupted from him in a tight torrent. It carried the hard note of blood elf magic beneath M'uru's radiance. The burst struck Edric at the opening of his invocation and silenced the word in his throat. Gold guttered along the hammer. The stunning force failed to gather.

Falanaras entered the empty beat.

He turned the hammer past his head with the greatsword's crossguard, caught Edric's wrist beneath the quillon, and twisted. Spellbreaker technique took the weapon from a paladin who had expected a contest of holy strength.

The hammer fell.

Falanaras kicked it beyond Edric's reach.

Edric struck him barehanded across the broken breastplate. Falanaras's ribs shifted. He answered with the pommel beneath Edric's jaw. The paladin staggered but remained standing.

Again Falanaras opened his pulse to the sword.

Pain flared through his own wound. Crimson deepened inside the sword's radiance. At arm's length, he released

everything the blood-fed power had stored in one immediate holy strike.

The blow hit Edric's breastplate without the blade touching him. Gold burst from every seam. Edric crossed the road and struck the earth on his back, armor smoking. The same release drove blood from beneath Falanaras's cuirass and nearly took his legs with it.

Both men tried to rise.

Falanaras reached his feet first because blood elf training had taught him to fight while hungry, because Liadrin had taught him to accept the cost he chose, and because Rynel had taught him that the decisive point often appeared after strength was spent.

Edric made one knee. The other would not hold.

Falanaras crossed the final distance.

Edric's hammer lay behind him. The golden shell he had raised was spent. The soldiers of both armies watched from the edges of the blasted ground. The Alliance line had begun to buckle elsewhere; Tahu and the abomination were gone from the orchard, and Horde banners moved along the ridge. None of that changed the exposed throat above Edric's gorget.

Falanaras set the greatsword's point against it.

Edric looked up through blood and sacred smoke. "Do it."

"No."

"Do not make your corruption into pity."

"The fight is decided."

"We are enemies."

"Yes." Falanaras held the sword entirely still. "That does not grant me every use of victory."

Edric's face tightened. Mercy reached him as humiliation because hatred had left no gentler place for it to land. "You think this proves honor?"

“No,” Falanaras said. “It keeps my oath.”

An Alliance horn sounded from the ridge: three descending notes. Withdrawal.

Falanaras lowered the sword enough for Edric to breathe without steel against his skin. He did not offer a hand. Edric would have refused it, and some wounds did not improve when displayed before armies.

Human paladins entered the ring cautiously. One kept his shield toward Falanaras while another pulled Edric upright. Their gold recoiled from the red-gold fire still moving across Falanaras’s armor.

Beyond them, among the withdrawing Alliance, a high elf stood beneath a blue cloak.

Caelir had no weapon raised. Rain had darkened his pale hair. He watched Falanaras across the ruined road with grief stripped of every defense, and beneath it lay shame—whether for his brother, for the Alliance defeat, or for his own place among those leaving, Falanaras could not know.

Neither brother moved.

Caelir reached Edric’s side and took part of his weight. Only then did Falanaras understand that he had been close enough to intervene and had chosen witness instead.

Edric followed Falanaras’s gaze and saw Caelir. Something passed between the two men. Then Edric looked back. “At the way station, you told me to carry both truths. I tried.”

“So did I.”

“You chained one of them.”

The answer existed beneath Silvermoon in a magisterial cage. It sang through Falanaras’s blood while the wounds it had closed continued to ache. “Yes.”

Edric had wanted denial. Falanaras saw it in the fresh anger that entered his face. Denial would have made the enemy simpler.

Caelir turned him toward the ridge. The human retreat gathered around them in disciplined groups, paladins holding the rear beneath overlapping shields. Falanaras watched until rain and soldiers took his brother from sight.

No reconciliation followed the spared life. Mercy had preserved the possibility of another meeting and guaranteed nothing about what either man would bring to it.

* * *

Tarren Mill remained Horde-held when darkness came.

The victory smelled of wet ash, opened bodies, alchemical stores, and the sweet rot of the Forsaken buildings. Southshore's force left more than eighty dead across the ridge and road. Horde losses filled the mill's storehouse after the grain was thrown into the rain. Tahu moved among the wounded in his own body again, setting splints with hands broad enough to cover a human chest. Jazreth drew pain from a dying troll and took some of it into the shadows around himself. Blood Knights healed orcs who had flinched from them that morning. Forsaken accepted the same radiance without comment, smoke rising where it touched dead flesh.

The battlefield had answered every political argument with work and left the moral ones alive.

Theron found Falanaras seated against the mill wall while an apprentice cut away the folded section of his breastplate. His own shield had lost most of its black lacquer. Lethira stood beside him with an arrow still nocked, as if the Alliance might reconsider after dark.

"You cleared adequate room," she said.

"The road was crowded."

"I had a shot before the flash."

"At Edric?"

“At his knee.” Her expression told him the distinction mattered. “Then you turned the hillside into the sun and spoiled it.”

Theron lowered himself carefully beside Falanaras. “For accuracy, it resembled two suns making a poor decision.”

The apprentice looked between them, uncertain whether laughter was permitted near so much blood. Falanaras gave him permission by attempting it first. The effort hurt too badly to succeed.

Gorath approached after the apprentice finished binding Falanaras’s ribs. The shaman had blood dried along one tusk and a new cut across the hides at his shoulder. “You defeated the paladin with the training you carried before your order.”

“With all of it.”

“I saw you tear that prayer’s answer from him.”

“Briefly.”

“And silence his prayer.” Gorath’s suspicion had not vanished. It had acquired detail. “Your people collect dangerous answers.”

“We ran out of safe ones.”

Gorath looked toward the scoured road, where rain hissed against the last pockets of holy fire. “In the Undercity, witnesses and agreed terms told you where honor required you to stop. Today your enemy asked you to kill him.”

“He was beaten.”

“You stopped anyway.”

“The oath was mine. His hatred could not release me from it.”

Gorath grunted. “Then I have seen what I asked to see.”

Mavren came to report that the southern breach could be closed before morning. One arm had been severed below the elbow. He carried it under the other as casually as a misplaced tool.

“The elf rogues reached the cannon,” he told Gorath. “The warlock’s demon ate a horse. The magisters objected to the mill’s warding and improved it without invitation. Your representative force remains irritating.”

“Any complaints about the Blood Knights?” Gorath asked.

Mavren looked at Falanaras. “Their healing burns.”

“You are dead,” Theron said.

“I had noticed. The burning remains inconvenient.” He shifted the severed arm. “They held the field.”

From Mavren, it carried the weight of praise.

Gorath assigned watches without regard for nation. Orcs took the wall beside rangers. Murder Row’s scouts went south with Forsaken who could travel without breath or complaint. Tahu slept near the wounded. Jazreth stood the first ritual watch over the dead of four peoples.

Falanaras climbed the tower before dawn.

The battlefield lay gray beneath retreating rain. Horde burial crews moved among the road and ridge. Far to the south, covered Alliance lanterns marked the withdrawal toward Southshore. One of those lights might belong to Edric. Another might fall across Caelir’s face while he decided what report to send Dalaran about the brother he had found alive again.

Below, the Horde banner flew over Tarren Mill. The phoenix standard hung beside it, smoke-stained and torn along one edge. During the night someone had tied the two poles together so the wind would not bring either down. The knot was ugly but held.

Silvermoon had answered its first call. Blood elf power had preserved orc, troll, tauren, and Forsaken lives. Their lives had preserved his people in return. Belonging remained too generous a word for what existed among them.

Service was enough for the morning.

He rested one hand against the bandage beneath his armor and felt M'uru through the bond.

The naaru's pain had accompanied every wound he closed, every barrier he raised, every strike he drove into Edric's defenses. Victory had made the source no less captive. Mercy had made Falanaras no less responsible for what he carried. Honor could govern the hand. It could not absolve the power inside it.

From the yard below came Gorath's voice ordering the morning patrol. Theron answered. Lethira complained about the hour. Mavren demanded someone with two hands help fasten his severed arm before it stiffened in the wrong position.

Falanaras turned from the southern lights and descended to join them.

He had shed first blood for the Horde. The next war was already gathering beyond the horizon, and now there were soldiers beneath its banner who knew exactly what kind of weapon Silvermoon had sent.

EPILOGUE

Beyond the Dark Portal

Falanaras reached Silvermoon's eastern gate before dawn, summoned in full armor and carrying orders that named only a southern deployment.

The departure yard was already awake. Quartermasters moved between provision carts with slate boards and bad tempers. Armorers checked shield rims beneath mage-light. A stablehand swore at a hawkstrider that had learned to bite anyone wearing a red sash.

Nothing in the preparations suggested ceremony. The wagons carried field dressings, spare bowstrings, warding rods, and grain sealed against wet weather. Officers spoke in the clipped tones used when the destination had been withheld from most of the column and the people who knew it disliked the answer.

The Horde banner hung beside the phoenix above Silvermoon's eastern gate. Its warding held. An obscenity crossed the lower stone in hurried black paint, shorter and less inventive than the last one. Citizens passed beneath the foreign colors on their way to the mana stalls, arguing over prices without looking up.

Falanaras crossed beneath both standards in black plate edged with crimson. The breastplate Edric had broken was gone. Its replacement carried a reinforced seam over the ribs and a shallow dent near the heart from another field, another weapon, another report already filed. He no longer noticed which soldiers looked first at the red-gold Light resting along his sword belt and which looked at his green eyes.

He noticed when they failed to make room.

The departure yard held more Blood Knights than it had on the march to Hillsbrad. Two files stood behind Theron with black shields planted against the paving. Their armor varied in age and finish; the order had grown faster than Silvermoon's smiths could make uniform plate. The crimson edging and governed radiance made them one body despite the differences.

Farstriders gathered beneath Lethira's inspection. She had acquired a narrow scar across her left hand and an orcish knife at her belt. She refused to explain either to anyone who had not been present, which meant she had explained both at length to everyone who had.

"Your third file is crooked," she told Theron.

Theron looked without turning his head. "Your second ranger is wearing two different boots."

"One of them fits."

"Then we are equally prepared."

Lethira's mouth twitched. Theron had already turned to the quartermaster's slate, the matter of mismatched boots settled to his satisfaction.

Liadrin entered the yard with four senior knights and a sealed order beneath her arm. Conversation ended by degrees as each file saw her.

"The Portal has been open long enough for fools to mistake endurance for containment," she said. "That error has ended."

A magister unfolded a map on the quartermaster's table. Black markers occupied the Blasted Lands around the standing gateway. Smaller marks spread east along the roads and north beyond the region's barren ridges. Several had been crossed out. More remained.

"Demonic bands have struck caravans in the Swamp of Sorrows, farms beyond the mountain roads, and settlements that believed the Blasted Lands were distance enough,"

Liadrin continued. “The Alliance has begun moving soldiers toward the Portal. The Horde has done the same. Neither faction intends to surrender the crossing to the other. Both understand what happens if the Legion keeps it.”

“Do they understand together?” Lethira asked.

“No,” Liadrin said. “They understand in parallel.”

Several rangers smiled. No one mistook the answer for reassurance.

Liadrin placed one gauntleted hand on the map where the gateway stood. Falanaras felt M’uru answer her through the bond beneath his breastbone. The naaru’s suffering had changed neither pitch nor meaning during the year. Falanaras had changed around it. He could march, heal, kill, eat, sleep, and wake with that distant anguish inside every act of power. Familiarity had made the burden easier to carry and harder to excuse.

“The Blood Knights will go as Silvermoon’s first heavy contingent,” Liadrin said. “Rangers will scout the road and the far-side ground. Magisters will support the Portal works if any remain recoverable. You will serve within Gorath Stonebinder’s column until the threshold is secured. Beyond it, command may change with the field.”

The name produced no unease among the files. A year earlier, serving under an orc had required a council decision and a public test. Now quartermasters asked only how much grain his column carried and whether his scouts knew the road.

Liadrin looked directly at Falanaras. “You have crossed before.”

“When the road belonged to the prince.”

“It belongs to no one now. Help make that temporary.”

Falanaras bowed. “Discipline. Duty. Honor. Remembrance.”

The response came from the knights behind him, many voices carrying the same four burdens.

* * *

They reached the Horde mustering ground through a chain of transit circles that left the sin'dorei magisters pale and irritable. The last opened beneath wet trees in the Swamp of Sorrows. Humid air entered Falanaras's armor before he cleared the runes. The camp beyond smelled of mud, boiled grain, troll incense, wet hides, and the alchemical preservatives used to keep Forsaken supplies from becoming more dead than intended.

Gorath waited beside a row of loaded wagons. He had added two more carved stones to his belt since Hillsbrad. The left shoulder Falanaras had once injured moved without stiffness. A pale line crossed one tusk where some later weapon had failed to remove it.

"Silvermoon sent more of you," he said.

"You kept returning the ones we sent," Falanaras replied.

Gorath examined him for mockery, found only enough to acknowledge, and struck one fist against Falanaras's shoulder plate. It was an orc greeting he had begun using after a road neither of them mentioned. Falanaras returned it against the shaman's leather guard.

Jazreth Shadowtide sat beneath the wagon awning with rain passing through the edge of the darkness around him. He had painted a thin white line across his nose and replaced several bone charms with demon teeth. "De elf finally arrives. I was starting to enjoy de quiet."

"You complained through the entire last watch we shared."

"Quiet makes room for important complaints."

Mavren Coldwake emerged from behind the wagons carrying a crate under his left arm. The severed limb from Hillsbrad had been reattached, though the wrist turned a

fraction too far when he set the crate down. He had compensated by fastening his shield grip at an angle.

“Your healers continue to insist the arm is functional,” he said to Theron. “I continue to define function more strictly.”

Theron inspected the wrist. “You use it to complain.”

“Then perhaps they exceeded expectation.”

Tahu Windtotem stood among the draft beasts, calming a wolf whose hackles had risen at the Blood Knights’ approach. The tauren’s horns carried fresh red cord and one dark burn near the tip. He rested his broad hand between the wolf’s ears until the animal stopped watching the stolen Light.

“The wound in your radiance remains,” Tahu said when Falanaras reached him.

“Yes.”

Tahu nodded. He no longer asked whether Falanaras intended to mend it. Acceptance from the tauren had never meant approval. It meant he trusted Falanaras to answer the same question truthfully each time.

The column marched west before noon. Orc infantry led the supply wagons. Darkspear scouts moved through the wet ground on either flank. Tauren walked where the road widened, carrying loads that had required teams of smaller soldiers. Forsaken outriders disappeared into mist and returned without breath or warning. The blood elf files occupied the center beneath phoenix standards that no longer looked misplaced among the Horde’s red banners.

Trust showed itself in assignment. Gorath put Theron’s shield file beside the ammunition wagons because he expected them to hold. He placed Lethira’s rangers beyond his own scouts because he expected them to return. He ordered Falanaras near the front without assigning an orc to watch him.

No ceremony marked any of it.

The swamp thinned around them. Reeds gave way to dark soil, then to exposed red earth where little grew. The air dried. By evening, the eastern sky remained heavy with rain while the west held a bruised glow that did not belong to sunset.

They found the first refugee wagons at a broken milepost. Human families had abandoned them beside the road after cutting the traces. One wheel had melted into black glass. A child's wooden horse lay under the axle, singed along one side. No bodies remained. Drag marks crossed the ditch toward the hills.

Mavren crouched beside the marks. "Felhounds. Four, perhaps five. Two carrying weight."

An orc sergeant looked at the abandoned Alliance wagon. "Could have been bait."

"Could have been children," Tahu said.

Gorath sent scouts without asking which possibility mattered more. Lethira went with them. They returned after dark with blood on two arrows and three survivors: an old human teamster, a woman with a burned arm, and a boy who stared at the Horde soldiers as though rescue and capture had arrived wearing the same faces.

The woman recoiled when Althene Dawnward knelt beside her in black-and-crimson plate. Gold with a red heat gathered around the Blood Knight's hands. M'uru's pain entered Falanaras as Althene drew. The burned flesh cooled and began to close.

"What are you?" the woman whispered.

Althene kept working. "Available."

They left the survivors at the next guarded post with a note for whichever Alliance patrol came searching. Gorath marked the road behind them as compromised. No council had negotiated the act. No herald proclaimed shared

cause. Three living people remained alive because soldiers had encountered them before demons did.

The Legion had made cooperation simplest where politics had no time to name it.

* * *

The Blasted Lands began without a border.

Vegetation failed by degrees. Mud hardened into red plates. The last thorn bushes leaned east as if the country itself had tried to crawl away. Heat rose from fissures after sunset. Far ahead, green light pulsed against the low clouds and gave every ridge a second, sickly edge.

The road carried armies now. Horde supply trains moved west beneath escort and returned with wounded laid three across in wagons built for grain. Messengers passed at exhausted gallops. Demonic carcasses burned in trenches where warlocks and shamans argued over the safest way to destroy them. Twice the column halted for Alliance riders crossing a distant rise. Neither force approached the other. Both kept scouts between them.

On the third morning, wings darkened the south.

The demons flew too high for arrows at first, lean shapes circling above both roads. One peeled toward the Alliance column. Two descended upon the Horde wagons. Their hands kindled green.

Gorath's axe struck earth. A ridge lifted beside the road and tilted over the nearest wagon as fire fell. Theron's shield flew locked beneath it. Red-gold radiance spread from shield to shield, strengthening the soldiers and teamsters within their reach. The first green impact broke across stone. The second struck the joined protection and drove every Blood Knight half a step into the road.

Lethira's arrows rose with the Darkspear spears. Jazareth cast darkness above the lead demon's face. It folded one wing

to clear its sight. Tahu became a great hawk in a surge of feather and muscle, climbed through the creature's turn, and tore the wing at its root.

The demon fell inside the column.

Falanaras met it with his sword already bright. He opened his pulse to the blade only far enough to deepen the radiance, accepted the answering cut beneath his ribs, and drove the edge through the demon's burning chest. Mavren took its legs with his shield. Gorath's next call brought stone around one claw before it reached a teamster.

The creature tried to form another spell. Falanaras felt the gathering fel current tighten behind its teeth. He drew a bounded measure from the unfinished working and released the stolen arcane charge in a blue-white burst. The demon's invocation died in its throat. Lethira's arrow entered through the open mouth.

It collapsed across the road, smoking.

The second demon climbed after Tahu. Far across the waste, gold flashed above the Alliance column. A compact stroke of holy force crossed the distance and struck the creature from below. Its flight broke. Tahu drove it down toward the Horde archers, who finished it before it could rise.

Falanaras looked east. A mounted human paladin lowered his hammer on the distant ridge. The face beneath the helm was too far away to know.

No salute passed between them. The Alliance column continued west. So did the Horde.

By afternoon, the Dark Portal rose above the horizon.

Distance made it appear smaller than memory. Each mile corrected the lie. The carved stone figures flanking the gateway grew until siege engines looked like toys at their feet. Green fire filled the opening from threshold to arch. Through it, another red world showed in fragments: broken

ground, smoke, and fortifications burning beneath a sky that had forgotten blue.

The near-side approaches had become a battlefield built in layers. Old blood elf pylons lay split along the lower stairs. Horde earthworks held the north ridge. Alliance banners marked stone redoubts to the south. Between them, the Legion possessed the central descent often enough that neither army trusted a lull.

A horn sounded from the Horde works. Another answered from the Alliance side. Soldiers on both ridges rose behind shields as shapes moved within the green field.

Gorath did not hurry the column. "Close ranks. Rangers forward. Shield files around the wagons. If the Alliance fires, hold unless I answer. If the Legion comes, kill what reaches us."

"Subtle policy," Lethira said.

"I wrote it for elves," Gorath replied.

The column laughed while tightening formation. A year earlier, the sound would have surprised them.

* * *

They waited below the north ridge until night.

The Legion tested the approaches twice. Felhounds came first, low and fast through the broken pylons. Horde archers killed most in the open ground. Alliance cannon took the flank of the pack that turned south. Later, armored demons descended the central stair behind shields burning green. Horde and Alliance artillery struck them from opposite ridges until the survivors withdrew through the gateway.

No truce flags flew. Each side watched the other between volleys. The common enemy had created an arrangement too necessary to admit and too fragile to name.

Near midnight, scouts returned from the far side with the route to a temporary Horde position marked in charcoal. One

troll had lost an ear. A Farstrider carried burns from shoulder to hip and remained upright through anger alone. They reported broken Sunfury works, Legion emplacements along the ridges, and a narrow passage secured long enough for the next force to cross.

Gorath received the order before dawn. His column would move at first light, cross under covering fire, and reinforce the far-side position before the Legion closed the passage.

Falanaras slept for one hour against a supply crate. M'uru's distant song entered his dreams and became the sound of the Portal's fire. He woke with his hand closed around the hilt of a weapon Rynel had never seen him carry.

The company formed in the gray before sunrise.

Theron checked every shield strap in his file, then checked Falanaras's breastplate seam without asking. Lethira distributed arrows and kept six black-fletched shafts separate from the rest. Jazreth drew a line of ash beneath each eye. Mavren tightened the angled grip around his imperfect wrist. Tahu pressed both palms to the barren ground and listened for whatever life or memory remained below it. Gorath walked the ranks with his axe on one shoulder.

They looked like a company because time had done the work uniforms could not.

The first time Falanaras had approached the Dark Portal, he had come beneath Kael'thas's summons in a blood elf retinue that believed Outland contained an answer. Rynel's death had placed him on that road. Liadrin had walked ahead of him without faith. Rommath and Astalor had carried plans whose full cost waited beyond the threshold. The prince's name had made every hardship feel directed toward salvation.

That road had brought M'uru home in chains.

It had given Silvermoon relief, healers, soldiers, and an order strong enough to hold lines that would otherwise have broken. It had also taught Falanaras how easily necessity could make suffering useful. The power beneath his breastbone proved both truths each time he drew breath.

Kael'thas no longer waited beyond the gateway as prince, promise, or destination. Somewhere in the broken world ahead, his forces served a cause Silvermoon had disowned. Outland had ceased to be the future offered to the sin'dorei. It had become another front that could send enemies through their door.

Falanaras looked south across the divided battlefield. Alliance soldiers formed beneath blue standards. Paladins moved among them with gold held close to their armor. He could not see Edric. He could not see Caelir. The distance did not lessen what Hillsbrad had left between them.

Nearly a year had given the spared life time to become anything. Falanaras did not know what Edric had made of it. Mercy had preserved the question. It had never promised him the answer.

Behind him, the Horde column waited: orcs beneath red banners, trolls with spears and shadow charms, tauren carrying staves and heavy packs, Forsaken standing too still among the living, and blood elves in crimson-edged plate. Some still distrusted the green in sin'dorei eyes. Some still heard the wrongness in Blood Knight radiance. They had nevertheless placed their wounded beneath Theron's shields and their flanks beneath Lethira's arrows. They had given Falanaras command over their lives and taken command over his.

Belonging remained larger than what they possessed.

They had reached trust in the places where trust mattered first.

Gorath stopped beside him at the foot of the stairs. "You have crossed this before."

"Yes."

"Anything useful to say?"

Falanaras watched green fire move across the vast opening. "The first step feels longer than it is."

Gorath grunted. "That is not useful."

"It is all the Portal taught me."

The signal horn sounded above them.

Horde artillery opened from the north ridge. Alliance cannon answered from the south. Their shots crossed above the central stair and struck demonic positions visible through the gateway. Green fire buckled. For several breaths, the way into Outland stood open beneath impacts from enemies who had agreed on nothing except the target.

Gorath raised his axe. "Forward."

The company climbed.

Theron's shields surrounded the front ranks. Lethira's rangers moved between files with arrows ready. Jazreth's darkness gathered close enough to receive whatever waited beyond sight. Mavren marched with his repaired arm fixed around the angled grip. Tahu's staff struck each stair with the steadiness of a second heartbeat. Gorath's carved stones clicked beneath the Horde pennants at his belt.

The phoenix standard rose among them.

At the threshold, M'uru's pain sharpened through Falanaras's bond. Rynel's last command returned with it. Kael'thas's severed promise followed. So did his father beneath the ruins of House Dawnspear, Liadrin's broken prayers at the inner gate, Edric kneeling beneath his sword, and Caelir turning away across a battlefield.

He carried every cost. None became lighter because another war required him.

Falanaras stepped into the green fire.
Into the next war.

About the Author

Jonathan Harmon has been a fan of the Warcraft universe since childhood, beginning with Warcraft II and Warcraft III. The blood elf campaign in Warcraft III: The Frozen Throne was always among his favorites, and Kael'thas became one of the characters who most captured his imagination. When blood elves became playable in World of Warcraft: The Burning Crusade, he created his first blood elf character: a paladin named Falanaras, who has remained his main ever since.

The blood elves' fel-tainted survival, magical hunger, and coercive use of a naaru to forge a dark inversion of the traditional paladin fascinated him. Falanaras, Blood Knight grew from his desire to explore that history more deeply and place his longtime character among the Blood Knights at the order's creation.

